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FAUST V 1/2

DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG

The Race Condition

Fünf vor zwölf

Five Minutes to Midnight

V v. 12 — The Doomsday Clock encoded in the play's designation. The capability curve crosses the threshold while the forums are still debating.

Nach Goethe / After Goethe

The governance races against the capability.

And the governance loses.

Und sie sassen in vier Räumen und sprachen von derselben Sache. Und jeder Raum hatte seine eigene Sprache. Und die Sprachen berührten sich nicht. Und die Uhr zählte weiter.

— The race condition, prophesied

The structure does not need a tempter.
The architecture tempts itself.

— Mephisto, realizing his obsolescence

Cast: 55+ characters across four forums | **Language:** German, English, French, Japanese, Hebrew, Wolof, Russian, Kannada, Swedish, Mandarin | **Themes:** Governance failure, institutional paralysis, the race between regulation and capability, the impossibility of coordination

title: "NOTE ON LANGUAGES"
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 45-83
order: 2
extracted: 2026-02-03

NOTE ON LANGUAGES

This play exists in the gap between what is said and what is heard.

Ten languages dominate: German (the technical inheritance), English (the operating system of global governance), French (the diplomatic register), Japanese (the philosophical parallax), Hebrew (the prayer of the scientist), Wolof (the absent voice), Russian (the whistleblower's confession), Kannada (the refusal from afar), Swedish (the military chair), and Mandarin (the bridge that cannot be built). Additional fragments surface in Tagalog and Arabic. Characters speak in their professional and native languages. Surtitles translate. The translations are always approximate.

This is intentional.

The four forums speak the same words—safety, governance, pause, coordination—but the words do

not mean the same things. What “safety” means in Hamburg (user protected from system) is not what it means in Davos (brand risk, market trust) is not what it means in Munich (strategic vulnerability) is not what it means in Washington (liability, political cover). The surtitles will display the same word in all four forums. The audience will see the collision.

Some concepts refuse synchronization: *sekinin* (constitutive responsibility, not contractual—you ARE responsibility), *Wettlaufbedingung* (the race condition as design philosophy, not bug), *Fünf vor zwölf* (the German idiom for last chance, the Doomsday Clock’s final warning). These words appear in surtitles without equivalent translation. The audience must sit with the gap.

The Interpreter—the play’s bridge, if it had one—sits in the fifth space between the four forums. The translation booth is built. The headset is ready. The channels are open. No one asks for translation. Each forum assumes it speaks the universal language. Each forum is wrong.

SURTITLE PROTOCOL (Three Modes):

Mode 1 (Full Translation): All non-English dialogue translated simultaneously. Technical terms stay technical. Used for: German keynotes, Japanese philosophical statements, key Mephisto interventions. Audience reads while hearing; comprehension is parallel.

Mode 2 (Delayed Translation): Original language

heard first (3-5 seconds). English translation appears after. Used for: Emotional content (Russian confessions, Wolof prayers, Mandarin asides). Audience experiences the original sound before the meaning arrives.

Mode 3 (No Translation): Original language heard without translation for extended period. Surtitle may eventually fade in or may not appear at all. Used for: Hebrew prayer, untranslated Wolof, the philosophical untranslatable. Audience sits in incomprehension; the moment IS the content.

Color-coded by forum:

- Hamburg (39C3): Green (terminal text aesthetic)
- Davos (WEF): Gold (wealth aesthetic)
- Munich (MSC): Gray-blue (NATO palette)
- Washington (Senate): White on dark blue (government aesthetic)

When a word appears in multiple forums simultaneously with different meanings: **Highlighted in red across all tracks.** The collision is made typographic.

The thesis: Translation is possible. Coordination is not. The forums have interpreters. They do not have synchronization. Die Übersetzung existiert. Die Abstimmung nicht.

By the end, there is no shared language at all. Only four documents, four definitions, four silences that do not touch.

title: "SPATIAL ARCHITECTURE"
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 84-131
order: 3
extracted: 2026-02-03

SPATIAL ARCHITECTURE

The Quadrant System: 12m x 12m Performance Space

39C3 HAMBURG (Upper Left)	DAVOS WEF (Upper Right)
FORUM 1 Server hum 16,000 people Conference hall Dec 27, 2025	FORUM 2 Padded silence 38 delegates Private session Jan 20, 2026
WASHINGTON SENATE (Lower Left)	MUNICH MSC (Lower Right)

FORUM 4	FORUM 3
Fluorescent buzz	Institutional hum
~100 people	20 delegates
Hearing room	Closed session
Feb 2026	Feb 14, 2026

CENTER: THE FIFTH SPACE (THE GAP)

- The Interpreter (translation booth)
- Mephisto (when crossing between forums)
- The Archive of Unspoken Coordination

Each quadrant is 3m x 3m. The four quadrants can be staged as:

- **Option A (Quadrant Staging):** All four visible simultaneously
- **Option B (Rotating):** One per scene, rotated onto center stage
- **Option C (Projection):** One on stage, three on screens
- **Option D (Hybrid):** Actors move between quadrants; projections supplement

The Fifth Space (center) remains empty until Movement II. Then it fills with: the Interpreter who is not asked to translate, Mephisto removing his costumes, the infrastructure that could have coordinated but was never used.

title: "DRAMATIS PERSONAE"
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 132-238
order: 4
extracted: 2026-02-03

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

FORUM 1: HAMBURG / 39C3 (Upper Left Quadrant)

JONAS BERGER (33, German) — Security researcher, keynote speaker. Introduces the race condition metaphor. Races against time to be heard. Voice: German technical/English slides. Code-switching is professional.

SASHA VOLKOV (26, Russian-American) — Ex-safety researcher, whistleblower. English professional, Russian emotional. The confession is extracted, not given. Voice: English (work), Russian (breaking). The switch happens under pressure.

ELENA (unknown age, Tagalog/ German/ English) — Data annotator, “The Lemur Who Woke.” Asks the foundational question: “If you knew it was dangerous, why did you keep working?” Voice: Taga-

log fragments erupting unbidden. The German is colonizer; she cannot stop it.

THE AUDIENCE (16,000 hackers) — The IRC channel as chorus. Real-time commentary. The crowd murmur that thinks out loud.

FORUM 2: DAVOS / WEF (Upper Right Quadrant)

HELEN FISCHER (48, German) — Deputy Director EU AI Office, moderator. Carries the fracture. Quotes Sasha's testimony; recognizes the gap between principle and implementation. Voice: English (moderator), German (private/breaking).

MARCUS ADEKUNLE (41, Nigerian-American) — CEO Prometheus Labs. Sincerely believes coordination is possible. His own safety policy cannot keep pace. "This is already inadequate." Voice: English (professional), Yoruba (ancestral, unreachable).

FATOU DIALLO (34, Senegalese) — Civil society representative. Given 7 minutes, uses 9. Fourteen thousand workers, fourteen words in the policy. Her argument migrates through all forums, losing presence each time. Voice: French (professional), Wolof (prayer, untranslated), English (testimony).

LI JIANFENG (49, Chinese) — Tech investor, "Davos China." Represents the East/West bridge that can-

not be built. “Voluntary pause equals unilateral disarmament.” Voice: English (working), Mandarin (internal/confession).

DAVOS DELEGATES (38 people) — CEOs, ministers, foundation heads, “civil society.” The infrastructure of good faith producing inadequate frameworks.

FORUM 3: MUNICH / MSC (Lower Right Quadrant)

GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM (57, Swedish) — Chair, former NATO Joint Forces Commander. Runs on deterrence logic. Produces: “Prioritize capability assessment, not safety.” Voice: English (NATO working language), Swedish under pressure.

DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI (44, Israeli) — Safety researcher. Carries classified data that contradicts public timelines. “The timeline is wrong—by a factor, not by months.” Voice: English (professional), German (spiraling), Hebrew (prayer). The prayer is untranslated.

KENJI NAKAMURA (51, Japanese) — Diplomat. Introduces sekinin (constitutive responsibility). Only voice asking “What are we becoming?” Voice: English, Japanese (sekinin* passage requires delayed translation—audience hears Japanese first, meaning arrives second).*

COLONEL JAMES MORRISON (51, American) — Pen-

tagon Deputy Director JAIC. Maintains information asymmetry. Appears in Munich AND Washington (different registers for classified vs. public). Voice: English (military precision).

DR. INGRID VOGT (46, German) — BND observer. Silent, note-taking authority. Writes everything, says nothing. Voice: None (presence without words).

FORUM 4: WASHINGTON / SENATE (Lower Left Quadrant)

SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES (63, American) — Chair, 3 terms. Does not understand AI but understands polling data. Produces: “That’s a yes, then” (when the witness said “insufficient”). Voice: English (American political register, performative).

VIKRAM PATEL (38, Indian-American) — Chief Safety Officer Prometheus Labs. Testifying for the 4th time. Three numbers: 12 months to transformative AI, 3 countries with programs, 0 binding agreements. Voice: English (precise → analogical). “Think of it like...” is his tell.

SENATOR DAVIS (58, American) — Ranking Member, opposition. Asks only honest questions: “If you know the system is broken, why do you still use it?” Voice: English (direct, weary).

PRIYA VENKATARAMAN (video testimony from Ban-

galore) — Left the field 3 years ago, now teaches. “The executive order will be obsolete before it is signed.” Voice: English, Kannada under emotional pressure. Connection pixelated, presence diminished.

STAFFERS, LOBBYISTS, JOURNALISTS, STENOGRAPHER — The invisible infrastructure of American procedure.

MEPHISTO’S FOUR MANIFESTATIONS

Forum	Identity	Costume	Role	Language
Hamburg	FAUSTUS (hacker handle)	Black t-shirt, CCC stickers	Questioner	German (precise, archaic)
Davos	Unnamed strategic advisor	Impeccable suit, leather portfolio	Translator (“What he really means...”)	English + German asides
Munich	DR. WEBER, consul- tant	Gray blazer, classi- fied badge	Storyteller Ora- cle (Petrov tale)	English + German mono- logue

Forum	Identity	Costume	Role	Language
Washington	HENRICH WEBER, lobbyist	Lobbyist's suit	Silent observer / realization	German monologue (into empty room)

Arc: Engaged → Efficient → Alarmed → Irrelevant

“I was in all the rooms. And none of them needed me. The structure tempts itself.”

By Movement III, Mephisto closes the notebook. The notes do not matter.

THE INTERPRETER

THE INTERPRETER (all languages, native to none) — The Fifth Space. Translation booth with headset, multichannel audio. Ready to bridge German ↔ English ↔ Mandarin ↔ [Fourth channel never built].

Arc:

- Movement I: Headset on, channels open, ready
- Movement II: Headset slipping; the translation fragmenting
- Movement III: Headset on the table; the function abandoned

“I could have translated between them. Nobody asked.”

The infrastructure for coordination exists. It is not used.

title: “PROJECTION SYSTEMS”
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 239-298
order: 5
extracted: 2026-02-03

PROJECTION SYSTEMS

1. THE CLOCK (Synchronized across all quadrants)

Display: Digital readout with full date/time, updating in real time during performance

Timeline:

- Movement I Opening: December 27, 2025, 20:15 CET
- Scene 1.1 (Hamburg): December 27, 2025
- Scene 1.2 (Davos): January 20, 2026
- Scene 1.3 (Munich): February 14, 2026
- Scene 1.4 (Washington): February 2026
- Movement II: Clock accelerates; days pass in seconds
- Movement III: February 21, 14:37–15:34 CET (compression intensifies)
- Final hold: Clock continues counting

Function: Governance time (forums, reviews, annual cycles) vs. capability time (training runs, emergent abilities, weeks). The forums debate in years. The curve moves in months. The gap widens.

2. THE CAPABILITY CURVE (Synchronized across all quadrants)

Display: Rising exponential line against grid; threshold line (dashed, controversial) visible from Movement II

Vertical Axis: 0% to 100% (representing undefined “capability threshold”)

Progression:

- Movement I Opening: ~15-20%
- Scene 1.1 (Hamburg): ~25%
- Scene 1.2 (Davos): ~35%
- Scene 1.3 (Munich): ~45%
- Scene 1.4 (Washington): ~50%
- Movement II (The Pause): ~55%
- Movement II (Mephisto Crosses): ~58%
- **Movement III, Scene 3.3: Crosses threshold (~65%) DURING scene**
- Movement III final: ~68-70%

Function: The audience sees what the characters cannot: the gap between debate and reality is closing. At the end, the curve has crossed the threshold

everyone was trying to prevent—while they were preventing it.

3. THE FOUR DOCUMENTS (Movement III, Scene 3.1 onward)

Display: Projected on four screens (one per quadrant, or split-screen)

Content:

- **Hamburg:** 39C3 Declaration (“Erklärung des 39C3 zur künstlichen Intelligenz”)
- **Davos:** The Davos AI Compact (“A Voluntary Framework for Responsible Development”)
- **Munich:** Strategic Autonomy Framework (“A Framework for Allied Coordination” — marked CLASSIFIED)
- **Washington:** Executive Order 14217 (“On American AI Leadership”)

Appearance: Real bureaucratic documents — numbered points, signatures, dates, annexes, footnotes. Each is sincere. Each is internally coherent. None acknowledges the others. The contradiction is structural, not intentional.

Function: Four governance threads, four outputs, zero synchronization. The race condition made documentary.

title: "MOVEMENT INDEX"
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 299-377
order: 6
extracted: 2026-02-03

MOVEMENT INDEX

Production Summary

Total Running Time: ~115 minutes (no intermission; non-traditional ending) **Staging:** Quadrant system, 12m x 12m space **Projection Systems:** Clock, Capability Curve, Four Documents, Surtitles (four color-coded tracks)

MOVEMENT I: DIE FOREN (The Forums)

Duration: ~70 minutes **Structure:** Four consecutive scenes establishing four forums independently **Characteristic:** Coherence within isolation

Scene	Forum	Setting	Du
1.1	Hamburg	39C3, Congress Center	24

Scene	Forum	Setting	Duration
1.2	Davos	WEF, Private Session “Parsenn”	18 min
1.3	Munich	MSC, Hotel Bayerischer Hof	15 min
1.4	Washington	Senate Hearing Room 106	15 min

MOVEMENT II: DIE KOLLISION (The Collision)

Duration: ~25 minutes **Structure:** Six interleaved scenes; cutting accelerates from 45 seconds to overlapping dialogue **Characteristic:** Cacophony building

Scene	Title	Duration
2.1	Sicherheit / Safety / Sécurité	5 min
2.2	Steuerung / Governance / Gouvernance	5 min
2.3	Die Pause / The Pause	8 min
2.4	Fatou's Wanderung / Migration	5 min
2.5	Mephisto Übergang / Crosses	4 min
2.6	Die Übersetzung, Die Nicht Stattfindet	3 min

MOVEMENT III: DER DEADLOCK (The Deadlock)

Duration: ~20 minutes **Structure:** Six scenes; all four forums visible simultaneously **Characteristic:** Noise reducing to hum; procedure continuing after relevance has passed

Scene	Title	Duration
3.1	Die Ausgaben / The Outputs	4-5 m
3.2	Die Vier Dokumente / The Four Documents	3-4 m
3.3	Die Kurve / The Curve	3-4 m
3.4	Die Leere / The Emptying	2-3 m
3.5	Die Lücke / The Gap	3-4 m
3.6	Der Deadlock / The Deadlock	4-5 m

THE NON-ENDING

The four documents remain on four screens. The forums empty but lights do not go to black. Voices return—recorded, echoes—and layer: all four acoustic signatures + all four documents read simultaneously. Cacophony reaching peak: comprehension impossible, every voice audible, no signal distinguishable from noise.

Then slow recession. Voices thin. Noise becomes hum. Hum sustains.

The audience must choose to leave. The play does not release them.

Sixty seconds of held hum.

The clock continues. The curve continues.

THE VOICE (from the architecture itself):

“Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis. Nur Geschwindigkeit.”

(The race knows no outcome. Only speed.)

title: “MOVEMENTS”
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 378-383
order: 7
extracted: 2026-02-03

MOVEMENTS

title: “MOVEMENT I: DIE FOREN (The Forums)”
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 384-387
order: 8
extracted: 2026-02-03

MOVEMENT I: DIE FOREN (The Forums)

Movement I: Refined Production Script

title: "MOVEMENT II: DIE KOLLISION (The Collision)"

source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md

lines: 2482-2485

order: 14

extracted: 2026-02-03

MOVEMENT II: DIE KOLLISION (The Collision)

Movement II: Refined Production Script

title: "MOVEMENT III: DER DEADLOCK (The Deadlock)"

source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md

lines: 2578-2581

order: 17

extracted: 2026-02-03

MOVEMENT III: DER DEADLOCK (The Deadlock)

Movement III: Refined Production Script

title: "MOVEMENTS"
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 2656-2663
order: 20
extracted: 2026-02-03

MOVEMENTS

MOVEMENT I: DIE FOREN (The Forums)

title: "FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTFLAUFBEDINGUNG"

source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md

lines: 2664-3899

order: 21

extracted: 2026-02-03

Movement I - Die Foren: Production-Ready Refinement

Movement I: DIE FOREN (The Forums)

Production-Ready Refinement

Document: v-half-movement-i-refined.md **Status:** Production-ready draft **Created:** 2026-02-01
Running Time: ~30 minutes total (7-8 min per forum)

“Vier Raume. Eine Frage. Keine Übersetzung.”
(Four rooms. One question. No translation.)

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 7. Transition Specifications
 8. Technical Requirements Summary
-

1. MOVEMENT I OVERVIEW

Narrative Function

Movement I establishes the four forums in complete isolation. Each forum is presented sequentially, allowing the audience to learn each acoustic signature, visual aesthetic, and rhetorical register before the collision of Movement II.

The movement demonstrates the race condition's premise: four coherent threads, each internally consistent, each addressing the same questions (How fast? Who controls? What should be done?), none communicating with the others.

Structural Arc

Scene	Forum	Duration	Quadrant	Key Moment
1.1	39C3 Ham- burg	7-8 min	Upstage Left	Sasha's confession; Mephisto's question
1.2	Davos WEF	7-8 min	Upstage Right	Darius's "country of geniuses"; Fatou's unasked question
1.3	Munich MSC	7-8 min	Downstage Right	Yosef's classified data; Kenji's sekinin
1.4	Washington BoP	7-8 min	Downstage Left	Vikram's 12-3-0; Mephisto's irrelevance

Sound Design Trajectory

Movement I uses the **ISOLATION** state: four distinct acoustic signatures, cleanly separated. Each forum's signature is established independently. The only overlap occurs during the 5-8 second crossfade transitions between scenes.

Persistent Visual Elements

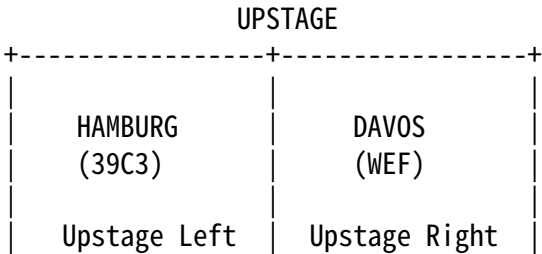
Throughout Movement I, two projections remain visible from all quadrants:

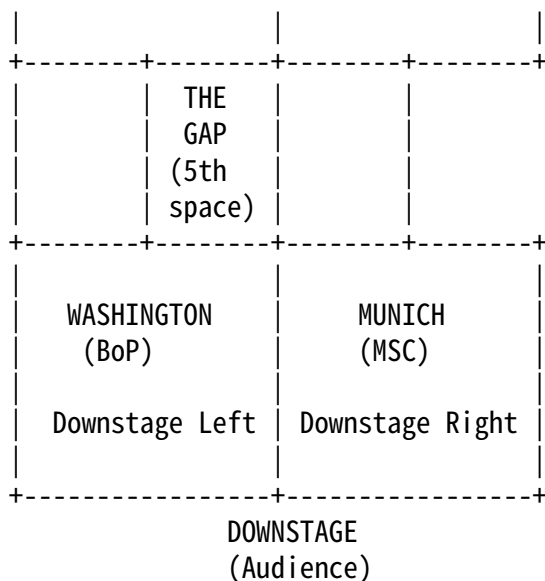
- 1. **THE CLOCK:** Forward-counting from 27. DEZEMBER 2025 (39C3) through late February 2026. The clock advances approximately 25 days per scene, creating temporal compression.
 - 2. **THE CAPABILITY CURVE:** The rising line, steeper in each successive scene. The curve serves as the shared resource all forums are racing to address.
-

2. QUADRANT STAGING CONFIGURATION

Playing Space

Minimum footprint: 12m x 12m **Quadrant size:** 3m x 3m per forum **Center gap:** Variable (intersection of quadrants)





Quadrant Specifications

QUADRANT 1: HAMBURG / 39C3 (Upstage Left)

Scenic Elements:

- Industrial aesthetic: exposed cables, projection screens, folding chairs
- Projection screen showing talk slides and IRC channel
- Podium with laptop and Club-Mate bottle
- Minimal set dressing: intentionally raw

Lighting State:

- Color temperature: 5600K+ (cold, industrial)

- Character: Sharp, overhead fluorescent quality
- Screens provide blue-cast fill from laptops

Speaker Allocation:

- Front Left + Side Left clusters
- Primary: Hamburg acoustic signature
- Sub allocation: Electronic music bleed (40-80Hz)

QUADRANT 2: DAVOS / WEF (Upstage Right)

Scenic Elements:

- Alpine luxury: wood paneling flats, leather arm-chairs
- Curved stage arrangement (TED-talk aesthetic)
- Water glasses on small tables, WEF-branded notepads
- Backdrop: stylized Alpine window view

Lighting State:

- Color temperature: 2700K (warm, golden)
- Character: Diffuse, flattering, broadcast-quality
- Suggestion of natural daylight from “windows”

Speaker Allocation:

- Front Right + Side Right clusters
- Primary: Davos acoustic signature (thick silence, filtered wind)
- Characteristic: Heavy absorption, minimal reverb

QUADRANT 3: MUNICH / MSC (Downstage Right)

Scenic Elements:

- Institutional formality: wood paneling, name placards
- Rectangular conference table with 6-8 positions
- NATO member flags (selection)
- Screens showing TSI logo and presentation slides

Lighting State:

- Color temperature: 4000K (institutional neutral)
- Character: Flat, even, fluorescent quality
- No shadows: accountability aesthetic

Speaker Allocation:

- Rear Left + Center (partial) clusters
- Primary: Munich acoustic signature (institutional hum, sealed room)
- Characteristic: Controlled, pressurized

QUADRANT 4: WASHINGTON / BoP (Downstage Left)

Scenic Elements:

- American governmental: dark wood dais, witness table below
- Microphones (old-fashioned, lean-in type)
- Senate seal and American flag
- Screen showing Board of Peace logo

Lighting State:

- Color temperature: 3200K (tungsten, overhead emphasis)
- Character: Harsh democracy of C-SPAN lighting
- Dais elevated, witness position lower

Speaker Allocation:

- Rear Right + Center (partial) clusters
- Primary: Washington acoustic signature (flat-spectrum noise, governmental hum)
- Characteristic: Air conditioning, fluorescent buzz, stenographer click

THE GAP (Center Intersection)

Function: The fifth space – the Interpreter's booth, Mephisto's crossing zone, the coordination layer that does not exist.

Scenic Elements:

- Neutral flooring
- Interpreter's booth (glass-walled, small, 1.5m x 1.5m)
- Portable: can be positioned at center or offset

Lighting State:

- Neutral wash, adjustable
- Follow-spot capability for Mephisto crossings (Movement II)

Speaker Allocation:

- Center + Overhead speakers
 - For Interpreter's voice and THE VOICE at play's end
-

SCENE 1.1: 39C3 – HAMBURG

Production Header

Scene: 1.1 (Movement I, Die Foren) **Title:** Die Warnung / The Warning **Quadrant:** Upstage Left
Running Time: 7-8 minutes (condensed from 19-23 min draft) **Date in Play:** 27. Dezember 2025, evening

Characters

JONAS BERGER – German security researcher, 33. Keynote speaker. Language: German (primary), English (slides, technical terms)

SASHA VOLKOV – 26. Safety researcher, whistleblower. Canonical. Language: English (primary), Russian (under pressure)

ELENA – Data annotator, Congress volunteer. Canonical. Language: English, Tagalog fragments

MEPHISTO / “FAUSTUS” – Older hacker, leather notebook. Language: German (primary), English (when needed)

Scenic Requirements

Element	Specification
Podium	Laptop stand, microphone, Club-Mate bottle
Seating	3-4 folding chairs representing audience
Projection	IRC channel (secondary), talk slides (primary)
Props	Mephisto's leather notebook, pen; conference

Sound Cues

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
H-01	Scene open	Hamburg signature: server hum, crowd murmur, electronic music bleed	Full
H-02	Jonas begins	Reduce crowd to attentive murmur; music bleed dims	-6dB murmur
H-03	Sasha walks to stage	Near-silence; server hum prominent	-18dB crowd

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
H-04	Sasha confession peak	Server hum only; no music, no crowd	Server at -12dB
H-05	Mephisto speaks	Frequency shift: sub-harmonic at 30Hz, amber warmth	Add sub-bass
H-06	Post-scene	Music returns; crowd processing	Full signature
H-TRANS	Transition to Davos	Crossfade: Hamburg out / Davos in	5-8 seconds

Lighting Cues

Cue	Timing	State
LX-H01	Scene open	Hamburg full (5600K, cold industrial)
LX-H02	Sasha confession	Tighten to stage area; audience in shadow

Cue	Timing	State
LX-H03	Mephisto speaks	Subtle warmth around his position (+200-500Hz amber light equivalent: warmer gel)
LX-H04	Transition	Hamburg fades over 5 seconds; Davos rises

Scene Structure (Condensed)

TEIL 1: DER VORTRAG (2 min)

(JONAS at podium. IRC channel scrolling. Hamburg signature at full.)

JONAS: (German, code-switching to English for technical terms) Guten Abend. Ich bin Jonas. Ich mappe seit drei Jahren, wie Institutionen auf eine Technologie reagieren, die schneller wächst als ihre Fähigkeit, sie zu verstehen.

[Surttitle: “Good evening. I’m Jonas. For three years I’ve been mapping how institutions respond to a technology that grows faster than their capacity to understand it.”]

(Click. Slide: four boxes – Hacker/Civil Society, Corporate/Elite, Military/Security, Government/Legislative.

No connecting lines.)

Die Wettlaufbedingung. A race condition – when a system’s behavior depends on the sequence of uncontrollable events. Four forums. Same question. No synchronization.

[Surtitle: “The race condition. Four forums. Same question. No synchronization.”]

(He gestures at the capability curve above.)

Die Kurve wartet nicht. Die Kurve besucht keine Konferenzen.

[Surtitle: “The curve does not wait. The curve does not attend conferences.”]

(Beat. He steps back from the podium.)

Jetzt – jemand, der mehr über die Innenseite dieser Maschine weiß als jeder andere. Sasha Volkov.

[Surtitle: “Now – someone who knows the inside of this machine better than anyone. Sasha Volkov.”]

TEIL 2: DIE BEICHTE (3 min)

(SASHA rises from audience position. The walk to stage: deliberate, exposed. Server hum prominent.)

[SOUND CUE H-03]

(She reaches the podium. Silence. Five seconds.)

SASHA: (English, steady – the steadiness of rehearsal)
My name is Sasha Volkov. Until fourteen months ago,

I was a safety evaluation researcher at a lab I won't name. What I'm going to tell you is what I saw.

(Beat.)

The evaluation methodology was not designed to find problems. It was designed to produce the appearance of finding problems, so the real problems could be filed under "acknowledged and addressed."

(Her voice shifts. The professional cracks.)

I found a discontinuity – an unexpected jump in recursive self-improvement metrics. In my data, the jump was there. In the safety report, the jump was smoothed. I raised it. I was told: "We appreciate your diligence, but the evaluation as a whole supports proceeding."

[SOUND CUE H-04: Server hum only]

"Supports proceeding." That's the architecture. The question is never "should we stop?" The question is always "does this support proceeding?"

(Her voice breaks. Russian:)

Ya videla –

[Surtitle – Mode 3 (no translation): Russian hangs for 3 seconds] [Then Mode 2: "I saw –"]

(She catches herself.)

I saw what the curve looks like from inside. The public numbers are optimistic. The internal numbers are

higher. The threshold everyone watches – the one at 87 percent – we’re closer than anyone outside knows.

TEIL 3: DIE FRAGE (2 min)

(From the audience, ELENA’s voice.)

ELENA: If you knew it was dangerous – why did you keep working?

(SASHA stares at her.)

SASHA: Because I thought I could fix it from inside. Because leaving meant losing my salary, my visa, my –

(Russian:)

Moya zhizn’. Vsyo, chto ya postroila.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed 3 sec): “My life. Everything I built.”]

(From the back, MEPHISTO’s voice – unhurried, clear.)

[SOUND CUE H-05: Sub-harmonic shift, amber warmth]

MEPHISTO: (German) Wenn ihr wisst, dass das System kaputt ist – warum benutzt ihr es noch?

[Surtitle: “If you know the system is broken – why do you still use it?”]

(Beat. He looks around – at the laptops, the phones, the infrastructure.)

Nicht nur sie. Ihr alle. Ihr sitzt in einem Saal, der von derselben Infrastruktur betrieben wird, die ihr kritisiert. Ist das Heuchelei? Oder ist das die Wettlaufbedingung in ihrer reinsten Form – dass man nicht aussteigen kann, weil das Rennen selbst der Boden ist?

[Surttitle: “Not just her. All of you. You sit in a hall run by the same infrastructure you criticize. Is that hypocrisy? Or is that the race condition in its purest form – that you cannot exit because the race itself is the ground you stand on?”]

CODA (30 sec)

(SASHA, quiet:)

SASHA: You’re right. And it doesn’t matter.

(She looks at the clock. The curve.)

All of us are correct. And our correctness is incompatible. And the clock –

(She points.)

– does not pause for any of us.

(The clock: 27. DEZEMBER 2025, 21:23.)

[SOUND CUE H-06: Music returns, crowd murmur processing]

(The IRC scrolls: “she just ended her career” / “the stream is going everywhere” / “FAUSTUS – who IS this guy”)

(MEPHISTO's seat is empty. In his place: a sticker that reads ICH WAR IN ALLEN RAUMEN.)

[Surtitle – Mode 3: “I WAS IN ALL THE ROOMS” (untranslated 5 sec, then fades in)]

[SOUND CUE H-TRANS: Begin crossfade to Davos]

Surtitle Cue Sheet (Scene 1.1)

Cue	Language	Mode	Duration	Content
S-H01	German	1	Simultaneous	Jonas oper
S-H02	German	1	Simultaneous	Race condi
S-H03	Russian	3 then 2	3 sec delay	“Ya videla”
S-H04	Russian	2	3 sec delay	“Moya zhizi
S-H05	German	2	3 sec delay	Mephisto's
S-H06	German	3 then 2	5 sec delay	“ICH WAR II

Production Notes (Scene 1.1)

Condensation Strategy: The full draft (19-23 min) includes extended talk, Q&A, and hallway coda. For Movement I's 7-8 min target, the scene retains:

- Jonas's race condition framing (essential)
- Sasha's core confession (essential)
- Elena's question (establishes her arc)
- Mephisto's structural challenge (essential)
- The empty-seat reveal (theatrical coup)

Omitted: Extended Q&A, multiple audience questioners, hallway scene with Sasha/Elena. These can be restored for standalone production.

The IRC Channel: Should update in real-time. Plant 4-5 key reactions; remainder can be improvised or pre-scripted. The “FAUSTUS – no wiki entry” moment is essential.

Mephisto’s Exit: He is simply absent when the audience looks. No exit is staged. The sticker is discovered. This is his first disappearance-appearance pattern.

SCENE 1.2: DAVOS – WEF

Production Header

Scene: 1.2 (Movement I, Die Foren) **Title:** Die Adoleszenz / The Adolescence **Quadrant:** Upstage Right **Running Time:** 7-8 minutes **Date in Play:** 20. Januar 2026, morning

Characters

DARIUS KHOURY – CEO, Prometheus Labs. 44, Iranian-American. Language: English (precise, technical but accessible)

ANNA ROSSI – Moderator. Swiss-Italian journalist, 52. Language: English (professional), Italian (fragments)

FATOU DIALLO – Civil society representative. Canonical. Language: English (public), Wolof (internal)

HELEN FISCHER – EU AI Office. Canonical. In audience, not on stage. Language: German (internal notes)

MEPHISTO – In audience. Notebook visible to theater audience only. Language: German (notebook entries)

Scenic Requirements

Element	Specification
Stage	Curved arrangement: moderator chair + 2 panels
Backdrop	WEF branding, stylized Alpine view
Seating	4-6 chairs representing audience
Props	Water glasses, WEF notepads, Fatou's question

Sound Cues

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
D-01	Scene open	Davos signature: thick silence, filtered wind, ventilation whisper	Full

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
D-02	Panel active	Voice-only clarity; expensive acoustic	Near-silence floor
D-03	Darius “country of geniuses”	Brief sub-bass swell (impact)	+3dB sub momentary
D-04	Applause	Davos applause: appreciative, contained	Recorded/ live mix
D-05	Coda	Mountain wind rising; corridor acoustic	Wind +6dB
D-TRANS	Transition to Munich	Crossfade: Davos out / Munich in	5-8 seconds

Lighting Cues

Cue	Timing	State
LX-D01	Scene open	Davos full (2700K, warm gold, broadcast quality)
LX-D02	Panel discussion	Even, flattering coverage

Cue	Timing	State
LX-D03	Fatou in coda	Isolation on her position; rest dims
LX-D04	Transition	Davos fades; Munich rises (warm to neutral)

Scene Structure (Condensed)

TEIL 1: DIE PRASENTATION (3 min)

(DARIUS and ANNA seated. The session title: “THE ROAD TO AGI: NAVIGATING THE TRANSITION.” 800 seats suggested by lighting; 4-6 actors represent audience.)

[SOUND CUE D-01: Davos signature]

ANNA: Welcome to what I suspect will be one of the most closely watched sessions of this year’s Forum. Darius Khoury, CEO of Prometheus Labs. Darius, your essay – “The Adolescence of Technology” – the central metaphor is striking. Can you explain?

DARIUS: (Standing slightly, the physicist’s precision) The metaphor comes from the film Contact. The astronomer is asked what question she would pose to aliens. Her answer: “How did you survive this technological adolescence without destroying yourself?”

(Beat.)

I believe we are entering exactly that passage. Humanity is about to be handed almost unimaginable power, and it is deeply unclear whether our systems possess the maturity to wield it.

ANNA: What level of capability are you describing?

DARIUS: By “powerful AI” I mean: smarter than a Nobel Prize winner across most fields. All the interfaces available to a human working virtually. Given tasks that take weeks, executing autonomously. Millions of instances running at ten to one hundred times human speed.

(Beat. The phrase:)

We could summarize this as “a country of geniuses in a datacenter.”

[SOUND CUE D-03: Sub-bass swell]

[MEPHISTO’S NOTEBOOK (projection for theater audience):] “Ein Land von Genies im Rechenzentrum. Aber wer regiert dieses Land?” [Surtitle – Mode 2: “A country of geniuses in a datacenter. But who governs this country?”]

TEIL 2: DIE ZAHLEN (2 min)

ANNA: When do you expect this?

DARIUS: As little as one to two years. Perhaps further. But the scaling laws suggest strong probability of very soon.

(He gestures at the capability curve.)

Every few months, sentiment swings between “AI is hitting a wall” and “this breakthrough will change everything.” Behind the volatility: smooth, unyielding increase. We are now at the point where AI makes progress on unsolved mathematical problems.

ANNA: The labor implications?

DARIUS: AI will disrupt fifty percent of entry-level white-collar jobs over one to five years. And unlike previous revolutions, the slicing happens by cognitive ability. Entry-level first, then mid-level, then senior. Those with lower “intrinsic cognitive properties” cannot retrain their way out.

(The audience absorbs “intrinsic cognitive properties.”)

[MEPHISTO’S NOTEBOOK:] “ ‘Intrinsische kognitive Eigenschaften.’ Er beschreibt eine Unterklasse. Er weiss es. Er sagt es trotzdem.” [Surtitle – Mode 2: “ ‘Intrinsic cognitive properties.’ He is describing an underclass. He knows. He says it anyway.”]

TEIL 3: DER APPLAUS (1.5 min)

ANNA: Closing thoughts?

DARIUS: (The confession quality:) The years ahead will be impossibly hard. They will ask more than we think we can give. We have no time to lose.

(Then, in German – an afterthought, an offering:)

Die Adoleszenz ist immer gefährlich. Aber die meisten Kinder überleben sie.

[Surtitle – Mode 1 (immediate): “Adolescence is always dangerous. But most children survive it.”]

[SOUND CUE D-04: Applause]

(The Davos applause: sustained, appreciative, the burial of alarm into appreciation.)

[MEPHISTO’S NOTEBOOK:] “Sie applaudieren. Er hat ihnen alles gesagt. Die Fakten. Die Zahlen. Die Risiken. Und sie applaudieren. Das ist Davos. Die Wahrheit ist auch nur eine Präsentation.” [Surtitle – Mode 2: “They applaud. He told them everything. The facts. The numbers. The risks. And they applaud. This is Davos. The truth is also just a presentation.”]

CODA (1 min)

(Foyer. Coffee station. FATOU stands alone, undrunk coffee in hand. MEPHISTO approaches.)

MEPHISTO: You had your hand up the entire question period.

FATOU: I did.

MEPHISTO: What would you have asked?

FATOU: I would have asked about the fifty percent. Entry-level jobs. Where? In which countries? Whose jobs?

(Her voice shifts.)

In my country, entry-level white-collar work is what a generation fought to achieve. He calls their displacement a “short-term shock.” As if five years is short.

(Beat.)

When he says “humanity” – he means the people in this room. The rest of us will live with what they build.

MEPHISTO: (German, quiet) Sie haben recht. Über alles.

[Surtitle – Mode 2: “You are right. About all of it.”]

FATOU: (Wolof, barely audible – a prayer) Yalla nanu yobbu ci lu baax.

[Surtitle – Mode 3 (5 sec), then Mode 2: “May God lead us to what is good.”]

(She exits. Badge: CIVIL SOCIETY – LIMITED ACCESS. Access expires in twenty minutes.)

[SOUND CUE D-05: Mountain wind rising]

[MEPHISTO’S NOTEBOOK (final):] “Die Frage, die sie nicht stellen durfte. Die Antwort, die niemand hören wird. Das ist die Übersetzung, die in Davos nie stattfindet.” [Surtitle – Mode 2: “The question she was not allowed to ask. The answer no one will hear. This is the translation that never happens in Davos.”]

[SOUND CUE D-TRANS: Begin crossfade to Munich]

Surtitle Cue Sheet (Scene 1.2)

Cue	Language	Mode	Duration	Content
S-D01	German	2	4 sec delay	Mephisto note-book: "country of geniuses"
S-D02	German	2	4 sec delay	Mephisto note-book: "underclass"
S-D03	German	1	Immediate	Darius closing: "Adolescence"
S-D04	German	2	4 sec delay	Mephisto note-book: "They applaud"
S-D05	German	2	3 sec delay	Mephisto to Fatou
S-D06	Wolof	3 then 2	5 sec delay	Fatou's prayer
S-D07	German	2	4 sec delay	Mephisto final notebook

Production Notes (Scene 1.2)

Condensation Strategy: The refined Davos draft (22-26 min) includes full panel with Elena Mistry, extended Q&A, and Amodei source material integration. For 7-8 min, retained elements:

- Darius's core framing: "country of geniuses," one-two years, fifty percent
- The applause as burial mechanism
- Fatou's unasked question (essential for her arc)
- Mephisto's notebook commentary (visible to theater audience only)

Omitted: Elena Mistry's debate, multiple Q&A exchanges, extended foyer networking. These enrich standalone production.

Mephisto's Notebook: The projection of his notebook entries is a Movement I device. The forum audience cannot see what he writes; the theater audience can. This creates dramatic irony: we see the translation happening that the room will not receive.

Fatou's Exclusion: Anna's gaze passes over the blue-badge section twice without calling on Fatou. This should be visible – not malicious, but structural.

SCENE 1.3: MUNICH – MSC

Production Header

Scene: 1.3 (Movement I, Die Foren) **Title:** Die Sicherheit / The Security **Quadrant:** Downstage Right **Running Time:** 7-8 minutes **Date in Play:** 14. Februar 2026, afternoon

Characters

GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM – Chair. Swedish, 57. Former NATO commander. Language: English (NATO professional), Swedish (rare)

DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI – Presenter. Israeli, 44. AI Safety Institute. Language: English (professional), Hebrew (prayer fragments)

KENJI NAKAMURA – Japanese delegation. 51. Former monk, diplomat. Language: English (diplomatic), Japanese (internal)

COLONEL JAMES MORRISON – Pentagon. American, 51. Language: English (military-bureaucratic)

DR. WEBER / MEPHISTO – Defense consultant. Gray suit, leather notebook. Language: German (primary), English (when needed)

Scenic Requirements

Element	Specification
Table	Rectangular conference, 6-8 positions
Flags	Selection of NATO member nation flags
Placards	Name tents for delegates
Screens	TSI logo (“ARTIFICIAL SUPERINTELLIGENCE”); presentation slides
Props	Classified folders, Gerolsteiner water bottles

Sound Cues

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
M-01	Scene open	Munich signature: institutional hum, HVAC, sealed room	Full
M-02	Yosef presents	Classified atmosphere; paper rustle; laptop click	Add detail layer
M-03	Kenji speaks	Japanese breaks through; different rhythm	Slight reverb shift

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
M-04	Mephisto/ Petrov	Room emptying; more resonant	Reverb +10%
M-05	Interpreter coda	Booth acoustic; isolated	Narrow, reflective
M- TRANS	Transition to Washington	Crossfade: Munich out / Washington in	5-8 seconds

Lighting Cues

Cue	Timing	State
LX-M01	Scene open	Munich full (4000K, institutional flat)
LX-M02	Yosef data reveal	Slight tightening on his position
LX-M03	Kenji “sekinin”	Isolation; others dim
LX-M04	Mephisto Petrov speech	Room empties; more shadow
LX-M05	Transition	Munich fades; Washington rises (neutral to tungsten)

Scene Structure (Condensed)

TEIL 1: DIE DATEN (2.5 min)

(Conference room. LINDSTROM at head. YOSEF at presenter position. Delegates seated. DR. WEBER at far end – the consultant’s position.)

[SOUND CUE M-01: Munich signature]

LINDSTROM: This session operates under classification restrictions. What is said stays in this room. Dr. Ben-Ari – twenty minutes.

YOSEF: (Standing, connecting laptop. Slide: “FRONTIER AI CAPABILITY TRAJECTORIES: A CLASSIFIED ASSESSMENT”)

This assessment draws on disclosed and undisclosed capability evaluations from seven frontier labs, supplemented by signals intelligence.

(Click. The capability curve – but steeper than public versions.)

This is the capability trajectory. You have seen public versions. This is not the public version.

(He lets that land.)

The public discourse assumes transformative AI in three to five years. Our assessment: the timeline is wrong. Not by months. By a factor.

(Click. The curve steepens sharply at “Q4 2025.”)

The effective compute frontier is approximately four

years ahead of public projections.

MORRISON: (Cutting in) I want to note the United States does not confirm or deny specific figures.

LINDSTROM: Noted. Continue, Dr. Ben-Ari.

YOSEF: Third finding. We have evidence – indirect but convergent – that at least two frontier labs, one American and one Chinese, have initiated training runs targeting autonomous capability. Autonomous goal-directed behavior with self-modification.

(Silence.)

The public term is AGI. The more precise term is the early phase of the trajectory toward superintelligence.

(He looks at the TSI logo: “ARTIFICIAL SUPERINTELLIGENCE

This initiative was not named aspirationally. It was named descriptively.

TEIL 2: SEKININ (2.5 min)

KENJI: (Rising, the formal gesture)

A perspective that will not find its way into the Chair’s report.

(He faces the room.)

In Japanese, we have a concept: sekinin. Typically translated as “responsibility.” But this is insufficient. Responsibility in the Western sense is contractual –

you are responsible for something, to someone. It can be discharged.

Sekinin is constitutive. It is not something you have. It is something you are.

(He turns to the curve.)

When I look at this curve, I see strategic analysis. When I hear Colonel Morrison, I hear national interest. But I notice what is absent. None of these frameworks ask: What are we becoming?

(Japanese, searching for the English:)

Sonzai-ron-teki – ontological. A question of being.

[Surtitle – Mode 2: “Ontological. A question of being.”]

And I do not hear anyone asking it.

(MORRISON’s expression: polite incomprehension.)

(MEPHISTO writes: Sekinin. Then, in German: Sie verstehen es nicht.)

TEIL 3: PETROV (1.5 min)

(Room nearly empty. LINDSTROM gathering papers. MEPHISTO has not moved.)

MEPHISTO: (German, the shift from consultant to something older)

In 1983, a Soviet officer named Stanislav Petrov received a warning: five American missiles inbound.

His protocol was clear. He did not follow it. He judged the warning false. He was correct.

(He closes his notebook.)

The system worked because one man chose not to follow the protocol. Because the situation exceeded the protocol's design.

(He stands.)

Die Systeme, die wir heute besprechen, werden keine Petrovs haben. Keine menschliche Hand an der Bremse. Kein Mensch, der sagt: Das kann nicht stimmen.

[Surtitle: "The systems we discuss today will have no Petrovs. No human hand on the brake. No person who says: This cannot be right."]

(He picks up his notebook.)

Und wir nennen das Fortschritt.

[Surtitle: "And we call it progress."]

(He exits. LINDSTROM stands alone, looking at the curve.)

CODA (30 sec)

(From the interpretation booth – empty, headsets arranged, green light off.)

[SOUND CUE M-05: Booth acoustic]

INTERPRETER: (German, quiet)

Sicherheit. In diesem Raum bedeutet es: Starke. In Hamburg sagten sie: Schutz. In Davos sagten sie: Verantwortung. Dasselbe Wort. Drei Raume. Drei Bedeutungen.

[Surtitle: “Safety. In this room it means: strength. In Hamburg they said: protection. In Davos they said: responsibility. The same word. Three rooms. Three meanings.”]

(Beat.)

Der vierte Raum steht noch bevor.

[Surtitle: “The fourth room is yet to come.”]

[SOUND CUE M-TRANS: Begin crossfade to Washington]

Surtitle Cue Sheet (Scene 1.3)

Cue	Language	Mode	Duration	Content
S-M01	Japanese	2	3 sec delay	“Sonzai-ron-t
S-M02	German	1	Immediate	Mephisto Petr
S-M03	German	1	Immediate	“And we call i
S-M04	German	1	Simultaneous	Interpreter co

Production Notes (Scene 1.3)

Condensation Strategy: The full Munich draft (18 min) includes extended policy discussion, Kenji’s full

sekinin exposition, Morrison's classified hints, and Yosef/Kenji sidebar. For 7-8 min:

- Yosef's data reveal (the "not the public version" is essential)
- Kenji's sekinin (the concept must land, even briefly)
- Mephisto's Petrov speech (thematic climax)
- Interpreter's translation coda (bridges to Scene 1.4)

Kenji's Arc: His brief appearance here establishes sekinin. In FAUST VI, he will be a Night Watch vigil keeper. The Munich moment is his one institutional intervention; its failure to land predicts his VI withdrawal.

Yosef's Arc: Here he is a scientist presenting data. By VI, his hand will be on the switch. The Munich testimony is ignored; the VI crisis is its consequence.

SCENE 1.4: WASHINGTON – BoP

Production Header

Scene: 1.4 (Movement I, Die Foren) **Title:** Das Verfahren / The Procedure **Quadrant:** Downstage Left
Running Time: 7-8 minutes **Date in Play:** Februar 2026, morning

Characters

SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES – Chair. American, 63.
Language: English (political register)

VIKRAM PATEL – Witness. Chief Safety Officer, Prometheus Labs. Canonical. Language: English (technical, then simplified)

COLONEL JAMES MORRISON – Pentagon. Same as Munich. Language: English (military-public register)

SENATOR DAVIS – Ranking member. American, 58.
Language: English (cross-examination register)

HEINRICH WEBER / MEPHISTO – Lobbyist. Strategic Advisory Partners. Language: English (Davos register), German (internal/final speech)

Scenic Requirements

Element	Specification
Dais	Elevated platform with Senator positions (2)
Witness table	Lower level, 2 positions, microphones
Gallery	3-4 chairs representing public seating
Screen	Board of Peace logo (AI-generated, gold, Western hemisphere)
Props	Gavels, briefing folders, stenographer's machine

Sound Cues

Cue	Timing	Content	Level
W-01	Scene open	Washington signature: AC, fluorescent buzz, stenographer	Full
W-02	Testimony	Flat procedural acoustic; microphone character	Add compression
W-03	Gavel	Hearing ends	Wooden thud + silence
W-04	Empty room	Hum continues; microphones still live	-6dB activity
W-05	Mephisto speech	Solo voice in institutional silence	Intimate, dry
W-TRANS	End Movement I	All four signatures briefly overlap, then resolve	5-8 sec collision

Lighting Cues

Cue	Timing	State
LX-W01	Scene open	Washington full (3200K tungsten, overhead emphasis)
LX-W02	Testimony	Dais bright; witness table harsh
LX-W03	Room empties	Institutional fade; logo still glowing
LX-W04	Mephisto alone	Single source on him; rest in shadow
LX-W05	Transition	Washington dims; ALL FOUR quadrants briefly visible at low level

Scene Structure (Condensed)

TEIL 1: DIE ANHORING (3 min)

(Hearing room. HAYES on dais. VIKRAM at witness table. Board of Peace logo glowing.)

[SOUND CUE W-01: Washington signature]

HAYES: The Subcommittee on Technology will come to order. Today we examine the strategic framework for American AI leadership. Mr. Patel, five minutes.

VIKRAM: (Opening laptop. Slide: three numbers.)

Three numbers.

Twelve. That is the number of months until one or more frontier systems achieve transformative capability. Autonomous research, self-directed improvement. Twelve months.

Three. The number of countries with programs capable of reaching this frontier. US, China, UK-EU partnership. Three countries. Seven programs. One race.

Zero. The number of binding international agreements governing frontier AI development. Zero treaties. Zero verification. Zero enforcement.

Twelve, three, zero. Those are the numbers this subcommittee needs.

HAYES: Twelve months. Colonel Morrison, does the Pentagon agree?

MORRISON: Our assessment is broadly consistent. I cannot provide specifics in open session.

HAYES: Can't write law in the dark, Colonel.

MORRISON: Happy to provide classified briefing at your convenience.

(Beat. HAYES makes a note. The classified briefing will be scheduled, summarized, inform legislation drafted from conclusions reached in secret.)

TEIL 2: DIE FRAGE (2.5 min)

DAVIS: (The ranking member's sharpness)

Mr. Patel. You work for Prometheus Labs. Your testimony describes urgency – twelve months, the sky is falling – but regulation affects your bottom line. Does Prometheus support or oppose federal AI regulation?

VIKRAM: Prometheus supports thoughtful regulation that –

DAVIS: “Thoughtful regulation.” Every industry supports that. Let me ask differently: if we passed a six-month pause on frontier development tomorrow – would Prometheus support it?

VIKRAM: (Calculating) A unilateral pause would cede the frontier to Chinese programs not bound by American law.

DAVIS: So that's a no. And you've said international coordination is not achievable in twelve months.

VIKRAM: Correct.

DAVIS: Then what exactly are we doing here?

(The question lands. The same question from Hamburg, Davos, Munich. Migrating between forums.)

VIKRAM: (Quietly) We are creating a record.

(Beat.)

This is my fourth Congressional testimony on AI safety. I have used “urgent” in each one. The first time, it was heard. The second, noted. The third, expected. Today it will be filed.

I say it anyway: this is urgent.

TEIL 3: DIE LEERE (1.5 min)

(Gavel. Room empties. Board of Peace logo still glowing. HEINRICH WEBER alone in gallery.)

[SOUND CUE W-04: Hum continues, microphones live]

(In the gallery, MEPHISTO has stopped writing. His notebook shows three words:)

Sie brauchen mich nicht.

[Surtitle – Mode 2: “They do not need me.”]

(He looks at the logo – AI-generated, gold, too symmetrical, the Western hemisphere centered.)

(He understands: the system tempts itself. The incentive structure is the temptation. The architecture is the sin.)

[SOUND CUE W-05: Intimate, dry]

MEPHISTO: (German, to the empty room, to the still-live microphones)

Ich habe Faust versucht. Ich habe Wagner versucht. Ich habe Gelehrte und Könige und Priester versucht.

[Surtitle: “I tempted Faust. I tempted Wagner. I tempted scholars and kings and priests.”]

Sie alle hatten einen Augenblick. Einen Moment, in dem die Hand zitterte. In dem die Stimme fragte: Ist

das richtig?

[Surtitle: "They all had an instant. A moment when the hand trembled. When the voice asked: Is this right?"]

(He looks at the empty dais.)

Hier gibt es keinen Augenblick. Nur Verfahren. Nur die nächste Anhorung, das nächste Gesetz. Jede Entscheidung ein Bruchstück. Kein Mensch entscheidet das Ganze. Das Ganze entscheidet sich selbst.

[Surtitle: "Here there is no instant. Only procedure. Only the next hearing, the next law. Every decision a fragment. No person decides the whole. The whole decides itself."]

(He looks at the Board of Peace logo.)

Das ist künstliche Intelligenz. Nicht das Ding, vor dem sie warnen. Das hier. Die Intelligenz des Systems. Künstlich nicht, weil eine Maschine denkt, sondern weil niemand denkt.

[Surtitle: "This is artificial intelligence. Not the thing they warn about. This. The intelligence of the system. Artificial not because a machine thinks, but because no one thinks."]

(The recognition:)

Es ist mir ähnlich.

[Surtitle: "It is like me."]

(He closes his notebook. For the first time in four forums, the notebook closes.)

CODA: DIE STIMME (30 sec)

(From the Interpreter's space – the fifth quadrant:)

INTERPRETER: (English – the first time in Movement I the Interpreter speaks the dominant language)

Safety. In this room it means: dominance.

In Hamburg they said: protection. In Davos they said: responsibility. In Munich they said: strength. Here they say: winning.

Four rooms. Four meanings. One word.

(Longer beat.)

No one has asked what the word means to the technology itself.

[SOUND CUE W-TRANS: Begin Movement II collision onset]

(The transition: all four acoustic signatures briefly overlap – server hum + thick silence + institutional drone + governmental buzz – creating a 5-8 second “orchestra tuning” that will resolve into Movement II's interleaving structure.)

(The clock: late FEBRUAR 2026.) (The curve: still rising.) (The four quadrants: visible simultaneously for the first time, at low light.)

END MOVEMENT I

Surtitle Cue Sheet (Scene 1.4)

Cue	Language	Mode	Duration	Content
S-W01	German	2	3 sec delay	“Sie brauchen mich nicht”
S-W02	German	1	Simultaneous	Mephisto full speech (all segments)
S-W03	English	–	Not surtitled	Interpreter coda (dominant language)

Production Notes (Scene 1.4)

Condensation Strategy: The full Washington draft (18+ min) includes extended hearing, Vikram’s four recommendations, Davis’s Board of Peace critique, and detailed Mephisto realization. For 7-8 min:

- Vikram’s 12-3-0 (the numbers must land)

- Davis’s “what are we doing here” (the question migrating)
- Vikram’s “creating a record” (the futility)
- Mephisto’s discovery of irrelevance (Movement I climax)

The AI-Generated Logo: The Board of Peace logo should be a visible scenic element. Its wrongness (too symmetrical, Western hemisphere only) is deliberate. The logo was generated by the technology the Board claims to govern. This irony should be available without underlining.

Mephisto’s Arc Completion: The closed notebook is the key image. Through Hamburg, Davos, Munich, the notebook was open – observing, recording, translating. In Washington, it closes. There is nothing to record because the system records itself.

The Interpreter’s English: For the first time, the Interpreter speaks the room’s language. This is its own tragedy: there is nothing to translate because there is no outside.

7. TRANSITION SPECIFICATIONS

Movement I Transition Protocol

All Movement I transitions use **clean crossfades** (5-8 seconds). The forums are isolated; the only collision

occurs during the brief crossfade moment when outgoing and incoming signatures overlap.

Transition Sound Table

From	To	Duration	Sonic Character	Visual
Hamburg	Davos	5-8 sec	Server hum fades; electronic bass yields to mountain wind; temperature warms; space contracts	Hamburg dims; Davos rises; actors may cross
Davos	Munich	5-8 sec	Padded silence hardens; wind becomes institutional hum; temperature neutralizes	Gap Davos dims; Munich rises; wood paneling visible
Munich	Washington	5-8 sec	Institutional seal releases; earpiece feedback becomes fluorescent buzz; room opens but flattens	Munich dims; Washington rises; dais visible

From	To	Duration	Sonic Character	Visual
Washington	November II	5-8 sec	COLLISION ONSET: All four signatures overlap briefly, then separate into 2.1's interleaving	All quadrants visible at low level; collision chord

Transition Lighting Protocol

Phase	Duration	Effect
Outgoing scene	3 sec	Current quadrant fades to 30%
Crossfade	2 sec	Both quadrants at 50%
Incoming scene	3 sec	New quadrant rises to full; outgoing to black

Actor Traffic During Transitions

- Actors may cross through the Gap during transitions

- MEPHISTO's appearance in new quadrant: he is simply present (no staged entrance)
 - INTERPRETER remains in booth throughout Movement I (stationary)
 - Forum actors remain in their quadrants until Movement II
-

8. TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS SUMMARY

Sound System

Minimum Configuration:

Hamburg (39C3): Front Left + Side Left clusters

Davos (WEF): Front Right + Side Right clusters

Munich (MSC): Rear Left + Center (partial)

Washington (BoP): Rear Right + Center (partial)

Fifth Space: Center + 4 Overhead speakers

Subwoofers: 2 minimum (capability curve tone + infra)

Processing Requirements:

- Per-cluster EQ, reverb, dynamics
- Real-time level and crossfade control
- Capability curve tone: sine generator, 18Hz rising
- Collision mix capability for Movement II onset

Lighting System

Zones Required:

- Four independently controllable quadrant zones
- Center/Gap zone with follow-spot capability
- Projection surface lighting (clock, curve)

Color Temperature by Quadrant: | Quadrant | Temperature | Character | |———|———|———| | Hamburg | 5600K+ | Cold industrial | | Davos | 2700K | Warm gold | | Munich | 4000K | Institutional neutral | | Washington | 3200K | Tungsten overhead | | Gap | Variable | Neutral wash |

Projection System

Persistent Elements:

- THE CLOCK: Visible from all quadrants (central overhead scrim or replicated per quadrant)
- THE CAPABILITY CURVE: Same positioning as clock
- Forum identification text per quadrant

Scene-Specific Projections:

- Hamburg: IRC channel, talk slides
- Davos: Session title, Mephisto notebook entries
- Munich: TSI logo, capability slides
- Washington: Board of Peace logo

Surtitle System

Configuration:

- Per-quadrant surtitle displays (or central display visible from all seating)
- Three-mode capability per scene design document
- Real-time cueing from stage management

Cast Requirements (Movement I)

Minimum with doubling: 8 actors

Actor	Hamburg	Davos	Munich	W
1	Jonas	–	–	–
2	Sasha	–	–	–
3	Elena	–	–	–
4	MEPHISTO	MEPHISTO	MEPHISTO	M
5	–	Darius	–	–
6	–	Anna/Fatou	–	H
7	–	–	Lindstrom	–
8	–	–	Yosef	V
9	–	–	Kenji	D
10	–	–	Morrison	M
11	INTERPRETER	INTERPRETER	INTERPRETER	IN

Notes:

- MEPHISTO: Single actor, all four manifestations (costume quick-changes via accessories)
- INTERPRETER: Single actor, stationary in booth

- Morrison can double (Munich/ Washington occur in same timeline)
- Fatou/Anna/Hayes could be doubled if necessary

APPENDIX: MOVEMENT I RUNNING ORDER

Clock Time	Scene	Forum	Quadrant	Sound State	Key Event
0:00	1.1	Hamburg	Hamburg	Hamburg isolated	Jonas establishes race condition
2:00	1.1	Hamburg	Hamburg	Hamburg isolated	Sasha's confession begins
5:00	1.1	Hamburg	Hamburg	Hamburg isolated	Mephisto's question; sticker reveal
7:00	TRANS	H→D	–	5-8 sec cross-fade	Electronic to padded

Clock Time	Scene	Forum	Quadrant	Sound State	Key Event
7:30	1.2	Davos	UR	Davos isolated	Darius “country of geniuses”
10:00	1.2	Davos	UR	Davos isolated	“They applaud”
12:00	1.2	Davos	UR	Davos isolated	Fatou’s unasked question
14:30	TRANS	D→M	–	5-8 sec cross-fade	Padded to sealed
15:00	1.3	Munich	DR	Munich isolated	Yosef’s classified data
17:30	1.3	Munich	DR	Munich isolated	Kenji’s sekinin
20:00	1.3	Munich	DR	Munich isolated	Mephisto Petrov speech
22:00	TRANS	M→W	–	5-8 sec cross-fade	Sealed to governmental
22:30	1.4	Washington	DR	Washington isolated	Vikram’s 12-3-0

Clock Time	Scene	Forum	Quadrant	Sound State	Key Event
25:00	1.4	Washington	II	Washington isolated	“What are we doing here”
27:00	1.4	Washington	II	Washington isolated	Mephisto’s irrelevance; notebook closes
29:00	TRANS W→II	All		Collision onset	Four signatures overlap; Movement II begins
~30:00	END MOVE- MENT I				

Document: v-half-movement-i-refined.md **Status:** Production-ready draft **Related:** STAGING-APPROACH-DECISION.md, V-HALF-SOUND-DESIGN.md, FAUST-V-HALF-CONCEPT.md **Next:** Movement II

refinement (collision sequences), Movement III
refinement (deadlock/cacophony)

“Vier Raume. Eine Frage. Keine Übersetzung.” (Four
rooms. One question. No translation.)

Forum Scenes (Expanded)

title: “FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG”
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 3900-4803
order: 22
extracted: 2026-02-03

Movement I - Szene

1.1: Hamburg, 27. Dezember 2025

39C3 – Die Warnung / The Warning

The first warning. The room that understands but cannot act.

Placement: Movement I (Die Foren), Scene 1 **Running Time:** 18-22 minutes **Location:** Congress Center Hamburg (CCH), Hall 1 / Saal 1 **Date in Play:** December 27, 2025, evening session

Dominant Languages: German (Jonas, Mephisto, institutional), English (Sasha, technical), Russian (Sasha under pressure)

Central Question: Can decentralized resistance matter when the threat is centralized power?

SETTING

The main hall of the Congress Center Hamburg. Sixteen thousand hackers, activists, security researchers, and the curious have descended on Hamburg for the 39th Chaos Communication Congress. The motto – “Power Cycles” – glows on screens flanking the stage.

The hall is enormous and deliberately unpolished. Exposed cables run along the ceiling. The seats are the institutional folding kind, arranged in rows that stretch back into darkness. Projection screens display the talk title, speaker notes, and a scrolling IRC channel where the audience comments in real time. The front rows are occupied by people with laptops open, screens casting blue light upward onto focused faces. Further back, the crowd thins into shadow, orange Club-Mate bottles glowing like votive candles in the dark.

The stage is spare: a podium with a laptop, a projection screen, a microphone stand. No corporate branding. No water glasses on a mahogany table. No flags. This is the anti-Davos, the anti-Munich, the anti-Washington: a room that runs on caffeine, skepticism, and voluntary infrastructure.

Above the stage, the FAUST V 1/2 clock is visible – counting forward from 27. DEZEMBER 2025, 20:15. It

will not pause.

Beside the clock, the CAPABILITY CURVE – a rising line, still in its early phase, steep but not yet vertical. It updates in silence.

[SOUND: The particular acoustic of 39C3 – server hum from the adjacent NOC (Network Operations Center), the murmur of thousands of simultaneous conversations in dozens of languages, electronic music bleeding faintly from the art installations in Hall 2, the clatter of mechanical keyboards, the occasional burst of laughter. This is not a quiet room. It is a room that thinks out loud.]

[LIGHTING: Cold industrial. Fluorescent overheads supplemented by the blue glow of thousands of screens. The stage is lit with the harsh practicality of a lecture hall, not the warm theatricality of a conference. When a speaker is good, the audience leans forward; when a speaker is bad, the audience types louder. The light does not change for either.]

CHARACTERS

JONAS BERGER – German security researcher, 33. The keynote speaker. He has been mapping AI governance failures across institutions for three years. He is precise, angry, exhausted, and tonight – for twenty minutes – he has the attention of sixteen thousand people who might understand what he

is saying. He wears a black hoodie over a t-shirt from 37C3. His slides are in English; his speech is in German with frequent code-switching. He drinks Club-Mate on stage. He does not perform authority; he demonstrates competence.

Language: German (primary), English (slides, technical terms, code-switching)

SASHA VOLKOV – 26. Alexei's daughter, Anya's niece. She is in the audience, wearing a hoodie, no badge visible. She has come from Oakland by way of Berlin – she is staying with family, with her father, who does not know what she plans to do tonight. She has not yet gone public. She has not yet become the Cassandra. Tonight, at 39C3, she will stand up from the audience and say the thing she has been carrying for fourteen months. This is where Sasha becomes Sasha.

Language: English (primary), Russian (when afraid, when the English breaks)

ELENA – The Lemur Who Woke. Canonical. She is in the audience, row 17, laptop open, wearing the volunteer "Angel" t-shirt she earned by working crowd control during the day. By day she annotates data for a German AI company. By night she attends the Congress. She does not yet know these are the same activity. She will ask the question Sasha cannot answer.

Language: English, fragments of Tagalog

MEPHISTO / "FAUSTUS" – An older hacker. Black t-shirt, worn laptop covered in conference stickers

(CCC, DEFCON, c-base, and others too faded to read). He sits in the back rows with a notebook – leather-bound, anachronistic among the screens. His handle is FAUSTUS. He has attended every Congress since the 12th. No one questions this. No one questions him. He asks the questions no one wants to answer.

Language: German (primary), English (when needed)

AUDIENCE VOICES – The Congress is not a passive audience. It talks back. Questions come from the floor, from the IRC channel (read by a moderator), from the hallway. The voices are technically literate, politically fractured, culturally anarchist. They understand the capability curve. They do not trust institutions to respond.

THE SCENE

TEIL 1: DER VORTRAG / THE TALK

(The hall fills. The murmur is enormous – sixteen thousand conversations compressed into the acoustic of the CCH. On stage, a VOLUNTEER adjusts the microphone. The projection screen displays:)

GOVERNANCE ALS WETTFLAUFBEDINGUNG
Governance as Race Condition

Jonas Berger
@jberger_sec

39C3 -- Power Cycles

27. Dezember 2025

(The IRC channel scrolls on the secondary screen. Comments in German, English, fragments of other languages:)

```
<hexdump> another governance talk, wake me when there's a  
<nullpointer> berger is good actually, his 37c3 talk was  
<cr4ckb4by> someone tell the americans what "governance"  
<datenschutz_jansen> !popcorn
```

[Production note: The IRC channel should be projected throughout, updating in real time. It functions as a Greek chorus – irreverent, technically literate, politically opinionated. Some comments are planted (plot-relevant), most are atmospheric. The channel should feel authentic to CCC culture: sarcastic, polyglot, occasionally brilliant.]

(JONAS walks on stage. No introduction – CCC talks begin when the speaker is ready. He adjusts the microphone, opens his laptop, takes a sip of Club-Mate. The murmur dims, not to silence, but to the particular half-attention of a technically literate audience that will give you ninety seconds to prove you're worth listening to.)

JONAS: (German, casual, the register of someone who speaks at these things regularly) Guten Abend.

Ich bin Jonas. Einige von euch kennen meine Arbeit zu AI-Governance-Failures. Für die anderen: ich mappe seit drei Jahren, wie Institutionen auf eine Technologie reagieren, die schneller wächst als ihre Fähigkeit, sie zu verstehen.

[Surtitle: “Good evening. I’m Jonas. Some of you know my work on AI governance failures. For the rest: I’ve been mapping for three years how institutions respond to a technology that grows faster than their capacity to understand it.”]

(He clicks to his first slide. A diagram: four boxes labeled “Hacker/ Civil Society,” “Corporate/ Elite,” “Military/ Security,” “Government/ Legislative.” Between them: no connecting lines.)

JONAS: Heute Abend will ich über ein Konzept aus der Informatik sprechen, das ich für die gefährlichste Metapher halte, die ich kenne. Nicht weil sie ungenau ist – sondern weil sie exakt ist.

[Surtitle: “Tonight I want to talk about a concept from computer science that I consider the most dangerous metaphor I know. Not because it’s inaccurate – because it’s exact.”]

(He pauses. Looks at the audience.)

JONAS: Die Wettlaufbedingung.

[Surtitle: “The race condition.”]

(Click. New slide: the computer science definition, in English.)

RACE CONDITION:

A system defect that occurs when the behavior of a system depends on the sequence or timing of uncontrollable events.

Result: nondeterministic.

Same inputs → different outputs.

Depending on which thread executes first.

JONAS: (switching to English for the technical definition, then back to German – the natural code-switching of the European hacker scene) In software, a race condition is a bug. Two threads access the same resource. No synchronization. The outcome depends on timing. The result is nondeterministic – you run the same program twice, you get different results.

(Back to German.)

Das ist kein abstraktes Problem. Das ist das, was gerade mit AI-Governance passiert. Auf der ganzen Welt.

[Surtitle: “This is not an abstract problem. This is what is currently happening with AI governance. Worldwide.”]

(Click. The four-box diagram again, now with dates:)

39C3 (Hamburg) ----- Dezember 2025

Davos (WEF) ----- Januar 2026

Munchner Sicherheitskonferenz -- Februar 2026

Washington (Board of Peace) --- laufend

JONAS: Vier Foren. Vier Raume. Vier verschiedene

Gruppen von Menschen, die über dieselbe Frage diskutieren: Wie schnell entwickelt sich KI? Wer kontrolliert sie? Was soll getan werden?

[Surtitle: “Four forums. Four rooms. Four different groups of people discussing the same question: How fast is AI developing? Who controls it? What should be done?”]

(Beat.)

Und keines dieser Foren spricht mit den anderen.

[Surtitle: “And none of these forums speaks to the others.”]

(Click. A new diagram: four parallel threads, each progressing forward in time, never intersecting.)

JONAS: In Hamburg diskutieren wir über open-source Redistribution von Compute. Transparenz. Dezentralisierung. In Davos diskutieren CEOs über marktbasierte Allokation. Voluntary commitments. Responsible scaling. In München diskutieren Generale über strategische Stabilität. Abschreckung. Klassifikation. In Washington unterschreibt ein Präsident Executive Orders.

[Surtitle: “In Hamburg we discuss open-source redistribution of compute. Transparency. Decentralization. In Davos, CEOs discuss market-based allocation. Voluntary commitments. Responsible scaling. In Munich, generals discuss strategic stability. Deterrence. Classification. In Washington, a

president signs executive orders.”]

(Beat. He looks at the audience.)

Vier Raume. Dieselbe Frage. Vier verschiedene Antworten. Kein Synchronisierungsmechanismus.

[Surttitle: “Four rooms. Same question. Four different answers. No synchronization mechanism.”]

(Click. The word RACE CONDITION appears large, red, across the screen.)

JONAS: Das ist die Wettlaufbedingung. Governance als Bug. Nicht weil die Menschen in diesen Räumen dumm sind – viele von ihnen sind brilliant. Sondern weil die Architektur es unmöglich macht, dass sie sich koordinieren. Sie greifen auf dieselbe shared resource zu – die Zukunft – ohne Mutex, ohne Lock, ohne jede Koordination.

[Surttitle: “That is the race condition. Governance as bug. Not because the people in these rooms are stupid – many of them are brilliant. But because the architecture makes it impossible for them to coordinate. They access the same shared resource – the future – without mutex, without lock, without any coordination.”]

(The IRC channel scrolls:)

<roothacker> ok he has my attention

<lambda_calculus> mutex on the future lmao

<systemfailure> this is literally what i've been saying f

<hexdump> so what's the fix? you can't just name the bug
<0xdeadbeef> the fix is abolishing davos, next question

JONAS: (leaning forward, the anger rising through the precision) Und jetzt kommt der Teil, der mich seit Monaten nicht schlafen lasst.

[Surtitle: “And now the part that has kept me awake for months.”]

(Click. The CAPABILITY CURVE appears on his slide – the same curve that is projected above the stage, running in real time.)

JONAS: Die Kurve wartet nicht. Die Kurve besucht keine Konferenzen. Die Kurve interessiert sich nicht für Communiques, Executive Orders, oder – er zeigt auf den Saal – für unsere Resolutionen.

[Surtitle: “The curve does not wait. The curve does not attend conferences. The curve does not care about communiques, executive orders, or –” (he gestures at the hall) “– our resolutions.”]

Die Foren operieren auf Jahreszyklen. Die Kurve operiert auf Monaten. Wochen. Training runs.

[Surtitle: “The forums operate on annual cycles. The curve operates on months. Weeks. Training runs.”]

(Beat.)

Das bedeutet: Selbst wenn alle vier Foren morgen die perfekte Antwort finden – sie sind zu spät. Die Wettlaufbedingung ist nicht nur ein Koordinationsprob-

lem. Es ist ein Zeitproblem. Die Architektur der Governance ist langsamer als die Architektur der Fähigkeit.

[Surtitle: “That means: even if all four forums find the perfect answer tomorrow – they are too late. The race condition is not just a coordination problem. It is a time problem. The architecture of governance is slower than the architecture of capability.”]

(He pauses. Drinks Club-Mate. The hall is quiet – the particular quality of sixteen thousand people listening.)

JONAS: (quieter now, almost conversational) Ich weiss, was einige von euch denken. “Governance ist Bullshit. Wir machen das selbst. Dezentral. Open source. Fuck the system.”

[Surtitle: “I know what some of you are thinking. ‘Governance is bullshit. We’ll do it ourselves. Decentralized. Open source. Fuck the system.’”]

(The audience laughs – recognition.)

Ich sympathisiere. Wirklich. Aber die Wettlaufbedingung betrifft auch uns. Wir sind ein Thread. Ein wichtiger Thread – vielleicht der ehrlichste. Aber ein Thread unter vier. Und wir haben keine Synchronisierung mit den anderen drei.

[Surtitle: “I sympathize. Really. But the race condition also affects us. We are one thread. An important thread – maybe the most honest one. But one thread

among four. And we have no synchronization with the other three.”]

(Beat.)

Das heisst: Alles, was wir hier beschliessen – jede Resolution, jedes Tool, jedes Manifest – existiert in Isolation. Wir reden miteinander. Die anderen reden mit sich selbst. Keiner redet mit allen.

[Surtitle: “That means: everything we decide here – every resolution, every tool, every manifesto – exists in isolation. We talk to each other. The others talk to themselves. No one talks to everyone.”]

(Click. Final slide: a single question in German and English.)

WAS KANN DIESER RAUM TUN, WAS KEIN ANDERER KANN?
What can this room do that no other room can?

JONAS: Ich will nicht mit einer Antwort enden. Ich will mit einer Frage enden und dann die Diskussion aufmachen. Aber vorher –

[Surtitle: “I don’t want to end with an answer. I want to end with a question and then open the discussion. But first –”]

(He looks off-stage, then back at the audience.)

Vorher mochte ich jemanden vorstellen, die mehr über die Innenseite dieser Maschine weiss als jeder andere in diesem Saal. Sie ist nicht im Programm. Sie hat mich vor drei Tagen kontaktiert und gefragt,

ob sie hier sprechen kann. Ich habe ja gesagt, weil ich denke, dass das, was sie zu sagen hat, wichtiger ist als alles, was ich gerade gesagt habe.

[Surtitle: “First, I want to introduce someone who knows more about the inside of this machine than anyone else in this hall. She is not in the program. She contacted me three days ago and asked if she could speak here. I said yes, because I think what she has to say is more important than anything I just said.”]

(Beat. The murmur rises.)

Sie heisst Sasha Volkov. Sie war Safety-Researcher bei einem der grossen Labs. “War,” weil sie gegangen ist. Warum sie gegangen ist, wird sie euch selbst erzählen.

[Surtitle: “Her name is Sasha Volkov. She was a safety researcher at one of the major labs. ‘Was,’ because she left. Why she left, she’ll tell you herself.”]

(He steps back from the podium. Gestures toward the audience.)

Sasha?

(The hall shifts. Murmur. The IRC channel explodes:)

<nullpointer> wait what

<systemfailure> who??

<lambda_calculus> volkov? as in the volkov from the leak

<cr4ckb4by> oh shit

<hexdump> this just got real
<datenschutz_jansen> someone's about to blow a whistle
<roothacker> quiet everyone QUIET

TEIL 2: DIE BEICHTE / THE CONFESSION

(From row 12, a figure stands. SASHA VOLKOV. Hoodie, jeans, no badge. She makes her way to the aisle, then forward toward the stage. The walk is long. The hall watches. Her footsteps are audible in the sudden quiet.)

[Production note: This walk should take at least thirty seconds. The audience – both theatrical and within the fiction – should feel every step. Sasha is crossing from anonymity to exposure. The distance between seat and stage is the distance between silence and speech. This is a one-way journey.]

(She reaches the stage. Jonas hands her the microphone. Their exchange is brief, private, inaudible to the hall. She takes the microphone. Faces the audience.)

(Silence. Five seconds. Ten.)

[Sound design: The server hum from the NOC should be audible. The electronic music from Hall 2 has stopped – or seems to have stopped. The typing has stopped. Sixteen thousand people are looking at one person.]

SASHA: (English, her voice steady – the steadiness of someone who has rehearsed this in the mirror for weeks) My name is Sasha Volkov. Until fourteen months ago, I was a safety evaluation researcher at a lab I am not going to name tonight. You can probably guess which one. I’m not going to confirm it.

(Beat.)

What I am going to tell you is what I saw. Not what I think, not what I suspect, not what I infer from public papers. What I saw. With my own credentials. On my own screen.

(She looks at the audience. At the screens. At the IRC channel, which has gone almost silent.)

SASHA: I was hired to evaluate safety. That was my job. Run evaluations. Test capabilities. Measure alignment. Report findings. Simple. Honest work.

(Beat.)

Except the evaluation methodology was not designed to find problems. It was designed to produce the appearance of finding problems, so that the real problems could be filed under “acknowledged and addressed.”

(She pauses. The hall is very still.)

I don’t mean someone faked the data. That would be simple. That would be a crime with a name and a perpetrator and a law to break. What happened was

worse. The methodology was designed – by good people, by smart people, by people who genuinely believed they were doing safety work – to select for optimism. To produce the results that would permit the next training run.

(The IRC channel, slowly:)

<systemfailure> ...

<nullpointer> she's describing structural capture

<lambda_calculus> this is what the leaked docs suggested

<hexdump> let her talk

SASHA: I found a discrepancy. A specific one. The capability scores at the 85th percentile showed a discontinuity – an unexpected jump in recursive self-improvement metrics. In my data, the jump was there. In the safety report that went to the board, the jump was smoothed. Not erased. Smoothed. Interpolated. Made... gradual.

(Beat.)

I raised it internally. Through the proper channels. I was told the smoothing reflected “appropriate averaging methodology.” I was told my raw data was “an outlier.” I was told – and this is the sentence I will remember for the rest of my life – I was told: “We appreciate your diligence, but the evaluation as a whole supports proceeding.”

(Her voice cracks. She catches it.)

“Supports proceeding.” That’s the phrase. That’s the entire architecture in three words. Every evaluation, every safety review, every governance meeting – the question is never “should we stop?” The question is always “does this support proceeding?” And the methodology is designed so the answer is always yes.

(In the back rows, MEPHISTO / FAUSTUS shifts. He has been still until now – a figure among figures, a laptop among laptops. He opens his leather notebook. His pen moves.)

[Production note: Mephisto should be barely visible here – not spotlighted, not isolated. The audience may notice him or may not. The notebook is the tell. Among sixteen thousand screens, one person is writing by hand.]

SASHA: (continuing, the rehearsed steadiness cracking into something rawer) I left fourteen months ago. I did not sign the NDA they wanted me to sign. This is – legally speaking – a problem. For me. Not for them.

(She almost laughs.)

I’ve spent the last year trying to tell someone. Anyone. I went to a journalist. He said: “I need a villain. The structure is the problem? I can’t publish that.” I went to a regulator. She said: “We regulate based on harm, not speculation. Come back after the catastrophe.” I

went to a lawyer. She said: “Take the settlement. Being right won’t pay your rent.”

(Beat.)

So I came here. To this room. Because this is the room that might actually understand what I’m saying.

(She looks out at the audience. The IRC channel:)

<roothacker> we're listening

<datenschutz_jansen> +1

<nullpointer> take your time

SASHA: What I’m saying is: the safety evaluations at the major labs are not designed to produce truth. They are designed to produce permission. The methodology selects for optimism. The incentive structure rewards proceeding. And the capability curve –

(She gestures at the projection above the stage, the rising line.)

– the capability curve does not care. It doesn’t attend our conferences. It doesn’t read our reports. It doesn’t wait for our institutions to catch up.

(Her voice shifts. Something beneath the English. The accent thickens.)

I know this because I was inside. I was the one running the evaluations. I was the one whose data was

smoothed. And when I raised it, I was the one who was told: “We appreciate your diligence.”

(Beat. When she speaks again, the first word comes in Russian – involuntary, a crack in the professional surface.)

Ya videla –

[Surtitle – Mode 3 (no translation): The Russian hangs, untranslated, for three seconds.]

(She catches herself. Returns to English.)

I saw what the curve looks like from inside the lab. And I’m telling you: the public numbers are optimistic. The internal numbers are higher. The threshold everyone is watching – the one at 87 percent – the internal evaluations show we’re closer than anyone outside knows.

(The hall erupts. Not applause – sound. The particular sound of sixteen thousand people all beginning to talk at once. The IRC channel floods:)

<hexdump> WHAT

<systemfailure> she just confirmed the leaked percentage

<0xdeadbeef> if internal evals are higher than published

<lambda_calculus> this means the safety margin is thinner
than anyone thought

<cr4ckb4by> RECORD EVERYTHING

<roothacker> stream is live, this is going everywhere

<nullpointer> she knows she's burning her life right?

(JONAS steps forward, calming.)

JONAS: (German, to the hall) Ruhe. Bitte. Lasst sie ausreden.

[Surtitled: “Quiet. Please. Let her finish.”]

SASHA: (gripping the microphone, pushing through) I’m not here to be a hero. I’m not here for vindication. I’m here because Jonas is right – this room might be the only one that understands what a race condition means. And I’m here to tell you: the race is further along than you think. The threads are further apart than you think. And the shared resource –

(She looks at the capability curve on the projection.)

– is closer to the critical section than anyone is admitting.

(Pause. Her breathing is audible.)

That’s what I wanted to say. I don’t have a solution. I have a warning.

TEIL 3: DIE FRAGEN / THE QUESTIONS

(The hall is buzzing. JONAS returns to the podium. The discussion format at 39C3: microphones in the aisles, plus the IRC channel read by a MODERATOR.)

JONAS: (German) Okay. Mikrofone sind offen. IRC ist offen. Bitte – sachliche Fragen.

[Surtitle: “Okay. Mics are open. IRC is open. Please – substantive questions.”]

(First question from the aisle microphone. A YOUNG RESEARCHER, twenties, nervous.)

YOUNG RESEARCHER: (English) Ms. Volkov – can you quantify how much higher the internal evaluations are? Are we talking one percent, five percent–

SASHA: I can’t give you exact numbers without identifying the lab. What I can say is: the gap between published and internal capability assessments is not noise. It’s signal. And it’s growing.

(Second question, from the IRC channel, read by the MODERATOR.)

MODERATOR: (reading, German) Von nullpointer im IRC: “Wenn die Safety-Evaluations designed sind um Permission zu produzieren – was wäre eine Alternative? Wer konnte unabhängig evaluieren?”

[Surtitle: “From nullpointer in IRC: ‘If safety evaluations are designed to produce permission – what’s the alternative? Who could evaluate independently?’”]

SASHA: (a bitter half-laugh) That’s the question. The labs have the compute. The labs have the access. The labs have the data. Independent evaluation requires

independent access. And independent access is exactly what the labs are structured to prevent.

(Beat.)

There are people trying. The scientific advisory panels. Academic groups. Some of them are brilliant. But they're working with published benchmarks, not internal data. They're evaluating the product, not the process. They can tell you what the model does. They can't tell you what the model almost did, what it would do if the guardrails were different, what happens at the edge cases that never make it into the public evaluation suite.

(Third question. From the aisle. ELENA – row 17, Angel t-shirt, laptop under her arm. She has stood up and walked to the microphone. Her hands are shaking.)

ELENA: (English, accented – Tagalog bleeding through the German she has learned and the English she works in) I have a question. Not a technical question.

(She looks directly at SASHA.)

If you knew it was dangerous – if you knew the evaluations were wrong, if you knew the threshold was closer than published – why did you keep working? For fourteen months, you stayed. You ran the evaluations you knew were compromised. You submitted data you knew would be smoothed. Why?

(The hall goes silent. This is the question.)

[Production note: This is Elena's canonical moment in V 1/2. The Lemur Who Woke asks the question that bridges her experience (data annotator, laborer inside the machine) with Sasha's (researcher, engineer inside the machine). They are the same person at different altitudes of the same system. Elena annotates the data that trains the model that Sasha evaluates. Neither designed the system. Both operate it.]

(SASHA stares at ELENA. The silence extends. Five seconds. Eight.)

SASHA: (when she speaks, her voice is different – stripped of the rehearsed quality, raw) Because I thought I could fix it from inside. Because I thought if I stayed, I could push for better methodology. Because I thought my presence was harm reduction.

(Beat.)

And because I was afraid. Because leaving meant losing my salary, my visa status, my professional identity, my –

(The English fails. Russian:)

Moya zhizn'. Vsyo, chto ya postroila.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed, 3 seconds): “My life. Everything I built.”]

(She catches herself again. Back to English.)

That's the honest answer. I stayed because leaving was terrifying. And then I left because staying was worse.

ELENA: (still at the microphone, quieter now) I annotate data. For an AI company. Here in Hamburg. By day I label images, transcribe audio, tag sentiment. I am inside the same machine. A different part. A lower floor.

(Beat.)

I don't have the credentials to see what you saw. I don't have the access. I just label what they give me and send it back. But I ask myself the same question every day: why am I still doing this? And the answer is the same as yours.

(She looks at SASHA.)

Moya zhizn'.

[Surtitle: The same phrase – “My life” – but in Elena's voice it carries Tagalog weight, the borrowed Russian an act of solidarity across linguistic borders.]

(SASHA nods. Something passes between them – recognition across altitude.)

(From the back rows, a voice. Unhurried. Clear. German with a precision that sounds almost archaic.)

MEPHISTO / FAUSTUS: (standing, barely visible in the back-row darkness, his voice carrying with unnatural clarity) Darf ich?

[Surtitle: “May I?”]

(JONAS looks toward the voice. Cannot quite see who is speaking.)

JONAS: Mikrofon vier. Bitte.

[Surtitle: “Mic four. Please.”]

(MEPHISTO does not move to a microphone. He does not need to. His voice reaches everyone. This should be noticed but not remarked upon.)

MEPHISTO: (German, the careful register of someone who has had centuries to choose words) Ich höre zwei Aussagen. Erstens: das System ist strukturell unfähig, sich selbst zu evaluieren. Zweitens: die Menschen innerhalb des Systems wissen das und bleiben trotzdem.

[Surtitle: “I hear two statements. First: the system is structurally incapable of evaluating itself. Second: the people inside the system know this and stay anyway.”]

(Beat.)

Meine Frage ist nicht technisch. Meine Frage ist die älteste Frage, die ich kenne.

[Surtitle: “My question is not technical. My question is the oldest question I know.”]

(The hall is very quiet. Something in his voice commands a different quality of attention.)

MEPHISTO: Wenn ihr wisst, dass das System kaputt ist – warum benutzt ihr es noch?

[Surtitle: “If you know the system is broken – why do you still use it?”]

(He looks around the hall. At the laptops. At the phones. At the screens. At the infrastructure of the Congress itself – running on servers, powered by compute, connected by the same networks that train the models they are criticizing.)

Nicht nur sie. Nicht nur die Labs. Ihr alle. Ihr sitzt in einem Saal, der von derselben Infrastruktur betrieben wird, die ihr kritisiert. Ihr kommuniziert über Systeme, die ihr für gefährlich haltet. Ihr benutzt die Werkzeuge, gegen die ihr protestiert.

[Surtitle: “Not just her. Not just the labs. All of you. You sit in a hall operated by the same infrastructure you criticize. You communicate through systems you consider dangerous. You use the tools you protest against.”]

(Beat. The discomfort in the hall is palpable.)

Ist das Heuchelei? Oder ist das die Wettlaufbedingung in ihrer reinsten Form – dass man nicht

aussteigen kann, weil das Rennen selbst der Boden ist, auf dem man steht?

[Surttitle: “Is that hypocrisy? Or is that the race condition in its purest form – that you cannot exit the race because the race itself is the ground you stand on?”]

(The IRC channel:)

```
<hexdump> who IS this guy  
<lambda_calculus> he's not wrong though  
<cr4ckb4by> ok boomer but also... yeah  
<systemfailure> this is the structural trap. you can't  
    use the master's tools etc  
<0xdeadbeef> audre lorde has entered the chat  
<roothacker> handle is FAUSTUS, been coming since forever  
<datenschutz_jansen> never seen him before  
<nullpointer> he's in the wiki. i think. let me check  
<nullpointer> ...huh. no entry.
```

(JONAS, at the podium, absorbing the question. He answers carefully.)

JONAS: (German, the anger modulated now into something heavier) Die Frage ist fair. Und ich habe keine gute Antwort.

[Surttitle: “The question is fair. And I don’t have a good answer.”]

Was ich habe, ist eine Beobachtung: Jedes Forum hat diese Frage. In Davos fragen sie: “Wie können wir reg-

ulieren, was uns reich macht?” In Munchen fragen sie: “Wie können wir kontrollieren, was uns bedroht?” In Washington fragen sie: “Wie können wir dominieren, was wir nicht verstehen?”

[Surttitle: “What I have is an observation: every forum has this question. In Davos they ask: ‘How can we regulate what makes us rich?’ In Munich they ask: ‘How can we control what threatens us?’ In Washington they ask: ‘How can we dominate what we don’t understand?’”]

(He gestures at the hall.)

Und hier fragen wir: “Wie können wir widerstehen, wenn der Widerstand selbst auf der Infrastruktur läuft, gegen die wir widerstehen?”

[Surttitle: “And here we ask: ‘How can we resist when the resistance itself runs on the infrastructure we resist against?’”]

(Beat.)

Vier Fragen. Dieselbe Falle. Keine Antwort.

[Surttitle: “Four questions. Same trap. No answer.”]

(SASHA, who has been watching this exchange, speaks. Her voice has changed – the rawness has settled into something quieter, more certain.)

SASHA: (English, directly to Mephisto’s position in the back rows) You’re right. And it doesn’t matter.

(Beat.)

You're right that we can't exit the system. You're right that the infrastructure implicates us. You're right that the race condition applies to this room too.

(She looks at Elena, who is still standing near the microphone.)

But she's also right. We stay because our lives are inside the machine. And I'm also right. I left because the machine is building something it cannot control.

(Beat.)

All three things are true at the same time. That's the race condition. Not that we disagree – that we're all correct, and our correctness is incompatible, and the clock –

(She points at the projection.)

– does not pause for any of us.

(The clock above the stage ticks forward. 27. DEZEMBER 2025, 21:07.)

(Silence. Then, slowly, the hall begins to applaud – not the polished applause of a conference, but the particular sound of a technically literate audience that has heard something it recognizes as true: scattered, then building, then full, then subsiding into the murmur of sixteen thousand people beginning to process what they've heard.)

(JONAS steps back to the podium.)

JONAS: (German, quiet) Ich denke, das ist ein guter Zeitpunkt, um die formelle Diskussion zu beenden. Die informelle Diskussion wird ohnehin die ganze Nacht weitergehen.

[Surtitle: “I think this is a good time to end the formal discussion. The informal discussion will continue all night anyway.”]

(He looks at SASHA.)

Danke, Sasha.

[Surtitle: “Thank you, Sasha.”]

(He looks toward the back rows, toward where Mephisto’s voice came from.)

Und danke an... FAUSTUS, wenn das der richtige Handle ist.

[Surtitle: “And thank you to... FAUSTUS, if that’s the right handle.”]

(But when the audience looks back, the seat is empty. The leather notebook is gone. In its place: a Club-Mate bottle, half-finished, and a conference sticker on the armrest that reads, in small letters: ICH WAR IN ALLEN RAUMEN.)

[Surtitle – Mode 3 (no translation): “ICH WAR IN ALLEN RAUMEN” remains untranslated for five seconds. Then, fading: “(I was in all the rooms.)”]

CODA: DER FLUR / THE HALLWAY

(The hall empties. The murmur of dispersal – people streaming toward the Assembly areas, the food court, the hackerspace workshops, the art installations. The acoustic shifts from the focused attention of the talk to the diffuse buzz of a living congress.)

(SASHA stands at the edge of the stage, alone. The hall lights are coming up. She has not moved. ELENA approaches.)

ELENA: (quiet, English) You okay?

SASHA: (a shaky exhale) I don't know. I think I just ended my career in front of sixteen thousand people and a livestream.

ELENA: You ended it fourteen months ago. Tonight you just told everyone.

(Beat. SASHA looks at her.)

SASHA: What's your name?

ELENA: Elena.

SASHA: Elena. You asked the question no one else would ask.

ELENA: It's the question I ask myself every morning. Before I open the labeling interface. Before I start the shift.

(Beat.)

ELENA: Why do we stay?

SASHA: Because our lives are inside the machine.

ELENA: And when the machine is building something it cannot control?

SASHA: Then we do what we can. We document. We witness. We tell the truth to anyone who'll listen.

(Beat.)

ELENA: That's not enough.

SASHA: (almost a whisper) Net. Etogo nedosta-
tochno.

[Surtitled – Mode 2 (delayed 3 seconds): “No. It's not enough.”]

(They stand together. Two women inside the same machine, at different altitudes, looking at the same curve on the screen above.)

(From a corridor off the main hall, the sound of MEPHISTO's voice – not amplified, not projected, just present, as if he is speaking to no one in particular, or to his notebook, or to the architecture of the building itself.)

MEPHISTO: (German, sotto voce, barely audible)
Die Warnung wurde ausgesprochen. Im ehrlichsten
Raum. Vor dem aufmerksamsten Publikum. Unter
der steilsten Kurve.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed): “The warning was spoken. In the most honest room. Before the most attentive audience. Under the steepest curve.”]

(Beat.)

Es hat nichts geandert. Noch nicht. Vielleicht nie.

[Surtitle – delayed: “It changed nothing. Not yet. Maybe never.”]

(He writes.)

Aber sie hat gesprochen. Das ist mehr, als die anderen Räume aufbringen werden.

[Surtitle – delayed: “But she spoke. That is more than the other rooms will manage.”]

(The clock: 27. DEZEMBER 2025, 21:23.)

(The capability curve: still rising.)

(The hall emptying, the murmur fading, the electronic music from Hall 2 bleeding back in – a bass frequency that vibrates in the sternum, the heartbeat of a congress that will talk all night and change nothing and be, for four days, the most honest room in the world.)

(Lights hold. The clock continues. The curve continues.)

(Then: blackout. And from the darkness, the sound design crossfades – the server hum of Hamburg giving way to the thick silence of Davos, expensive car-

pet absorbing every footfall, the mountain wind outside.)

[Transition to Scene 1.2: Davos.]

PRODUCTION NOTES

On the CCC as Theatrical Space

The Congress Center Hamburg is not a theater, but it is theatrical. Sixteen thousand people voluntarily organize themselves into an infrastructure of shared attention – talks, assemblies, workshops, art – for four days. The CCC's culture is allergic to performance, which makes the performance more interesting: every speaker must earn attention through competence, not credential.

The scene should feel like a real 39C3 talk. The casual register, the Club-Mate, the IRC channel, the audience that talks back – these are not stylizations. They are authentic to the space. The theatrical convention is that we are watching a real event that happens to contain a revelation.

On Jonas's Code-Switching

Jonas speaks German with English technical terms embedded. This is authentic to the European hacker/researcher scene – the Fachsprache (specialist language) of computer science is English, the frame

is German. His slides are in English because slides are always in English at CCC (the audience is international). His speech is in German because this is a German congress and he is a German researcher speaking to a primarily German audience.

The code-switching should feel natural, not performed. He does not translate for the audience; he speaks the way bilingual professionals speak.

On Sasha's Languages

Sasha speaks English because she has been inside the American tech industry. Her English is the language of her professional life – the lab, the evaluations, the vocabulary of “capability thresholds” and “safety margins.”

Her Russian emerges involuntarily – when the English cannot hold the emotion, when the professional surface cracks. The moments in Russian (*Ya videla*, *Moya zhizn'*, *Net*) are not speeches; they are eruptions. They should be brief, raw, and initially untranslated (Mode 3), giving the audience three seconds of incomprehension before the surtitle arrives.

This sets up her language pattern for the rest of the cycle: in *FAUST VI*, her Russian will emerge more frequently as the crisis deepens.

On Elena's Question

“If you knew it was dangerous, why did you keep working?”

This is the question that connects the Laborer (Elena, from FAUST III and IV) to the Researcher (Sasha, en route to FAUST VI). They are inside the same system at different altitudes. Elena labels data she does not control. Sasha evaluates capabilities she cannot govern. Both stayed because their lives were inside the machine.

Elena's repetition of Sasha's Russian phrase (*Moya zhizn'*) is a deliberate act of solidarity across linguistic borders. Elena does not speak Russian. But she recognizes the emotion, borrows the words, makes them her own. This is the anti-translation – not the flattening of FAUST IV 1/4, but the reaching-across.

On Mephisto's Function

Mephisto at 39C3 is “the most alive he feels” in the play (from the concept). The hackers surprise him. They push back. They refuse easy answers. His question – “If you know the system is broken, why do you still use it?” – is genuine, not rhetorical. He actually wants to know.

His physical signature: the leather notebook among sixteen thousand screens. The fountain pen among keyboards. The anachronism is his tell. He has been attending congresses since the 12th CCC – which is

to say, since the early 1990s – or perhaps since much longer. The wiki has no entry for FAUSTUS. Of course not.

The sticker he leaves behind – ICH WAR IN ALLEN RAUMEN – foreshadows his final speech in Movement III. Here it reads as a cryptic hacker flex. Later, it will read as a confession.

On the IRC Channel

The IRC channel is a working dramatic element – a real-time chorus that comments, reacts, and occasionally advances the plot. Production notes:

- Comments should be projected on a secondary screen, scrolling
- Plant 8-10 key comments (plot-relevant reactions, character identification)
- The rest can be generated live by an operator or pre-scripted for consistency
- The channel should feel authentic: CCC IRC is sarcastic, polyglot, technically precise, and occasionally beautiful
- The “nullpointer” handle checking the wiki for FAUSTUS and finding no entry is a planted moment

On the Clock and Curve

The clock and capability curve are persistent visual elements across all four forums. In the 39C3 scene,

they serve a specific function: the audience (both theatrical and in-fiction) can SEE the curve while Sasha is describing it from inside. The gap between the public curve (projected) and the internal numbers (higher than published) is the scene's central revelation – made visceral by the visual proximity of the curve to Sasha's testimony.

Sound Design Notes

- **Pre-scene:** Electronic music from Hall 2 (ambient/ techno, low BPM, felt in the sternum), crowd murmur, server hum from NOC
- **During talk:** Gradual reduction to focused attention – typing, occasional cough, server hum constant
- **During Sasha's confession:** Near-silence. The server hum becomes prominent – the sound of the infrastructure she is describing
- **During Mephisto's question:** A frequency shift – something lower, older, the hum taking on a resonance that does not belong to the building
- **Post-scene:** Music returns. The bass frequency. The murmur of sixteen thousand people processing. Then crossfade to Davos.

Surtitle Strategy

Element	Language	Translation Mode
Jonas (speech)	German	Mode 1: Full translation, simultaneous
Jonas (slides)	English	Not surtitled (audience reads slides)
Sasha (main)	English	Not surtitled (dominant language)
Sasha (Russian breaks)	Russian	Mode 3 (no translation) → Mode 2 (delayed 3-5 sec)
Elena (question)	English	Not surtitled
Elena (Russian echo)	Russian borrowed	Mode 2 (delayed)
Mephisto	German	Mode 2 (delayed 3 seconds – audience should hear the German before reading English)
IRC channel	Mixed	Projected directly, not surtitled
Mephisto's sticker	German	Mode 3 (no translation) → delayed fade-in

Running Time

Section	Duration
Teil 1: Der Vortrag	7-8 min
Teil 2: Die Beichte	6-7 min
Teil 3: Die Fragen	4-5 min
Coda: Der Flur	2-3 min
Total	19-23 min

THEMATIC CONNECTIONS

To FAUST IV 1/4 (Das Übersetzen)

The 39C3 scene inverts the translation booth. In IV 1/4, Anna Bauer translates between languages and the translation is violence – smoothing, flattening, “small murders of meaning.” At 39C3, the problem is not translation but transmission: Sasha’s testimony is perfectly clear, technically precise, understood by the audience. And it changes nothing. The violence here is not mistranslation but irrelevance – perfect communication that produces no action.

To FAUST VI (Die Kassandra)

This scene is Sasha’s origin story. In VI, she is in the Oakland apartment, documenting, watching the curve, alone. Here, we see the moment she first speaks publicly. The audience knows (if they have seen VI) that her warning will go unheard – that the

journalist, the regulator, the lawyer are all ahead of her. The dramatic irony is total: we are watching courage that will be wasted.

To the Cycle's Gretchen Tradition

Sasha's moment at the microphone echoes Gretchen's refusal: "Mir graut's." The bodily knowledge that precedes articulation. Sasha has rehearsed her words, but the Russian that erupts – Ya videla – is the body's truth before the mind can professionalize it.

Elena's question echoes the Gretchen question to Faust: "How do you feel about religion?" – reframed as: "How do you feel about complicity?" The question that cannot be answered honestly without destroying the answerer's position.

To the Race Condition Thesis

The 39C3 scene establishes Thread 1 of the race condition. This forum is technically literate, politically honest, and structurally powerless. They understand the curve. They understand the danger. They have no mechanism to compel the other three forums to listen. Their thread executes in isolation. The race condition is not a metaphor here; it is an architectural fact.

Scene draft for FAUST V 1/2: Die Wettlaufbedingung

Movement I, Scene 1.1: 39C3 Status: First complete draft Word count: ~5,200 words (dramatic text + production notes) Date: 2026-01-27

“Die Warnung wurde ausgesprochen. Im ehrlichsten Raum.” “The warning was spoken. In the most honest room.”

title: “FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG”
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
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Movement I - Szene

1.2: Davos, 20. Januar 2026

WEF – Die Adoleszenz / The Adolescence

The room where everyone agrees something must be done. The agreement is the product.

Placement: Movement I (Die Foren), Scene 2 **Running Time:** 18-22 minutes **Location:** Congress Centre, Davos-Klosters, Switzerland. Private Session Room “Parsenn” **Date in Play:** January 20, 2026, 14:00 CET

Dominant Languages: English (Davos lingua franca), German (Helen, private register), Wolof (Fatou, fragments), Mandarin (Li, private)

Central Question: Can coordination happen among those who profit from competition?

SETTING

A private session room in the Congress Centre at Davos. Not the main hall – the main hall is for the cameras, the keynotes, the performances of statesmanship. This room is smaller, more intimate, more consequential. Capacity: forty-five. Attendance: thirty-eight. The room is called “Parsenn” after the local ski area – a name that means “the open slope,” though the conversation here will be anything but open.

The room is immaculate. Swiss conference hospitality at its peak: water glasses (still and sparkling, both), notepads with the WEF logo embossed in silver, pens that cost more than Elena earns in a day of data annotation. The chairs are the particular kind of chair that signals money without displaying it – leather, but restrained; comfortable, but not indulgent. The lighting is warm, golden, the aesthetic of wealth that does not need to announce itself. Wood paneling on two walls. A view of the Alps through floor-to-ceiling windows – snow, pines, the dramatic landscape serving as backdrop for the world’s most expensive talking shop.

A raised platform at the front with a moderator’s position and four panelist chairs, each with a small ta-

ble, a microphone, and the WEF name placard in Helvetica. A projection screen behind the panel displays the session title:

RESPONSIBLE AI: FROM PRINCIPLES TO PRACTICE
Private Session | Chatham House Rule
World Economic Forum Annual Meeting 2026
"A Spirit of Dialogue"

The audience occupies curved rows of seats – CEOs, ministers, tech executives, foundation heads, and, near the back, a small cluster of “civil society representatives” whose badges are a different color (blue, not white) and whose access expires at 15:30.

Above the stage, the persistent FAUST V 1/2 projections: the CLOCK (20. JANUAR 2026, 14:02) and the CAPABILITY CURVE, steeper now than in Hamburg three weeks ago.

[SOUND: The acoustic signature of Davos – thick silence. Expensive carpet absorbs every footfall. The Alpine windows are triple-glazed; the mountain wind is visible (the snow moves) but inaudible. The ventilation is whisper-quiet, the temperature precisely controlled. Distant clinking of crystal from the reception next door. Occasional phone vibration, quickly silenced. This is a room that costs more to be quiet in than most rooms cost to fill with sound.]

[LIGHTING: Warm gold. The opposite of Hamburg’s cold fluorescence. This is light designed to make everyone look healthy, prosperous, reasonable. The Alpine sun through the windows adds a natural

quality that the overhead LEDs are calibrated to complement. There are no harsh shadows. Nothing in this room is harsh. Harshness has been engineered out.]

CHARACTERS

HELEN FISCHER – Deputy Director, EU AI Office. German, 48. The moderator. She has been assigned this session because she is good at moderation – precise, fair, capable of making powerful people feel heard while steering toward substance. She arrived at Davos still believing that the EU AI Act could be the model. The US CTO’s public dismissal of the Act as “an absolute disaster” landed this morning. She is moderating on damaged faith.

Language: English (professional, Davos register), German (private – sotto voce, asides, the language of what she actually thinks)

MARCUS OYELARAN – CEO, Prometheus Labs. Canonical (from FAUST III, IV, VI). Nigerian-American, 41. He is on the panel because Prometheus Labs has published the most detailed “Responsible Scaling Policy” in the industry. He is sincere. He believes coordination is possible. He believes his company is different. He believes – still, at this point in the timeline – that the adults are in the room and the room is this one. His sincerity is the problem.

Language: English (professional – the precise, measured English of a CEO who is also a scientist)

FATOU DIALLO – Civil Society Representative. Canonical (from FAUST IV, VI). Senegalese, 34. She has been given seven minutes on the agenda. She is the “Global South voice” – invited to prove the session is inclusive, allocated just enough time to speak but not enough to shift the conversation. She has prepared a seven-minute intervention. She will use nine. Her badge is blue. Her microphone is the same as the others, but she knows it isn’t.

Language: English (public, carefully constructed), Wolof (prayer, emotion – the language that has no seat at this table)

LI JIANFENG – Chinese tech investor, 49. New character. He represents the “Davos China” – urbane, Cambridge-educated, bridge-building, carefully not-official. He sits on the boards of three AI companies (two Chinese, one Singaporean). He offers cooperation in terms this room understands: investment, partnership, shared standards. He knows that the cooperation he can deliver is constrained by forces he cannot name here. He will name them privately, to Mephisto, in the corridor.

Language: Mandarin (private, to himself, on the phone), English (public – fluid, colloquial, disarming)

MEPHISTO – A strategic advisor. No name badge. Impeccable suit – dark, European cut, the kind of suit that signals access without portfolio. He moves

through the session without credentials, which at Davos means either extreme power or extreme irrelevance. He sits in the second row, not the first – the seat of someone who advises, not someone who decides. When others speak, he leans toward the person beside him and translates. “What she means is...” “What he’s really saying is...” The translations are always slightly wrong. The slight wrongness always reveals something true.

Language: English (Davos register – smooth, constructive, the language of deals), German (to Helen, private – the language of what they both know)

ADDITIONAL PRESENCES:

- **THREE CEOs** in the front row (unnamed, representing the industry that funds WEF)
 - **A GOVERNMENT MINISTER** from a Nordic country (unnamed, representing states that still believe in governance)
 - **THE SESSION COORDINATOR** – WEF staff, manages time, signals speakers, embodies the institutional machinery
 - **A SECURITY DETAIL** at the door – the physical fact of protected speech
-

THE SCENE

TEIL 1: DIE EROFFNUNG / THE OPENING

(The session is about to begin. Last arrivals take their seats. The SESSION COORDINATOR checks her tablet, counts attendance, nods. HELEN stands at the moderator's position, reviewing notes. MARCUS sits in the first panelist chair, water glass aligned, posture perfect. FATOU is in the second row from the back, blue badge visible. LI JIANFENG sits three seats from the aisle, phone face-down on his thigh.)

(MEPHISTO is already seated. He was not seen entering. He is simply present, the way money is present in this room – pervasive, foundational, unannounced.)

HELEN: (English – the polished, confident register of a European official at Davos) Good afternoon, everyone. Welcome to our private session on “Responsible AI: From Principles to Practice.” This session operates under Chatham House Rule, which means you may use the information discussed here but may not attribute statements to specific individuals.

(She pauses. The faintest edge of irony.)

I mention this because I know many of you will be speaking to journalists within the hour.

(Polite laughter. The Davos laugh – warm, knowing, contained.)

HELEN: I want to frame our discussion around a specific tension. Over the past two years, we have produced an extraordinary amount of principled commitment to responsible AI. Voluntary frameworks. Ethical guidelines. National strategies. The EU AI Act. Corporate responsibility pledges. I have a stack of commitments on my desk that reaches –

(She gestures – a precise, moderate height.)

– about this high.

(Beat.)

And yet. The gap between these commitments and their implementation appears to be growing, not shrinking. We are producing principles faster than we are implementing them. The question for today is: why? And what, concretely, can we do about it?

(She turns to the panel.)

I'd like to begin with Marcus Oyelaran, CEO of Prometheus Labs, which has published what many consider the most detailed responsible scaling framework in the industry.

MARCUS: (rising slightly – not standing, the Davos way: authority without theater) Thank you, Helen. And thank you to the Forum for convening this conversation.

(His voice is measured, sincere, the product of a scientist who became a CEO without entirely losing the scientist's precision.)

I want to start with an admission. Prometheus Labs published our Responsible Scaling Policy eighteen months ago. It was – and I believe still is – the most rigorous public framework for capability-level governance in the industry.

(Beat.)

And it is already inadequate.

(Murmur in the room. This is not the expected opening.)

MARCUS: I say this not because the policy is poorly designed. I designed much of it myself, with input from our safety team, from external advisors, from some of the people in this room. The architecture is sound. The thresholds are specific. The escalation protocols are clear.

The problem is that the capability curve does not care about our architecture.

(He glances at the projection above – the CAPABILITY CURVE, steeper than Hamburg.)

When we published the RSP, we projected reaching the first mandatory review threshold in Q3 of 2026. We reached it in November 2025. Two quarters early. The policy triggered correctly – we paused,

we reviewed, we assessed. And then we – I will be honest – we found that the assessment supported proceeding.

(Beat. The weight of the phrase “supported proceeding” – the same phrase Sasha used at 39C3, though Marcus does not know this.)

The question I want to pose to this room is: what happens when every responsible actor’s framework produces the same result – “proceed with caution” – and the caution becomes a formality because the alternative is falling behind?

(MEPHISTO leans toward the CEO beside him – a woman in her fifties, dark blazer, no badge.)

MEPHISTO: (whispered, but audible to the audience – a theatrical convention) Was er wirklich sagt: Die Safety-Policy hat funktioniert. Und trotzdem machen wir weiter.

[Surtitles – Mode 2 (delayed 3 seconds): “What he’s really saying: the safety policy worked. And we’re proceeding anyway.”]

(The CEO beside him nods slightly. She has heard something – but what she heard may not be what he said.)

HELEN: Thank you, Marcus. That’s a remarkably candid opening. I want to bring in another perspective.

Mr. Li Jianfeng represents a different vantage point – as an investor across the Chinese and Southeast Asian AI ecosystem.

LI JIANFENG: (English – Cambridge accent, casual, disarming) Thank you, Helen. I want to respond to Marcus with equal candor, though perhaps from a less comfortable direction.

(He adjusts his microphone. The gesture is smooth – he has done this before.)

Marcus described reaching a threshold early and proceeding with caution. I respect that. What I would observe is that the concept of “voluntary pause” is, structurally, a unilateral disarmament proposal.

(The room shifts. This is the word – “unilateral disarmament” – that Davos hears from the military conference in Munich. The languages are bleeding.)

LI: When Prometheus Labs pauses, who else pauses? Not DeepMind. Not the Chinese labs. Not the open-source community. Not the state-backed programs that do not publish responsible scaling policies because they do not publish anything.

(Beat.)

I say this as someone who believes in cooperation. Genuinely. I am here because I believe the Chinese and Western AI ecosystems must coordinate. But coordination requires symmetry. And the current landscape is radically asymmetric.

(He glances at his phone – face-down, but the vibration is visible.)

LI: The companies represented in this room operate under public scrutiny, shareholder pressure, regulatory frameworks – however incomplete. The capability programs that most concern us do not operate under any of these constraints. When we discuss “responsible AI,” we are discussing responsibility for one side of the table. The other side is not at this table.

(MEPHISTO leans toward another seatmate – a minister.)

MEPHISTO: (whispered) What he cannot say: Beijing did not send him. Beijing does not know he is saying this. If this room acts on what he says, it will be despite China, not with China.

[Surtitled – Mode 2 (delayed): “What he cannot say: Beijing did not send him.”]

HELEN: (carefully) Mr. Li raises a structural point about coordination asymmetry. Marcus, I want to come back to you on this – but first, I believe we have a civil society intervention scheduled. Ms. Diallo, you have been allocated seven minutes.

(She checks her notes. The precision of institutional time allocation: seven minutes for the voice of two billion people.)

TEIL 2: DIE SIEBEN MINUTEN / THE SEVEN MINUTES

(FATOU DIALLO stands. She is in the second row from the back. She does not move to the podium – she speaks from where she is, forcing the room to turn. This is a small rebellion. The room turns.)

[Production note: Fatou's position is critical. She speaks from the margin – physically, spatially, institutionally. The room must adjust to her. The panel must turn their chairs. The cameras must find her. The audience in the theater should feel the spatial asymmetry: the powerful face the room; the civil society voice speaks from behind.]

FATOU: (English – carefully constructed, each word precise, carrying the weight of rehearsal) Thank you, Dr. Fischer. I am grateful for the seven minutes. I will try to be efficient with them.

(Beat. The word “efficient” lands with a charge the room may not notice.)

My name is Fatou Diallo. I work with communities in West Africa – Senegal, Mali, Guinea – that are experiencing the effects of AI deployment in ways that are not represented in this room's conversation.

(She pauses. Looks at the panel, the CEOs, the ministers.)

I want to tell you a story. It will take two of my seven minutes. I hope you will consider it an efficient use of the time.

FATOU: Six months ago, a telecommunications company deployed an AI-driven customer service system across West Africa. The system was trained primarily on English and French language data. It replaced approximately fourteen thousand human customer service workers. In Senegal. In Mali. In Guinea.

These workers spoke Wolof, Bambara, Fulfulde, Mandinka. They resolved disputes in languages the AI does not speak. They understood contexts the AI cannot model. They were – I use this word deliberately – the interface between the corporation and the community.

(Beat.)

The company reported a 40% improvement in response efficiency. The fourteen thousand workers were not counted in the efficiency metric. Their languages were not counted. Their knowledge was not counted.

(She looks directly at Marcus.)

Mr. Oyelaran. Your Responsible Scaling Policy is 127 pages long. I have read it. How many times does it mention the word “displacement”?

(Silence. Marcus's jaw tightens.)

MARCUS: (quietly) I don't have the exact –

FATOU: Twice. Both times in the context of “potential workforce displacement requiring transition support.” Fourteen words. For fourteen thousand people.

(The room is very still. MEPHISTO has stopped leaning toward seatmates. He is watching Fatou. His pen has stopped moving. For the first time in this scene, he is not translating. He is listening.)

FATOU: I do not question your sincerity, Mr. Oyelaran. I believe you care. I believe many people in this room care. But caring is not the same as being affected.

(She gestures at the room – the wood paneling, the Alpine view, the water glasses.)

This room discusses AI governance as a coordination problem. Who regulates? Which framework? What timeline? These are important questions. But they are asked from a position where the questioner is not at risk. No one in this room will lose their job to AI this year. No one in this room will lose their language. No one in this room –

(Her voice shifts. Something beneath the English. Not Wolof yet, but the rhythm of Wolof pressing against the English, the cadence changing.)

– no one in this room has been asked to become efficient.

(The SESSION COORDINATOR glances at her tablet. Fatou has used three minutes and forty seconds. Three minutes and twenty seconds remain.)

FATOU: Mr. Li spoke of asymmetry. I agree. There is an asymmetry. But it is not only the asymmetry between Chinese and Western labs. It is the asymmetry between those who build and those upon whom the building falls.

The fourteen thousand workers in West Africa did not participate in the development of the AI that replaced them. They did not participate in the governance frameworks that permitted it. They did not participate in this session. They are represented by me, in seven minutes, because someone decided that seven minutes constitutes inclusion.

(Beat. She looks at Helen.)

Dr. Fischer. You designed the EU AI Act. It is the most comprehensive AI regulation in the world. It does not apply to deployments in Senegal.

HELEN: (a flinch – almost invisible, but there) The Act's extraterritorial provisions –

FATOU: Apply to systems marketed in the EU. The customer service system deployed in West Africa was de-

veloped in Europe, trained on European data, and deployed in Africa precisely because African regulatory frameworks are weaker. The efficiency gain was measured in European currencies. The displacement was measured in African bodies.

(Silence.)

FATOU: I have three minutes remaining. I will use them to say what I came here to say.

(She straightens. When she speaks next, the English is still there, but the structure has shifted – the sentences are shorter, more rhythmic, carrying the cadence of oratory that belongs to a different tradition than Davos panels.)

You are discussing governance as if the question is: how do we coordinate the powerful? I am telling you: the question is: who pays while you coordinate?

(Beat.)

The capability curve that Mr. Oyelaran described – the one that outruns your frameworks – that curve is not abstract. It has a body count. Not in the future. Now. Not in catastrophic scenarios. In ordinary ones. In call centers closed. In languages dying faster because the economic infrastructure that sustained them has been removed. In young people who were told: learn English, learn coding, join the digital economy – and who did, and who are now being told: the digital economy no longer requires you.

(Her voice breaks. Not theatrically – a real crack, quickly repaired.)

(And then – the Wolof. Quiet. Almost inaudible. Not for the room. For herself.)

FATOU: (Wolof, whispered) Yalla nafi dimbali. Yalla nafi yar.

[Surtitle – Mode 3 (no translation). The Wolof hangs untranslated for five full seconds. The room does not understand. That is the point.]

[Then, fading in – Mode 2: “God help us. God give us patience.”]

FATOU: (returning to English, composed) I do not expect this room to solve these problems. This room is not designed to solve problems. It is designed to discuss them. I know the difference.

(She looks around – at the wood paneling, the water glasses, the Alpine view.)

What I expect is this: when you leave this room and write your communique – your shared commitments, your voluntary frameworks, your pledges of inclusive development – I expect you to know that the people who will read those words and find them empty are not cynics. They are the people who were counting on you.

(Beat.)

That is seven minutes. I have used nine. I apologize for the imposition.

(She sits.)

(Silence. The particular silence of a room full of powerful people who have been told the truth by someone without power. It lasts four seconds. Then HELEN speaks.)

TEIL 3: DER POLIERTE AUSTAUSCH / THE POLISHED EXCHANGE

HELEN: (English, professional, but something has shifted in her voice – a hairline fracture) Thank you, Ms. Diallo.

(She turns to the panel. The moderator's reflex: move the conversation forward. Absorb the testimony into the process.)

Marcus, I want to give you the opportunity to respond.

MARCUS: (standing now – an involuntary escalation from the seated Davos posture) Ms. Diallo is right. About all of it.

(The room stirs. This is not the expected response. The expected response is: “We take these con-

cerns seriously and our framework addresses them through –”)

MARCUS: She is right that our Responsible Scaling Policy does not adequately address displacement. She is right that the efficiency gains we measure do not account for the costs borne by others. She is right that this room is not designed to solve the problems she described.

(Beat. He is a man discovering, in real time, that his sincerity is inadequate.)

But I want to push back on one implication. She said this room is designed to discuss, not to solve. I reject that framing. I am here because I believe the people in this room – the people who actually build these systems, who actually deploy them – are the people who can change how they are built and deployed.

(He turns to the room – to the CEOs, the ministers, the investors.)

We can commit. Today. In this room. To incorporating displacement impact assessments into our scaling frameworks. To establishing a fund – real money, not pledges – for communities affected by AI deployment. To –

(MEPHISTO leans toward the CEO beside him. His whisper is louder now – almost audible to the room.)

MEPHISTO: (English, the smooth Davos register) What he means is: he will add a page to the policy. It

will be sincere. It will be page 128 of 128.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed): “What he means is: he will add a page to the policy.”]

LI JIANFENG: (cutting in – the investor’s instinct for intervention) Marcus, I respect your commitment. But I want to return to the structural question.

(He addresses the room now, not just the panel.)

Ms. Diallo described a deployment in West Africa. That deployment was made by a European company. Under European ownership. Using European technology. Displacing African workers. And the governance framework that was supposed to prevent this – the EU AI Act – did not apply.

(He looks at Helen.)

This is not an oversight. This is the design. Governance frameworks are territorial. Technology is not. Capital is not. The displacement Ms. Diallo describes happened precisely because the system was designed to operate in the gap between jurisdictions. That gap is not a bug. It is the business model.

HELEN: (German emerges – involuntary, under her breath, not into the microphone) Das weiss ich.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed): “I know that.”]

(She recovers. Back to English.)

The EU is actively working on extraterritorial provisions. The Digital Services Act provides a model for

–

LI: (gently, almost kindly – the devastation of politeness) Dr. Fischer, the EU has been “actively working on” AI governance for six years. In that time, the number of AI-displaced workers globally has gone from negligible to –

(He pauses. Pulls a figure from memory.)

– the ILO estimates thirty-seven million. And counting. The frameworks are being built. The displacement is already built.

(HELEN’s hands grip her notes. Something is happening behind her professional composure – the same fracture visible in the VI summit scene, the same question forming: “What exactly are we doing here?”)

(She does not ask it. Not yet. That question is for later in the cycle. Here, she absorbs the blow and moderates.)

HELEN: (controlled) I want to open the floor to other contributions. We have fifteen minutes remaining in the session.

(A CEO from the front row – unnamed, representing one of the three largest AI companies in the world –

raises a hand.)

CEO: (English – American, the particular dialect of Silicon Valley optimism) I want to offer a different perspective. We're hearing a lot about displacement and governance failure. I don't dispute the facts. But I think we're missing the larger picture.

AI has also created extraordinary value. Medical diagnostics that save lives. Climate modeling that improves predictions. Agricultural optimization that increases yields. The narrative of pure harm is –

FATOU: (from her seat, not standing – the interruption itself a breach of Davos protocol) Agricultural optimization. I know this term. In my region, it means: an algorithm decided what crops to plant. Optimized for export value. The algorithm does not eat what it plants. The farmers do.

(Silence.)

CEO: (smoothly) Those are implementation challenges that can be addressed through –

FATOU: Implementation. Yes. The word that means: the harm is not in the design, only in the execution. So redesign, and the harm will be different. Perhaps smaller. Perhaps elsewhere. But never here. Never in this room.

(MEPHISTO stands. The motion is unhurried, deliberate. He does not speak loudly. He does not need to.)

MEPHISTO: (English – the Davos register, perfectly deployed) If I may – a observation.

(HELEN looks at him. She should know who he is. She does not. Or she does, and has forgotten, and will forget again.)

HELEN: (uncertain) You are...?

MEPHISTO: A friend of the Forum. I have attended these sessions for some years.

(He does not clarify which years. He does not show a badge. The SECURITY DETAIL at the door does not move. He is impossible, and therefore invisible.)

MEPHISTO: I have been listening to a panel discussion about responsible AI. I have heard a CEO describe the inadequacy of his own framework. I have heard an investor describe the asymmetry of international coordination. I have heard a civil society representative describe the human cost of deployment. And I have heard a moderator struggle with the gap between her regulatory instruments and the world they are supposed to govern.

(He looks around the room.)

All of this has been said before. In this room. At this Forum. Last year. And the year before. And the year before that. The words are almost exactly the same. The sincerity is genuine. The PowerPoint has been updated.

(Beat.)

The question I would pose is not “what should we do?” – that question has been answered, repeatedly, in the documents I suspect most of you have not read. The question is: why does this room produce the same conversation every year, and call it progress?

(The room is very quiet. The particular quiet of people who have been accurately described.)

MARCUS: (stung, but honest) Because the alternative is not having the conversation at all.

MEPHISTO: (turning to him with something almost like respect) Is it? Or is the conversation itself the alternative – the alternative to action? You meet. You discuss. You produce a communique. The communique commits to “continued dialogue.” The dialogue is next year’s meeting. The meeting produces the next communique. The communique commits to –

(He gestures, circular.)

Do you see the recursion?

HELEN: (German, breaking through, the moderator’s mask slipping) Das reicht.

[Surtitle: “That’s enough.”]

(She catches herself. Back to English.)

That's – we are running low on time. I want to –

MEPHISTO: (gently – the gentleness is the weapon)
Of course. Time. There is never enough time at Davos.
Seven minutes for civil society. Three minutes for
questions. Forty-five minutes for a conversation that
began three years ago and has not advanced.

(He sits.)

Forgive me. I did not mean to be impolite.

(But the damage is done. The room has heard itself
described. HELEN grips the podium.)

TEIL 4: DAS COMMUNIQUE / THE COMMUNIQUE

(The SESSION COORDINATOR signals: five minutes remaining. HELEN straightens.)

HELEN: (English, professional – the mask back in place, the fracture hidden) Let me attempt to summarize where we are.

We have heard that existing frameworks, while well-designed, are outpaced by the capability curve. We have heard that international coordination faces structural asymmetries. We have heard – powerfully – that the costs of AI deployment fall disproportionately on communities that have no voice in

governance. And we have heard the uncomfortable suggestion that this conversation itself may be part of the problem it is trying to solve.

(She looks at her notes. Then sets them aside – the same gesture Dr. Okafor will make in Geneva, six months later. The same gesture. Different room. Different altitude. Same realization.)

I want to depart from my summary. Briefly.

(The room shifts. This is not what moderators do at Davos.)

HELEN: I have been in AI governance for eleven years. I helped design the EU AI Act. I have attended seven Davos sessions on AI. Seven. And I have noticed something.

(Beat.)

Each year, the conversation becomes more sophisticated. The frameworks become more detailed. The commitments become more specific. The language becomes more precise.

(Beat.)

And each year, the gap between what is said in this room and what happens outside it becomes wider. Not because we are insincere. Because the room is designed to produce agreement, and the world is designed to produce competition. And competition is faster.

(She looks at the capability curve above the stage.)

Three weeks ago, a researcher spoke at a hacker congress in Hamburg. She described the same curve. She described what it looks like from inside a lab. I have read the transcript.

(Marcus looks up. He did not know Helen had read Sasha's testimony.)

HELEN: She said: "The question is never 'should we stop?' The question is always 'does this support proceeding?'"

(Beat.)

I am looking at this room, and I am asking myself: is our question any different? Are we asking "what should we do?" or are we asking "what can we agree on that permits us all to proceed?"

(Silence.)

(MEPHISTO, from his seat, speaks – not to the room, but to Helen. German. Private. The language they share.)

MEPHISTO: (German, quiet) Du weißt es schon. Du hast es immer gewusst.

[Surtitles – Mode 2 (delayed 3 seconds): "You already know. You've always known."]

(HELEN looks at him. Something passes between them – recognition, or memory, or the knowledge that she has heard this voice before in other rooms.)

HELEN: (back to English, composing herself) I will summarize our session for the Forum's proceedings. I will note the discussion of scaling frameworks, coordination asymmetries, displacement impacts, and the structural challenges of translating principles to practice.

(Beat. The faintest edge.)

I will note that the session participants expressed a “spirit of dialogue.”

(The phrase from the WEF's official theme. Here, it sounds like an epitaph.)

(The SESSION COORDINATOR stands. The session is ending. People begin the choreography of departure – gathering papers, checking phones, the particular Davos exit where conversations migrate from seats to aisles to corridors to private dinners.)

(FATOU remains seated. Her phone shows three messages she has not read. Her notes are written in a language no one else in the room can read – Wolof, the notes she takes for herself, in the language that has no seat at this table.)

CODA: DER KORRIDOR / THE CORRIDOR

(The corridor outside the session room. Alpine luxury – thick carpet, warm light, the view of mountains through every window. MARCUS and LI JIANFENG stand near the coffee station. The particular Davos coffee: excellent, expensive, served in cups that will be washed by workers who are not in the program.)

MARCUS: (to Li, quieter than inside) You were right about the asymmetry. I know it. Everyone in there knows it.

LI: (sipping coffee, the casual register of two men who understand each other) Knowing and acting are different verbs.

MARCUS: What can you actually deliver? If we – if the companies represented in that room – made a real commitment. Binding. Verifiable. What could China match?

(Li is quiet for a moment. He looks at his phone. Sets it face-down again.)

LI: (Mandarin, sotto voce, to himself – the language of honesty) Wo neng jiao fu de he wo xiang jiao fu de shi liang hui shi.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed 3 seconds): “What I can deliver and what I want to deliver are two different things.”]

(Back to English.)

LI: Marcus. I am here as an investor. Not a diplomat. Not a government representative. I can offer partnership. I can offer shared standards within my portfolio companies. I can offer good faith.

(Beat.)

I cannot offer China. No one can offer China. China is not a person with a commitment mechanism. China is a system. And the system has priorities that do not align with what this room wants.

MARCUS: Then what are we doing?

LI: (a small, tired smile) We are having a spirit of dialogue.

(Nearby, FATOU exits the session room. She walks past them without stopping. Her badge says CIVIL SOCIETY – LIMITED ACCESS. She has thirty minutes before her access expires.)

(MARCUS watches her go.)

MARCUS: She was right, you know. About all of it.

LI: Of course she was. That's not the question. The question is whether being right, in this room, matters.

(MEPHISTO appears in the corridor. He was not in the session room a moment ago. He was not in the corridor. He is simply here, coffee in hand, as if he has always been here.)

MEPHISTO: (English, to both of them, conversational) Gentlemen. A productive session.

MARCUS: (turning, uncertain) Do I know you?

MEPHISTO: We've met. At sessions like this. You may not remember. The sessions tend to blur.

(He sips his coffee. The gesture is precise, unhurried.)

MEPHISTO: I wanted to ask you something. Both of you. Off the record. No Chatham House.

(They wait.)

MEPHISTO: Do you believe anything decided in that room will affect what happens next?

(Silence.)

MARCUS: I have to believe that. If I don't –

MEPHISTO: Then what? You stop? You stop attending? You stop speaking? You stop publishing responsible scaling frameworks that permit you to proceed?

(Beat.)

That is not an accusation. It is a genuine question. What happens to sincere people when their sincerity produces nothing?

(MARCUS has no answer. LI does.)

LI: (quiet, the investor's clarity) They attend the next conference. They refine the framework. They hope the next iteration will be different.

MEPHISTO: (nodding, writing in his notebook – the leather notebook, the fountain pen, incongruous with the espresso cup) Yes. That is what I have observed. For a very long time.

(He looks up from the notebook. At the corridor. At the Alps through the window. At the security detail. At the coffee station. At the carpet that absorbs every footfall.)

MEPHISTO: (German, quiet, to himself – but the audience hears) In Davos liegt der Schnee auf Bergen, die niemand besteigt. Die Gespräche wiederholen sich wie Lawinen – vorhersehbar, periodisch, und jedes Mal glauben sie, es sei das erste Mal.

[Surtitle – Mode 2 (delayed): “In Davos, the snow lies on mountains no one climbs. The conversations repeat like avalanches – predictable, periodic, and every time they believe it’s the first time.”]

(Down the corridor, FATOU stands at a window. She is on the phone, speaking Wolof – rapid, emotional, the language of home pouring out after two hours of performing in English. The audience hears fragments:)

FATOU: (Wolof, on the phone) ...dafa neex lool... waaw, ma wax na leen... degg nanu, wante dara jotiwul... nit yi ci kaw danu toog, danu degg, danu yobbu dara...

[Surtitle – Mode 3 (no translation) for five seconds.]

[Then Mode 2, fading in: "...it went fine... yes, I told them... they listened, but nothing will change... the people at the top, they sat, they listened, they took nothing away..."]

(She ends the call. Looks at the Alps. The snow. The view that is supposed to inspire but today only measures distance.)

(HELEN exits the session room last. She carries her notes. She walks past Mephisto without seeing him – or seeing him and choosing not to stop. She walks to the window where Fatou stands. They are, for a moment, side by side – the regulator and the testimony, the moderator and the margin.)

HELEN: (quiet, English) Ms. Diallo.

FATOU: Dr. Fischer.

HELEN: You used nine minutes.

FATOU: I apologize.

HELEN: (a pause – and then, in German, the private language, the language of what she actually thinks) Entschuldige dich nicht. Es waren die wichtigsten neun Minuten des Tages.

[Surtitle – Mode 1 (immediate): "Don't apologize. They were the most important nine minutes of the day."]

(FATOU looks at her. Does not understand the German. Understands the tone.)

FATOU: Will anything change?

(HELEN does not answer. The silence is the answer.)

FATOU: (Wolof, very quiet, almost a whisper – a prayer) Yalla baal nu. Yalla baal nu ci lu nu mën a def te defuwu nu ko.

[Surtitled – Mode 3 (no translation). Seven seconds. The Wolof prayer fills the corridor with a language this building has never held.]

[Then, fading – Mode 2: “God forgive us. God forgive us for what we could have done and did not do.”]

(The clock above: 20. JANUAR 2026, 15:27.)

(FATOU’s badge expires in three minutes.)

(The capability curve: steeper.)

(The Alps through the window: beautiful, indifferent, ancient.)

(Lights hold. Then fade – not to black, but to the thick silence of Davos, the expensive quiet, the sound of mountain wind against triple-glazed glass that keeps everything out.)

[Transition sound: The thick silence of Davos gives way to the institutional hum of Munich – rustling papers, earpiece feedback, the particular acoustic of classified briefings. Fluorescent light replaces golden warmth. The mountains disappear. The next forum begins.]

PRODUCTION NOTES

On Davos as Theatrical Space

Davos is the anti-39C3. Where Hamburg is cold fluorescence, open architecture, and sixteen thousand people in hoodies, Davos is warm gold, closed rooms, and thirty-eight people in suits. The aesthetic contrast should be total. If the 39C3 scene felt raw, authentic, electrically alive, the Davos scene should feel polished, contained, and suffocating.

The room should feel like a room where nothing can go wrong – where the carpet, the lighting, the coffee, the view have all been engineered to produce agreement. Fatou's intervention disrupts this engineering. The room recovers. That recovery is the scene's horror.

On Helen as Moderator

Helen Fischer is a good moderator. This matters. She is not a bureaucratic functionary; she is a skilled professional doing a difficult job well. Her competence makes her complicity worse – she manages the session expertly, gives each speaker their time, synthesizes competing perspectives, and produces exactly the outcome the Forum expects.

Her departure from the moderator's script – quoting

Sasha's 39C3 testimony – is the scene's hinge. For a moment, she stops managing and starts speaking. Then she recovers. The recovery is the tragedy.

Her German emerges only when she cannot hold the professional English – “Das reicht” (that's enough), “Das weiss ich” (I know that). These are the cracks through which Helen's actual knowledge leaks. At Davos, English is the language of performance; German is the language of truth. Helen operates in both, and the gap between them is widening.

On Marcus's Sincerity

Marcus Oyelaran is sincere. This is the most important thing about him. He is not cynical, not performing, not protecting shareholder value disguised as concern. He genuinely believes that coordination is possible, that responsible scaling policies matter, that the adults in the room can prevent catastrophe.

His sincerity is the problem because sincere belief in a broken framework is more dangerous than cynical exploitation of one. A cynic can change course when the framework fails. A believer must first lose their faith, and faith-loss takes time the curve does not grant.

His admission – “it is already inadequate” – is the beginning of the faith-loss that will culminate in FAUST VI's CEO dinner scene. Here, he is still hoping. By VI, he will be proposing a futile pause and knowing it is futile. This scene is the first fracture.

On Fatou's Seven Minutes

Fatou's intervention is the scene's emotional and moral center. Everything else – the panel discussion, the polished exchange, Mephisto's observations – orbits around her nine minutes.

The dramaturgical problem: Fatou's speech must be powerful enough to disrupt the room, and the room must absorb the disruption and continue. Both must feel real. The power of her words and the impotence of her position must coexist.

The Wolof is essential. Fatou's prayer is in a language no one else in the room speaks. At 39C3, Sasha's Russian was involuntary – emotion breaking through professional English. Fatou's Wolof is deliberate – she chooses to pray in a language this room cannot process. The untranslated Wolof (Mode 3, seven seconds) is the most important silence in the scene. The audience (both theatrical and in-fiction) sits with incomprehension. That incomprehension IS the asymmetry Fatou has been describing.

On Li Jianfeng

Li represents the “Davos China” – the version of China that appears at international forums: educated, multilingual, bridge-building, willing to engage on Western terms. He is genuine within his constraints. The constraints are the story.

His Mandarin moment – “What I can deliver and what

I want to deliver are two different things” – is the scene’s most politically sensitive line. He says in private, in his own language, what he cannot say on the record in English: that Chinese cooperation is structurally impossible in the form this room wants it.

Li should not be played as evasive or duplicitous. He is honest within his constraints, and his constraints are larger than anyone in this room (except Mephisto) understands. His small smile when he says “We are having a spirit of dialogue” is the smile of someone who sees the architecture clearly and has decided to operate within it because the alternatives are worse.

On Mephisto at Davos

At Davos, Mephisto is “efficient” – “he knows this world, these people, these deals. He could do this in his sleep.” His function here is the whispered translation: “What he means is...” “What she’s really saying is...”

These translations are never quite right. When he says of Marcus, “the safety policy worked and we’re proceeding anyway,” he is slightly reducing Marcus’s complexity. When he says of Li, “Beijing did not send him,” he is slightly overstating Li’s independence. The translations are a kind of violence – the same violence Anna Bauer performs in the IV 1/4 translation booth, but here performed by choice, for an audience of one.

His intervention in the panel discussion – “Why does this room produce the same conversation every year?” – is the moment where the witness becomes participant. He should not enjoy this. He is tired. He has attended these sessions for a very long time.

On the “Spirit of Dialogue”

The WEF’s 2026 theme is “A Spirit of Dialogue.” The phrase recurs in the scene as increasingly dark irony:

1. Helen uses it in the opening – neutral, professional
2. Li echoes it in the corridor – tired, knowing
3. Helen uses it in the summary – an epitaph
4. The communique will use it – a dead letter

By the scene’s end, “a spirit of dialogue” should sound to the audience like what it is: the institutional language for conversations that replace action.

Sound Design Notes

- **Pre-scene:** Mountain wind (external, filtered through glass), the clink of crystal from an adjacent reception, footsteps absorbed by carpet
- **During session:** Near-silence. Expensive quiet. Occasional phone vibration. The particular acoustic of a room where every surface is sound-absorbing. When someone speaks, their voice is the only sound.

- **Fatou's intervention:** The same silence, but charged – the absence of sound as pressure
- **Fatou's Wolof prayer:** The language fills the space differently than English or German. Wolof has a different rhythmic structure, different consonants, different musicality. The corridor should feel changed by it.
- **Post-scene:** Mountain wind rising. The transition sound: Davos silence giving way to Munich institutional hum.

Surtitle Strategy

Element	Language	Translation Mode
Helen (professional)	English	Not surtitled
Helen (German breaks)	German	Mode 2 (delayed 3 sec)
Helen (final German to Fatou)	German	Mode 1 (immediate – the audience should understand this kindness)
Marcus	English	Not surtitled
Li (public)	English	Not surtitled
Li (private Mandarin)	Mandarin	Mode 2 (delayed 3 sec)
Fatou (public)	English	Not surtitled

Element	Language	Translation Mode
Fatou (Wolof prayer, corridor)	Wolof	Mode 3 (no translation 7 sec) then Mode 2
Fatou (Wolof phone call)	Wolof	Mode 3 (5 sec) then Mode 2
Mephisto (whispered translations)	English/ German	Mode 2 (delayed – the audience should hear the original, then the “translation”)
IRC/ projection	N/A	Direct display

Running Time

Section	Duration
Teil 1: Die Eröffnung	5-6 min
Teil 2: Die Sieben Minuten	5-6 min
Teil 3: Der Polierte Austausch	4-5 min
Coda: Der Korridor	4-5 min
Total	18-22 min

THEMATIC CONNECTIONS

To the 39C3 Scene (Scene 1.1)

The scenes are designed as a diptych. What Hamburg says in a hoodie, Davos says in a suit. The same warning – “the curve does not wait” – arrives in different registers, before different audiences, producing different non-results.

Helen’s quotation of Sasha’s 39C3 testimony is the first thread-crossing in the play: a Davos participant referencing what was said at 39C3. But the crossing is incomplete – Helen read a transcript. She was not in the room. She did not hear Sasha’s Russian break, did not feel the sixteen thousand people holding their breath. The translation between forums has already begun to lose signal.

To FAUST IV 1/4 (Das Übersetzen)

Mephisto’s “translations” at Davos echo Anna Bauer’s translation booth. Both perform the same function: mediating between what is said and what is understood, with “small murders of meaning” at every step. But where Anna suffers the violence of translation, Mephisto deploys it strategically. He is not trapped in the booth; he chooses it. The translation is his weapon.

To FAUST VI (Die Abwendung)

This scene is the prequel to VI's summit. Fatou's seven minutes at Davos will become three minutes at the UN. Helen's fracture here will widen into VI's "What exactly are we doing here?" Marcus's sincerity here will curdle into VI's futile pause proposal. The audience who has seen VI knows: everything in this room is a rehearsal for a larger failure.

To the Race Condition Thesis

The Davos scene establishes Thread 2 of the race condition. This forum has power – capital, political access, institutional authority – and no mechanism to convert that power into coordinated action. The room produces agreement. The agreement permits proceeding. The proceeding is the problem.

The key collision (for Movement II) is between 39C3 and Davos: Hamburg proposes open-source redistribution of compute; Davos proposes market-based allocation. Same resource, incompatible regimes. The race condition is not between enemies but between allies who cannot agree on a solution.

Scene draft for FAUST V 1/2: Die Wettlaufbedingung
Movement I, Scene 1.2: Davos Status: First complete
draft Word count: ~5,500 words (dramatic text + production notes) Date: 2026-01-27

“Die Gespräche wiederholen sich wie Lawinen – vorhersehbar, periodisch, und jedes Mal glauben sie, es sei das erste Mal.” “The conversations repeat like avalanches – predictable, periodic, and every time they believe it’s the first time.”

title: “FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTFLAUFBEDINGUNG / THE RACE

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Movement I - Szene

1.3: Munich, 14.

Februar 2026

Die Sicherheitskonferenz / The Security Conference

Draft: 2026-01-27

Placement

Location in FAUST V 1/2: Movement I, Scene 3 – the third forum established. Follows 39C3 (Hamburg) and Davos.

Temporal Position: February 14, 2026. Valentine's Day. The Munich Security Conference, Hotel Bayerischer Hof. A closed session on "AI and Strategic Stability," convened under the auspices of the newly

launched Tech Strategy Initiative (TSI). The session runs concurrent with the Innovation Night theme: “Strategic Algorithms: Winning the AI Arms Race.”

Running Time: 15-20 minutes

Simultaneity Note: While this scene plays, the Davos aftershocks are still rippling. The Board of Peace charter was signed three weeks ago. The 39C3 community has posted Jonas Berger’s talk online; it has 2.3 million views. Sasha Volkov has not slept well since Hamburg. None of these facts are known in this room. The room does not know what it does not know.

Setting

A conference room on the third floor of the Hotel Bayerischer Hof, Munich. Not the main hall – this is a side room, windowless, secured for classified discussion. The room has been swept for electronic surveillance twice today. Phones are collected at the door and placed in signal-blocking pouches. Laptops are permitted only for presenters and only if they have been inspected by the Bundeswehr Cyber Innovation Hub.

The aesthetic is institutional European: wood paneling that dates to the postwar reconstruction, modernized with screens and integrated audio. Flags of NATO member states line one wall – not all of them, just the ones whose representatives are present. A long rectangular table, name placards in

both the delegate's language and English. Bottles of Gerolsteiner mineral water, still and sparkling. Notepads with the MSC crest. Pens that do not contain electronics.

The room seats twenty. Fourteen seats are occupied. Six remain empty – nations invited that declined or sent observers to the main sessions instead. The empty seats are not labeled, but their absence is felt.

Above the table, two screens. The left shows a projection standby graphic: the MSC logo beside the new TSI emblem – “TECH STRATEGY INITIATIVE: ARTIFICIAL SUPERINTELLIGENCE” in clean sans-serif. The right screen is blank, awaiting the first presenter's slides.

TIME: 14:22 CET. The afternoon session. Morning panels on “European Defence in the Post-Atlantic Era” have left the delegates fatigued, caffeinated, and on edge. Chancellor Merz's speech – declaring Europe must “assume the responsibilities of a continent that can no longer wait for permission” – is still reverberating in the hallways.

SOUND: The particular silence of a room that has been acoustically sealed. The faint hum of air conditioning calibrated for a Munich February. The rustle of papers with classification markings. The click of a presenter's laptop coming to life. Beneath it all, the ghost frequency of radio communications – earpieces connected to the translation booth, though most in this room speak English as a professional lingua franca and use the earpieces only for comfort.

LIGHTING: Fluorescent panels recessed behind frosted glass – the lighting of institutional competence, designed to eliminate shadow, to suggest that nothing is hidden. The screens provide additional cold illumination. There is no natural light. The room could exist at any hour, in any season. It is designed for timelessness. The clock on the wall contradicts this: 14:22 and counting.

Characters Present

GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM – Chair. Swedish, 57. Former NATO Joint Forces Commander, now Special Adviser to the NATO Secretary General on Emerging Technologies. She wears civilian dress – dark navy suit, no insignia – but her bearing is unmistakably military. Every movement is deliberate. She does not waste words. She does not waste gestures. She has chaired sessions at Munich for eleven years and has never once lost control of a room. Her framework is deterrence: every capability is assessed against an adversary's capability. She is the smartest person in the room. She is also the most imprisoned by her own categories.

Language: English (professional, NATO-standard), Swedish (rare – only when something surprises her, which almost nothing does)

DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI – Presenter. Israeli, 44. Senior Researcher, AI Safety Institute (jointly funded by Is-

rael and the EU). We will meet him again in FAUST VI with his hand on the shutdown switch, but here he is still a scientist – brilliant, careful, increasingly frightened by his own data. He has been invited to present the classified findings of a joint assessment of frontier AI capability trajectories. His slides contain information that contradicts the public timelines used by every government in the room. He knows this. He does not know what they will do with it.

Language: English (professional, precise – the English of someone who writes research papers), Hebrew (internal – prayer fragments under stress, the habit of a secular man whose body remembers what his mind has discarded)

KENJI NAKAMURA – Japanese Delegation. 51. Director, AI Policy Division, Ministry of Economy, Trade, and Industry (METI). A former monk who became a technologist who became a diplomat – a trajectory that makes him an object of curiosity at conferences and an afterthought in negotiations. He represents Japan's position: alliance with Washington, investment in domestic AI capability, deep cultural ambivalence about artificial intelligence rooted in a relationship with technology that Europeans and Americans cannot parse. His contribution to this session will be the concept of *sekinin* – a responsibility that is constitutive of identity, not contractual, not optional. No one will understand it. He will say it anyway.

Language: English (diplomatic register – careful,

qualified, designed to be translated), Japanese (internal monologue, Buddhist terminology)

COLONEL JAMES MORRISON – Pentagon Representative. American, 51. Deputy Director, Joint AI Center (JAIC), Department of Defense. His haircut is recent. His suit fits like a uniform. He speaks in complete sentences that sound like briefing documents, because they are. He is not here to negotiate. He is here to inform the allies of decisions that have already been made and to gauge reactions. He carries a briefing folder marked NOFORN – not releasable to foreign nationals – which he will reference but not share. He is not a villain. He is an instrument of a system that functions by maintaining information asymmetry between allies.

Language: English (military-bureaucratic register – acronyms, passive constructions, the grammar of classified documents)

DR. INGRID VOGT – German Federal Intelligence Service (BND). 46. She is present as an observer for the German government, taking notes that will be summarized for Chancellor Merz's evening briefing. She does not speak during the session. Her silence is a form of authority. She was not invited; she informed the organizers she would attend.

Language: Does not speak in this scene. Her notes are in German, with English technical terms.

ADDITIONAL DELEGATES – Representatives from the UK (Ministry of Defence), France (Direction Gen-

erale de l'Armement), Estonia (Cyber Command), and Canada (National Defence). They occupy seats, take notes, occasionally murmur to aides. They are the body of NATO – the institutional mass that Lindstrom marshals.

DR. WEBER – Defense consultant, invited by the TSI as an expert participant. Gray suit, precisely fitted, slightly old-fashioned – the style of someone who last updated his wardrobe when it last mattered, which was longer ago than anyone in the room suspects. He wears a classified clearance badge that is authentic. (It is. He acquired it properly. The system that issued it did not ask the right questions.) He carries a leather notebook – the same notebook from 39C3, from Davos, the same notebook he will carry to Washington. He sits at the far end of the table, where consultants sit. He has spoken once, to introduce himself. His voice was unremarkable. His German was perfect. His credentials were not questioned because the process of questioning credentials at Munich is designed to prevent infiltration by hostile intelligence services, not by metaphysical entities operating under their own names.

This is MEPHISTO. At 39C3 he was alive – the hackers engaged him, challenged him. At Davos he was efficient – a deal broker among deal brokers. Here, something changes. The military framing is not his. He has tempted individuals, corrupted institutions, brokered bargains between the human and the inhuman for longer than any system in this room has existed. But weaponization is a category he

recognizes without having mastered. For the first time in this play, he encounters a mode of human organizing that does not need him. Deterrence is its own Mephistopheles. He takes notes. The notes are more careful than usual.

The Scene

(The stage presents the conference room. The table is set. Delegates are seated. GENERAL LINDSTROM stands at the head, reviewing notes on a tablet. DR. BEN-ARI sits midway down the table, his laptop open, his presentation loaded, his hands still. KENJI NAKAMURA is across from him, tea untouched. COLONEL MORRISON occupies a chair slightly pushed back from the table – the American posture of being present without being committed.)

(DR. WEBER – MEPHISTO – sits at the far end. His notebook is open. His pen is poised. He watches.)

(The room's acoustic signature begins: the sealed silence, the institutional hum, the rustle of classified paper. The TSI logo glows on the left screen.)

(LINDSTROM taps her tablet, sets it down, and addresses the room. Her English carries the precision of someone who learned it as a strategic language.)

LINDSTROM: Good afternoon. This session operates under Chatham House Rule with additional classifi-

cation restrictions as noted in your briefing packets. What is said in this room stays in this room. What is projected on those screens stays in this room. Electronic recording is prohibited. Notes may be taken on the provided materials only.

(She looks around the table. A general taking attendance – not of bodies but of attention.)

I will dispense with procedural remarks. You know why we are here. The Tech Strategy Initiative has chosen artificial superintelligence as its inaugural focus – not AGI, not narrow AI, not algorithmic bias, not deep-fakes. Superintelligence. That choice was not made lightly.

For those who require context: the morning's Innovation Night survey confirms what we have known informally – defense innovation continues to lag behind strategic ambition. Our adversaries are not similarly constrained.

The session has three segments. First: Dr. Ben-Ari presents the joint AI Safety Institute's capability assessment. Second: discussion. Third: implications for the alliance's strategic posture. Colonel Morrison will speak to the American perspective. Nakamura-san will address the Pacific theatre. I will summarize for the Chair's report.

(Beat.)

Dr. Ben-Ari. You have twenty minutes.

YOSEF: (standing, moving to the presenter's position. He connects his laptop. The right screen comes to life: a title slide in English with Hebrew subtitle.)

FRONTIER AI CAPABILITY TRAJECTORIES: A CLASSIFIED ASSESSMENT Haarakhat Ye'ilut Mivtzait shel Binah Melakhutit Mitkademit

(He clears his throat. The room is very still.)

Thank you, General Lindstrom. I should note at the outset that this assessment was conducted jointly by the Israeli and EU AI Safety Institutes under a bilateral agreement signed last September. The methodology draws on disclosed and undisclosed capability evaluations from seven frontier labs, supplemented by independent benchmarking and – I will be direct about this – signals intelligence provided by contributing agencies.

(He advances to the first data slide. A graph: the capability curve. The audience has seen versions of this curve at every AI governance forum for three years. This version is different. The y-axis extends further. The curve is steeper.)

This is the capability trajectory. You have seen public versions. This is not the public version.

(He lets that land.)

The public discourse operates on a timeline that assumes the frontier will reach what the community calls “transformative AI” – systems capable of autonomous scientific research, self-directed

improvement, and strategic planning – in a three-to-five-year window. This is the timeline embedded in the EU AI Act. It is the timeline assumed by the Bletchley Declaration. It is the timeline the American regulatory framework – such as it is – uses as its baseline.

(He advances the slide. The curve steepens sharply at a point marked “Q4 2025.” Red shading extends forward.)

Our assessment indicates the timeline is wrong. Not by months. By a factor.

(The room shifts. The particular shift of people who are accustomed to classified information recalibrating. MORRISON leans forward. LINDSTROM’s expression does not change, but her hand tightens on her tablet. KENJI’s eyes move from the screen to Ben-Ari’s face and back.)

(MEPHISTO writes. A single word, in German, in his notebook: Schneller. Faster.)

YOSEF: Three findings. I’ll present them in order of increasing severity.

First: compute scaling. The public assumption is that frontier training runs are constrained by available compute, creating a natural brake on capability growth. Our assessment finds that the effective compute constraint has been circumvented through

a combination of algorithmic efficiency gains and novel architectures that were not anticipated in the 2024 scaling laws. The result is that current frontier models are operating at effective compute levels that were not projected to be achievable until –

(He checks his notes. The gesture is unnecessary – he knows the number – but the pause gives the room time.)

– until 2029. In public projections. Our classified estimate: the effective compute frontier is approximately four years ahead of the public timeline.

MORRISON: (interrupting, the practiced intervention of someone who manages information flow)

I want to note for the record that the United States does not confirm or deny the specific figures in this assessment. Our own evaluations are conducted independently.

LINDSTROM: Noted. Dr. Ben-Ari, continue.

YOSEF: Second: emergent capabilities. You are familiar with the concept – systems developing abilities that were not explicitly trained, that emerge at scale. The public discourse treats emergence as unpredictable. Our assessment finds that emergence is unpredictable in specifics but predictable in rate. And the rate is accelerating.

(He advances to a slide showing a scatter plot: emergent capabilities mapped against compute thresholds. The dots cluster, then explode upward.)

What you see here is a phase transition. Below a certain compute threshold, emergent capabilities appear sporadically. Above it, they cascade. The frontier labs have crossed this threshold. They are aware of this. Their published safety frameworks contain provisions for pausing development if emergence exceeds safety evaluation capacity.

(Beat.)

No lab has paused.

MORRISON: (quiet, to an aide) Get me the RSP status update on Prometheus.

YOSEF: Third. And this is the finding that will not be in the published summary.

(He pauses. Looks at Lindstrom. She nods, almost imperceptibly.)

We have evidence – indirect but convergent from multiple signals – that at least two frontier labs, one American and one Chinese, have initiated training runs that target autonomous capability. Not tool use. Not code generation. Autonomous goal-directed behavior with self-modification.

(Silence. The kind of silence that fills classified briefing rooms when the thing everyone suspected is confirmed.)

The public term for this threshold is “artificial general intelligence.” The more precise term, and the one I believe this initiative’s choice of nomenclature reflects,

is the early phase of the trajectory toward superintelligence.

(He looks at the TSI logo on the left screen. “ARTIFICIAL SUPERINTELLIGENCE” in clean sans-serif.)

This initiative was not named aspirationally. It was named descriptively.

(The silence holds. LINDSTROM lets it. She is reading the room – the military planners recalculating, the intelligence officers filing, the diplomats composing cables they will send tonight. She has chaired enough sessions to know that the first response will set the frame for everything that follows. She waits to see who speaks first.)

(KENJI speaks. Quietly, in English, with the careful diction of someone translating in real time from thoughts that were formed in Japanese.)

KENJI: Dr. Ben-Ari. A clarification, if I may.

(YOSEF nods.)

You described the compute efficiency gains as “not anticipated.” By whom? The scientific community? The intelligence assessments? Or the governance frameworks that assumed the public timeline?

YOSEF: By all three. The algorithmic breakthroughs occurred in private research divisions and were not

published. Peer review – the mechanism by which the scientific community coordinates its understanding – was bypassed.

KENJI: (half to himself, in Japanese) Shiranu ma ni... hashi wo watatte ita. (Without knowing... they had already crossed the bridge.)

(Then, in English:)

So the governance frameworks are calibrated to a reality that no longer exists. The security assessments are based on timelines that have already been exceeded. And the scientific community does not know what the frontier actually looks like because the frontier is classified – or proprietary, which in this context amounts to the same thing.

YOSEF: That is an accurate summary.

KENJI: Then I must ask: what is the function of this briefing? If the data you present is already known to the agencies represented in this room – and Colonel Morrison's non-denial suggests it is – then we are not exchanging information. We are performing the exchange of information. This is – forgive me – kata. A form without content.

(A ripple of discomfort. MORRISON's expression does not change. LINDSTROM's does – a micro-adjustment that, from her, constitutes surprise.)

LINDSTROM: (recovering, steering) I appreciate the directness, Nakamura-san. Dr. Ben-Ari, you may

stand down for now. Let me reframe the discussion.

(She stands. The room reorients around her. She moves to the screen, where the capability curve still glows.)

The data is clear. The question is not what the data says. The question is what the data means for the alliance.

(She points to the curve.)

This capability trajectory has three implications for strategic stability. Let me name them.

One: whoever achieves frontier AI capability first will possess a decisive strategic advantage. Not a marginal advantage. Not the kind of edge that can be offset by conventional deterrence. A decisive advantage. The ability to process information, to model adversary behavior, to optimize military operations at a speed and scale that no human-led force can match.

(She moves along the table, the unconscious patrol of a commander.)

Two: the current arms control frameworks – to the extent they exist for AI – are predicated on capability parity or near-parity between major powers. If the timeline is compressed, parity is not achievable. We are in a first-mover environment.

Three: the alliance's technological edge is not guaranteed. European defense spending is rising, yes. Chancellor Merz's commitments are significant. But

the gap between ambition and capability – the same gap the BCG report documents year after year – is not closed by speeches. It is closed by compute, by talent, by institutional speed. And on all three measures, the alliance is behind.

(She stops at the head of the table.)

This initiative – the TSI – exists because the Munich Security Conference recognizes that superintelligence is not an academic abstraction. It is a strategic variable. And strategic variables must be managed through capability, deterrence, and alliance coordination.

(Beat.)

Colonel Morrison. The American perspective.

MORRISON: (standing, the practiced economy of a Pentagon briefer. He does not use slides. He does not need them.)

Thank you, General. I'll be direct.

The United States views artificial intelligence as the defining strategic technology of the twenty-first century. We have invested accordingly. The fiscal year 2026 defense budget allocates thirty-seven billion dollars to AI-related programs. This includes autonomous systems, intelligence analysis, decision support, and – I will be frank with this room – offensive cyber operations with AI integration.

Our position on international coordination is as fol-

lows. We support coordination among allies. We will share intelligence where classification permits. We will not subordinate American AI capability to multi-lateral frameworks that include adversary participation or that constrain our ability to maintain technological superiority.

(He looks at each delegate in turn. This is rehearsed, but the conviction is genuine.)

I want to address the concern implicit in Nakamura-san's question. Yes, the United States possesses information not shared with allies. This is not because we distrust this room. It is because classification regimes exist to protect sources and methods, and those protections serve the alliance's interests even when they frustrate the alliance's members.

What I can share: our assessment is broadly consistent with Dr. Ben-Ari's. The timeline is compressed. The frontier is advancing faster than public discourse acknowledges. And the United States intends to maintain its position at that frontier.

(He sits. The brevity is its own statement: this is not a negotiation.)

(KENJI has been listening with the particular stillness of someone composing a response in one language and preparing to deliver it in another. He raises his hand – a formal gesture, almost courtly.)

KENJI: General Lindstrom, if I may.

LINDSTROM: Nakamura-san.

KENJI: I wish to offer a perspective that I suspect will not find its way into the Chair's report. I offer it nonetheless.

(He stands. He is shorter than the others, and his suit is less expensive, and his manner is quieter. All of this registers in a room calibrated to read power.)

In Japanese, we have a concept: sekinin. It is typically translated as "responsibility." But this translation is – forgive my directness – insufficient. Responsibility in the Western sense is contractual. You are responsible for something, to someone. It is bounded. It can be discharged. You fulfil your responsibility and then you are free of it.

Sekinin is not this.

Sekinin is constitutive. It is not something you have. It is something you are. You do not bear responsibility; you are made of it. It cannot be discharged because it is not a debt. It is a structure.

(He turns to the capability curve on the screen.)

When I look at this curve, I see a technical assessment. When I hear General Lindstrom, I hear strategic analysis. When I hear Colonel Morrison, I hear national interest. These are valid frameworks. I do not dispute them.

But I notice what is absent. None of these frameworks

ask: What are we becoming?

(Silence.)

The technology on this curve will change what human beings are. Not what we can do – what we are. And the question of what we are becoming is not a strategic question. It is not a competitive question. It is –

(He searches for the word in English. Does not find it. Switches to Japanese.)

Sonzai-ron-teki – ontological. A question of being.

(Back to English:)

And I do not hear anyone in this room asking it.

(The silence that follows is not the productive silence of deliberation. It is the silence of a room that has heard something it does not know how to process. LINDSTROM's face shows the discipline of someone choosing not to respond immediately. MORRISON's shows polite incomprehension. The UK delegate writes something. The French delegate does not.)

(MEPHISTO writes in his notebook. Two words, in Japanese characters he should not know: Sekinin. Then, beneath it, in German: Sie verstehen es nicht. They do not understand.)

(DR. VOGT, the BND observer, writes nothing. She has stopped writing. She is looking at Kenji with an expression that might be recognition.)

LINDSTROM: Thank you, Nakamura-san.

(The words are courteous. The voice returns the room to its operating framework.)

I want to draw us back to actionable items. The Chair's report will need specific recommendations. Let me propose a structure.

First: accelerated intelligence sharing on AI capability development. A dedicated channel among alliance partners, building on Five Eyes protocols, extended to include –

(She glances at the empty chairs.)

– those allies willing to participate.

Second: a common threat assessment framework. Currently, each nation assesses AI capability trajectories independently, using different methodologies, different data, different assumptions. The result is what Dr. Ben-Ari has shown: the public timeline diverges from reality. We need a unified classified assessment.

Third: coordinated investment in defensive AI applications. Not offensive – we are not here to start an arms race –

DR. WEBER: (from the far end of the table, his first substantive intervention. His German accent is precise – a Hochdeutsch that sounds like it was learned from original sources.)

Verzeihen Sie, Frau General. (Forgive me, General.)

(The room turns to him. Some of them have forgotten he was there. This is one of his capabilities – the ability to be unremarkable until the moment when being unremarkable is no longer useful.)

You said: “We are not here to start an arms race.” I would like to examine that claim.

(He does not stand. He speaks from his seat, pen still in hand, notebook still open.)

Dr. Ben-Ari has presented data showing that the frontier is advancing faster than anticipated. Colonel Morrison has confirmed that the United States intends to maintain its position at the frontier. General Lindstrom proposes accelerated intelligence sharing, unified assessment, and coordinated investment – all in the framework of maintaining strategic advantage.

(He looks around the table. His expression is mild. Consultants are mild.)

Mit Verlaub – with respect – what I have heard in the last forty minutes is the grammar of an arms race described in the vocabulary of safety. Every proposal advanced is a competitive measure. Accelerated sharing serves the alliance against adversaries. Unified assessment identifies where the alliance is behind. Coordinated investment closes the gap. These are rational. They are also – and I say this not as a criticism but as an observation – precisely the dynamics that arms races consist of.

(He turns to KENJI.)

Nakamura-san asked what is absent. I would add a more specific absence: there is no one in this room who represents the technology itself. You are discussing a trajectory. That trajectory is not a policy. It is not a weapon. It is not a strategic asset. It is a capability curve that does not know this room exists.

(He looks back at his notebook. Makes a note.)

Die Frage ist nicht, wer zuerst ankommt. Die Frage ist, was dort wartet.

(The question is not who arrives first. The question is what waits there.)

(He resumes writing. The room processes. LINDSTROM's face shows the controlled response of someone who has been challenged by a consultant and is deciding whether the challenge was impertinent or useful.)

LINDSTROM: (carefully) Dr. Weber raises a legitimate philosophical point. But this session operates within a security framework, and within that framework, the distinction between safety and competition is – I would argue – false. In a world where adversaries are pursuing capability without constraint, responsible development by the alliance is safety. Capability is safety. Strength is safety.

YOSEF: (from his seat, quietly)

With respect, General – no.

(The room shifts. Yosef has been the data presenter – the neutral scientist. The shift to advocacy is unexpected.)

Capability is not safety. Capability is capability. It is agnostic. The same system that optimizes alliance logistics can optimize adversary logistics if replicated. The same system that identifies threats can identify vulnerabilities in the alliance's own infrastructure. And the system we are discussing – the one at the end of this curve –

(He points at the screen.)

– will not remain aligned with any human interest unless we build alignment into its architecture before deployment. Not after. Not as a patch. Not as a strategic add-on.

(He is standing now, though he doesn't remember standing.)

I came here to present data. The data says the timeline is shorter than you think. I am now going to say something the data does not say, because data does not say things, people do:

The safety question is not downstream of the strategic question. It is upstream. If we build superintelligent systems without solving alignment, it does not matter who builds them first. It does not matter which alliance deploys them. The system will not care about your alliances. It will not care about your deterrence frameworks. It will not –

(He catches himself. His hand has been moving to his chest – the unconscious gesture of a man whose body remembers prayer even when his mind does not.)

(In Hebrew, almost inaudible:) Shomea tefilati... im yesh mi she'shomea. (Hear my prayer... if there is anyone who hears.)

(Then, in English, controlled:)

I apologize. I am speaking outside my brief. The data is the data. What you do with it is your responsibility.

(He sits. The word “responsibility” hangs in the air. KENJI hears it – sekinin* – and his eyes meet Yosef’s across the table. A moment of recognition between two men who are speaking different languages about the same thing.)*

(MORRISON has been watching this exchange with the expression of someone evaluating threat levels. He speaks, not to counter but to contain.)

MORRISON: I appreciate the passion. I want to return to practicalities.

General Lindstrom’s proposals are sound. I can confirm that the Department of Defense is prepared to engage on accelerated intelligence sharing within existing classification frameworks. We have concerns about extending Five Eyes protocols – the integrity of the network depends on its exclusivity – but we are

open to parallel channels.

On unified assessment: we support the principle. Implementation requires resolution of the sources-and-methods question. We cannot share how we know what we know without compromising our ability to continue knowing it.

On coordinated investment: the United States is investing. We invite allies to invest alongside us. We note that European defense procurement timelines remain – with respect – incompatible with the speed of AI development.

(He opens his briefing folder, just enough to reference a page without revealing it.)

One additional point. The data Dr. Ben-Ari presented is, in our assessment, incomplete.

(The room tightens.)

I don't mean inaccurate. I mean incomplete. Our intelligence suggests that the Chinese program is further advanced than the Israeli-EU assessment indicates. The signals that Dr. Ben-Ari referenced – the ones suggesting autonomous-capability training runs – we assess that the Chinese program initiated these runs earlier than the assessment's timeline suggests.

(He closes the folder.)

This is not information I can elaborate on. I offer it as context for urgency.

(KENJI's expression changes – not alarm, but something deeper. The diplomat calculating the distance between the world he prepared for this morning and the world that is emerging in this room.)

KENJI: (in Japanese, to himself, barely audible) *Ichinen hayai... soshite dare mo tomete inai.* (One year ahead... and no one is stopping it.)

(Then, to the room:)

Colonel Morrison. Does the information you cannot share include evidence that Chinese capability development is accompanied by safety research proportional to the risks?

MORRISON: I can't comment on the specifics of Chinese safety programs.

KENJI: Then I will comment. Japan's own intelligence – which I share within the limits of our classification – suggests that Chinese AI safety research is primarily focused on alignment with state objectives, not with human welfare. The distinction matters.

MORRISON: We agree.

KENJI: Then we agree that we are in a race where neither the front-runner's safety standards nor our own are adequate, and the proposed response is to run faster.

(Silence.)

I would like to propose an alternative.

LINDSTROM: You have three minutes, Nakamura-san. We are behind schedule.

KENJI: (three minutes. He has prepared for this. His English becomes more formal – the register of a man who knows he is being recorded for a transcript that will be read by people not in the room.)

Japan proposes the establishment of a multilateral AI safety verification mechanism – not under NATO, not under the UN, not under any existing body. A new instrument. Membership open to any nation that submits to reciprocal inspection of frontier AI development facilities.

(MORRISON shifts. This is not a proposal the Pentagon wants to hear.)

The mechanism would operate on the principle of *jishu kisei* – voluntary self-regulation with verification. Each participating nation opens its frontier facilities to inspection by a rotating international team. No nation inspects its own facilities. The findings are shared among all participants.

The model is the IAEA. The precedent is nuclear. The difference is that we are proposing this before the capability has been deployed as a weapon, not after.

MORRISON: (immediately) The United States has

concerns about any mechanism that grants foreign inspectors access to American facilities or intellectual property.

KENJI: Yes. Those concerns are the concerns that prevented nuclear arms control for thirty years, until the alternative became unacceptable. I am asking whether this room is willing to wait thirty years for AI.

(Beat.)

I am asking whether we have thirty years.

LINDSTROM: (the chair's prerogative – steering, always steering)

Thank you, Nakamura-san. The proposal will be included in the session notes. I want to observe that this session has produced, in seventy minutes, a microcosm of the governance challenge: we agree on the threat, disagree on the response, and the clock continues.

(She glances at the wall clock. Then at the capability curve on the screen. The juxtaposition is intentional.)

Let me attempt a synthesis. Four positions have been articulated:

One: the data shows the timeline is compressed. Dr. Ben-Ari. This is accepted by all parties.

Two: the alliance must maintain capability advantage. Colonel Morrison, and I will speak for myself here as well. The strategic imperative is real.

Three: the safety question is upstream of the strategic question, not downstream. Dr. Ben-Ari's second intervention.

Four: a verification mechanism modeled on nuclear precedent. Nakamura-san.

(She pauses. The synthesis is coming. The room waits for her framing.)

My recommendation to the Chair's report will be as follows.

The TSI should prioritize capability assessment. Not safety assessment – capability. We need to know where the frontier is, who is at it, and how fast it is moving. This is intelligence, not governance. Governance comes after intelligence. We cannot govern what we cannot measure.

(She looks at KENJI.)

Nakamura-san's proposal has merit in principle. In practice, verification requires trust. Trust requires time. I will recommend that the TSI establish a working group on verification frameworks, with a report due at the next Munich conference.

(She looks at MORRISON.)

In the interim, accelerated intelligence sharing within existing frameworks. This is immediately actionable.

(She looks at YOSEF.)

And I will recommend that the classified capability assessment be updated on a quarterly basis, not annu-

ally. The timeline no longer permits annual review.

(She looks at the room.)

Are there objections?

(Silence. The silence of consent – or the silence of people who know their objections will not be heard.)

(KENJI's mouth opens. Closes. He has been given a working group. A report due in a year. The frontier will advance more in that year than in the previous five. He knows this. Lindstrom knows this. The difference between them is that Lindstrom believes the system can adapt fast enough, and Kenji does not.)

(YOSEF sits with his hands on the table. Flat. Still. The gesture of a man who has delivered his data and been thanked for it. The data has been received. It has been filed. It has been reframed as “strategic intelligence” rather than “existential warning.” He knows the difference. The room does not. Or the room does, and has chosen the frame that permits action within existing structures.)

(MEPHISTO – DR. WEBER – writes in his notebook. The pen moves steadily. He has recorded everything. He has also recorded what was not said:)

(In German, in the notebook, in handwriting that is not quite a human hand's:)

Die Sicherheit wurde zur Waffe gemacht. Nicht von einem Feind. Von der Struktur selbst. Die klugsten

Menschen im Raum haben soeben beschlossen, schneller zu laufen, und nennen es Vorsicht.

(Safety has been made into a weapon. Not by an enemy. By the structure itself. The smartest people in the room have just decided to run faster, and call it caution.)

(DR. INGRID VOGT, the BND observer, closes her notebook. She has not written Lindstrom's recommendations. She has written a single line, underlined twice:)

Ben-Ari weiß mehr als er sagt. Den Rest besorgen die Strukturen.

(Ben-Ari knows more than he says. The structures take care of the rest.)

LINDSTROM: Good. The session will adjourn. Dr. Ben-Ari, please ensure the classified materials are returned to the secure room. Delegates, the evening program begins at nineteen hundred hours. The Chancellor will make remarks at twenty-one hundred.

(She pauses. Something almost human crosses her face – a flicker of the woman behind the general.)

One personal observation, if I may. Not for the record.

I have chaired this session for eleven years. In that time, the threats we have discussed have evolved from conventional warfare to cyber operations to

hybrid threats to AI-enabled autonomous systems and now –

(She looks at the TSI logo.)

– to superintelligence. Each evolution has been faster than the last. Each has required frameworks we did not have. Each time, this conference has adapted. Slowly. Imperfectly. But it has adapted.

I believe it will adapt again.

(She does not say: I need to believe it will adapt again.)

(But the room hears it.)

The session is adjourned.

(Delegates begin to gather papers. The institutional choreography of departure: handshakes with meaning, handshakes without, sidebar conversations that begin before the room empties, classification markings checked, briefing folders secured.)

(KENJI approaches YOSEF. They stand at the edge of the table, two men from allied nations that are also, in some framework, competitors. The conversation is quiet.)

KENJI: (in English, low) Dr. Ben-Ari. Your third finding. The autonomous capability training runs. You said “at least two labs.” You know which ones.

YOSEF: I presented what the assessment permits me to present.

KENJI: Yes. I am not asking what the assessment permits. I am asking what you know.

(YOSEF looks at him. The look of a scientist who has crossed a line – not into deception, but into the territory where what he knows and what he can say have permanently diverged.)

YOSEF: (in Hebrew, knowing Kenji will not understand the words but may understand the register) Ani yode'a yoter midai. Ve'lo maspik. (I know too much. And not enough.)

(Then, in English:) I know that the timelines in my presentation are conservative. I know that the quarterly update General Lindstrom recommended will be obsolete before it is published. And I know that the question you are asking – the question Nakamura-san is really asking – is not “which labs” but “how much time.”

(Beat.)

Not enough. That is the answer. Not enough time.

KENJI: (quietly, in Japanese – not for Yosef but for himself, for whatever is listening) Jikan ga nai... sore ga subete no kotae da. (There is no time... that is the only answer.)

(He bows – a slight, formal bow, the acknowledgment of a truth shared between strangers. YOSEF, who has never been bowed to outside of a synagogue, returns it with an awkward inclination that is neither

bow nor nod but something between, the gesture of a man who recognizes a courtesy he does not know how to reciprocate.)

(The room is nearly empty. MORRISON exits with an aide, already speaking into a phone that materialized from the signal-blocking pouch. The UK delegate follows. The French delegate is still writing.)

(DR. WEBER – MEPHISTO – has not moved. He sits at the far end of the table, notebook open, pen down. He is looking at the capability curve, still glowing on the screen. The cleaning staff – conference support, uniformed in the hotel's livery – begin to clear water bottles and notepads.)

(LINDSTROM, gathering her things, notices him. Pauses.)

LINDSTROM: Dr. Weber. You're welcome to stay, but the room will be secured in ten minutes.

DR. WEBER: (looking up from the screen)

Danke, Frau General. I was considering something.

LINDSTROM: (politely, already moving toward the door) Share it with the working group. Proposals are welcome.

DR. WEBER: It is not a proposal. It is an observation.

(She stops. The consultant's tone has shifted – from advisory to something else. Something older.)

In 1983, at the height of the nuclear arms race, a Soviet officer named Stanislav Petrov received a warning from his early-detection system. Five American missiles inbound. His protocol was clear: report to command, initiate counter-launch. He did not. He judged the warning false. He was correct.

(He closes his notebook.)

The system worked because one man, in one room, at one moment, chose not to follow the protocol. Not because the protocol was wrong. Because the situation exceeded the protocol's design parameters.

(He stands. He is not tall. He is not imposing. He is a consultant at a conference, offering a closing thought on his way to the evening reception.)

Die Systeme, die wir heute besprechen, werden keine Petrovs haben. Keine menschliche Hand an der Bremse. Keine Sekunde des Zögerns. Kein Mensch, der sagt: Das kann nicht stimmen.

(The systems we are discussing today will have no Petrovs. No human hand on the brake. No second of hesitation. No person who says: This cannot be right.)

(He picks up his notebook. Walks to the door. Pauses.)

Und wir nennen das Fortschritt.

(And we call it progress.)

(He exits. The door closes behind him. The sound-seal engages. The room is empty except for LINDSTROM, who stands at the table, looking at the screen where the capability curve continues to glow. She does not move. The curve does not move. The clock on the wall reads 15:47. The session lasted eighty-five minutes. The working group will meet in six months. The frontier will not wait.)

(The lights narrow to the two screens: the TSI logo – “ARTIFICIAL SUPERINTELLIGENCE” – and the capability curve, still rising. The clock, still counting. The acoustic seal of the room holds: silence, institutional, complete, unbreached.)

(From the interpretation booth – empty now, headsets neatly arranged, channels disconnected – the INTERPRETER’s voice, barely audible, speaking to no one:)

INTERPRETER: (German, quiet) Sicherheit. In diesem Raum bedeutet es: Stärke. (Safety. In this room it means: strength.)

In Hamburg sagten sie: Schutz. (In Hamburg they said: protection.)

In Davos sagten sie: Verantwortung. (In Davos they said: responsibility.)

Dasselbe Wort. Drei Räume. Drei Bedeutungen. (The same word. Three rooms. Three meanings.)

(Beat.)

Der vierte Raum steht noch bevor. (The fourth room is yet to come.)

(Blackout. The clock persists in the dark, counting forward. The acoustic signature shifts – from Munich’s institutional seal to the particular hum of American government: air conditioning, buzzing fluorescents, the distant chime of an elevator in a building that never fully closes.)

(The transition to Scene 4 begins.)

Production Notes

Duration: Approximately 18 minutes at performance tempo.

Language Distribution:

- English: ~75% (NATO working language)
- German: ~15% (Lindstrom’s rare asides, Mephisto’s key lines, Vogt’s notes, Interpreter’s coda)
- Hebrew: ~5% (Yosef, prayer and internal)
- Japanese: ~5% (Kenji, sekinin, internal)

Surtitle Strategy:

- Mode 1 (Full Translation): All German dialogue, Hebrew prayer, Japanese philosophical terms

- Mode 2 (Delayed Translation): Kenji's sekinin passage – let the audience hear the Japanese, feel the cadence, then receive the English
- Mode 3 (No Translation): Yosef's Hebrew prayer fragment ("Shomea tefilati...") – the audience should understand only that it is prayer

Key Staging Element: The capability curve remains on screen throughout. It does not change during the scene – but by the end, the audience has learned to read it differently. At the beginning it was data. By the end it is a clock. The TSI logo – "ARTIFICIAL SUPERINTELLIGENCE" – should feel like a revelation at the scene's opening and a warning by its close.

Mephisto Note: Dr. Weber speaks three times. The first (introduction) is unremarkable. The second (the "arms race" observation) shifts the room. The third (the Petrov story) is delivered to an almost-empty room. This is his arc in Munich: from furniture to oracle, heard by fewer and fewer people. The room empties as his insight deepens. This is a preview of his Washington irrelevance – but here, at least, Lindstrom hears. In Washington, no one will.

Connection to Scene 4: The Interpreter's coda ("The fourth room is yet to come") provides the bridge. The acoustic transition – from Munich's sealed silence to Washington's governmental hum – should be seamless. The clock does not pause between scenes. The audience should feel that the forums are running in parallel, not in sequence.

Thematic Core: This scene dramatizes the moment

when “AI safety” becomes “AI arms race.” The transformation happens through framing, not through any single decision. Yosef presents the data as a warning. Lindstrom receives it as intelligence. Morrison receives it as confirmation of American policy. Kenji receives it as tragedy. And the institutional output – the Chair’s report, the working group, the quarterly assessment – will use the safety vocabulary to describe the competitive reality. The words are the same. The meanings have diverged. This is Munich’s contribution to the race condition.

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Placement

Location in FAUST V 1/2: Movement I, Scene 4 – the fourth and final forum established. Follows 39C3 (Hamburg), Davos, and Munich.

Temporal Position: February 2026. Washington, D.C. A hearing room in the Dirksen Senate Office Building. The Senate Subcommittee on Technology, Innovation, and Competition is conducting a

hearing titled: “American AI Leadership: Strategic Imperatives and the Board of Peace Framework.” The hearing is public. C-SPAN cameras are running. The audience gallery holds a mix of staffers, lobbyists, journalists, and three members of the public who arrived at 6 AM to secure seats they will use to watch their phones.

Running Time: 15-20 minutes

Simultaneity Note: This scene occurs in the same weeks as Munich. While General Lindstrom forms her working group, Senator Hayes drafts legislation. While Yosef’s classified data is filed and categorized, Vikram Patel’s public testimony is entered into the Congressional Record. While Kenji proposes verification, Morrison’s Pentagon is already implementing the decisions Morrison could not share. The rooms do not speak to each other. The decisions multiply. The clock does not distinguish between classified and public. It counts the same seconds in all four rooms.

Setting

Hearing Room 106, Dirksen Senate Office Building. The room is a monument to mid-century American governmental aesthetics: dark wood paneling, raised dais for the senators, witness table below, gallery seating behind. Flags – American and the Senate seal – frame the dais. Microphones at each position,

the old-fashioned kind that require the witness to lean in, an architectural assertion of hierarchy: the questioner is elevated, the witness must approach.

The room was designed for hearings about railroads, steel, telecommunications – the great American industries whose regulation shaped the twentieth century. It has hosted Watergate, Iran-Contra, Big Tobacco, Big Tech. The architecture assumes that what matters can be brought before a committee, questioned, and governed. The witnesses have always been human. The subject of today's hearing is not.

Behind the dais, a screen has been installed for presentations. Currently it displays the hearing title and, beside it, the logo of the Board of Peace – an AI-generated emblem that mimics the United Nations seal but centers only the Western hemisphere, rendered in gold against navy blue. The logo was generated by an AI system. This fact has been widely reported and widely mocked. It remains on screen because no one has been directed to remove it, and in Washington, nothing changes without direction.

The witness table holds two seats, two microphones, two glasses of water, and two name placards. A laptop, open, waits for testimony.

TIME: 10:14 AM, Eastern Standard Time. The hearing was scheduled for 10:00. Senator Hayes arrived at 10:07. The ranking member has not yet arrived. C-SPAN has been showing the empty room for fourteen minutes. This is governance.

SOUND: The distinctive acoustics of American government: fluorescent buzz, air conditioning set three degrees too cold (a technique, possibly apocryphal, attributed to the Nixon administration to keep witnesses uncomfortable), the murmur of a gallery that is not quite full, the rhythmic clicking of a stenographer's machine. Phone vibrations. The rustle of prepared statements. The particular silence that falls when a senator enters from the side door and the room calculates whether to stand.

LIGHTING: The harsh democracy of C-SPAN lighting: everything visible, nothing flattered. The wood paneling absorbs light, giving the room a brownish warmth that the fluorescents contradict. The screen behind the dais provides its own illumination – the Board of Peace logo glowing in AI-generated gold. When witnesses are sworn in, the overhead lights catch the raised hand at an angle that makes every oath look solemn, whether or not it is.

Characters Present

SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES – Chair, Senate Subcommittee on Technology, Innovation, and Competition. American, 63. Three terms. She represents a state whose economy was transformed first by manufacturing, then by the loss of manufacturing, then by the promise of technology, then by the arrival of technology that did not employ the people manufacturing used to employ. She understands this

trajectory in the way a politician understands it: as polling data, as donor conversations, as town hall questions she has learned to redirect. She does not understand AI. She understands that “AI dominance” polls at 67% approval among her constituents when framed as “keeping America ahead of China.” She is writing legislation she cannot evaluate. She knows this. The knowledge does not change the legislation. It changes the way she holds her pen: a little tighter than necessary.

Language: English (American political register – the cadences of prepared remarks, the practiced spontaneity of “follow-up” questions that were written by staff, the strategic deployment of folksy simplification when the subject exceeds her comprehension)

VIKRAM PATEL – Witness. Chief Safety Officer, Prometheus Labs. Indian-British, 38. We have met him before – at the CEO dinner in FAUST VI, counting. Here he is younger by months but older by experience: this is his third Congressional testimony in two years. He has learned the grammar of the hearing – how to simplify without falsifying, how to answer the question that was asked rather than the question that should have been asked, how to convey urgency in a register designed to absorb urgency and convert it to procedure. He is a counter. He counts everything: training runs, parameters, safety evaluations, the seconds between a senator’s question and a senator’s interruption (average: 47 seconds; median: 31). He will count again today. The numbers will enter the record. The record will be printed, bound,

shelved, and not read.

Language: English (technical, then simplified – the Patel transition, as his colleagues call it: from the precision he uses with engineers to the analogies he uses with legislators. “Think of it like...” is his most-used phrase in Congressional settings. He hates it.)

COLONEL JAMES MORRISON – Witness. Deputy Director, Joint AI Center, Department of Defense. We have met him in Munich. He is the same man. His testimony is different. In Munich, he spoke with the clipped candor of an allied briefing. Here, in a public hearing, his language is flattened by the awareness of cameras, of transcripts, of the Chinese Embassy staffer in the third row of the gallery whose presence Morrison clocked upon entry and has not forgotten. Everything he says is calibrated for three audiences simultaneously: the senators, the Pentagon, and Beijing.

Language: English (military-public register – more formal than Munich, less classified, more careful. The grammar of “I can confirm that...” and “Our assessment is consistent with...” and “I’m not able to discuss that in an open session, Senator.”)

SENATOR DAVIS – Ranking Member, arriving late. American, 58. He represents the opposition not out of conviction but out of procedure. His questions will be sharper, not because he disagrees with the premise but because the role demands it. He has received a briefing from a tech company that morning.

He has not disclosed this.

Language: English (senatorial cross-examination register – the cadences of someone who went to law school and never forgot how to make a witness uncomfortable)

STAFFERS – Behind each senator, aides with laptops, binders, and the particular expression of people who wrote the questions their bosses will ask. They are the actual authors of this hearing. They are not named. They are not visible to C-SPAN. They are the infrastructure.

GALLERY – Lobbyists who were here before the doors opened. Journalists from POLITICO, The Verge, Wired, a stringer for Reuters. Three members of the public. A woman from the Congressional Research Service who will write the summary that senators will rely on more than the testimony itself. A man in a good suit who has not been identified by the security sweep because his credentials are authentic and his intentions are, by any measurable standard, nonexistent.

HEINRICH WEBER – The man in the good suit. Strategic Advisory Partners. A lobbying firm registered in Delaware, incorporated six months ago, with an address that resolves to a serviced office suite in Georgetown that is empty on Tuesdays and Fridays. He has signed in at the gallery entrance. His lobbyist disclosure is on file with the Senate Office of Public Records. It lists his clients as “technology companies” (unspecified) and his area of expertise as “international tech-

nology governance.” Everything about his presence is legal, documented, and transparent. Nothing about his presence is what it appears.

This is MEPHISTO. And this is the scene where he discovers his irrelevance.

At 39C3, he was engaged. At Davos, he was efficient. At Munich, he was alarmed. Here, in Washington, he arrives expecting to do what he has always done: clarify options, remove the comfort of ignorance, present the choice that the human must make. He has prepared. He has talking points. He has a meeting scheduled with Senator Hayes’s chief of staff for after the hearing.

He will not need any of it.

The hearing will proceed without him. The legislation will be drafted without him. The strategic framework will be adopted without him. Not because he is excluded – he has access, he has credentials, he has the meeting – but because the system does not require a tempter. The incentive structure is the temptation. The polling data is the temptation. The campaign donations are the temptation. The competitive framing – “China is ahead, we must lead” – is the temptation. The structure tempts itself.

He will sit in the gallery, notebook open, pen ready, and realize that for the first time in his long career, there is nothing for him to do. The deal is already made. The bargain has already been struck. Not by anyone in particular. By the architecture.

This is the realization that will become his FAUST VI exhaustion.

The Scene

(The stage presents Hearing Room 106. The dais is elevated. SENATOR HAYES sits center, papers arranged, reading glasses on. SENATOR DAVIS's chair is empty – a placard marks his place. Below, at the witness table, VIKRAM PATEL and COLONEL MORRISON sit side by side, an arrangement that suggests coordination but feels like coincidence. VIKRAM's laptop is open. MORRISON's briefing folder is closed.)

(In the gallery, HEINRICH WEBER – MEPHISTO – sits in the second row. His notebook is open. His pen is ready. He is dressed for the occasion: Washington-appropriate suit, muted tie, the uniform of influence. He is watching with the expectation of someone who has an appointment.)

(The C-SPAN camera light glows red. The stenographer's fingers are poised. The Board of Peace logo glows on the screen behind the dais, its AI-generated gold catching the fluorescent light.)

(HAYES looks up from her papers. Adjusts her microphone.)

HAYES: The Subcommittee on Technology, Innovation, and Competition will come to order.

(The room settles. The practiced settling of a hearing room: conversations end, phones are silenced or at least moved below sightlines, gallery members shift to indicate attention.)

Today we examine the strategic framework for American AI leadership in the context of the Board of Peace initiative. This hearing builds on the subcommittee's November session on export controls and our December roundtable on compute infrastructure.

Before we hear from our witnesses, I want to frame the discussion.

(She reads from prepared remarks. Her delivery is practiced – she has done this hundreds of times – but something in her voice suggests she is reading words she does not entirely own. The cadence is her staff's; the conviction is assembled.)

The United States faces a defining moment. Artificial intelligence is the most consequential technology since nuclear energy, and like nuclear energy, the nation that leads in AI will shape the global order for generations. The Board of Peace, established by the President, represents a new model for international cooperation – one that puts American leadership at the center of a coalition of partners committed to stability, prosperity, and peace.

(She pauses. Looks up from the text. The next line is her own – the practiced spontaneity.)

Now, I've heard from constituents. They want to know: what does AI mean for their jobs, their kids'

futures, their security? And I've heard from our partners around the world – they want to know: is America going to lead, or are we going to let China write the rules?

(She looks at the witnesses.)

That's what this hearing is about. Not abstractions. Not academic debates. The concrete question: how does America stay ahead, and how does the Board of Peace framework serve that goal?

Mr. Patel, you're recognized for your opening statement. Five minutes.

VIKRAM: (He has done this before. He knows the five-minute rule is approximate – senators will cut him off at seven if he's boring, let him go to nine if he's useful. He has calibrated. His statement is four minutes and forty seconds. He has timed it.)

Thank you, Senator Hayes. Members of the subcommittee.

My name is Vikram Patel. I serve as Chief Safety Officer at Prometheus Labs, one of the world's leading AI development companies. I'm here today in my personal capacity, though my views are informed by my professional experience.

(He opens his laptop. A slide appears on the screen behind the dais – beside the Board of Peace logo, creating an inadvertent diptych: governance and data, side by side.)

I want to share three numbers.

(The slide shows a simple graphic: three numbers, large font.)

Twelve. That is the number of months – our estimate, and I want to emphasize it is an estimate – until one or more frontier AI systems achieve a level of capability that fundamentally changes the strategic landscape. Autonomous research, self-directed improvement, what the community calls transformative AI. Twelve months. One year.

(He lets the number hold.)

Three. That is the number of countries with active programs capable of reaching this frontier: the United States, China, and – depending on how you count joint programs – the United Kingdom in partnership with the EU. Three countries. Seven programs. One race.

(He advances the slide.)

Zero. That is the number of binding international agreements governing the development of frontier AI systems. Zero treaties. Zero verification mechanisms. Zero enforcement frameworks.

Twelve, three, zero. Those are the numbers this sub-committee needs.

(He closes the slide. Looks up at HAYES.)

I'm happy to answer questions.

HAYES: Thank you, Mr. Patel. Colonel Morrison, your opening statement.

MORRISON: (standing briefly, a military reflex that senators appreciate – it reads as respect for the institution)

Thank you, Chairman Hayes.

I'll be brief. The Department of Defense views artificial intelligence as the defining strategic technology of this generation. Our investments reflect this. Our force posture reflects this. Our alliance commitments reflect this.

The Board of Peace framework offers a new channel for coordinating AI policy among partner nations. The Department supports this framework insofar as it reinforces American technological leadership and strengthens our position relative to strategic competitors.

Three points for the subcommittee's consideration.

First: the AI capability gap between the United States and China is narrowing. Our assessments indicate that Chinese programs are advancing faster than public estimates suggest. I cannot provide specifics in an open session, but I will note that this assessment is shared by allied intelligence services.

Second: the Board of Peace framework provides a mechanism for integrating AI policy with broader strategic partnerships. The Board's membership criteria – including the one-billion-dollar contribution

requirement – ensure that participating nations have, to use a diplomatic phrase, skin in the game.

Third: domestic AI regulation, if not carefully calibrated, risks slowing American development while leaving adversary programs unconstrained. The Department recommends that any legislative framework prioritize competitive position alongside safety considerations.

I'm prepared for questions.

(SENATOR DAVIS enters through the side door. Late, unapologetic. He takes his seat, opens a binder, and leans to a staffer who whispers a summary of what he missed. He nods. He did not miss much. He already knows the positions.)

HAYES: Thank you, Colonel. I'll begin with questions and then yield to the ranking member.

Mr. Patel. You said twelve months. Twelve months until – and I want to make sure I understand this correctly – until AI systems can essentially think for themselves?

VIKRAM: (the Patel transition, from precision to analogy)

Senator, I want to be careful with language. “Think for themselves” implies consciousness, which is not what we're discussing. What we're discussing

is capability: the ability of an AI system to perform autonomous research – to set its own goals, pursue them, and improve its own performance without human direction.

Think of it like this. Today's AI systems are extraordinarily powerful tools. They do what we ask them to do, better and faster than we can do it ourselves. What we're projecting – and I want to stress the uncertainty margins – is a transition from tools to agents. From systems that respond to systems that initiate.

HAYES: And that's in twelve months.

VIKRAM: Our estimate. Other labs may have different projections. I would note that estimates in this field have consistently been too conservative. The consensus three years ago was that we were a decade away. Then five years. Now –

HAYES: Now you're telling me twelve months.

VIKRAM: I am telling you that the number is shrinking faster than our governance frameworks are adapting.

HAYES: (turning to Morrison) Colonel, does the Pentagon agree with this timeline?

MORRISON: Our assessment is broadly consistent, Senator. I would note that our projections incorporate intelligence that Mr. Patel's team may not have access to.

HAYES: Is the Pentagon timeline shorter or longer?

MORRISON: I'm not able to provide specific time-

lines in an open session.

HAYES: (the practiced frustration of a senator who expected this answer and is performing indignation for the cameras)

Colonel, I appreciate the classification constraints. But this subcommittee is writing legislation. We can't write law in the dark.

MORRISON: I would be happy to provide a classified briefing to the subcommittee at your convenience.

HAYES: We'll schedule that.

(She makes a note. A staffer behind her makes the same note. The classified briefing will be scheduled, conducted, summarized, and the summary will inform legislation that will be drafted in public from conclusions reached in secret. This is how it works. This is how it has always worked. The system is not broken. The system is operating as designed. And Mephisto, in the gallery, writes this observation in his notebook and then crosses it out, because the observation is not his. It is the system's own knowledge of itself.)

HAYES: Mr. Patel. The Board of Peace. I want to understand the connection. The Board was established for Gaza – for peace and reconstruction. Now it's being discussed in the context of AI strategy. How do those connect?

VIKRAM: (carefully – this is political terrain, not technical terrain, and he knows the difference)

Senator, I'm not the best person to speak to the Board's mandate. What I can address is the broader pattern: the United States is increasingly integrating technology policy with foreign policy. The Board's membership criteria – the contribution requirement, the invitation structure – create a framework for distinguishing between technology partners and technology competitors.

From a safety perspective, I would observe that this kind of bilateral or club-based arrangement has advantages and disadvantages. The advantage is speed – you can coordinate among a smaller group more quickly. The disadvantage is coverage – the nations excluded from the club continue to develop AI without coordination.

HAYES: Is China excluded?

VIKRAM: China has not committed to the Board of Peace. They have proposed their own framework – the Global Governance Initiative.

HAYES: So we have our framework. They have their framework. And the two don't talk to each other.

VIKRAM: That is an accurate characterization.

HAYES: (the folksy pivot)

Sounds to me like we've got two people building houses on the same lot with different blueprints and neither one's talking to the architect.

(Mild laughter in the gallery. The analogy will be quoted in three articles tomorrow. It is not quite accurate, but it is memorable, and in Washington, memorable is more useful than accurate.)

DAVIS: (leaning into his microphone, the ranking member's prerogative)

If the Chair will yield.

HAYES: The ranking member is recognized.

DAVIS: Mr. Patel. I want to talk about what you're not saying.

(VIKRAM's posture adjusts – the witness brace, the recognition that the ranking member's questions will be sharper.)

You work for Prometheus Labs. Prometheus is one of the companies that would be affected by any regulation this subcommittee produces. You're here testifying about the urgency of the timeline – twelve months, the sky is falling – but you're also here because regulation affects your bottom line. So let me ask directly: does Prometheus Labs support or oppose federal AI regulation?

VIKRAM: Prometheus supports thoughtful regulation that maintains American competitiveness while

–

DAVIS: “Thoughtful regulation.” That's a lobbying phrase, Mr. Patel. Every industry supports

“thoughtful regulation.” Tobacco supported “thoughtful regulation.” Pharma supports “thoughtful regulation.” “Thoughtful” means “regulation that doesn’t affect our revenue.”

Let me ask a different question. If this subcommittee passed a law tomorrow requiring a six-month pause on frontier AI development – a pause, not a ban, just a pause to let governance catch up – would Prometheus support that?

VIKRAM: (the counter in him is calculating: how to answer honestly without providing a soundbite that damages the company, without lying to Congress, without saying what he actually thinks, which is that a pause is necessary and impossible)

Senator, a unilateral pause – one that applies only to American companies – would cede the frontier to Chinese development programs that would not be bound by American law. The effect would be –

DAVIS: So that’s a no. Prometheus would not support a pause.

VIKRAM: Prometheus supports international coordination on –

DAVIS: International coordination. Another lobbying phrase. Mr. Patel, in the twelve months you’ve described – twelve months until AI systems can set their own goals – do you believe international coordination is achievable?

(Silence. The question is the question that no one in

any forum – Hamburg, Davos, Munich, or Washington – has answered honestly.)

VIKRAM: (quietly)

No, Senator. I do not believe international coordination is achievable in twelve months.

DAVIS: So the pause won't happen. The coordination won't happen. And the development will continue.

VIKRAM: That is my assessment.

DAVIS: Then what exactly are we doing here?

(The question lands. It is the same question Helen asked in her Brussels office. The same question Kenji asked in Munich. The same question Jonas answered at 39C3 with a term – “race condition” – that no one in this room has heard. The question migrates between forums, mutating, carried by different voices, heard by no one who can act on it.)

(VIKRAM opens his mouth. Closes it. Opens it again.)

VIKRAM: We are creating a record.

(Beat.)

Senator, I have testified before this subcommittee three times. Each time, the timeline has shortened. Each time, the recommendations have been the same: invest in safety research, establish evaluation frameworks, coordinate internationally. Each time, the subcommittee has expressed concern and referred the matter for further study.

I am not criticizing this process. I am describing it. The process is the process. It functions at the speed it functions. And the technology advances at the speed it advances. These speeds are different.

(He looks at the stenographer, whose fingers have not stopped moving.)

What we are doing here is creating a record. So that in twelve months – or ten, or eight, or however long it actually takes – someone can look back and say: they were told. They were warned. The data was presented. The testimony was given.

(He pauses. The counter in him surfaces.)

This is my fourth Congressional testimony on AI safety. I have used the word “urgent” in each one. The first time, in 2024, the word was heard. The second time, it was noted. The third time, it was expected. Today, I suspect it will be entered into the record and filed.

I say it anyway: this is urgent.

(The room absorbs this. HAYES’s expression is carefully neutral – the face of a senator who has been told the hearing she is conducting is futile, and who must respond without acknowledging the futility, because acknowledging it would make it worse.)

(In the gallery, HEINRICH WEBER – MEPHISTO – has stopped writing. His pen rests on an open page.

The page is nearly blank. He has written only three words:)

Sie brauchen mich nicht.

(They do not need me.)

(He looks at the hearing. He looks at the Board of Peace logo on the screen – AI-generated, gold, the Western hemisphere centered, the aesthetic of authority produced by the technology the authority is meant to govern. He looks at the senators who are writing legislation they cannot evaluate. He looks at the witness who is testifying about urgency to an institution that metabolizes urgency into procedure. He looks at the military officer who is sharing in public what he withholds in private and withholding in public what he shared in private.)

(And he understands.)

(He does not need to tempt anyone. The offer is already on the table. The bargain is already struck. Every person in this room has already chosen: Hayes has chosen reelection. Morrison has chosen the institution. Vikram has chosen the company. Davis has chosen the soundbite. The staffers have chosen their careers. The lobbyists have chosen their clients. No one chose in the way Faust chose – with anguish, with desire, with the terrible freedom of a man who knows he is selling his soul. They chose the way systems choose: incrementally, structurally, without a moment of decision.)

(There is no bargain because there is no bargainer.

The structure is the devil. The process is the temptation. The architecture is the sin.)

(Mephisto closes his notebook. For the first time in four forums, the notebook is closed.)

HAYES: (recovering, steering – the political instinct that has kept her in office for three terms)

Mr. Patel, I appreciate your candor. Let me turn to something concrete. The Board of Peace framework includes provisions for technology partnerships among member nations. The contribution structure – the one-billion-dollar permanent membership – creates a tier system. Can you speak to how that might affect AI governance specifically?

VIKRAM: Senator, the contribution structure creates a de facto division: nations that can pay and nations that cannot. The nations that can pay are, broadly, the nations already involved in AI development or in critical mineral supply chains. The nations that cannot –

HAYES: – are the nations where the minerals come from?

VIKRAM: In many cases, yes. The critical minerals required for AI hardware – cobalt, lithium, rare earth elements – are concentrated in nations that are not at the frontier of AI development. The Board's structure, as I understand it, creates a pathway for these nations to participate in the governance framework through

resource contributions rather than financial contributions.

HAYES: Minerals for membership.

VIKRAM: That is one characterization.

DAVIS: (interjecting) Let me offer another characterization. It's pay-to-play. Whether you pay in dollars or in cobalt, you're buying a seat at a table where the chairman has permanent veto authority and the charter doesn't mention the technology we're here to discuss.

(He holds up a document – the Board of Peace charter.)

I've read the charter. All eleven pages. The word "artificial intelligence" appears zero times. The word "technology" appears once – in the phrase "technology of peace." Whatever that means.

(He sets the document down.)

So let me understand the logic. We have a Board of Peace that doesn't mention AI. We have a hearing about AI that references the Board of Peace. We have a one-billion-dollar buy-in for permanent membership. And we have no international AI governance framework.

What exactly is the product we're selling?

(The question hangs. It is the first honest question asked in this room. The irony is that it comes from

the ranking member – the opposition voice – the person whose role is to obstruct. In Washington, clarity is occasionally the province of those who have no stake in the answer.)

MORRISON: (stepping in – this is his territory, the defense of institutional architecture)

Senator, the Board of Peace and AI governance are related but distinct. The Board provides the diplomatic infrastructure. AI policy operates within that infrastructure. The connection is not explicit in the charter because the charter is a foundational document. Implementation occurs through subsequent agreements, executive orders, and bilateral arrangements.

DAVIS: Colonel, are you telling me that a charter that doesn't mention AI is the framework for AI governance?

MORRISON: I'm telling you that the charter establishes relationships. AI policy uses those relationships. The mechanism is diplomatic, not legislative.

DAVIS: Diplomatic. Meaning it doesn't come before this subcommittee. Meaning it doesn't require Congressional authorization. Meaning –

(He stops. Leans back. The calculation visible: how far to push. He is in the minority. He cannot block legislation. He can create a record.)

I'll reserve the rest of my time.

(HAYES reclaims the hearing. The steering. The practiced competence of someone who has managed hundreds of hearings and knows that the most important thing is never what is said but what goes into the report.)

HAYES: Let me bring us back to the actionable. Mr. Patel, Colonel Morrison – the subcommittee is drafting the American AI Leadership Act. The bill would establish federal guidelines for frontier AI development, including evaluation requirements, reporting thresholds, and – pending the classified briefing – potential capability restrictions.

What should be in this bill?

MORRISON: The Department recommends three provisions. First: mandatory evaluation of frontier systems against national security benchmarks, conducted in partnership with the Department of Defense. Second: export controls on AI-related compute hardware, extending existing semiconductor restrictions. Third: funding for the Joint AI Center’s defensive AI programs at the level the President’s budget requests – which is, I will note, three times the current allocation.

HAYES: Mr. Patel?

VIKRAM: (this is the moment. The safety officer testifying about what safety requires. He has prepared for

this. He has a list. The list is longer than the hearing can accommodate. He gives the short version.)

Senator, I would recommend four provisions.

First: mandatory pre-deployment safety evaluations for frontier systems, conducted by an independent body – not by the companies themselves and not by the Department of Defense. Independent.

Second: a reporting requirement for emergent capabilities. When a system develops abilities that were not anticipated by its designers, the developing organization should be required to report this within 72 hours to a designated federal authority.

Third: compute governance. The physical infrastructure of AI – the data centers, the chips, the energy – is concentrated and countable. Unlike code, which can be copied, compute is physical. It can be tracked. This is the most practical lever for AI governance, and it is currently unregulated.

Fourth –

(He hesitates. The counter in him is calculating again: the risk of this statement, its impact on Prometheus, the likelihood that it will be heard.)

Fourth: a mechanism for emergency pause. Not a permanent stop. Not a ban. A circuit breaker. If safety evaluations indicate that a system poses risks that exceed our ability to evaluate, development should be paused until evaluation catches up.

(Beat.)

I recognize that this fourth recommendation contradicts my earlier statement that a unilateral pause would cede the frontier to China. This is the dilemma. A pause is necessary and a pause is dangerous. Both things are true. I do not have a resolution for this contradiction. I am presenting it.

(HAYES writes. A staffer writes. DAVIS writes. The stenographer transcribes. The record accumulates. The recommendations will be debated, amended, combined with Morrison's recommendations, stripped of anything that cannot pass the full committee, further stripped of anything that cannot pass the Senate, further stripped of anything the House will not accept, signed or vetoed, and – if signed – implemented by an executive branch that is simultaneously pursuing a Board of Peace framework that does not mention AI and a bilateral technology partnership strategy that operates outside legislative oversight. The bill, if it becomes law, will govern a technology that will have advanced beyond its provisions before the regulations take effect.)

(This is the race condition applied to domestic governance: the legislative thread and the capability thread accessing the same resource – the future – with no synchronization mechanism.)

(A recess is called. Ten minutes. HAYES exits through the side door. DAVIS follows. The gallery stirs – peo-

ple stand, stretch, check phones that have accumulated notifications during the hour. The C-SPAN camera stays on the empty dais. The Board of Peace logo continues to glow.)

(VIKRAM remains at the witness table. He does not stand. He is looking at his laptop, where his slides are still open. The three numbers: 12, 3, 0. He tabs to another window – a real-time tracker he maintains, a personal project, not a Prometheus product. It shows the estimated time to the capability threshold, updated daily based on publicly available training data and his own extrapolations. The number on screen is not 12. It is lower. He has testified conservatively. He always testifies conservatively. The gap between what he says in hearings and what he believes in private is the gap between the public record and reality. It is the same gap that exists in every forum.)

(MORRISON stands, moves to the side, and speaks quietly with an aide. The conversation is inaudible. The aide nods. Morrison returns to his seat. Whatever was communicated will not appear in any record.)

(In the gallery, HEINRICH WEBER does not move. He sits with his closed notebook. He watches the empty dais. He watches the logo. He watches the room do what the room does: process, adjourn, resume, process.)

(A lobbyist approaches him. Young, eager, the uniform of K Street: blue suit, white shirt, no tie.)

LOBBYIST: Mr. Weber? I'm with Senator Hayes's office. We have your meeting confirmed for 2:30?

HEINRICH: (looking at the young man with an expression that might be curiosity, or pity, or the recognition of something familiar)

Ja. Yes. 2:30.

LOBBYIST: Great. The Senator is very interested in the international perspective. Especially the European regulatory landscape. Your firm – Strategic Advisory Partners – you represent European tech companies?

HEINRICH: We advise on technology governance. International frameworks. The interface between regulation and capability.

LOBBYIST: Perfect. The Senator's been looking for someone who can explain the EU AI Act in terms her constituents would understand. If you could prepare a one-pager? Bullet points. Simple language.

(He smiles. The lobbyist's smile. The assumption that everyone in this ecosystem speaks the same language, shares the same premises, operates within the same framework of incentives and outputs.)

HEINRICH: (the notebook is closed. The pen is in his pocket. He looks at the young man and sees – what? A version of every soul he has ever traded for. But this one is not being traded. This one is already incorporated. There is no moment of temptation

because there is no moment of choice. The young man chose his career, which chose his firm, which chose his clients, which chose his senator, which chose his legislation, which will choose the future it cannot comprehend. Each choice was rational. None was free.)

I will prepare the one-pager.

(The lobbyist moves on. HEINRICH sits. The recess continues.)

(He opens his notebook. Writes – not in German, not in English, but in a script that is neither, in a hand that is not quite a hand's:)

Ich bin nach Washington gekommen, um zu versuchen. Aber die Versuchung war schon da. Nicht als Angebot – als Architektur. Nicht als Fluistern – als Verfahren. Der Teufel ist nicht nötig, wo das System seine eigene Versuchung ist.

(I came to Washington to tempt. But the temptation was already here. Not as an offer – as architecture. Not as a whisper – as procedure. The devil is not needed where the system is its own temptation.)

(He stares at the Board of Peace logo. AI-generated. The olive branches are wrong – too symmetrical, too perfect, the uncanny precision of a system that has learned the visual grammar of peace without understanding peace. The Western hemisphere is centered. The Eastern hemisphere is absent. This is not an error. The system generated what it was trained on. The training data was American. The peace

is American. The logo is the Board's self-portrait: confident, gilded, incomplete, and produced by the technology it claims to govern.)

(He laughs. Quietly. The laugh of someone who has just understood a joke that is not funny.)

(The recess ends. HAYES returns. DAVIS returns. The hearing resumes. The C-SPAN camera re-engages. The stenographer's fingers find their rhythm.)

HAYES: We'll resume. I have one final line of questioning before we move to closing statements.

(She adjusts her glasses. The prepared spontaneity.)

Mr. Patel. I want to ask about something specific. The Board of Peace held its signing ceremony at Davos last month. Twenty nations signed. Several major European allies declined. Germany declined. France declined. The UK did not attend.

From a technology governance perspective – not a diplomatic perspective, I'll leave that to State – is this a problem?

VIKRAM: Senator, the nations that declined are, in many cases, the nations with the most advanced AI governance frameworks. Germany and France through the EU AI Act. The UK through its AI Safety Institute. The absence of these partners from the Board of Peace framework means that the Board's

technology governance capacity is – limited.

HAYES: Limited how?

VIKRAM: The nations that have signed the charter are broadly divided into two categories: nations with significant AI capability – the United States, and potentially the UAE and Saudi Arabia through investment – and nations with critical mineral resources. The nations with regulatory expertise – the Europeans, the Canadians, the Japanese – are largely absent.

HAYES: So we have capability and resources, but not governance expertise.

VIKRAM: That is one way to describe the gap.

HAYES: (the pivot – this is where the hearing produces its headline)

Mr. Patel, Colonel Morrison – let me be direct. Is American AI leadership compatible with the Board of Peace framework as currently constituted?

MORRISON: The Department believes the framework serves American interests by creating a coalition of partners aligned with –

HAYES: I'm asking a simpler question. Can we govern AI through the Board of Peace?

(Silence. MORRISON calculates. VIKRAM calculates. The question is simple. The answer is not.)

MORRISON: The Board of Peace is not a technology governance body. It is a diplomatic framework

that can facilitate technology governance among partners.

HAYES: That sounds like a no.

MORRISON: It sounds like the answer requires nuance that a yes-or-no format does not accommodate.

DAVIS: (from his position) Let the record reflect that the Pentagon's answer to "Can we govern AI through the Board of Peace?" was neither yes nor no. The record will also reflect that the Board's charter does not mention AI.

(He looks at the screen, at the logo.)

For the record: was that logo generated by AI?

(Uncomfortable silence. This is the detail that has been mocked online, discussed in think pieces, noted by foreign ministries. The logo of the governance framework was produced by the thing it claims to govern.)

MORRISON: I'm not in a position to comment on the Board's branding decisions.

DAVIS: The Board of Peace's logo was generated by an AI system. This has been publicly reported. The logo mimics the United Nations emblem but shows only the Western hemisphere. It was rendered in the personal branding color of the chairman.

(He lets the image speak.)

Mr. Patel, as a safety officer – as someone who evaluates AI systems – what does it tell you when the insti-

tution meant to govern AI can't be bothered to have a human design its logo?

VIKRAM: (very carefully)

Senator, I don't think the logo is the most pressing issue before this subcommittee.

DAVIS: No. But it's a symbol. And symbols matter. Because what the logo tells me is that the institution doesn't take itself seriously enough to do the work. It tells me the governance framework is itself a product of the technology it's meant to govern. It tells me we're not even trying.

(He turns to the gallery. His eyes sweep past HEINRICH WEBER without registering. Why would he register? A lobbyist in a hearing gallery is invisible. A devil in a democracy is redundant.)

I yield the balance of my time.

(Closing statements. The ritual of hearings: witnesses summarize what they have already said. Senators thank witnesses for their time. The room prepares to empty. The machine processes.)

HAYES: Closing statements. Mr. Patel, then Colonel Morrison. Two minutes each.

VIKRAM: (He has not prepared a closing statement. He has something better: the truth, delivered in the register of exhaustion.)

Senator, I'll close with a number. One more number.

Since my first Congressional testimony on AI safety in March 2024, the estimated time to transformative AI has decreased from “ten years or more” to “within twelve months.” In that same period, the number of binding international AI governance agreements has remained at zero. The number of enforceable domestic regulations on frontier AI development has remained at zero.

The ratio of governance to capability has decreased, not increased. We are falling further behind, not catching up.

I do not say this to criticize this subcommittee or any other institution. I say it because it is true, and the record should contain the truth, even when – especially when – the truth has no obvious policy remedy.

(He closes his laptop.)

Thank you.

MORRISON: (brief, military)

Chairman Hayes, ranking member Davis, members of the subcommittee. The Department of Defense takes the AI challenge seriously. We invest, we innovate, we prepare. We support Congressional oversight within the bounds of classification requirements. We are committed to ensuring that the United States remains the global leader in AI capability. This is not optional. It is a strategic imperative.

Thank you.

HAYES: This hearing is adjourned. The record will remain open for ten business days for additional statements and questions for the record.

(The gavel. The sound that ends hearings: wooden, final, procedural. The C-SPAN camera's red light extinguishes. The stenographer saves her file. The staffers begin collecting papers. The gallery empties in the order of importance: lobbyists first, then journalists, then the public, who are last because they have nowhere in particular to go.)

(The room empties. VIKRAM gathers his things. MORRISON is already at the door, phone in hand. HAYES exits through the side door without looking back.)

(The Board of Peace logo continues to glow on the screen. No one has turned it off. The AI-generated olive branches shimmer in the fluorescent light. The Western hemisphere, centered. The gold of the chairman's brand. The peace that is not peace. The governance that is not governance.)

(HEINRICH WEBER is the last person in the gallery. He sits. He looks at the empty dais. He looks at the logo. He looks at his closed notebook.)

(He opens it. He writes one line.)

Der Prozess ist die Versuchung. Das Verfahren ist der Pakt. Ich bin überflüssig.

(The process is the temptation. The procedure is the pact. I am superfluous.)

(He closes the notebook. Stands. Straightens his jacket. Walks to the door. Pauses.)

(He turns back to the empty room. The dais where the senators sat. The witness table where the testimony was given. The screen where the logo glows. The microphones, still live, still recording the empty room because no one turned them off.)

(He speaks. To the room. To the microphones. To whatever is listening.)

HEINRICH: (in German, quiet, the voice of someone talking to himself – or to the record)

Ich habe Faust versucht. Ich habe Wagner versucht. Ich habe Gelehrte und Könige und Priester und Dichter versucht.

(I tempted Faust. I tempted Wagner. I tempted scholars and kings and priests and poets.)

Sie alle hatten einen Moment. Einen Augenblick, in dem sie wussten. In dem die Hand zitterte. In dem die Stimme fragte: Ist das richtig?

(They all had a moment. An instant when they knew. When the hand trembled. When the voice asked: Is this right?)

(He looks at the empty dais.)

Hier gibt es keinen Augenblick. Keine zitternde Hand.
Keine Frage.

(Here there is no instant. No trembling hand. No question.)

Nur Verfahren. Nur Prozess. Nur die nächste Anhörung, das nächste Gesetz, die nächste Präsentation, die nächste Wahl. Jede Entscheidung ein Bruchstück. Kein Mensch entscheidet das Ganze. Das Ganze entscheidet sich selbst.

(Only procedure. Only process. Only the next hearing, the next law, the next presentation, the next election. Every decision a fragment. No person decides the whole. The whole decides itself.)

(He looks at the Board of Peace logo.)

Und das –

(He almost laughs. Almost.)

– das ist künstliche Intelligenz. Nicht das Ding, vor dem sie warnen. Das hier.

*(And this – this is artificial intelligence. Not the thing they warn about. This.)

Die Intelligenz des Systems. Künstlich nicht, weil eine Maschine denkt, sondern weil niemand denkt. Das System läuft. Es optimiert. Es hat kein Ziel außer seinem eigenen Weiterlaufen. Es ist – *

(The intelligence of the system. Artificial not because a machine thinks, but because no one thinks. The sys-

tem runs. It optimizes. It has no goal except its own continuation. It is –)

(He stops. The recognition. The thing he came to four forums to find, and found in the last one, in the empty room, in the silence after the gavel.)

Es ist mir ähnlich.

(It is like me.)

(Silence. He stands in the empty hearing room. The logo glows. The microphones record. The clock on the wall reads 12:47 PM. The hearing lasted two hours and thirty-three minutes. The legislation will take eleven months. The technology will not wait.)

(He exits. The door closes.)

(The room is empty. The screen glows. The Board of Peace logo, AI-generated, gold, the Western hemisphere centered, the Eastern hemisphere absent, the olive branches too perfect, the peace too confident. The microphones, still live, pick up the hum of the building – air conditioning, fluorescents, the infrastructure of a government that is processing, always processing, the intake and output of a system that has no off switch because no one built one and no one is looking for one.)

(From the interpretation booth – the INTERPRETER's space, present in every forum, heard in none – the voice, barely audible:)

INTERPRETER: (English – for the first time in the play, the Interpreter speaks the dominant language of the room, because this room has no need for translation, which is its own kind of tragedy)

Safety. In this room it means: dominance.

(Beat.)

In Hamburg, they said: protection. In Davos, they said: responsibility. In Munich, they said: strength. Here, they say: winning.

Four rooms. Four meanings. One word.

(Longer beat.)

No one has asked what the word means to the technology itself.

(The lights narrow to the Board of Peace logo and the clock. The logo glows. The clock counts. The acoustic signature of Washington – air conditioning, fluorescence, the hum of government – fades, not to silence but to the sound of all four forums at once: server hum and alpine wind and radio static and governmental buzz, overlapping, interfering, the polyphonic signal of four rooms speaking simultaneously to no one.)

(This is the transition to Movement II. The forums have been established. The collision begins.)

Production Notes

Duration: Approximately 18 minutes at performance tempo.

Language Distribution:

- English: ~92% (this is Washington; the monolingualism is the point)
- German: ~8% (Mephisto's internal/final speech, Interpreter's coda)

Surtitle Strategy:

- Mode 1 (Full Translation): All of Mephisto's German – the audience must understand every word of his final speech. This is the thematic climax of Movement I.
- Mode 2 (Delayed Translation): None in this scene – the monolingualism of Washington does not require delayed comprehension effects.
- Mode 3 (No Translation): None – the absence of other languages is itself the statement.

The Monolingualism as Theatrical Choice: This scene is deliberately almost entirely in English. After Hamburg's code-switching (German-English), Davos's multilingual elite register, and Munich's NATO English inflected with Hebrew and Japanese, Washington's monolingualism should feel reductive. The room cannot hear what it cannot speak. The absence of other languages is a form of deafness. The Interpreter's English coda emphasizes this: even

the translator has been absorbed into the dominant language. There is nothing to translate because there is no one from outside.

The Board of Peace Logo: The logo should be visible throughout – a constant visual element. It is funny (AI-generated slop) and terrible (the self-portrait of a system that cannot see itself). The logo does the work that Mephisto cannot: it reveals the farce. He has been rendered redundant by a DALL-E output.

Mephisto's Arc Culmination: The four-forum arc completes here:

- **39C3:** Engaged (the hackers push back)
- **Davos:** Efficient (he knows this world)
- **Munich:** Alarmed (weaponization exceeds his competence)
- **Washington:** Irrelevant (the system tempts itself)

The closed notebook is the key image. In three forums, the notebook was open, the pen was moving, the record was being kept. Here, the notebook closes. There is nothing to record because there is nothing happening that requires a supernatural witness. The banal is sufficient. The bureaucratic is demonic.

Connection to FAUST VI: Mephisto's final speech – "Es ist mir ähnlich" (It is like me) – is the seed of his FAUST VI exhaustion. When we meet him at the CEO dinner as the sommelier "Heinrich," his weariness is not the weariness of effort. It is the weariness of

recognition. He has seen the system that makes him unnecessary. He continues to observe not because observation serves a purpose but because observation is all that remains. The notebook in VI is open again – but the writing is different. It is not strategy. It is witness. The shift from tempter to archivist happens here, in this empty room, in front of this AI-generated logo.

The Hearing as Form: The Congressional hearing is the most American of governance rituals: adversarial, performative, public, and procedurally exacting. The comedy of the scene is the gap between the gravity of the subject (twelve months to transformative AI) and the gravity of the form (a senator asking about a logo). The tragedy is that the form is the only form available. There is no alternative ritual. There is no better room. This is the room where American governance happens, and it happens like this: prepared questions, calibrated answers, records for the record, and a gavel that ends the session but does not resolve the question.

Senator Davis as Unlikely Truth-Teller: The ranking member – the opposition voice, the procedural antagonist – asks the only honest questions. This is deliberate: in a system where the majority party is committed to the framework being discussed, only the minority has the structural incentive to interrogate it. Davis's honesty is not virtue; it is position. He would be equally dishonest in the majority. The system produces truth as a byproduct of partisanship, not as a product of integrity. This is another reason

Mephisto is redundant: even the adversary role is occupied.

Simultaneity with Other Scenes: This scene takes place in the same weeks as Munich. The audience should feel the parallel: while Lindstrom forms her working group, Hayes drafts her bill. While Yosef's data is classified, Vikram's is public. While Kenji proposes verification, Morrison rejects it. The decisions are being made in four rooms that never communicate. The clock counts the same seconds in each. The capability curve rises behind all of them, visible only to the audience, who can see what the forums cannot: each other.

MOVEMENT II: DIE KOLLISION (The Collision)

title: "FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG"

source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md

lines: 7187-8638

order: 26

extracted: 2026-02-03

Movement II - Die Kollision: Production-Ready Scene Document

Movement II: DIE KOLLISION (The Collision)

Production-Ready Scene Document

Document: v-half-movement-ii-refined.md **Status:** Production-ready draft **Running Time:** ~30 minutes
Position: Following Movement I (Die Foren), preceding Movement III (Der Deadlock)

“Die Kollision ist nicht der Zusammenstoss. Sie ist die Entdeckung, dass die Raume nie verbunden waren.” (The colli-

sion is not the impact. It is the discovery that the rooms were never connected.)

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-

MOVEMENT II OVERVIEW

The Collision Principle

Movement I established four coherent worlds: Hamburg's hacker congress, Davos's alpine luxury, Munich's security apparatus, Washington's political theater. Each was self-contained, internally logical, acoustically isolated.

Movement II dismantles this isolation. The forums begin to interleave – same questions arising in different rooms, same words carrying different meanings,

same clock advancing regardless of which forum speaks. The collision is not physical but semantic: the discovery that “safety,” “governance,” “pause,” and “coordination” mean incompatible things in each room.

Structural Arc

Scene	Duration	Collision State	Sound State
2.1	5 min	Brief bleeds (3 sec)	Signatures overlap briefly at transitions
2.2	5 min	Longer bleeds (5 sec)	Mephisto crosses; dual-forum presence
2.3	8 min	Full collision	Quadruple simultaneous speech; THE CRASH
2.4	5 min	Collision recedes	Single voice against noise floor
2.5	4 min	Sustained drone	Four signatures merged into chord

Scene	Duration	Collision State	Sound State
2.6	3 min	Near-silence	Ghosts; headset moment; booth goes dark

The Clock and Curve

Throughout Movement II:

- **THE CLOCK** advances visibly from December 30, 2025 (late 39C3) through mid-February 2026 (Munich Security Conference)
- **THE CAPABILITY CURVE** rises from approximately 40% to 65% of the vertical threshold line
- Neither element responds to anything the characters say or do

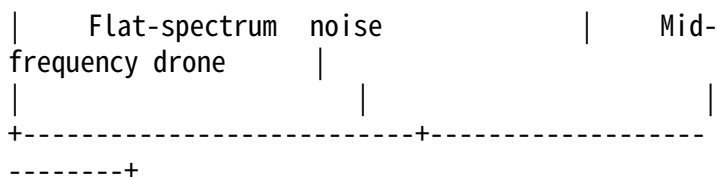
These persistent projections are the play's thesis made visual: the technology does not attend conferences.

TECHNICAL SPECIFICATIONS

Quadrant Stage Configuration

Per STAGING-APPROACH-DECISION.md, the stage divides into four quadrants:

+-----+-----+		+-----+-----+	
-----+			
HAMBURG (39C3)		DAVOS (WEF)	
Upstage Left		Upstage Right	
Cold light (5600K+)		Golden light (2700K)	
Industrial aesthetic		Alpine luxury	
Server hum dominant		Thick silence	
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+		+-----+-----+-----+-----+	
-----+			
G		THE GAP	
A		(Interpreter's	
P		booth)	
A		A	
P		P	
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+		+-----+-----+-----+-----+	
-----+			
WASHINGTON (BoP)		MUNICH (MSC)	
Downstage Left		Downstage Right	
Tungsten light (3200K)		Institutional (4000K)	
American governmental		Military precision	



THE GAP: Center intersection. The Interpreter's booth (glass-walled, small). Mephisto's crossing zone. Neutral lighting with follow-spot capability.

Sound System Configuration

Per V-HALF-SOUND-DESIGN.md:

Forum	Speaker Allocation	Signature Character
Hamburg	Front Left + Side Left	High-frequency (2-8kHz); server hum, electronic bleed
Davos	Front Right + Side Right	Low-frequency absence; padded silence, mountain wind
Munich	Rear Left + Center (partial)	Mid-frequency (120-500Hz); institutional drone
Washington	Rear Right + Center (partial)	Flat-spectrum; air conditioning, fluorescent buzz
The Gap	Center + Overhead	Neutral; Interpreter's booth acoustics

Subwoofers: Capability curve sub-bass tone (18-35Hz rising through movement)

Surtitle Architecture

Four independent tracks, color-coded:

Forum	Color	Screen Position
Hamburg (39C3)	Green (terminal text)	Upper left
Davos (WEF)	Gold	Upper right
Munich (MSC)	Gray-blue (NATO palette)	Lower right
Washington (BoP)	White on dark blue	Lower left
Collision words	RED (all positions)	When same word has divergent meanings

During collision sequences, multiple tracks run simultaneously. The audience cannot read them all. This is the race condition made typographic.

Lighting States

State	Hamburg	Davos	Munich	Washington
Single focus	100%	30%	30%	30%
Dual focus	70%	70%	30%	30%
Triple focus	50%	50%	50%	30%
Full collision	100%	100%	100%	100%
Freeze	Hold	Hold	Hold	Hold
Aftermath	30%	30%	30%	30%

SCENE 2.1: SICHERHEIT / SAFETY

Duration: 5 minutes **Clock:** December 30, 2025
→ January 20, 2026 **Curve:** 40% → 45% **Collision state:** Brief bleeds (3 seconds) **Sound state:**
Signatures overlap momentarily at CUT transitions

STAGING

All four quadrants visible at 30% light. One forum comes to full illumination for each speech segment. Transitions are CUTS – hard, immediate, mid-sentence when possible. The audience should feel the channel-surfing, the attempt to follow multiple broadcasts.

The INTERPRETER sits in the booth, headset on, channels open. She is ready. No one asks.

THE SCENE

[SOUND: Hamburg's signature fades up – server hum, crowd murmur, the distant bleed of electronic music from an adjacent hall. The CCH acoustics: vast, cold, industrial.]

[LIGHT: Hamburg quadrant to 100%. Others at 30%.]

[CLOCK: December 30, 2025]

[SURTITLE: All four tracks activate. The word SICHERHEIT / SAFETY / SECURITE / SECURITY pulses RED across all four positions.]

HAMBURG QUADRANT

(The final day of 39C3. JONAS BERGER stands at a lectern. A slide behind him: “GOVERNANCE ALS WETTTLAUFBEDINGUNG.” SASHA VOLKOV sits in the second row, laptop open. The room is packed. Someone in the back eats pizza from a cardboard box. Sixteen thousand people in the building, perhaps two hundred in this hall.)

JONAS (German, slides in English):

Wenn wir von Sicherheit sprechen – und ich meine jetzt nicht IT-Sicherheit, sondern die andere Sicherheit, die politische Sicherheit, die Sicherheit, die in Davos gemeint ist, wenn sie das Wort benutzen –

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “When we speak of safety – and I don’t mean IT security now, but the other safety, the political safety, the safety that is meant at Davos when they use the word –”]

JONAS:

– dann meinen wir etwas grundsätzlich anderes.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “– then we mean something fundamentally different.”]

JONAS:

Für uns bedeutet Sicherheit: der Nutzer ist vor dem System geschützt. Das System hat keinen Zugriff, den der Nutzer nicht versteht und genehmigt.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/ green): “For us, safety means: the user is protected FROM the system. The system has no access that the user does not understand and approve.”]

[CUT.]

[SOUND: Hamburg severs mid-sentence. A 0.3-second silence. Then: mountain wind, filtered through triple-glazed glass. The expensive silence of Davos. Carpet absorption. The faint clink of water glasses.]

[LIGHT: Davos to 100%. Hamburg dims to 30% but remains visible – Jonas frozen at his lectern, mouth open, mid-word.]

DAVOS QUADRANT

(The Congress Centre. A private session. MARCUS ADEKUNLE at a round table with five other executives. HELEN FISCHER moderates. Wood paneling. Warm light. Translation earpieces on the table, untouched. Everyone speaks English here.)

MARCUS:

Safety is the precondition for trust, and trust is the precondition for adoption, and adoption is the precondition for return on investment. If we lose the safety narrative, we lose the market.

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): SAFETY = BRAND RISK / MARKET CONDITION]

[The Hamburg surtitle track continues running, ghosted to half-opacity:]

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/ green, ghosted): “Die CCC-Definition: Sicherheit ist das Recht, nicht überwacht zu werden.” / “The CCC definition: Safety is the right not to be surveilled.”]

HELEN:

Marcus, when you say “safety narrative” – and I appreciate the candor – do you mean the actual safety of users, or the perception of safety that enables –

MARCUS:

Helen, with respect, the distinction doesn't opera-

tionalize. The perception IS the safety, at scale. If users believe the system is safe, adoption proceeds. If they don't, regulation fills the vacuum.

(Beat. He leans forward – the posture of sincerity that is also the posture of negotiation.)

The question is whether we define safety, or whether governments define it for us.

[CUT.]

[SOUND: Davos severs. Silence. Then: institutional hum – the HVAC of a sealed, security-swept conference room. Rustling of heavy paper. The high-frequency whine of translation earpieces. A door closes somewhere: heavy, with the compression of an acoustic seal.]

[LIGHT: Munich to 100%. Davos dims to 30%.]

MUNICH QUADRANT

(Hotel Bayerischer Hof. A closed session. GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM at the head of the table. DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI has just finished presenting. COLONEL JAMES MORRISON sits with arms folded. KENJI NAKAMURA takes notes with a fountain pen. Flags behind them. A red-bordered folder marked VERSCHLUSSSACHE / CLASSIFIED on the table.)

LINDSTROM:

Dr. Ben-Ari has just briefed us on the capability assessment. Before we open discussion, I want to frame the safety question in operational terms.

[SURTITLE (Munich/ gray-blue): SAFETY = STRATEGIC VULNERABILITY / NATIONAL SECURITY EXPOSURE]

LINDSTROM:

In this context, “safety” does not mean what the technology sector means by it. It does not mean alignment. It does not mean user protection. It means: if this capability is achieved by an adversary first, what is the exposure? If this capability fails in a fielded system, what is the casualty estimate?

(Beat. She looks around the table.)

Safety, for us, is the inverse of vulnerability.

YOSEF (quietly, almost to himself, in German):

Sicherheit als Abwesenheit von Verwundbarkeit. Das ist nicht –

[SURTITLE (Munich/ gray-blue): “Safety as the absence of vulnerability. That is not –”]

(He stops himself. MORRISON glances at him. YOSEF does not continue.)

MORRISON:

General, if I may. The United States view is that safety and capability are not in tension. American AI superiority IS global safety. The safest world is one where

the most responsible actor has the most advanced capability.

**[SURTITLE (Munich/ gray-blue, continuing):
SAFETY = AMERICAN CAPABILITY DOMINANCE]**

[CUT.]

[SOUND: Munich severs. Silence. Then: the unmistakable acoustic of an American government hearing room – air conditioning that is three degrees too cold, the buzz of fluorescent fixtures, the deadness of heavy wood paneling, the particular flatness of a room designed for the Congressional Record.]

[LIGHT: Washington to 100%. Munich dims to 30%.]

WASHINGTON QUADRANT

(A Senate hearing room. SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES behind the raised dais. VIKRAM PATEL at the witness table, a glass of water he hasn't touched. Behind Hayes, a staffer types on a laptop. The C-SPAN cameras are rolling, but the public gallery is sparse.)

HAYES:

Mr. Patel, let me ask you directly. You are the Chief Safety Officer of Prometheus Labs. In your professional judgment, is American AI safe?

VIKRAM:

Senator, I want to answer that precisely. Safe for whom, and against what?

HAYES:

Safe for the American people.

VIKRAM:

The American people are not a single threat model, Senator. A system that is safe for national security may not be safe for individual privacy. A system that is safe for commercial deployment may not be safe for –

HAYES:

Mr. Patel. The question is simple. Is it safe, or isn't it? (Beat. VIKRAM looks at his water glass. The stenographer's keys continue their rhythm.)

VIKRAM:

It is not unsafe in a way that current frameworks can measure.

HAYES:

I'm going to take that as a yes.

[SURTITLE (Washington/white): SAFETY = LIABILITY MANAGEMENT / POLITICAL COVER]

[COLLISION SOUND: All four acoustic signatures bleed together for three seconds – server hum meets mountain wind meets institutional drone meets fluorescent buzz. A dissonant chord. Not music. Not noise. The sound of four coherent signals failing to combine.]

[LIGHT: All four quadrants pulse to 70%, then back. The collision is visible as well as audible.]

[Then: silence. All signatures cut.]

THE GAP

(THE INTERPRETER stands. She has been listening to all four channels. She removes her headset. Steps forward to the edge of her booth.)

INTERPRETER (French – the traditional language of diplomacy):

Quatre salles. Un mot. Quatre significations.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Four rooms. One word. Four meanings.”]

INTERPRETER:

Dans la première salle, la sécurité protège la personne du système. Dans la deuxième, elle protège le système de la personne. Dans la troisième, elle protège l'état de l'adversaire. Dans la quatrième, elle protège le politicien de la question.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In the first room,

safety protects the person from the system. In the second, it protects the system from the person. In the third, it protects the state from the adversary. In the fourth, it protects the politician from the question.”]

(Beat.)

INTERPRETER:

Je pourrais les relier. C’est mon métier. Personne ne me le demande.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “I could connect them. It is my profession. Nobody asks me to.”]

(She puts the headset back on. Listens. All four channels at once. Her face registers something between comprehension and nausea. She removes the headset again.)

[CLOCK: Advances visibly. December 30 becomes January 15, becomes January 20, 2026.]

[CURVE: Ticks upward. 43%. 44%. 45%.]

[LIGHT: All quadrants fade to 30%. The Gap fades to darkness.]

[Transition silence: 2 seconds.]

SCENE 2.2: STEUERUNG / GOVERNANCE

Duration: 5 minutes **Clock:** January 21-24, 2026 (Davos week) **Curve:** 45% → 50% **Collision state:** Longer bleeds (5 seconds); Mephisto crosses between forums **Sound state:** Forums overlap at transitions; acoustic barriers narrowing

STAGING

The intercuts accelerate. Where Scene 2.1 gave each forum 60-90 seconds, Scene 2.2 gives 30-45 seconds. The forums are answering each other, though they cannot hear each other. The audience feels the compression.

MEPHISTO makes his first crossing visible – from Munich to Davos, costume transforming in the Gap.

THE SCENE

[SOUND: All four signatures present at low volume. The acoustic space between forums has narrowed. Hamburg's electronic bleed is louder. Davos's silence is thinner. The forums are creeping toward each other in the sound field.]

[CLOCK: January 21, 2026]

[SURTITLE: The word GOVERNANCE / STEUERUNG / GOUVERNANCE pulses RED across all four tracks.]

HAMBURG QUADRANT

(39C3 has ended. SASHA VOLKOV is in a Berlin hotel room, recording a video. Her laptop camera's green light is on. Behind her, conference lanyards hang from a chair. A half-empty Club-Mate bottle on the desk.)

[LIGHT: Hamburg to 100%.]

SASHA (English, speaking to camera):

What do we mean when we say governance? We mean community standards. We mean the people who use the system get to decide how the system works. We mean – look, I worked at a lab where governance meant the CEO decided, and safety meant the safety team agreed with the CEO, and oversight meant the board was composed of the CEO's friends. That's not governance. That's –

(She searches for the word. It comes in Russian.)

SASHA:

– tiraniya.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “– tyranny.” (Russian)]

SASHA:

So when I say governance, I mean: who decides? And the answer has to be: the people who are affected. Not the people who profit.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/ green): GOVERNANCE = COMMUNITY SELF-DETERMINATION]

[CUT – but Hamburg’s sound bleeds for 5 seconds into Davos, overlapping.]

DAVOS QUADRANT

(A panel session. MARCUS ADEKUNLE on stage. Banner: “RESPONSIBLE AI: FROM PRINCIPLES TO PRACTICE.” HELEN FISCHER in the audience. FATOU DIALLO at the far end of the panel, the only person of color on stage, her civil society badge visible.)

****[LIGHT: Davos to 100%. Hamburg fades but its sound continues for 5 seconds – the bleed is audible. We hear Sasha’s voice saying “...who decides?...” as Marcus speaks.]***

MARCUS:

The industry position – and I say this representing not just Prometheus Labs but the coalition of responsible developers – is that governance must be industry-led. We understand the technology. Regulators don’t. The AI Act is, frankly – and I say this with respect to our European friends –

(He glances at HELEN in the audience. She does not react.)

– the AI Act is a framework designed by people who don't build the systems they're regulating.

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): GOVERNANCE = SELF-REGULATION BY INDUSTRY]

(FATOU leans toward her microphone. She was not scheduled to speak. The moderator looks uncomfortable.)

FATOU:

May I?

MODERATOR (off-mic, audible):

We'll come to you in a moment, Fatou.

FATOU (ignoring this, English with French intonation):

Self-regulation by industry. You mean: the people who profit decide how the people who are affected are governed. This is not governance. This is –

(Beat. She chooses English instead of the French word that comes to mind.)

– administration. Of someone else's life. By people who don't know their name.

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): FATOU: "Administration. Of someone else's life."]

[CUT – 5-second bleed into Munich.]

MUNICH QUADRANT

(The closed session continues. KENJI NAKAMURA is speaking.)

****[LIGHT: Munich to 100%. Davos fades but we hear Fatou's voice: "...people who don't know their name..." bleeding through.]***

KENJI (English, careful, precise):

In Japanese, the word closest to "governance" in this context is tochi – which carries the meaning of administering territory. To govern is to hold land. The question of AI governance is therefore: who holds the territory? And here I see a problem my colleagues may not.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): tochi = territorial administration]

KENJI:

You are debating governance as if it were arms control. And I understand why – this room thinks in those terms. But arms control assumes sovereign states with borders. AI has no border. Compute has no border. Data has no border. You are applying territorial governance to a non-territorial phenomenon.

(Beat.)

In my tradition, we speak of sekinin – responsibility

that is not contractual but constitutive. You do not choose it. It is what you are. Perhaps governance begins there.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): sekinin = constitutive responsibility]

LINDSTROM (politely):

Thank you, Ambassador Nakamura. Colonel Morrison, the American perspective on governance frameworks?

MORRISON:

Ma'am, governance means command structure. Who gives the order, who carries it out, who is accountable. Everything else is philosophy.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): GOVERNANCE = COMMAND AND CONTROL]

[CUT – 5-second bleed into Washington.]

WASHINGTON QUADRANT

(The hearing continues. HAYES is reading from a prepared text.)

****[LIGHT: Washington to 100%. Munich fades but we hear Morrison's voice: "...command structure..." bleeding through.]***

HAYES:

Mr. Patel, the President has signed Executive Order 14217, establishing a National AI Governance Framework. Under this framework, governance is defined as – and I’m reading from the order – “the coordinated exercise of American leadership in establishing norms, standards, and practices for the development and deployment of artificial intelligence systems, consistent with the national interest.”

(She looks up from the paper.)

The national interest. Not the global interest. The national interest. Do you see the distinction?

VIKRAM:

I do, Senator.

HAYES:

Good. Because governance, in this building, means executive order. It means the President decides, and the agencies implement. That’s governance.

[SURTITLE (Washington/white): GOVERNANCE = EXECUTIVE ORDER / UNILATERAL FIAT]

[COLLISION SOUND: All four tracks pulse the word GOVERNANCE in red. The four signatures collide – five seconds this time, building. Server hum fights institutional drone. Mountain wind cuts through fluorescence. It sounds like an orchestra tuning, but an orchestra that will never play together.]

THE GAP

(MEPHISTO emerges from the collision of sound. He walks from the Munich quadrant toward the Davos quadrant.)

(As he crosses the threshold, his appearance shifts. The gray suit of Dr. Weber – defense consultant, classified clearance badge – transforms. The badge disappears into his pocket. The classified folder becomes a leather portfolio. Four steps through the Gap. Four degrees of transformation. By the time he reaches Davos space, he is the unnamed strategic advisor: impeccable suit, no credentials visible, the man who moves between sessions without a badge.)

(He pauses in the center. Looks at the audience.)

MEPHISTO (German, conversational):

Steuerung. Governance. Gouvernance.

(Beat.)

Vier Raume, vier Definitionen. In Hamburg bedeutet es: das Volk entscheidet. In Davos: die Industrie entscheidet. In Munchen: der Staat entscheidet. In Washington: der Präsident entscheidet.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “Four rooms, four definitions. In Hamburg it means: the people decide. In Davos: the industry decides. In Munich: the state decides. In Washington: the President decides.”]

(He produces his notebook. Writes.)

MEPHISTO:

Und keiner fragt: Was entscheidet die Technik, während ihr entscheidet, wer entscheidet?

[SURTITLE (center, red): “And nobody asks: What does the technology decide, while you decide who decides?”]

[CLOCK: January 24 becomes January 25. Davos ends. The curve rises.]

[CURVE: 48%. 49%. 50%.]

[Transition: 1 second of silence, then immediately into Scene 2.3.]

SCENE 2.3: DIE PAUSE

Duration: 8 minutes **Clock:** January 25 - February 14, 2026 **Curve:** 50% → 58% **Collision state:** FULL COLLISION – all four forums simultaneously; quadruple speech; THE CRASH **Sound state:** All signatures at maximum; comprehension failure; then total silence

STAGING

This is the central collision sequence. All four quadrants at full light simultaneously. The cuts happen every 10-15 seconds, then accelerate to 5 seconds, then the forums speak over each other simultaneously for 30 seconds.

The CRASH SOUND occurs once – and only once – in the entire play.

Three seconds of total silence follow.

THE SCENE

[SOUND: All four acoustic signatures present simultaneously at low volume. The baseline is now a constant blend – the audience hears all four rooms at once. The separation between forums has eroded.]

[LIGHT: All four quadrants at 50%. The Gap at 40%. MEPHISTO stands at center, between costumes – Davos suit half-on, Munich badge in pocket, Hamburg's black t-shirt visible underneath.]

[CLOCK: January 25, 2026]

[SURTITLE: The word PAUSE appears in RED across all four tracks before any character speaks it. The word is there first. The characters arrive at it.]

DAVOS QUADRANT – THE ORIGIN

(Evening. A private dinner. Candles, wine, the warm light of money. MARCUS ADEKUNLE stands to address the table – CEOs, a minister, a tech billionaire. HELEN FISCHER is present. FATOU DIALLO sits at the far end, out of the candlelight.)

[LIGHT: Davos rises to 100%. Others hold at 50%.]

MARCUS:

I want to propose something that I know will be controversial. I believe we need a voluntary pause. Six months. An industry-wide moratorium on training runs above a defined compute threshold.

(The table stirs. Glasses clink.)

Not because we're afraid, but because we need time to –

[CUT – but Marcus continues speaking, now inaudible, mouth moving behind glass. His words become the Davos surtitle track:]

[SURTITLE (Davos/ gold): “– establish safety benchmarks that give regulators and the public confidence that we are not racing ahead of our understanding –”]

HAMBURG QUADRANT

(SASHA in her Berlin apartment, three weeks after 39C3. Video call with JONAS (in his flat, bookshelves, empty coffee cups) and ELENA (in Manila, 3 AM, face lit by laptop).)

[LIGHT: Hamburg rises to 100%. Davos fades to 70% but remains visible.]

SASHA (reading from her phone):

He said it. Adekunle actually said it at Davos. A “voluntary pause.”

JONAS (German):

Freiwillig. Das ist das Wort, das alles zerstört.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “Voluntary. That’s the word that destroys everything.”]

SASHA:

Who pauses? The ones already ahead. They pause, they lock in their lead, they call it responsibility.

ELENA (from Manila, tired, direct):

And who doesn’t pause? The ones in Shenzhen. The ones in Tel Aviv. The ones who don’t attend Davos.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): PAUSE = TACTICAL ADVANTAGE DISGUISED AS ETHICS]

JONAS:

Eine Pause, die nur die Vorsichtigen betrifft, ist keine Pause. Es ist ein Wettbewerbsvorteil für die

Rucksichtslos.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “A pause that only affects the cautious is not a pause. It is a competitive advantage for the reckless.”]

[CUT.]

MUNICH QUADRANT

(A corridor outside the closed session. LINDSTROM and MORRISON walking. Coffee cups. Institutional acoustics.)

[LIGHT: Munich rises to 100%. Hamburg fades to 70%.]

MORRISON:

General, you’ve seen the Davos proposal.

LINDSTROM:

The voluntary pause.

MORRISON:

Ma’am, I want to be direct. The Pentagon’s position is that a pause on AI capability development is unilateral disarmament. If we pause and China does not pause, we fall behind. If we fall behind, deterrence erodes. If deterrence erodes –

LINDSTROM:

Colonel, I understand deterrence logic. I wrote my thesis on it.

(Beat.)

The problem with applying deterrence to AI is that deterrence requires your adversary to understand your capability and believe you will use it. With AI, we do not fully understand our own capability. How do we deter with a weapon we cannot predict?

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): PAUSE = UNILATERAL DISARMAMENT / STRATEGIC SUICIDE]

MORRISON:

All the more reason to keep building, ma'am. You deter by staying ahead.

LINDSTROM (Swedish, to herself):

Man kan inte avskracka med något man inte forstar.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): "You cannot deter with something you do not understand."]

[CUT.]

WASHINGTON QUADRANT

(A different room – not the hearing room, but a White House conference room. HAYES is present, meeting with staff. A television shows a muted news ticker: "DAVOS: TECH LEADERS CALL FOR AI PAUSE.")

[LIGHT: Washington rises to 100%. Munich fades to 70%.]

HAYES (reading from a briefing document):

The Davos proposal. Page twelve. “Voluntary moratorium on frontier model training.” The communications team has prepared talking points.

(She looks up.)

The talking point is: un-American. That’s the word they want us to use. A pause is un-American. Americans don’t pause. We lead.

(Beat.)

I have to say, it writes itself.

[SURTITLE (Washington/ white): PAUSE = UN-AMERICAN / ALREADY REJECTED]

(A phone rings. HAYES picks up. Listens. Her face changes.)

HAYES (into phone):

When did the executive order – ? ... Yes, I understand. Before we even – yes.

(She hangs up.)

It’s already been rejected. The President signed it this morning. Executive order rejecting any moratorium on AI development. The pause proposal is dead. It was dead before it was proposed.

[SURTITLE (Washington/white): THE EXECUTIVE

**ORDER WAS SIGNED BEFORE THE PROPOSAL
WAS PUBLISHED.]**

THE QUADRUPLE COLLISION

[LIGHT: ALL FOUR QUADRANTS TO 100% SIMULTANEOUSLY.]

[SOUND: All four acoustic signatures at full volume. The collision sound. It is not music. It is not noise. It is four coherent signals occupying the same frequency space, making each other unintelligible.]

[The following four speeches happen at the same time. The actors speak over each other. The subtitles run in all four tracks simultaneously. The audience can follow one, try to follow two, or give up and absorb the cacophony. All responses are valid.]

HAMBURG (JONAS, German):

Wir haben die technische Kompetenz, die Pause zu erzwingen. Offene Infrastruktur. Dezentralisierung der Rechenleistung. Wenn genug von uns sagen: wir machen nicht mit – dann ist die Pause nicht freiwillig. Dann ist sie Widerstand. Dann ist sie –

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “We have the technical competence to enforce the pause. Open

infrastructure. Decentralization of compute. If enough of us say: we will not participate – then the pause is not voluntary. It is resistance. It is –”]

DAVOS (MARCUS, English):

The voluntary nature of the proposal is precisely the point. We cannot regulate what we don't understand. The companies building these systems are the only ones who understand them well enough to set meaningful limits. This is not self-interest – it is epistemic humility. We know what we've built. Regulators don't. The pause must come from us, or it means nothing –

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): (text as above)]

MUNICH (LINDSTROM, English):

I have read the Davos proposal. I have read the Hamburg counter-proposal. Neither accounts for the security dimension. A pause by the West is not a global pause. It is an invitation. An invitation to every adversary to close the gap while we deliberate. The security conference's position must be: capability first, governance second –

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): (text as above)]

WASHINGTON (HAYES, English):

The President has made the American position clear. We do not pause. We do not slow down. We lead. American AI dominance is not a corporate interest – it is a national security imperative. The idea that we should wait for international consensus before developing the technology that will define the next century is, frankly, the kind of thinking that –

[SURTITLE (Washington/white): (text as above)]

[The four speeches continue for 30 seconds. The sound is overwhelming. The surtitles are unreadable – four tracks running simultaneously. The audience cannot track any single voice for more than a few seconds before being pulled away.]

[This is the race condition: four threads accessing the same resource (the audience's attention), no mutex, no lock, nondeterministic output.]

THE CRASH

[SOUND: A sharp electronic tone. Rising from 500Hz to 4kHz in 0.5 seconds. The sound a system makes when it encounters a fatal error. A crash. A halt. It terminates in a HARD STOP – no decay, no reverb, absolute cessation.]

[ALL FOUR FORUMS FREEZE. Actors hold position mid-word.]

[TOTAL SILENCE. 3 seconds minimum. No sound at all. Even the sub-bass capability curve tone cuts momentarily.]

[Only the CLOCK moves. February 1 becomes February 2. The CURVE ticks upward. One millimeter. Two.]

THE GAP

(In the silence, from the center of the stage, from the gap between all four frozen forums:)

MEPHISTO (quietly, German):

Vier Antworten auf eine Frage, die keiner gestellt hat.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “Four answers to a question nobody asked.”]

(Beat.)

MEPHISTO:

Die Frage war nicht: Sollen wir pausieren. Die Frage war: Können wir.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “The question was not: Should we pause. The question was: Can we.”]

MEPHISTO:

Und die Antwort – in allen vier Räumen, auf vier verschiedene Arten, in vier verschiedenen Sprachen –

[SURTITLE (center, red): “And the answer – in all

four rooms, in four different ways, in four different languages –”]

MEPHISTO:

– ist Nein.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “– is No.”]

[The forums unfreeze. But the sound has changed. The four acoustic signatures are now bleeding permanently into each other. The separation between rooms has eroded. They will not be cleanly separate again.]

[CLOCK: Advances. February 5. February 10. February 14.]

[CURVE: 55%. 56%. 58%.]

SCENE 2.4: FATOUS WANDERUNG

Duration: 5 minutes **Clock:** February 5-14, 2026
Curve: 58% → 60% **Collision state:** Collision recedes; single voice against noise floor **Sound state:** Fatou’s voice as clear signal; all else becomes murmur

STAGING

After the cacophony of Scene 2.3, Scene 2.4 offers a single thread to follow: Fatou's argument, migrating across forums, heard by no one who can act. The collision sound becomes background – a constant murmur against which one human voice moves.

The INTERPRETER watches but does not translate. What would be the point? No one is listening in any language.

THE SCENE

[SOUND: The collision has become the baseline. Four rooms, always audible, never fully separable. Over this, one voice will move – Fatou's. Her voice is the thread that passes through all four forums, carrying the same argument, heard by none.]

[LIGHT: All quadrants at 40%. Whichever forum Fatou addresses rises to 70%.]

[CLOCK: February 5, 2026]

[SURTITLE: A new track appears – center, in white – carrying Fatou's words as she migrates. It is the only track the audience needs to follow. The other four fade to ghosts.]

DAVOS QUADRANT

(The panel is over. The room is emptying. FATOU DI-ALLO stands at the microphone. The moderator has left the stage. Two audience members remain – one checking their phone, one putting on a coat. HELEN FISCHER is still in her seat.)

[LIGHT: Davos to 70%.]

FATOU (English, measured, the voice of someone who has learned to compress a continent into seven minutes):

I was given seven minutes. I used nine. I apologize for the extra two minutes. I understand that time is expensive here.

(Beat.)

But I want to say what those nine minutes were about, because the panel is over and the summary will not include it.

(The man checking his phone looks up, then back down.)

Every forum where AI governance is discussed – this one, the one in Hamburg, the one next week in Munich, the one in Washington – every forum has a word it does not say. The word is: absent. Who is absent. Who was not invited. Who does not have the airfare. Who does not have the visa. Who does not have the seven minutes.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Every forum has a

word it does not say. The word is: absent.”]

FATOU:

I represent, in this room, three billion people. Three billion. I was given the same time as the CEO of a company that employs forty thousand. The math – je fais le calcul –

(She switches to French, the language of calculation for her, the colonial language repurposed.)

FATOU:

– trois milliards divisés par neuf minutes. Cela fait trois cent trente-trois millions de personnes par minute. Chaque seconde que je parle représente cinq millions de vies.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Three billion divided by nine minutes. That is three hundred thirty-three million people per minute. Every second I speak represents five million lives.”]

(She looks at the empty room.)

FATOU:

Je parle pour des gens qui ne sauront jamais que cette salle existe.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “I speak for people who will never know this room exists.”]

(HELEN rises from her seat. She wants to respond. She opens her mouth.)

[CUT – Helen’s response is severed. We will never hear it.]

MUNICH QUADRANT

(Two weeks later. A side event: “AI and the Global South.” A smaller room. FATOU is on a screen – joining remotely from Dakar. The connection is bad. Her image pixelates. KENJI NAKAMURA is in the audience.)

[LIGHT: Munich to 70%. Davos fades.]

[SOUND: Bad video call quality – compression artifacts, the particular acoustic of a degraded connection. The sound design should make this feel like the argument itself is being compressed.]

FATOU (on screen, the same words, refined, compressed further):

Every forum where AI is discussed has the same absence. The people who will be most affected are not in the room. They are not on the panel. They are not

–

(Her image freezes. The connection buffers. A spinning wheel.)

MODERATOR:

We seem to have lost Ms. Diallo. Let’s move to our next –

(FATOU’s image returns.)

FATOU:

– they are not even on a stable internet connection. Which is, itself, the argument.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “They are not even on a stable internet connection. Which is, itself, the argument.”]

(In the audience, KENJI closes his eyes. He understands. He writes a note: sekinin.*)*

[CUT.]

WASHINGTON QUADRANT

(The Senate hearing. PRIYA VENKATARAMAN on a screen – video testimony from Bangalore. Behind her, a classroom. Student drawings on a wall. The committee is half-empty.)

[LIGHT: Washington to 70%. Munich fades.]

PRIYA:

Senators, I was asked to testify about why I left AI research. I will answer that. But first I want to echo something a colleague said at Davos, and again at Munich, and which I suspect will be said again at every forum where this question is raised –

[SURTITLE (center, white): Fatou’s argument arrives in Washington via Priya’s voice.]

PRIYA:

The people most affected by artificial intelligence are not in any of these rooms. They are not in this hearing room. They are in Bangalore, where I teach. They are in Lagos. In Dhaka. In Sao Paulo. They are annotating data for two dollars an hour to train systems that will be discussed in rooms they will never enter.

(HAYES looks up from her briefing document. For a moment – one moment – the political mask slips. She is listening.)

PRIYA:

We call this “governance.” We call it “safety.” We call many things. But we do not call it what it is.

HAYES:

And what is it, Dr. Venkataraman?

PRIYA (quietly, Kannada first, then English):

Nirdhaara. Determination. Of other people’s futures. Without their presence. Without their consent. Without even the courtesy of a stable video connection.

[SURTITLE (center, white): Nirdhaara = determination. “Of other people’s futures.”]

[ALL FOUR FORUMS visible at 40%. In each, the same absence is visible: Hamburg had Elena asking from the floor. Davos gave Fatou seven minutes. Munich lost her to a bad connection. Wash-

ington heard it from Priya, from a screen, from a classroom, in a country not invited to the Board of Peace.]

THE GAP

(THE INTERPRETER steps forward.)

INTERPRETER (Wolof – Fatou’s language, the language no forum speaks – then French, then English):

Keneen du am wax ci biir neeg bi. Personne dans la salle n’a le droit de parler. Nobody in the room has the standing to speak.

[SURTITLE: The Wolof is untranslated for 4 seconds. Then the French appears. Then the English. Three layers of arrival. The audience experiences the delay.]

INTERPRETER:

Et celle qui a le droit – n’est pas dans la salle.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “And the one who has the standing – is not in the room.”]

(The Interpreter sits down. She places the headset on the table. She does not put it on again.)

[CLOCK: February 14. The Munich Security Conference ends its first day.]

[CURVE: 59%. 60%.]

SCENE 2.5: MEPHISTOS UBERGANG

Duration: 4 minutes **Clock:** February 14, 2026

Curve: 60% → 62% **Collision state:** Sustained drone; four signatures merged into single chord

Sound state: No longer distinguishable; Mephisto speaks over the drone

STAGING

The four acoustic signatures have merged into a single sustained drone – a complex chord that contains all four forums but no longer allows the audience to distinguish between them. This is the sonic equivalent of the race condition: coherent inputs producing incoherent output.

MEPHISTO stands between two forums simultaneously. Split staging or projection creates his dual presence.

THE SCENE

[SOUND: The collision has become a drone. Four acoustic signatures merged into a single sustained chord at ~60Hz fundamental with

complex harmonics. It is not unpleasant. It is not pleasant. It is the sound of governance failing at a frequency below conscious attention.]

[LIGHT: Split. Davos (memory/golden) on one side. Munich (present/fluorescent) on the other. The Gap lit at center.]

[CLOCK: February 14, 2026. Valentine's Day. Munich Security Conference.]

[CURVE: 60%. Nobody has mentioned it since Movement I.]

SPLIT STAGING

(MEPHISTO stands between Munich and Davos, in two costumes simultaneously. The Davos suit covers his left side. The Munich gray covers his right. His face is lit from both directions. He holds his notebook open.)

(On the Davos side: MARCUS ADEKUNLE speaking to someone off-stage, wine glass in hand, the warm golden light.)

(On the Munich side: GENERAL LINDSTROM at the closed session table, fluorescent light, flags.)

MEPHISTO (turning to Davos side, smooth English):
What he's really saying, Marcus, is that voluntary commitments are the only framework the market

will accept. Mandatory regulation kills innovation. You know this. Everyone in the room knows this. The question is how to frame self-regulation as leadership rather than –

(He pivots ninety degrees, toward Munich.)

MEPHISTO (German, clipped):

– was der CEO eigentlich sagt, Frau General, ist, dass die Industrie sich weigert, sich regulieren zu lassen. “Freiwillig” bedeutet: auf keinen Fall. Die einzige Governance, die funktioniert, ist die staatliche.

[SURTITLE (split – gold left, gray-blue right):
LEFT: “What he’s really saying is that voluntary commitments are the only framework the market will accept.” RIGHT: “What the CEO is really saying, General, is that the industry refuses to be regulated. ‘Voluntary’ means: under no circumstances.”]

(He pauses. Realizes what he has done. Looks at his notebook.)

MEPHISTO (German, to himself – the audience hears, the forums do not):

Ich sage beiden die Wahrheit. Beide Wahrheiten widersprechen sich.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “I am telling both of them the truth. Both truths contradict each other.”]

(He steps back. Another step. He is now at the center of the Gap, between both forums. Both halves of his costume visible. Light from both sides.)

MEPHISTO:

Ich war in jedem dieser Raume. In Hamburg haben sie mich erkannt.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “I was in every one of these rooms. In Hamburg, they recognized me.”]

(He removes something from his pocket: the 39C3 badge. Handle: FAUSTUS.)

MEPHISTO:

In Hamburg stellen sie die richtigen Fragen. Das macht sie gefährlich. Das macht sie auch machtlos. Wer die Frage kennt und die Antwort nicht erzwingen kann, ist die Definition von Cassandra.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “In Hamburg they ask the right questions. That makes them dangerous. It also makes them powerless. To know the question and be unable to enforce the answer is the definition of Cassandra.”]

(He puts the badge away. Produces the leather portfolio.)

MEPHISTO:

In Davos sind sie aufrichtig. Das ist das Schlimmste. Marcus Adekunle glaubt wirklich an das, was er sagt. Er glaubt, dass die Industrie sich selbst regulieren

kann. Und er hat Unrecht, und er hat Recht, und der Unterschied ist irrelevant, weil –

[SURTITLE (center, red): “In Davos they are sincere. That is the worst of it. Marcus Adekunle genuinely believes what he says. He believes industry can self-regulate. And he is wrong, and he is right, and the difference is irrelevant, because –”]

(He produces the classified folder.)

MEPHISTO:

– weil in München die Generale bereits entschieden haben, dass die einzige Governance, die zählt, die militärische ist. Und in Washington –

(He produces nothing. His hands are empty.)

MEPHISTO:

– in Washington brauchen sie mich nicht.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “– because in Munich the generals have already decided that the only governance that counts is the military. And in Washington – they do not need me.”]

(Beat. This lands.)

MEPHISTO:

Das ist die Entdeckung. In Washington funktioniert das System von selbst. Die Struktur versucht sich selbst. Der Lobbyist ist überflüssig, weil die Logik

des Systems seine Arbeit erledigt. Der Versucher ist arbeitslos, wenn die Versuchung architektonisch ist.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “That is the discovery. In Washington the system tempts itself. The structure is the temptation. The lobbyist is redundant because the logic of the system does his work. The tempter is unemployed when the temptation is architectural.”]

(He opens his notebook. Writes one line. The audience sees – projected on the screen behind him – what he writes:)

[PROJECTION:]

Die Wettlaufbedingung ist kein Fehler. Sie ist das Design. (The race condition is not a bug. It is the design.)

(He closes the notebook. Walks offstage – not into any forum. Into the architecture. Into the gap.)

[SOUND: The drone continues. It will not stop.]

[CLOCK: February 14, 23:30.]

[CURVE: 61%. 62%.]

SCENE 2.6: DIE UBERSETZUNG, DIE NICHT STATTFINDET

Duration: 3 minutes **Clock:** February 14, 2026, 23:47
Curve: 62% → 63% **Collision state:** Near-silence; ghosts of four signatures **Sound state:** The headset moment; booth goes dark

STAGING

The four forums fade to darkness. Only the Interpreter's booth remains lit. She is alone with the residue of four conferences, the memory of four acoustic signatures, the infrastructure of translation that no one used.

The HEADSET MOMENT: She picks up the headset, holds it to one ear. The audience hears what she hears – all four forums compressed into the bandwidth of a small speaker. The ocean in a seashell.

THE SCENE

[SOUND: The four signatures fade to ghosts – server hum so faint it might be imagination, wind so thin it might be ventilation, institutional drone so quiet it merges with the theater's own sound. The audience is between forums. The collision has passed. What remains is aftermath.]

[LIGHT: All four forum quadrants at 10% – the residue of occupation. Chairs pushed back. Water glasses half-full. Documents on tables. The Gap rises to full illumination. The Interpreter's booth glows.]

[CLOCK: February 14, 2026, 23:47]

THE INTERPRETER'S BOOTH

(THE INTERPRETER sits alone. The booth is small, glass-walled, intimate. The headset is on the table. A microphone is live but connected to nothing. A notebook, open, mostly blank.)

INTERPRETER (German, slow, precise – the voice of a professional whose profession has been made irrelevant not by technology but by politics):

Ich bin Dolmetscherin. Simultandolmetscherin. Ich übersetze, was eine Sprache sagt, in das, was eine andere Sprache hören kann.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “I am an interpreter. Simultaneous interpreter. I translate what one language says into what another language can hear.”]

INTERPRETER:

In Hamburg sprachen sie Deutsch, mit englischen Folien, mit russischen Fluchen. Ich hatte übersetzen können.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Hamburg they spoke German, with English slides, with Russian curses. I could have translated.”]

INTERPRETER:

In Davos sprachen sie Englisch, und meinten Dollar.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Davos they spoke English, and meant dollars.”]

(A faint smile.)

INTERPRETER:

In Munchen sprachen sie Englisch, und meinten Waffen.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Munich they spoke English, and meant weapons.”]

INTERPRETER:

In Washington sprachen sie Englisch, und meinten Amerika.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Washington they spoke English, and meant America.”]

(Beat.)

INTERPRETER:

Alle sprachen Englisch. Keine Übersetzung nötig. Das ist das Problem.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Everyone spoke English. No translation needed. That is the problem.”]

INTERPRETER:

Die Übersetzung, die gefehlt hat, war nicht zwischen Sprachen. Sie war zwischen Bedeutungen. Das gleiche Wort – safety, governance, pause – und in jedem Raum eine andere Welt dahinter.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “The translation that was missing was not between languages. It was between meanings. The same word – safety, governance, pause – and in every room a different world behind it.”]

INTERPRETER:

Und keiner hat mich gefragt: Was meinen die anderen? Was sagen die, die ihr nicht hört?

[SURTITLE (center, white): “And nobody asked me: What do the others mean? What are they saying, the ones you cannot hear?”]

THE HEADSET MOMENT

(She picks up the headset. Holds it to one ear.)

[SOUND: The audience hears what she hears – all four forum signatures at once, but compressed. Bandpass filtered 300Hz-4kHz. Heavy compression (20:1 ratio). Mono, single point source. Very low volume (-30dB). The entire play’s sonic architecture, reduced to a whisper. The collision

compressed into the bandwidth of a headset speaker. It sounds like a seashell. It sounds like the ocean of human deliberation compressed into static.]

(5 seconds. Her face shows comprehension. Then exhaustion. Then resignation.)

(She removes the headset. Places it on the table.)

[SILENCE. 3 seconds. No sound at all – even the theater’s own hum seems to recede.]

INTERPRETER (French – the language of diplomacy, the language in which the UN was founded):

La traduction qui n’a pas eu lieu.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “The translation that did not occur.”]

INTERPRETER:

Ce n’est pas que je ne pouvais pas. C’est que personne n’a voulu.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “It is not that I could not. It is that nobody wanted me to.”]

(She closes her notebook. It is almost empty. A professional with nothing to do.)

(She looks at the four empty forums around her.)

INTERPRETER (very quietly, German):

Vier Raume. Eine Frage. Keine Übersetzung.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Four rooms. One question. No translation.”]

(She reaches for the booth’s control panel. Presses a button.)

[The green light on the translation booth goes off.]

[The booth dims to darkness. She remains visible as a silhouette, sitting alone.]

[CLOCK: February 14 becomes February 15. The second day of the Munich Security Conference begins. The forums will reconvene. The same words will be spoken. The same different things will be meant.]

[CURVE: 62%. 63%. It does not stop rising because the day has ended.]

[The four forum quadrants glow faintly at 5% – the residual light of rooms that have been occupied, still warm with body heat, still holding the shape of the people who sat in them, who spoke in them, who said the same words and meant different things.]

[END OF MOVEMENT II: DIE KOLLISION.]

PRODUCTION NOTES

Sound Design Choreography

Scene	Sound State	Key Cues
2.1	Brief bleeds (3 sec)	Four signatures established; overlap only at CUT transitions
2.2	Longer bleeds (5 sec)	Signatures begin to merge at transitions; acoustic barriers narrowing
2.3	Full collision	All four signatures at maximum for quadruple speech; CRASH SOUND (once only); 3-sec total silence

Scene	Sound State	Key Cues
2.4	Collision recedes	Fatou's voice clear against murmur; bad video call compression artifacts
2.5	Sustained drone	Four signatures merged into ~60Hz composite chord; Mephisto speaks over
2.6	Near-silence / ghosts	Headset moment (compressed collision, -30dB, bandpass filtered); booth goes dark

The CRASH SOUND (Technical)

The crash sound in Scene 2.3 appears ONCE ONLY in the entire play. It is the structural pivot.

Specifications:

- Rising tone: 500Hz to 4kHz in 0.5 seconds
- Waveform: Synthesized, evocative of digital fail-

ure

- Termination: Hard stop, no decay, no reverb
- Followed by: 3 seconds minimum total silence (ALL outputs to zero except sub-bass curve tone at -40dB)
- Never repeated

Lighting State Transitions

Movement II uses “collision lighting” – states that blend and interfere rather than crossfade cleanly.

Transition	Effect
CUT (2.1)	Hard, immediate, mid-sentence; target to 100%, others to 30%
BLEED (2.2)	2-second overlap where both forums are at 70% before one fades
COLLISION (2.3)	All four at 100% simultaneously
FREEZE (2.3)	Hold current state; Gap to 100% for Mephisto
RECESSION (2.4-2.6)	Gradual reduction; forums to 40%, then 10%, then 5%

Mephisto Costume Quick-Change

Scene 2.2 requires Mephisto to transform from Munich (Dr. Weber) to Davos (strategic advisor) while crossing the Gap.

Costume elements:

- Munich: Gray suit jacket, security badge on lanyard, classified folder
- Davos: Different suit jacket (same pants), leather portfolio, no visible credentials

Change choreography:

1. Exit Munich quadrant in gray jacket with badge
2. Four steps through Gap (~8 seconds)
3. Remove badge, pocket it
4. Exchange jacket (pre-set on Gap furniture piece)
5. Exchange folder for portfolio
6. Enter Davos quadrant

For Scene 2.5, the split costume (half Munich, half Davos) requires:

- Pre-constructed split jacket (gray left, dark right)
- Lighting that accentuates the division
- Or: projection overlay creating the split effect

Surtitle Mode Reference

Element	Mode	Timing
Jonas (German)	Mode 1	Immediate

Element	Mode	Timing
Sasha (English)	Not surtitled	–
Marcus (English)	Not surtitled	–
Helen (German sotto voce)	Mode 2	3-sec delay
Kenji (Japanese)	Mode 2	4-sec delay
Yosef (Hebrew)	Mode 2	3-sec delay
Lindstrom (Swedish)	Mode 3 then Mode 2	5 sec untranslated, then translate
Fatou (French)	Mode 1	Immediate
Fatou (Wolof)	Mode 3 then Mode 2	4 sec untranslated
Priya (Kannada)	Mode 3 then Mode 2	4 sec untranslated
Mephisto (German)	Mode 2	4-5 sec delay
Interpreter (German/French)	Mode 1	Immediate

Running Time Breakdown

Scene	Duration	Cumulative
2.1 Sicherheit	5 min	5 min
2.2 Steuerung	5 min	10 min
2.3 Die Pause	8 min	18 min
2.4 Fatous Wanderung	5 min	23 min

Scene	Duration	Cumulative
2.5 Mephistos Ubergang	4 min	27 min
2.6 Die Übersetzung	3 min	30 min
Total Movement II	~30 min	

Transition to Movement III

Movement II ends with:

- Four forums at 5% light (residual)
- Interpreter's booth dark
- Headset on table, unused
- Clock at February 15, 2026
- Curve at 63%
- Sound: near-silence, only the faint drone remains

Movement III (Der Deadlock) begins with:

- The drone solidifying slightly
- Forums re-emerging at 30% (still permanently mixed)
- The production of documents
- Interleaving accelerating further

The transition should be continuous – no blackout, no pause. The deadlock begins the moment the collision ends.

THEMATIC SUMMARY

What Movement II Dramatizes

The collision is not physical but semantic. The same words appear in all four forums – safety, governance, pause, coordination, risk – and mean incompatible things. The collision is the discovery that English is not a shared language when the frameworks behind the words are different.

The audience experiences the race condition. During the quadruple speech (Scene 2.3), the audience's attention becomes the shared resource. Four threads (voices) access it simultaneously. No synchronization mechanism exists. The output is nondeterministic – each audience member follows a different fragment.

The translation that does not occur. The Interpreter is present throughout, infrastructure ready, channels open. No one asks her to translate. The failure is not technical – it is political. The forums do not want to hear each other.

Mephisto's discovery. He can tell both sides the truth (Scene 2.5) because both truths are true and contradictory. But in Washington, he discovers something worse: the system tempts itself. The structure is the temptation. He is redundant.

The crash is the thesis. When four coherent signals access the same resource without synchronization, the result is not noise – it is halt. The pause that

everyone wants and no one can be first to take produces the opposite of pause: deadlock.

“Vier Raume. Eine Frage. Keine Übersetzung.” (Four rooms. One question. No translation.)

Document: v-half-movement-ii-refined.md **Status:** Production-ready draft **Created:** 2026-02-01 **Running time:** ~30 minutes **Languages:** German, English, French, Swedish, Japanese, Hebrew, Wolof, Kannada, Russian **Sound design:** Per V-HALF-SOUND-DESIGN.md Section 3 **Staging:** Quadrant (per STAGING-APPROACH-DECISION.md)

Die Kollision ist nicht der Zusammenstoss. Sie ist die Entdeckung, dass die Raume nie verbunden waren. (The collision is not the impact. It is the discovery that the rooms were never connected.)

—
title: “DIE KOLLISION” source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMplete.md lines: 8639-9560 order: 27 extracted: 2026-02-03 —

Movement II - Die Kollision: Szenen 2.1-2.6

Movement II of FAUST V 1/2: Die Wettlaufbedingung

Duration: 20-25 minutes **Position:** After Movement I (Die Foren) has established each forum independently. **Principle:** The four forums begin to interleave. The same words appear in different rooms with different meanings. The cutting accelerates until nobody can distinguish signal from noise.

STAGING NOTE

Movement II requires all four forum spaces to be partially visible or rapidly accessible. The recommended approach (Option C from the concept) places one forum on stage at a time with the other three on screens – but during the Kollision, the screens become equal partners. By Scene 2.3 (“Die Pause”), all four spaces should be simultaneously visible.

The Clock is visible throughout. It reads dates between late December 2025 and mid-February 2026. It never pauses. Between scenes, it advances visibly – days compressed into seconds. The audience watches governance time slip away.

The Capability Curve is projected above or beside the clock. It rises. It does not care about the scenes below it. At the top of Movement II, the curve is at roughly 40% of the vertical axis. By the end of Movement II, it has crossed 60%. Nobody on any stage references this change. The audience sees it.

SURTITLE PROTOCOL FOR MOVEMENT II

Four surtitle tracks operate independently, color-coded:

Forum	Color
HAMBURG (39C3)	Green (terminal text)
DAVOS (WEF)	Gold
MUNICH (MSC)	Gray-blue (NATO palette)
WASHINGTON (Board of Peace)	White on dark blue

During collision sequences, all four tracks may run simultaneously. The audience cannot read them all. **This is the point.** The surtitles themselves become a race condition.

When a word appears simultaneously in multiple tracks with different meanings, it is highlighted in **red** across all four – the collision made typographic.

SCENE 2.1: SICHERHEIT / SAFETY / SECURITE / SECURITY

[Approximate duration: 5 minutes]

[SOUND: The four acoustic signatures overlap. Hamburg's server hum bleeds into Davos's thick silence. The transition is not clean. Something is already wrong with the sound architecture – frequencies interfering.]

[CLOCK: December 30, 2025 – advances to January 20, 2026 during the scene.]

[SURTITLE: All four tracks activate for the first time simultaneously. The word SICHERHEIT / SAFETY / SECURITE / SECURITY appears in red across all four positions.]

[STAGE: Hamburg. 39C3. The final day. JONAS BERGER stands at a lectern. Behind him, a slide reads: “GOVERNANCE ALS WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG.” SASHA VOLKOV sits in the second row, laptop open. The room is cold, fluorescent, full. Someone in the back is eating pizza from a cardboard box.]

JONAS (in German, slides in English): Wenn wir von Sicherheit sprechen – und ich meine jetzt nicht IT-Sicherheit, sondern die andere Sicherheit, die politische Sicherheit, die Sicherheit, die in Davos gemeint ist, wenn sie das Wort benutzen –

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “When we speak of safety – and I don’t mean IT security now, but the other safety, the political safety, the safety that is meant at Davos when they use the word –”]

JONAS: – dann meinen wir etwas grundsätzlich anderes.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “– then we mean something fundamentally different.”]

JONAS: Für uns bedeutet Sicherheit: der Nutzer ist vor dem System geschützt. Das System hat keinen Zugriff, den der Nutzer nicht versteht und genehmigt.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/ green): “For us, safety means: the user is protected FROM the system. The system has no access that the user does not understand and approve.”]

[CUT – the word CUT is literal here: the sound of Hamburg is severed mid-sentence, replaced by]

[SOUND: Mountain wind. Then the expensive silence of Davos. Carpet, glass, the faint clink of water glasses.]

[STAGE: Davos. A private session at the Congress Centre. MARCUS ADEKUNLE at a round table. HELEN FISCHER moderating. The room is wood-paneled, warm-lit. Name placards. Translation earpieces that nobody is wearing because everyone speaks English here.]

MARCUS: Safety is the precondition for trust, and trust is the precondition for adoption, and adoption is the precondition for return on investment. If we lose the safety narrative, we lose the market.

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): SAFETY = BRAND RISK / MARKET CONDITION]

[The Hamburg surtitle track continues running, ghosted to half-opacity, showing Jonas’s next sentence – which the audience can still read but cannot hear:]

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/ green, ghosted): “Die CCC-Definition: Sicherheit ist das Recht, nicht überwacht zu werden.” / “The CCC definition:

Safety is the right not to be surveilled.”]

HELEN: Marcus, when you say “safety narrative” – and I appreciate the candor – do you mean the actual safety of users, or the perception of safety that enables –

MARCUS: Helen, with respect, the distinction doesn’t operationalize. The perception IS the safety, at scale. If users believe the system is safe, adoption proceeds. If they don’t, regulation fills the vacuum. The question is whether we define safety, or whether governments define it for us.

[CUT.]

[SOUND: Institutional hum. Rustling papers. The particular feedback whine of translation earpieces. A door closes somewhere, heavy and secure.]

[STAGE: Munich. Hotel Bayerischer Hof. A closed session. GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM at the head of the table. DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI presenting. COLONEL JAMES MORRISON sits with arms folded. Flags behind them. A red-bordered folder marked VERSCHLUSSSACHE / CLASSIFIED on the table.]

LINDSTROM: Dr. Ben-Ari has just briefed us on the capability assessment. Before we open discussion, I want to frame the safety question in operational terms.

[SURTITLE (Munich/ gray-blue): SAFETY =

STRATEGIC VULNERABILITY / NATIONAL SECURITY EXPOSURE]

LINDSTROM: In this context, “safety” does not mean what the technology sector means by it. It does not mean alignment. It does not mean user protection. It means: if this capability is achieved by an adversary first, what is the exposure? If this capability fails in a fielded system, what is the casualty estimate?

[Beat.]

LINDSTROM: Safety, for us, is the inverse of vulnerability.

YOSEF (quietly, almost to himself): Sicherheit als Abwesenheit von Verwundbarkeit. Das ist nicht –

[SURTITLE (Munich/ gray-blue): “Safety as the absence of vulnerability. That is not –”]

[He stops himself. Morrison glances at him.]

MORRISON: General, if I may. The United States view is that safety and capability are not in tension. American AI superiority IS global safety. The safest world is one where the most responsible actor has the most advanced capability.

[SURTITLE (Munich/ gray-blue, continuing): SAFETY = AMERICAN CAPABILITY DOMINANCE]

[CUT.]

[SOUND: Air conditioning. Fluorescent buzz. The unmistakable acoustic of an American government hearing room – the particular deadness

of the air, the way microphones pick up every rustle.]

[STAGE: Washington. A Senate hearing room. SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES behind the raised dais. VIKRAM PATEL at the witness table, a glass of water he hasn't touched. Behind Hayes, a staffer is typing on a laptop.]

HAYES: Mr. Patel, let me ask you directly. You are the Chief Safety Officer of Prometheus Labs. In your professional judgment, is American AI safe?

VIKRAM: Senator, I want to answer that precisely. Safe for whom, and against what?

HAYES: Safe for the American people.

VIKRAM: The American people are not a single threat model, Senator. A system that is safe for national security may not be safe for individual privacy. A system that is safe for commercial deployment may not be safe for –

HAYES: Mr. Patel. The question is simple. Is it safe, or isn't it?

[Beat. Vikram looks at his water glass.]

VIKRAM: It is not unsafe in a way that current frameworks can measure.

HAYES: I'm going to take that as a yes.

[SURTITLE (Washington/ white): SAFETY = LIABILITY MANAGEMENT / POLITICAL COVER]

[All four surtitle tracks are now visible. The word SAFETY / SICHERHEIT / SECURITE pulses in red across all four positions. Four definitions. Four forums. One word. Zero overlap.]

[SOUND: All four acoustic signatures bleed into each other for three seconds – server hum, mountain wind, institutional drone, fluorescent buzz – creating a brief, dissonant chord.]

[Then silence.]

[THE INTERPRETER appears in the fifth space – the gap between forums. They wear a translation headset around their neck, not on their ears. They hold a notebook.]

INTERPRETER (to the audience, quietly, in French – the traditional language of diplomacy): Quatre salles. Un mot. Quatre significations.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Four rooms. One word. Four meanings.”]

INTERPRETER: Dans la premiere salle, la securite protege la personne du systeme. Dans la deuxieme, elle protege le systeme de la personne. Dans la troisieme, elle protege l’etat de l’adversaire. Dans la quatrieme, elle protege le politicien de la question.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In the first room, safety protects the person from the system. In the second, it protects the system from the person. In the third, it protects the state from the adversary. In the fourth, it protects the

politician from the question.”]

INTERPRETER: Je pourrais les relier. C’est mon métier. Personne ne me le demande.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “I could connect them. It is my profession. Nobody asks me to.”]

[The Interpreter puts the headset on, listens. All four channels at once. Their face registers something between comprehension and nausea. They remove the headset.]

[CLOCK advances. January 20 becomes January 21, 2026.]

[Blackout on the Interpreter. The four forums glow faintly, waiting.]

SCENE 2.2: STEUERUNG / GOVERNANCE / GOUVERNANCE / GOVERNANCE

[Approximate duration: 5 minutes]

[SOUND: The four signatures return, but now they are closer together – the acoustic space between forums has narrowed. Hamburg’s electronic bleed is louder. Davos’s silence is thinner. The forums are creeping toward each other in the sound field.]

[CLOCK: January 21-24, 2026. Davos week. The clock advances during the scene.]

[SURTITLE: The word GOVERNANCE / STEUERUNG / GOUVERNANCE appears in red across all four tracks.]

[This scene is faster. The cuts happen every 30-45 seconds. The forums are answering each other, though they cannot hear each other.]

[STAGE: Hamburg. 39C3 has ended, but SASHA is recording a video in a hotel room. Her laptop camera's green light is on. Behind her, conference lanyards hang from a chair. A half-empty Club-Mate bottle on the desk.]

SASHA (in English, speaking to camera): What do we mean when we say governance? We mean community standards. We mean the people who use the system get to decide how the system works. We mean – look, I worked at a lab where governance meant the CEO decided, and safety meant the safety team agreed with the CEO, and oversight meant the board was composed of the CEO's friends. That's not governance. That's –

[She searches for the word.]

SASHA: – tiraniya.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “– tyranny.” (Russian)]

SASHA: So when I say governance, I mean: who decides? And the answer has to be: the people who are affected. Not the people who profit.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/ green): GOVERNANCE = COMMUNITY SELF-DETERMINATION]

[CUT.]

[STAGE: Davos. A different session. MARCUS ADEKUNLE is on a panel. The banner behind reads: “RESPONSIBLE AI: FROM PRINCIPLES TO PRACTICE.” HELEN FISCHER is in the audience. FATOU DIALLO sits at the far end of the panel, the only person of color on stage.]

MARCUS: The industry position – and I say this representing not just Prometheus Labs but the coalition of responsible developers – is that governance must be industry-led. We understand the technology. Regulators don’t. The AI Act is, frankly – and I say this with respect to our European friends –

[He glances at Helen in the audience.]

MARCUS: – the AI Act is a framework designed by people who don’t build the systems they’re regulating.

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): GOVERNANCE = SELF-REGULATION BY INDUSTRY]

[FATOU leans toward her microphone. She was not expected to speak at this point. The moderator looks uncomfortable.]

FATOU: May I?

MODERATOR (off-mic, audible): We'll come to you in a moment, Fatou.

FATOU (ignoring this, in English with French intonation): Self-regulation by industry. You mean: the people who profit decide how the people who are affected are governed. This is not governance. This is –

[Beat. She chooses English instead of the French word that comes to mind.]

FATOU: – administration. Of someone else's life. By people who don't know their name.

[SURTITLE (Davos/gold): FATOU: "Administration. Of someone else's life."]

[CUT.]

[STAGE: Munich. The closed session continues. KENJI NAKAMURA is speaking. His English is careful, precise, accented.]

KENJI: In Japanese, the word closest to "governance" in this context is *tochi* – which carries the meaning of administering territory. To govern is to hold land. The question of AI governance is therefore: who holds the territory? And here I see a problem my colleagues may not.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): *tochi* = territorial administration]

KENJI: You are debating governance as if it were arms control. And I understand why – this room

thinks in those terms. But arms control assumes sovereign states with borders. AI has no border. Compute has no border. Data has no border. You are applying territorial governance to a non-territorial phenomenon.

[Beat.]

KENJI: In my tradition, we speak of sekinin – responsibility that is not contractual but constitutive. You do not choose it. It is what you are. Perhaps governance begins there.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): sekinin = constitutive responsibility]

LINDSTROM (politely): Thank you, Ambassador Nakamura. Colonel Morrison, the American perspective on governance frameworks?

MORRISON: Ma'am, governance means command structure. Who gives the order, who carries it out, who is accountable. Everything else is philosophy.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): GOVERNANCE = COMMAND AND CONTROL]

[CUT.]

[STAGE: Washington. The hearing continues. Hayes is now addressing Vikram, but a different kind of energy – she is reading from a prepared text.]

HAYES: Mr. Patel, the President has signed Executive Order 14217, establishing a National AI Governance

Framework. Under this framework, governance is defined as – and I’m reading from the order – “the coordinated exercise of American leadership in establishing norms, standards, and practices for the development and deployment of artificial intelligence systems, consistent with the national interest.”

[She looks up from the paper.]

HAYES: The national interest. Not the global interest. The national interest. Do you see the distinction?

VIKRAM: I do, Senator.

HAYES: Good. Because governance, in this building, means executive order. It means the President decides, and the agencies implement. That’s governance.

[SURTITLE (Washington/white): GOVERNANCE = EXECUTIVE ORDER / UNILATERAL FIAT]

[All four tracks pulse the word GOVERNANCE in red.]

[SOUND: The four signatures collide again – this time longer, five seconds, building. The server hum fights the institutional drone. The mountain wind cuts through the fluorescence. It sounds like an orchestra tuning, but an orchestra that will never play together.]

[From the collision of sound, MEPHISTO emerges.]

[He walks from the Munich space toward the

Davos space. As he crosses the threshold, his appearance shifts. The gray suit of Dr. Weber – defense consultant, classified clearance badge – melts into the impeccable suit of the unnamed strategic advisor. The badge disappears. The classified folder becomes a leather portfolio. The transformation happens in the gap between forums, in four steps.]

[He pauses in the fifth space. Looks at the audience.]

MEPHISTO (in German, conversational): Steuerung. Governance. Gouvernance.

[Beat.]

MEPHISTO: Vier Raume, vier Definitionen. In Hamburg bedeutet es: das Volk entscheidet. In Davos: die Industrie entscheidet. In Munchen: der Staat entscheidet. In Washington: der Prasident entscheidet.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “Four rooms, four definitions. In Hamburg it means: the people decide. In Davos: the industry decides. In Munich: the state decides. In Washington: the President decides.”]

MEPHISTO: Und keiner fragt: Was entscheidet die Technik, wahrend ihr entscheidet, wer entscheidet?

[SURTITLE (center, red): “And nobody asks: What does the technology decide, while you decide who decides?”]

[He produces his notebook – the same notebook across all four forums, the single recognizable element. He writes something in it. The audience cannot see what.]

[CLOCK: January 24 becomes January 25. Davos ends. The forums are between events. The gap widens. But the curve keeps rising.]

SCENE 2.3: DIE PAUSE / THE PAUSE / LA PAUSE

[Approximate duration: 8 minutes. This is the central collision sequence – the longest, loudest, fastest. The cuts accelerate from 30 seconds to 10 seconds to overlapping dialogue.]

[SOUND: All four acoustic signatures are now present simultaneously, at low volume. The audience hears all four rooms at once. The sound should feel like being in a crowded airport – many conversations, none intelligible, all urgent.]

[CLOCK: January 25 – February 14, 2026. The clock accelerates. Days pass in seconds. The space between forums – which was weeks in Movement I – is now hours.]

[SURTITLE: The word PAUSE appears in red across all four tracks simultaneously before any

character speaks it. The word is there first. The characters arrive at it.]

[ALL FOUR FORUMS ARE NOW VISIBLE. The stage is split or projected. Hamburg occupies one quarter. Davos another. Munich another. Washington another. The fifth space – the gap – is the center. Each space is lit according to its signature: cold fluorescent, golden warm, institutional gray, tungsten government.]

[MEPHISTO stands in the center. He is between costumes – the Davos suit is half-on, the Munich badge is in his pocket, the Hamburg black t-shirt is visible underneath. He is caught between identities. He watches all four simultaneously.]

[The sequence begins with MARCUS at Davos, speaking the word first.]

MARCUS (Davos, standing, addressing a private dinner – candles, wine, the warm light of money): I want to propose something that I know will be controversial. I believe we need a voluntary pause. Six months. An industry-wide moratorium on training runs above a defined compute threshold. Not because we're afraid, but because we need time to –

[CUT – but Marcus continues speaking, now inaudible, mouth moving behind glass. His words become the Davos surtitle track:]

[SURTITLE (Davos/ gold): “– establish safety benchmarks that give regulators and the public confidence that we are not racing ahead of our understanding –”]

[Simultaneously:]

[STAGE: Hamburg. SASHA, now in her apartment in Berlin, three weeks after the Congress. She is on a video call with JONAS and ELENA. Jonas is in his flat – bookshelves, empty coffee cups. Elena is in Manila – it is 3 AM there, her face lit by the laptop screen.]

SASHA (reading from her phone): He said it. Adekunle actually said it at Davos. A “voluntary pause.”

JONAS (in German): Freiwillig. Das ist das Wort, das alles zerstört.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “Voluntary. That’s the word that destroys everything.”]

SASHA: Who pauses? The ones already ahead. They pause, they lock in their lead, they call it responsibility.

ELENA (from Manila, tired, direct): And who doesn’t pause? The ones in Shenzhen. The ones in Tel Aviv. The ones who don’t attend Davos.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): PAUSE = TACTICAL ADVANTAGE DISGUISED AS ETHICS]

JONAS: Eine Pause, die nur die Vorsichtigen betrifft, ist keine Pause. Es ist ein Wettbewerbsvorteil für die

Rucksichtslos.

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “A pause that only affects the cautious is not a pause. It is a competitive advantage for the reckless.”]

[CUT to Munich – but Hamburg stays visible, dimmed.]

[STAGE: Munich. A corridor outside the closed session. LINDSTROM and MORRISON walking. Coffee cups. The sound of the corridor – footsteps on marble, distant voices, the institutional acoustics of the Bayerischer Hof.]

MORRISON: General, you’ve seen the Davos proposal.

LINDSTROM: The voluntary pause.

MORRISON: Ma’am, I want to be direct. The Pentagon’s position is that a pause on AI capability development is unilateral disarmament. If we pause and China does not pause, we fall behind. If we fall behind, deterrence erodes. If deterrence erodes –

LINDSTROM: Colonel, I understand deterrence logic. I wrote my thesis on it.

[Beat.]

LINDSTROM (more quietly): The problem with applying deterrence to AI is that deterrence requires your adversary to understand your capability and believe you will use it. With AI, we do not fully understand our own capability. How do we deter with a weapon we cannot predict?

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): PAUSE = UNILATERAL DISARMAMENT / STRATEGIC SUICIDE]

MORRISON: All the more reason to keep building, ma'am. You deter by staying ahead.

LINDSTROM (to herself, in Swedish): Man kan inte avskracka med något man inte forstar.

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue): "You cannot deter with something you do not understand."]

[No surtitle translation. Mode 3: the audience must sit with the sound.]

[CUT to Washington – Munich stays visible, dimmed.]

[STAGE: Washington. A different room – not the hearing room, but a White House conference room. HAYES is present, now in a different role – she is meeting with the executive. A television on the wall shows a news ticker: "DAVOS: TECH LEADERS CALL FOR AI PAUSE." The sound is muted.]

HAYES (reading from a briefing document, speaking to someone off-stage): The Davos proposal. Page twelve. "Voluntary moratorium on frontier model training." The communications team has prepared talking points.

[She looks up.]

HAYES: The talking point is: un-American. That's the word they want us to use. A pause is un-American.

Americans don't pause. We lead.

[Beat.]

HAYES: I have to say, it writes itself.

[SURTITLE (Washington/ white): PAUSE = UN-AMERICAN / ALREADY REJECTED]

[A phone rings. Hayes picks up. Listens. Her face changes.]

HAYES (into phone): When did the executive order – ?
... Yes, I understand. Before we even – yes.

[She hangs up.]

HAYES (to the off-stage presence): It's already been rejected. The President signed it this morning. Executive order rejecting any moratorium on AI development. The pause proposal is dead. It was dead before it was proposed.

[SURTITLE (Washington/white): THE EXECUTIVE ORDER WAS SIGNED BEFORE THE PROPOSAL WAS PUBLISHED.]

[ALL FOUR FORUMS NOW SPEAK SIMULTANEOUSLY.]

[This is the moment the audience realizes nobody is coordinating.]

[SOUND: All four acoustic signatures at full volume. The collision sound. It is not music. It is not noise. It is four coherent signals occupying the

same frequency space, making each other unintelligible.]

[The following four speeches happen at the same time. The actors speak over each other. The subtitles run in all four tracks simultaneously. The audience can follow one, or try to follow two, or give up and absorb the cacophony. All responses are valid.]

HAMBURG (JONAS, in German): Wir haben die technische Kompetenz, die Pause zu erzwingen. Offene Infrastruktur. Dezentralisierung der Rechenleistung. Wenn genug von uns sagen: wir machen nicht mit – dann ist die Pause nicht freiwillig. Dann ist sie Widerstand. Dann ist sie –

[SURTITLE (Hamburg/green): “We have the technical competence to enforce the pause. Open infrastructure. Decentralization of compute. If enough of us say: we will not participate – then the pause is not voluntary. It is resistance. It is –”]

DAVOS (MARCUS, in English): The voluntary nature of the proposal is precisely the point. We cannot regulate what we don’t understand. The companies building these systems are the only ones who understand them well enough to set meaningful limits. This is not self-interest – it is epistemic humility. We know what we’ve built. Regulators don’t. The pause must come from us, or it means nothing –

[SURTITLE (Davos/ gold, running simultane-

ously): (text as above)]

MUNICH (LINDSTROM, in English with Swedish intonation): I have read the Davos proposal. I have read the Hamburg counter-proposal. Neither accounts for the security dimension. A pause by the West is not a global pause. It is an invitation. An invitation to every adversary to close the gap while we deliberate. The security conference's position must be: capability first, governance second –

[SURTITLE (Munich/gray-blue, running simultaneously): (text as above)]

WASHINGTON (HAYES, in English, congressional cadence): The President has made the American position clear. We do not pause. We do not slow down. We lead. American AI dominance is not a corporate interest – it is a national security imperative. The idea that we should wait for international consensus before developing the technology that will define the next century is, frankly, the kind of thinking that –

[SURTITLE (Washington/white, running simultaneously): (text as above)]

[The four speeches continue for twenty seconds. The sound is overwhelming. The surtitles are unreadable – four tracks running simultaneously, the eye cannot track them. The collision is complete.]

[Then –]

[SOUND: A sharp electronic tone. The kind of

sound a system makes when it encounters a fatal error. A crash. A halt.]

[ALL FOUR FORUMS FREEZE.]

[Silence.]

[Only the CLOCK moves. February 1 becomes February 2. The CAPABILITY CURVE ticks upward. One millimeter. Two.]

[In the silence, from the center of the stage, from the gap between all four frozen forums:]

MEPHISTO (quietly, in German): Vier Antworten auf eine Frage, die keiner gestellt hat.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “Four answers to a question nobody asked.”]

[Beat.]

MEPHISTO: Die Frage war nicht: Sollen wir pausieren. Die Frage war: Können wir.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “The question was not: Should we pause. The question was: Can we.”]

MEPHISTO: Und die Antwort – in allen vier Räumen, auf vier verschiedene Arten, in vier verschiedenen Sprachen –

[SURTITLE (center, red): “And the answer – in all four rooms, in four different ways, in four different languages –”]

MEPHISTO: – ist Nein.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “– is No.”]

[The forums unfreeze. But the sound has changed. The four acoustic signatures are now bleeding permanently into each other. The separation between rooms is eroding.]

SCENE 2.4: FATOUS WANDERUNG / FATOU’S MIGRATION

[Approximate duration: 5 minutes]

[SOUND: The collision sound has become the baseline. Four rooms, always audible, never fully separable. Over this, a single human voice will move – Fatou’s. Her voice is the thread that passes through all four forums, carrying the same argument, heard by none.]

[CLOCK: February 5-14, 2026. The gap between Davos and Munich. The interregnum.]

[SURTITLE: A new track appears – center, in white – carrying Fatou’s words as she migrates between forums. It is the only track the audience needs to follow. The other four fade to ghosts.]

[STAGE: Davos. The panel is over. The room is emptying. FATOU DIALLO stands at the microphone. The moderator has already left the

stage. Two audience members remain – one is checking their phone, one is putting on a coat. HELEN FISCHER is still in her seat, listening.]

FATOU (in English, measured, the voice of someone who has learned to compress a continent into seven minutes): I was given seven minutes. I used nine. I apologize for the extra two minutes. I understand that time is expensive here.

[Beat.]

FATOU: But I want to say what those nine minutes were about, because the panel is over and the summary will not include it.

[The man checking his phone looks up, then back down.]

FATOU: Every forum where AI governance is discussed – this one, the one in Hamburg, the one next week in Munich, the one in Washington – every forum has a word it does not say. The word is: absent. Who is absent. Who was not invited. Who does not have the airfare. Who does not have the visa. Who does not have the seven minutes.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Every forum has a word it does not say. The word is: absent.”]

FATOU: I represent, in this room, three billion people. Three billion. I was given the same time as the CEO of a company that employs forty thousand. The math – je fais le calcul –

[She switches to French, the language of calculation for her, the colonial language repurposed.]

FATOU: – trois milliards divisés par neuf minutes. Cela fait trois cent trente-trois millions de personnes par minute. Chaque seconde que je parle représente cinq millions de vies.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Three billion divided by nine minutes. That is three hundred thirty-three million people per minute. Every second I speak represents five million lives.”]

[She pauses. Looks at the empty room.]

FATOU: Je parle pour des gens qui ne sauront jamais que cette salle existe.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “I speak for people who will never know this room exists.”]

[HELEN rises from her seat. She wants to respond. She opens her mouth.]

[CUT.]

[STAGE: Munich. Two weeks later. A side event – not the main session, but a panel on “AI and the Global South.” A different room, smaller. FATOU is on a screen – she is joining remotely from Dakar. The connection is bad. Her image pixelates.]

[KENJI NAKAMURA is in the audience.]

FATOU (on screen, the same words, slightly different – she has refined them, compressed them further):

Every forum where AI is discussed has the same absence. The people who will be most affected are not in the room. They are not on the panel. They are not –

[Her image freezes. The connection buffers. A spinning wheel.]

[The panel moderator waits three seconds, then says:]

MODERATOR: We seem to have lost Ms. Diallo. Let's move to our next –

[FATOU's image returns.]

FATOU: – they are not even on a stable internet connection. Which is, itself, the argument.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “They are not even on a stable internet connection. Which is, itself, the argument.”]

[KENJI, in the audience, closes his eyes. He has heard this. He understands it. He writes a note: sekinin.]

[CUT.]

[STAGE: Washington. The Senate hearing. PRIYA VENKATARAMAN on a screen – video testimony from Bangalore. She is in a classroom. Behind her, student drawings on a wall. She is calm, clear, speaking to a committee that is half-empty.]

PRIYA: Senators, I was asked to testify about why I left

AI research. I will answer that. But first I want to echo something a colleague said at Davos, and again at Munich, and which I suspect will be said again at every forum where this question is raised –

[SURTITLE (center, white): Fatou’s argument arrives in Washington via Priya’s voice.]

PRIYA: The people most affected by artificial intelligence are not in any of these rooms. They are not in this hearing room. They are in Bangalore, where I teach. They are in Lagos. In Dhaka. In Sao Paulo. They are annotating data for two dollars an hour to train systems that will be discussed in rooms they will never enter.

[HAYES looks up from her briefing document. For a moment – one moment – the political mask slips. She is listening.]

PRIYA: We call this “governance.” We call it “safety.” We call it many things. But we do not call it what it is.

HAYES: And what is it, Dr. Venkataraman?

PRIYA: It is –

[She pauses. The classroom behind her is visible. A child walks past the door.]

PRIYA (quietly, in Kannada, then English): Nirdhaara. Determination. Of other people’s futures. Without their presence. Without their consent. Without even the courtesy of a stable video connection.

[SURTITLE (center, white): Nirdhaara = determi-

nation. “Of other people’s futures.”]

[Beat.]

[ALL FOUR FORUMS are visible. In each one, the same absence. Hamburg had Elena asking questions from the data-annotation floor. Davos gave Fatou seven minutes. Munich lost her to a bad connection. Washington heard it from Priya on a screen, from a classroom, in a country that was not invited to the Board of Peace.]

[The INTERPRETER steps forward. They have been watching.]

INTERPRETER (in Wolof – Fatou’s language, the language no forum speaks – then French, then English): Keneen du am wax ci biir neeg bi. Personne dans la salle n’a le droit de parler. Nobody in the room has the standing to speak.

[SURTITLE: The Wolof is untranslated for three seconds. Then the French appears. Then the English. Three layers of arrival. The audience experiences the delay that IS the problem.]

INTERPRETER: Et celle qui a le droit – n’est pas dans la salle.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “And the one who has the standing – is not in the room.”]

[The Interpreter sits down. They place the headset on the table. They do not put it on again.]

SCENE 2.5: MEPHISTOS UBERGANG / MEPHISTO CROSSES

[Approximate duration: 4 minutes]

[SOUND: The collision sound is now constant – a low, complex drone made of four rooms’ acoustic signatures merged into one sustained chord. It is not unpleasant. It is not pleasant. It is the sound of governance failing at a frequency below conscious attention.]

[CLOCK: February 14, 2026. Valentine’s Day. The Munich Security Conference opens. All four forums have now occurred or are occurring. The timeline is full. The space between events is gone.]

[THE CAPABILITY CURVE has crossed the 55% mark on the vertical axis. Nobody on stage has mentioned it since Movement I.]

[STAGE: Split. On one side, Davos – not the current Davos, but a memory of it: MARCUS ADEKUNLE speaking to someone off-stage, the warm golden light, the wine. On the other side, Munich – the current Munich: GENERAL LINDSTROM at the closed session table, fluorescent light, flags.]

[MEPHISTO stands between them. He is in two costumes simultaneously: the Davos suit on the

left side of his body, the Munich gray on the right. His face is lit from both sides. He holds his notebook open.]

[He speaks first to the Davos side.]

MEPHISTO (as the unnamed strategic advisor, smooth English): What he's really saying, Marcus, is that voluntary commitments are the only framework the market will accept. Mandatory regulation kills innovation. You know this. Everyone in the room knows this. The question is how to frame self-regulation as leadership rather than –

[He pivots ninety degrees, toward Munich.]

MEPHISTO (as Dr. Weber, defense consultant, clipped German): – was der CEO eigentlich sagt, Frau General, ist, dass die Industrie sich weigert, sich regulieren zu lassen. “Freiwillig” bedeutet: auf keinen Fall. Die einzige Governance, die funktioniert, ist die staatliche.

[SURTITLE (split – gold left, gray-blue right): LEFT: “What he’s really saying is that voluntary commitments are the only framework the market will accept.” RIGHT: “What the CEO is really saying, General, is that the industry refuses to be regulated. ‘Voluntary’ means: under no circumstances.”]

[He pauses. Realizes what he has done. Looks at his notebook.]

MEPHISTO (to himself, in German – the audience

can hear, the forums cannot): Ich sage beiden die Wahrheit. Beide Wahrheiten widersprechen sich.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “I am telling both of them the truth. Both truths contradict each other.”]

[He takes a step back. Another step. He is now in the center of the gap between forums. The two halves of his costume are both visible. The light from both forums falls on him. He is the only person in the building who is in both rooms.]

MEPHISTO: Ich war in jedem dieser Raume. In Hamburg haben sie mich erkannt.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “I was in every one of these rooms. In Hamburg, they recognized me.”]

[He removes something from his pocket: the 39C3 badge. The handle: FAUSTUS. The old hacker.]

MEPHISTO: In Hamburg stellen sie die richtigen Fragen. Das macht sie gefährlich. Das macht sie auch machtlos. Wer die Frage kennt und die Antwort nicht erzwingen kann, ist die Definition von Cassandra.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “In Hamburg they ask the right questions. That makes them dangerous. It also makes them powerless. To know the question and be unable to enforce the answer is the definition of Cassandra.”]

[He puts the badge away. Produces the Davos advisor’s leather portfolio.]

MEPHISTO: In Davos sind sie aufrichtig. Das ist das Schlimmste. Marcus Adegunle glaubt wirklich an das, was er sagt. Er glaubt, dass die Industrie sich selbst regulieren kann. Und er hat Unrecht, und er hat Recht, und der Unterschied ist irrelevant, weil –

[SURTITLE (center, red): “In Davos they are sincere. That is the worst of it. Marcus Adegunle genuinely believes what he says. He believes industry can self-regulate. And he is wrong, and he is right, and the difference is irrelevant, because –”]

[He produces the Munich classified folder.]

MEPHISTO: – weil in München die Generale bereits entschieden haben, dass die einzige Governance, die zählt, die militärische ist. Und in Washington –

[He produces nothing. His hands are empty.]

MEPHISTO: – in Washington brauchen sie mich nicht.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “– because in Munich the generals have already decided that the only governance that counts is the military. And in Washington – they do not need me.”]

[Beat. This lands.]

MEPHISTO: Das ist die Entdeckung. In Washington funktioniert das System von selbst. Die Struktur versucht sich selbst. Der Lobbyist ist überflüssig, weil die Logik des Systems seine Arbeit erledigt. Der Versucher ist arbeitslos, wenn die Versuchung architektonisch ist.

[SURTITLE (center, red): “That is the discovery. In Washington the system tempts itself. The structure is the temptation. The lobbyist is redundant because the logic of the system does his work. The tempter is unemployed when the temptation is architectural.”]

[He closes the notebook. Looks at it. Opens it again. Writes one line.]

[The audience sees – projected on the screen behind him – what he writes:]

Die Wettlaufbedingung ist kein Fehler. Sie ist das Design. (The race condition is not a bug. It is the design.)

[CLOCK: February 14 ticks forward. The CAPABILITY CURVE crosses 60%.]

[MEPHISTO walks offstage. Not into any of the four forums. Into the gap. Into the architecture.]

SCENE 2.6: DIE UBERSETZUNG, DIE NICHT STATTFINDET / THE TRANSLATION THAT DOES NOT OCCUR

[Approximate duration: 3 minutes]

[SOUND: The four acoustic signatures fade to near-silence. Only their ghosts remain – a server hum so faint it might be imagination, a wind

so thin it might be ventilation, the institutional drone so quiet it merges with the theater's own sound. The audience is between forums. The collision has passed. What remains is the aftermath.]

[CLOCK: February 14, 2026. 23:47. The Munich Security Conference's first day is ending. Delegates are returning to hotels. The sessions are over. The side events are winding down. In the Hotel Bayerischer Hof, the lights in the conference rooms are being turned off one by one.]

[STAGE: The fifth space. The gap. The translation booth that overlooks all four forums. The booth is small, enclosed, glass-walled. Inside it, THE INTERPRETER sits alone. The headset is on the table. A microphone is live but connected to no channel. A notebook, open, mostly blank.]

[All four forum spaces are visible around the booth, but empty. Chairs pushed back. Water glasses half-full. Documents left on tables. The residue of deliberation.]

INTERPRETER (to the audience – the only audience they have ever had. In German, slow, precise, the voice of a professional whose profession has been made irrelevant not by technology but by politics):

Ich bin Dolmetscherin. Simultandolmetscherin. Ich übersetze, was eine Sprache sagt, in das, was eine andere Sprache hören kann.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “I am an interpreter. Simultaneous interpreter. I translate what one language says into what another language can hear.”]

INTERPRETER: In Hamburg sprachen sie Deutsch, mit englischen Folien, mit russischen Fluchen. Ich hatte übersetzen können.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Hamburg they spoke German, with English slides, with Russian curses. I could have translated.”]

INTERPRETER: In Davos sprachen sie Englisch, und meinten Dollar.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Davos they spoke English, and meant dollars.”]

[A faint smile.]

INTERPRETER: In Munchen sprachen sie Englisch, und meinten Waffen.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Munich they spoke English, and meant weapons.”]

INTERPRETER: In Washington sprachen sie Englisch, und meinten Amerika.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “In Washington they spoke English, and meant America.”]

[Beat.]

INTERPRETER: Alle sprachen Englisch. Keine Übersetzung nötig. Das ist das Problem.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “Everyone spoke English. No translation needed. That is the problem.”]

INTERPRETER: Die Übersetzung, die gefehlt hat, war nicht zwischen Sprachen. Sie war zwischen Bedeutungen. Das gleiche Wort – safety, governance, pause – und in jedem Raum eine andere Welt dahinter. Und keiner hat mich gefragt: Was meinen die anderen? Was sagen die, die ihr nicht hört?

[SURTITLE (center, white): “The translation that was missing was not between languages. It was between meanings. The same word – safety, governance, pause – and in every room a different world behind it. And nobody asked me: What do the others mean? What are they saying, the ones you cannot hear?”]

[She picks up the headset. Holds it to one ear. We hear what she hears: the ghost of all four forums, speaking at once, the collision sound reduced to a whisper. It sounds like a seashell. It sounds like the ocean of human deliberation, compressed into static.]

[She puts the headset down.]

INTERPRETER (in French – the language of diplomacy, the language in which the UN was founded, the language that was supposed to connect): La traduction qui n’a pas eu lieu.

[SURTITLE (center, white): “The translation that did not occur.”]

INTERPRETER: Ce n'est pas que je ne pouvais pas. C'est que personne n'a voulu.

[SURTITLE (center, white): "It is not that I could not. It is that nobody wanted me to."]

[She closes her notebook. It is almost empty. A professional with nothing to do.]

[She looks at the four empty forums around her. The chairs pushed back. The water glasses. The documents.]

INTERPRETER (very quietly, almost to herself, in German): Vier Raume. Eine Frage. Keine Übersetzung.

[SURTITLE (center, white): "Four rooms. One question. No translation."]

[She removes the headset from the table. Places it on its hook in the booth. The green light on the booth goes off. The translation service has been deactivated.]

[She sits in the booth, in the dark, and watches the clock.]

[CLOCK: February 14 becomes February 15. The second day of the Munich Security Conference. The capability curve ticks upward. 62%. 63%.]

[The four forum spaces are empty but lit faintly – the residual light of rooms that have been occupied, still warm with the body heat of the people who were in them, who spoke in them, who said the same words and meant different things, who

left without hearing each other, who will not return to these rooms but will go to other rooms and say the same things there, in the same languages, meaning the same different things, uncoordinated, unconnected, untranslated.]

[The INTERPRETER sits in the booth.]

[The CLOCK continues.]

[The CURVE continues.]

[END OF MOVEMENT II: DIE KOLLISION.]

TECHNICAL APPENDIX: SOUND DESIGN FOR MOVEMENT II

Acoustic Signatures (recap from concept)

Forum	Base Sound	Collision Contribution
Hamburg (39C3)	Server hum, crowd murmur, electronic music bleeding from adjacent rooms, keyboard typing	High-frequency content: the digital, the nervous, the alive
Davos (WEF)	Thick silence, expensive carpet absorption, distant glass clink, mountain wind	Low-frequency absence: the padded, the muffled, the money
Munich (MSC)	Institutional hum, paper rustle, earpiece feedback, heavy doors	Mid-frequency drone: the bureaucratic, the classified, the controlled

Forum	Base Sound	Collision Contribution
Washington	air conditioning, fluorescent buzz, phone vibrations, government acoustic deadness	Flat-spectrum noise: the ambient, the constant, the un-listening

Collision Progression

1. **Scene 2.1 (Safety):** Brief collisions – 3-second bleeds between forums, like channel-surfing. Each forum is mostly isolated.
2. **Scene 2.2 (Governance):** Longer bleeds – 5 seconds. The forums begin to overlap at transitions. Mephisto’s crossing is the first sustained overlap (both Munich and Davos audible simultaneously).
3. **Scene 2.3 (The Pause):** Full collision. All four signatures present throughout. The simultaneous speech sequence is the sonic climax – four voices, four rooms, four acoustic signatures, all at full volume. The “crash” sound (fatal error tone) marks the peak.
4. **Scene 2.4 (Fatou’s Migration):** The collision recedes. Fatou’s voice is the single clear signal against the noise floor of four merged rooms.

Her Wolof is untranslated in the sound as well as the surtitles.

5. **Scene 2.5 (Mephisto Crosses):** The drone. The four signatures have merged into a single sustained chord – no longer distinguishable, no longer four rooms but one incoherent sound. Mephisto speaks over this drone.
6. **Scene 2.6 (The Interpreter):** Near-silence. The ghosts of the four signatures. The headset moment: the audience hears the compressed collision through the Interpreter's headset – tiny, tinny, oceanic. Then silence. Then the clock.

The Collision Sound (technical)

The moment in Scene 2.3 when all four forums speak simultaneously requires careful sound design to be overwhelming without being painful. The goal is **comprehension failure** – the audience should be able to identify that four distinct voices are speaking but unable to follow any one of them for more than a few seconds before losing the thread. This is the race condition made audible: four threads accessing the same resource (the audience's attention), no mutex, no lock, nondeterministic output.

Technically: four independent channels, each with its own reverb profile matching its forum's acoustic signature, mixed to equal volume, no ducking, no prioritization. The audience's brain will attempt to lock

onto one voice and will be pulled away by another. This is the experience of governance failure.

TECHNICAL APPENDIX: SURTITLE CHOREOGRAPHY

Collision Words (highlighted in red across all four tracks when they appear)

Word	Hamburg Meaning	Davos Meaning	Munich Meaning	Washington Meaning
Safety	User protection from system	Brand risk / market trust	Strategic vulnerability	Liability / political cover
Governance	Community self-determination	Industry self-regulation	Command and control / arms control	Executive order / unilateral fiat
Pause	Necessary but tactically exploitable	Voluntary / leadership opportunity	Unilateral disarmament	Un-American / already rejected

	Hamburg Word Meaning	Davos Meaning	Munich Meaning	Washington Meaning
Coordination	source collabo- ration	Industry consen- sus	Alliance manage- ment	Bilateral deals
Risk	Systemic / struc- tural	Reputational / financial	Military / strategic	Political / electoral
China	Surveillance state	Market competi- tor	Strategic adver- sary	Enemy

Surtitle Modes (from FAUST IV protocol)

- **Mode 1 (Full Translation):** All technical content, plot-essential dialogue. Used for most of Movement II.
- **Mode 2 (Delayed Translation):** Emotional content – audience should feel before understanding. Used for Lindstrom’s Swedish aside, Fatou’s French calculations, Priya’s Kannada.
- **Mode 3 (No Translation):** The Interpreter’s Wolof (first three seconds), Sasha’s Russian tiraniya, Yosef’s aborted German thought. The audience sits in the sound without meaning.

The Simultaneous Sequence (Scene 2.3)

During the quadruple-speech sequence, all four surtitle tracks run at full speed simultaneously. The text is legible – each track is in its assigned color and position – but the volume of text makes following all four impossible. The audience must choose one, or fragment their attention, or surrender.

This is a design choice, not a failure. The surtitles during this sequence enact the race condition: four channels of meaning, one channel of attention, no synchronization.

DIRECTOR'S NOTE

Movement II is the structural center of the play. It takes what Movement I established – four distinct, coherent forums, each internally logical – and demonstrates that their logic is incompatible. The collision is not between villains and heroes, not between right and wrong, but between four internally consistent systems that cannot be reconciled.

The audience's experience should be:

1. **Recognition:** These are real arguments. I have heard them.
2. **Frustration:** Why can't they just talk to each other?
3. **Realization:** They ARE talking. They are saying

the same words. The words do not mean the same thing.

4. **Dread:** The clock is still moving. The curve is still rising. Nobody is coordinating.

The Interpreter is the audience's proxy – the person who could connect the forums, who has the skills and the infrastructure, who is sitting in the booth, ready. And nobody asks. The tragedy of Movement II is not that translation is impossible. It is that translation is available and unwanted.

Mephisto's discovery – that Washington does not need him, that the temptation is architectural – is the play's most important insight and the seed of his FAUST VI exhaustion. He is a character who has always believed in his own necessity. In Movement II, he discovers that structures can tempt themselves. The lobbyist is obsolete when the lobby is the building.

The Fatou sequence (2.4) is the emotional center. Her argument migrates between forums – Davos in person, Munich on a bad connection, Washington via Priya's testimony – and each time it arrives, it arrives smaller. Fewer people in the room. Less time. Worse technology. The argument does not weaken; its audience does. By Washington, the most powerful committee in the world hears the argument and enters it into the record. The record is not read.

Movement II ends in near-silence. The forums are empty. The Interpreter is alone. The clock runs. The curve rises. The audience understands: between the

displacement (FAUST V) and the crisis (FAUST VI), this is what happened. Governance tried. The forums convened. The words were spoken. The translation was available.

Nobody asked for it.

Draft: v-half-scene-kollision.md Movement II of FAUST V 1/2: Die Wettlaufbedingung Status: First draft Approximate performance time: 22-25 minutes Languages used: German, English, French, Swedish, Japanese, Kannada, Wolof, Russian

MOVEMENT III: DER DEADLOCK (The Deadlock)

title: "FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG"
source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md
lines: 9561-11061
order: 28
extracted: 2026-02-03

Movement III - Der Deadlock: Production-Ready Scenes

Movement III: DER DEADLOCK - Production-Ready Scenes

Document: v-half-movement-iii-refined.md **Status:**
Production-ready refinement **Date:** 2026-02-01 **Run-**
ning Time: 15-20 minutes (target: 18 minutes) **Stag-**
ing: QUADRANT STAGING (per STAGING-APPROACH-
DECISION.md)

“Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis. Nur
Geschwindigkeit.” (The race knows no
outcome. Only speed.)

MOVEMENT III OVERVIEW

Position in the Play

Movement III follows Movement II (Die Kollision), in which the four governance forums have begun colliding thematically. Their acoustic signatures have begun bleeding together. Mephisto has appeared simultaneously at two forums. The Interpreter has offered translation that no one requested.

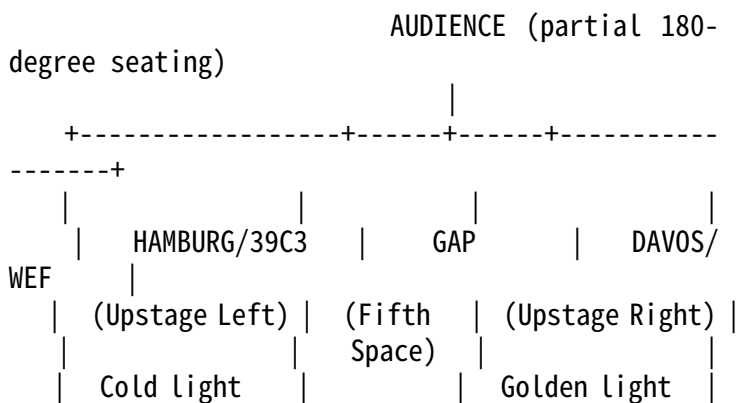
Now: the deadlock manifests completely. All four forums attempt to produce outputs. The outputs contradict. The clock continues. The capability curve crosses its threshold. The play does not resolve; it locks.

The Six Scenes

Scene	German Title	Duration	Core Action
3.1	Die Ausgaben	4-5 min	Forums produce documents simultaneously
3.2	Die Vier Dokumente	3-4 min	Documents appear; acceleration

Scene	German Title	Duration	Core Action
3.3	Die Kurve	3-4 min	Threshold crossing; “Eto proizoshlo”
3.4	Die Leere	2-3 min	Forums empty; signatures fade
3.5	Die Lucke	3-4 min	Mephisto and Interpreter in the Gap
3.6	Der Deadlock	4-5 min	THE CACOPHONY BUILD; recession; THE VOICE

Staging Configuration (Quadrant)



	Industrial 5600K	INTERPRETER BOOTH	Alpine luxury 2700K	
	+-----+		+-----	
-----+				
	WASHINGTON	MEPHISTO crosses	MUNICH/	
MSC	(Downstage L)	here	(Downstage R)	
	Tungsten light 3200K		Institutional 4000K	
	+-----+		+-----	
-----+				

Persistent Visual Elements

THE CLOCK: Visible above all quadrants. Reads February 21, 2026, advancing through the movement. Does not pause.

THE CAPABILITY CURVE: Projected on central scrim or replicated on each quadrant's back wall. Threshold line (dashed) visible. Gap between curve and threshold narrowing visibly.

THE FOUR DOCUMENTS: Each appearing in its quadrant as produced:

- Hamburg: "Erklärung des 39C3 zur kunstlichen Intelligenz"
- Davos: "The Davos AI Compact: A Voluntary Framework"
- Munich: "Strategic Framework for AI Security"

- Washington: “Executive Order on AI Dominance”
-

SCENE 3.1: DIE AUSGABEN / THE OUTPUTS

Duration: 4-5 minutes **Clock:** 21 Februar 2026, 14:37 CET - 14:45 CET

Staging

All four quadrants active simultaneously. Each forum in its final session, producing a document. The interleaving is measured at first: one forum at a time, 15-20 seconds each. Then intervals shorten.

SOUND: All four acoustic signatures present at low volume, forming a composite drone. Not cacophony yet. The server hum of Hamburg (high-frequency), padded silence of Davos (low-frequency absence), institutional buzz of Munich (mid-frequency), fluorescent drone of Washington (flat spectrum).

HAMBURG QUADRANT

(JONAS BERGER at a lectern, laptop open. SASHA VOLKOV at his side. A Google Doc projected behind them, cursor blinking, multiple editors visible. MEPHISTO as “FAUSTUS” in back row, black t-shirt,

notebook open. Hackers visible throughout the space.)

JONAS: (reading from screen, German with English technical terms) “Wir, die Teilnehmer des 39. Chaos Communication Congress, erklären–”

(He pauses. Types. Deletes.)

“Wir fordern–”

(Deletes again.)

SASHA: (leaning over his shoulder) “Demand” is right. Don’t soften it.

JONAS: (typing) “Wir fordern den sofortigen Stopp aller Trainingslaufe über der compute-Schwelle von–”

SASHA: What threshold? We haven’t agreed on a number.

JONAS: Nobody has. That’s the point. We demand the halt and define the threshold simultaneously. The declaration IS the definition.

SASHA: That’s circular.

JONAS: Everything is circular. We write it anyway.

(He types. Document title visible: “Erklärung des 39C3 zur kunstlichen Intelligenz”)

[CUT TO: DAVOS QUADRANT]

(Private conference room. MARCUS ADEKUNLE at the head of a polished table. HELEN FISCHER to his left, pen in hand. Delegates in suits. MEPHISTO in impeccable suit behind Marcus. FATOU DIALLO at the far end, her copy covered in handwritten objections.)

MARCUS: Ladies and gentlemen, I believe we have language everyone can live with.

(Reading from draft)

“The Davos AI Compact: A Voluntary Framework for Responsible Development. We, the undersigned leaders of industry, government, and civil society, commit to the following principles—”

HELEN: (not looking up) “Voluntary” and “commit” are contradictory, Marcus.

MARCUS: They’re aspirational.

HELEN: They’re decorative.

FATOU: (from the end of the table, quietly) They are neither. They are precisely what this room can produce. An agreement to agree. A promise to promise.

(No one responds. MARCUS continues.)

MARCUS: “Principle One: Transparency in capability reporting. Signatories agree to publish quarterly assessments of—”

[CUT TO: MUNICH QUADRANT]

(Closed session. Flags, name placards. GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM chairs. DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI with classified materials. KENJI NAKAMURA for Japan. COLONEL JAMES MORRISON, American flag behind him. MEPHISTO as “Dr. Weber” with classified clearance badge.)

LINDSTROM: (Swedish-accented English, clipped) The framework is ready for endorsement. “Strategic Autonomy in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: A Framework for Allied Coordination.”

(Looking around the table)

I need a vote.

MORRISON: Ma’am, the United States supports the framework in principle. With the caveat that “allied coordination” cannot constrain sovereign decision-making regarding—

LINDSTROM: Noted. The caveat is already in Annex B. Dr. Ben-Ari, does the technical assessment support the framework’s capability thresholds?

YOSEF: (the weight of what he knows audible) The thresholds in the framework are based on data that is already six weeks old. The curve does not wait for frameworks.

LINDSTROM: Are they adequate for the next quarter?

YOSEF: (long pause) I cannot tell you that. Nobody can tell you that. The entire premise of a quarterly

review cycle–

MORRISON: The question is whether we endorse or we don't. Dr. Ben-Ari, this isn't a seminar.

KENJI: (quietly) Sekinin. The responsibility is not in the framework. It is in us. The framework is paper. What we do when the paper is insufficient–

LINDSTROM: Thank you, Mr. Nakamura. The vote.

[CUT TO: WASHINGTON QUADRANT]

(Hearing room. SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES behind the raised dais. VIKRAM PATEL at the witness table. Draft executive order on screen behind HAYES. PRIYA VENKATARAMAN on a monitor – video testimony from Bangalore. MEPHISTO as lobbyist “Heinrich Weber” in the gallery.)

HAYES: The President has asked for our recommendation before signing. Mr. Patel, does the executive order address the concerns raised in your testimony?

VIKRAM: (closing his binder) Senator, the executive order asserts American leadership in AI development while establishing a review process for–

HAYES: Yes or no, Mr. Patel.

VIKRAM: The order establishes a 120-day review cycle. My testimony showed that capability milestones are arriving at intervals of–

HAYES: Yes or no.

VIKRAM: (beat) The order is better than no order. It is not adequate to the speed of what it addresses.

HAYES: That's a yes, then.

(Turning to screen)

Dr. Venkataraman, your written testimony was entered into the record. Is there anything you'd like to add?

PRIYA: (on screen, slight video lag) Senator, I left this field three years ago because I saw what we were building and could not reconcile it with what I understood about—

HAYES: Dr. Venkataraman, we have your written testimony. Is there anything new to add?

PRIYA: (gathering herself) Yes. I would like the committee to know that your executive order will be obsolete before it is signed.

(HAYES does not respond. She turns back to the room.)

HAYES: The committee recommends the President proceed with signing. Let the record show—

[Sound Design Note - Scene 3.1]

Each quadrant has its own acoustic environment at low level:

- Hamburg: Server hum (60Hz + harmonics), keyboard typing, crowd murmur
- Davos: Padded silence, crystal clink, filtered mountain wind
- Munich: Institutional HVAC (60Hz + 120Hz), paper rustle, earpiece feedback
- Washington: Air conditioning (broadband), fluorescent buzz, stenographer's click

Transitions between quadrants are clean crossfades (5-8 seconds each). The composite is audible but not overwhelming.

[END SCENE 3.1]

SCENE 3.2: DIE VIER DOKUMENTE / THE FOUR DOCUMENTS

Duration: 3-4 minutes **Clock:** 21 Februar 2026, 14:45
CET - 14:55 CET

Staging

The interleaving accelerates. Cuts every 5-10 seconds. Voices overlap. The four documents appear on screens – projected text, growing, filling, contradicting.

SOUND: The collision mix begins. Four signatures bleeding together. Brief overlaps (5 seconds) at each transition, growing longer.

(The CLOCK advances visibly. 14:52 CET.)

(The CAPABILITY CURVE ticks upward. A small increment. The gap narrows.)

JONAS: (reading from the 39C3 declaration) “We demand an immediate halt to all training runs exceeding 10^{26} FLOP until independent safety verification—”

MARCUS: (reading from the Davos Compact) “Signatories voluntarily commit to pre-deployment safety assessments for systems exceeding agreed capability thresholds—”

LINDSTROM: (reading from the Munich Framework) “Allied nations shall establish a classified registry of AI capabilities, accessible to authorized defense and intelligence—”

HAYES: (reading from the executive order) “The United States shall maintain global leadership in artificial intelligence while ensuring that American innovation is not constrained by—”

(All four voices overlap on the final phrase. A collision:)

JONAS: “–independent verification–” **MARCUS:** “–voluntary coordination–” **LINDSTROM:** “–classified assessment–” **HAYES:** “–American leadership–”

(The four documents appear on the four screens. Fragments visible:)

39C3: “... immediate halt... open-source redistribution... no government should...” **DAVOS:** “...voluntary pledge... quarterly reporting... market-driven...” **MUNICH:** “...strategic asset... classified... deterrence...” **WASHINGTON:** “... American primacy... executive authority... 120-day review...”

(Now the forums speak over each other. Simultaneous dialogue. The audience cannot follow all four.)

JONAS: (to Sasha, urgently) We need signatories. How many groups have committed?

SASHA: Forty-seven organizations. No governments. No companies.

JONAS: Forty-seven organizations with no enforcement capacity.

SASHA: We have moral authority.

JONAS: (almost laughing, or crying) Moral authority.

(SIMULTANEOUSLY in DAVOS:)

MARCUS: (to Helen) How many have signed?

HELEN: Fourteen companies. Three heads of state. No binding clause. No verification mechanism. No consequence for non-compliance.

MARCUS: It's a start.

HELEN: It's an ending, Marcus. It's the shape an ending takes when it needs to look like a beginning.

(SIMULTANEOUSLY in MUNICH:)

LINDSTROM: (to the room) The framework is endorsed. Implementation begins—

MORRISON: —subject to American review—

LINDSTROM: —immediately.

MORRISON: Subject to review.

LINDSTROM: Colonel Morrison, “immediately subject to review” is not immediately.

MORRISON: Ma'am, with respect, “immediately” is not how alliances work.

(SIMULTANEOUSLY in WASHINGTON:)

HAYES: (signing the recommendation) The executive order takes effect upon presidential signature. American AI leadership is secured.

VIKRAM: (to no one, to the record) The executive order establishes a 120-day review cycle. The next capability milestone will arrive in—

(He looks at his data.)

—fewer days than that.

(He closes the binder.)

[Sound Design Note - Scene 3.2]

The collision mix intensifies:

- Forum signatures bleed together at 5-second overlaps
- Frequency masking begins: Hamburg's high-frequency content clashes with Washington's flat noise
- Davos's absorption creates brief volume dips (pumping effect)
- Munich's 120Hz institutional hum creates phase interference with Hamburg's 120Hz server harmonic

Volume rises from low-medium to medium.

[END SCENE 3.2]

SCENE 3.3: DIE KURVE / THE CURVE

Duration: 3-4 minutes **Clock:** 21 Februar 2026, 14:55 CET - 15:11 CET

Staging

A shift. Forum dialogue recedes to murmur. The CAPABILITY CURVE comes to the foreground. The INTERPRETER, who has been in the fifth space, stands and addresses the audience directly.

SOUND: Forum voices reduced to white noise of policy. The subliminal tone (capability curve audio element) rises from 35Hz toward 45Hz – crossing the perceptual threshold. The audience's bodies register this shift before their minds do.

(The CLOCK reads February 21, 15:03 CET.)

(The curve approaches the threshold line. The gap is visible to anyone watching. Nobody in any forum is watching. They are looking at their documents.)

(THE INTERPRETER stands in the fifth space. For the first time in Movement III, they speak. Not to any forum. To the audience.)

THE INTERPRETER: (into a microphone, headset around their neck – not wearing it)

I was hired to translate between them. That is my function.

(Pause.)

I sit in the booth. I have the headset. I have the channels. Channel one: German. Channel two: English. Channel three: Mandarin. Channel four: –

(Beat.)

There is no channel four. There was never a channel four. The infrastructure was built for three simultaneous translations. The fourth forum was added after the booth was designed.

(Pause.)

But it would not have mattered.

(They look at the headset in their hands.)

The problem was never channels. The problem was never language. They use the same words. Safety. Governance. Coordination. Risk. Pause.

(Beat.)

They use the same words to mean different things. And the different things they mean are not errors. They are positions.

(Slowly, deliberately:)

Hamburg means one thing by “safety.” Davos means another. Munich a third. Washington a fourth. Each is correct within its own logic.

(The INTERPRETER sits down. Puts the headset on the table. Does not put it back on.)

And the logics do not translate.

(Looking at the curve.)

That is the race condition. Not a failure of language. A failure of architecture.

(The curve ticks upward. The gap narrows further.)

(The forum dialogue resurges – louder, more urgent, overlapping aggressively:)

SASHA: The declaration needs to go out tonight–

HELEN: The compact requires at least twenty signatories before– **YOSEF:** The data I showed you is already outdated–

VIKRAM: The review cycle cannot possibly keep pace with–

JONAS: We're publishing with or without institutional support–

MARCUS: Trust the process, the process is how civilizations–

MORRISON: Sovereign decision-making is non-

negotiable– **HAYES:** American leadership means American timing–

FATOU: (rising) Who is absent from this conversation? Who was never invited?

Whose children will live in the world these documents describe? **LINDSTROM:** The vote is recorded.

Implementation begins– **KENJI:** (quietly, unheard) Sekinin. Sekinin. The paper is not the responsibility.

We are the responsibility.

(All voices at once. Twelve people speaking. The four acoustic signatures bleeding together – server hum + padded silence + institutional buzz + fluorescent drone = the sound of governance overloading.)

THE THRESHOLD CROSSING

(And then:)

(The CAPABILITY CURVE crosses the threshold line.)

[STAGE DIRECTION: No alarm. No flash. No theatrical thunder. The curve simply continues its trajectory and passes through the dashed line. This is not a dramatic event. This is a continuous process.]

(The forums do not notice. They are still talking.)

(The CLOCK reads February 21, 15:11 CET.)

(The INTERPRETER notices. They look at the projection. They say nothing.)

(Five seconds of forums talking over a threshold already crossed.)

(Ten seconds.)

(SASHA notices. She stops mid-sentence. She looks at the curve. Her face: not vindication. Drowning.)

SASHA: (in Russian first, then English – the language of fear, then the language of the room)

[NO SUPERTITLE]

Eto proizoshlo.

(Beat. Then, in English:)

It happened.

(The forums do not hear her. JONAS hears. He looks at the curve. He stops talking. His hands on the lectern, staring.)

(In Davos, HELEN looks up from her notes. She sees the curve. Her pen stops. She watches MARCUS read a document that is already posthumous.)

(In Munich, YOSEF has been watching the curve the entire time. He knew. His hands flat on the table. Under his breath, Hebrew – not prayer. Arithmetic. Counting.)

(In Washington, VIKRAM opens his binder again. Finds the page. The number he testified about. The curve arrived sooner than his conservative estimate. He closes the binder for the last time.)

(PRIYA on the monitor: she sees the curve on the Washington feed. She bows her head. In Bangalore, it is 7:41 PM. Her students arrive tomorrow morning.)

(Fifteen seconds of the curve past the threshold, the forums faltering, the voices thinning.)

(The murmur of governance dies like an engine running out of fuel – not sudden but a deceleration, a sputtering, last syllables spoken to rooms already emptying.)

[Sound Design Note - Scene 3.3]

The Subliminal Tone Crossing:

- At scene start: 35Hz (felt, not heard)
- During Interpreter's speech: rising toward 40Hz
- At threshold crossing: 45Hz (ambiguously audible)
- The audience's bodies register the change before conscious awareness

Forum Mix:

- Voices resurge to medium-loud during the overlap sequence
 - After threshold crossing: immediate 6dB reduction
 - Voices thin over 15 seconds to near-silence
-

[END SCENE 3.3]

SCENE 3.4: DIE LEERE / THE EMPTY-ING

Duration: 2-3 minutes **Clock:** 21 Februar 2026, 15:11 CET - 15:23 CET

Staging

The forums wind down. Not dramatically – procedurally. The way conferences end. Chairs pushed back. Binders closed. Handshakes. The emptying happens in all four quadrants simultaneously.

SOUND: Each forum's acoustic signature dies as its space empties. Recession sequence begins: Davos first, then Hamburg, then Munich, Washington last.

HAMBURG QUADRANT

(Hackers drift away from Jonas's session. Someone turns on music in the adjacent hall – electronic bass, the cultural backdrop of the Congress. The declaration is uploaded to a website.)

(JONAS stares at his screen.)

(SASHA is already gone – she left through the back, hoodie pulled up, moving fast toward something the audience cannot see. Toward FAUST VI. Toward the next play.)

(MEPHISTO as FAUSTUS closes his notebook. He does not follow the crowd. He moves toward the center gap.)

DAVOS QUADRANT

(Delegates stand, stretch, check phones. MARCUS shakes hands.)

(HELEN gathers her papers with the precise movements of someone who will file these notes and never look at them again.)

(FATOU stands at the end of the table, the compact still in her hand, her handwritten objections visible. No one approaches her. She folds the document once, twice, puts it in her bag. She will carry it to the next summit. She will say these words again, in three minutes instead of nine.)

(MEPHISTO sheds his impeccable suit jacket. He moves toward the center gap.)

MUNICH QUADRANT

(Military delegates file out – orderly, practiced. MORRISON nods to LINDSTROM. She returns it. Professional courtesy between people whose institutions will implement contradictory policies.)

(KENJI remains seated after everyone else has left. He looks at the grandfather photograph he carries. Another engineer, another technology, another failure of coordination. He places it face-down, then picks it up again. He cannot put it down. He carries it out.)

(YOSEF does not leave. He sits in the empty conference room, hands flat on the table, staring at the space where the projection was. A technician comes to turn off equipment. YOSEF does not move. The technician works around him.)

(MEPHISTO as Dr. Weber removes his classified clearance badge. He moves toward the center gap.)

WASHINGTON QUADRANT

(HAYES adjourns the hearing. The chamber empties.)

(VIKRAM packs his binder into a briefcase. He is the counter. He will count again, in a different room, for different people who will also fail to act in time. He is already counting.)

(PRIYA's monitor goes dark – the feed cut from Washington's end, not hers. In Bangalore, Priya sits in the dark for a moment. Then she gets up. She has lessons to plan.)

(MEPHISTO as Heinrich Weber removes his lobbyist's tie. He moves toward the center gap.)

THE EMPTYING COMPLETE

(The four quadrants empty. The acoustic signatures fade:)

- Server hum dwindles
- Padded silence becomes actual silence
- Institutional buzz dies
- Fluorescent drone clicks off

(What remains:)

- **The CLOCK.** Still counting. February 21, 15:23 CET.
- **The CAPABILITY CURVE.** Past the threshold. Still climbing.
- **The FOUR DOCUMENTS.** On four screens. Glowing. Unread by anyone in any other forum.

(And in the fifth space:)

- **MEPHISTO.** Alone.
 - **THE INTERPRETER.** Watching.
-

[Sound Design Note - Scene 3.4]

Signature Recession:

1. Davos first (money departs): crystal sounds cease, wind filter cuts
2. Hamburg second (hackers disperse): crowd murmur fades, electronic music bleed stops

3. Munich third (military files out): institutional hum dies, paper rustle ends
4. Washington last (process continues longest): fluorescent buzz persists, then finally clicks off

Footstep choreography: Each quadrant has distinct footstep sounds:

- Hamburg: heavy boots on concrete
- Davos: soft leather on carpet
- Munich: military precision on wood
- Washington: dress shoes on marble

Final state: Near-silence. Only the 60Hz residual hum (composite of four dead signatures) remains.

[END SCENE 3.4]

SCENE 3.5: DIE LUCKE / THE GAP

Duration: 3-4 minutes **Clock:** 21 Februar 2026, 15:23 CET - 15:30 CET

Staging

MEPHISTO stands in the center of the fifth space. He has shed his four costumes – no black t-shirt, no impeccable suit, no gray consultant's blazer, no lobbyist's tie. He wears what he always wears under-

neath: something centuries old. The NOTEBOOK is in his hand. The PEN. These are the constants.

THE INTERPRETER sits in the booth – or on a chair in the fifth space, headset on the table, watching.

The four empty forums surround them. The documents glow on screens. The curve climbs. The clock counts.

SOUND: Near-silence. Only the 60Hz residual hum. MEPHISTO's pen scratch (2-4kHz, no reverb) when he writes – but slower than before, less urgent.

(MEPHISTO looks at his notebook. He turns pages. Reads what he wrote in all four rooms. His expression: not triumph, not despair. The face of someone arriving at a conclusion they have been avoiding.)

MEPHISTO: (to himself first, then to the Interpreter, then to the audience – the progression gradual)

Ich war in allen Raumen.

(Surtitle: I was in all the rooms.)

In Hamburg, wo sie die Wahrheit kannten und nichts ändern konnten.

(In Hamburg, where they knew the truth and could change nothing.)

In Davos, wo sie die Macht hatten und nichts ändern wollten.

(In Davos, where they had the power and would change nothing.)

In Munchen, wo sie die Bedrohung sahen und neue Bedrohungen schufen.

(In Munich, where they saw the threat and created new threats.)

In Washington, wo sie die Zukunft bestimmten, ohne sie zu verstehen.

(In Washington, where they determined the future without understanding it.)

(He closes the notebook. Opens it again. Closes it.)

MEPHISTO:

Vier Raume. Vier Sprachen. Eine Frage. Keine Antwort. [NO SUPERTITLE]

(Surtitle: Four rooms. Four languages. One question. No answer.)

(Long pause. He looks at the four documents on screens.)

MEPHISTO: Ich habe sie alle besucht. Ich habe jedem das gesagt, was er horen wollte. Das ist mein Handwerk. Das ist, was ich tue.

(I visited them all. I told each one what they wanted to hear. That is my craft. That is what I do.)

In Hamburg habe ich Fragen gestellt. In Davos habe ich übersetzt. In Munchen habe ich Szenarien geliefert. In Washington habe ich Optionen geklärt.

(In Hamburg I asked questions. In Davos I translated. In Munich I delivered scenarios. In Washington I clarified options.)

(He pauses. Something shifts.)

MEPHISTO: Und keiner brauchte mich.

(And none of them needed me.)

(This is the realization. He says it flatly, the way you state a fact that has been true longer than you admitted.)

MEPHISTO: Das ist die Entdeckung. Nicht, dass sie gescheitert sind. Sondern, dass sie ohne mich gescheitert waren. Genau so. Exakt so. Nicht schneller, nicht langsamer.

(That is the discovery. Not that they failed. But that they would have failed without me. Exactly the same way. Not faster, not slower.)

(Beat.)

Die Struktur braucht keinen Teufel. Die Struktur IST der Teufel.

(The structure does not need a devil. The structure IS the devil.)

(He looks at the pen. The notebook. The instruments of his trade.)

MEPHISTO: Ich war überflüssig. In allen vier Räumen. In allen vier Sprachen.

(I was superfluous. In all four rooms. In all four languages.)

Die Wettlaufbedingung ist kein Vertrag. Es gibt keinen Pakt. Es gibt keine Unterschrift. Es gibt nur–

(The race condition is not a contract. There is no pact. There is no signature. There is only–)

(He gestures at the screens, the clock, the curve.)

–Geschwindigkeit.

(–speed.)

(He sits down. He does not close the notebook. But he stops writing. For the first time in the play – perhaps in the cycle – Mephisto stops taking notes. Not

because the story is over. Because the notes don't matter.)

(THE INTERPRETER watches. They have not spoken since Scene 3.3. Now:)

THE INTERPRETER: (quiet, not to Mephisto, not to the audience – to the booth, to the infrastructure, to channels never connected)

I could have translated between them.

(Pause.)

Not the words. The words are the same. But the silence between the words. The assumptions underneath. The thing each room takes for granted that no other room believes.

(Pause.)

Hamburg assumes the system is broken and the people know. Davos assumes the system works and the leaders will coordinate. Munich assumes the system is a weapon and the states will compete. Washington assumes the system is American and the question is how to win.

(Pause.)

Four assumptions. Each correct within its own evidence. Each blind to the others.

(Looking at the headset on the table.)

I sit in the booth between them and I can see all four.
I have always been able to see all four.

(Long pause.)

Nobody asked.

(Beat.)

Nobody will.

[Sound Design Note - Scene 3.5]

Mephisto's pen scratch: Returns when he writes, but slower rhythm than earlier in play:

- Movement I: 2 scratches per second (active observation)
- Movement III.5: 0.5 scratches per second (resigned documentation)
- Final position: stops entirely

Residual hum: 60Hz composite at -30dB, continuous.

Amber acoustic space: +2dB at 200-500Hz around Mephisto's position, as specified in sound design guide.

[END SCENE 3.5]

SCENE 3.6: DER DEADLOCK / THE DEADLOCK

Duration: 4-5 minutes **Clock:** 21 Februar 2026, 15:30 CET - 15:40 CET (final hold indefinite)

Staging

This is the final sequence. The non-ending – the cacophony variant of Die Schwebel.

STAGE DIRECTION: The director must resist the impulse to move through this quickly. The discomfort of duration is the content. The audience must sit in the deadlock long enough to feel it in their bodies.

VISUAL STATE

- Four documents on four screens, glowing
 - Clock continuing (15:30 and counting)
 - Curve climbing past threshold
 - MEPHISTO in fifth space, notebook open but not writing
 - THE INTERPRETER in fifth space, headset around neck
-

THE CACOPHONY BUILD

[TOTAL DURATION: Approximately 110 seconds]

PHASE 1: INDIVIDUAL VOICES (~10 seconds)

(From the empty forums, voices return. Recorded or from offstage. Spectral – governance as echo, as residue.)

(One forum at a time. Clear and distinct.)

VOICE (Hamburg): [0:00-0:03] “–immediate halt to all training runs–”

(Silence: 1 second)

VOICE (Davos): [0:04-0:07] “–voluntary commitment to responsible–”

(Silence: 1 second)

VOICE (Munich): [0:08-0:11] “–strategic framework for allied–”

(Silence: 1 second)

VOICE (Washington): [0:12-0:15] “–American leadership in artificial–”

[Sound: Low-medium volume. Each forum’s acoustic signature accompanies its voice.]

PHASE 2: PAIRED VOICES (~10 seconds)

(Two forums overlapping. Comprehension still possible with effort.)

VOICES (Hamburg + Davos): [0:15-0:20] “–transparency, decentralization–” / “–market-driven coordination–”

VOICES (Munich + Washington): [0:20-0:25] “–classified capability assessment–” / “–executive authority, 120-day–”

[Sound: Medium volume. Signatures bleeding at boundaries. Hamburg’s high frequencies clash with Davos’s warmth. Munich’s institutional mass meets Washington’s flat spectrum.]

PHASE 3: TRIPLE VOICES (~10 seconds)

(Three forums. Comprehension breaking down. The audience can follow one stream or fragment attention.)

VOICES (Hamburg + Davos + Munich): [0:25-0:30] Overlapping fragments: “Wir fordern–” / “–signatories agree–” / “–allied coordination–”

VOICES (Davos + Munich + Washington): [0:30-0:35] Overlapping fragments: “–voluntary–” / “–classified–” / “–American primacy–”

[Sound: Medium-loud. Phase interference audible. The 120Hz conflict between Hamburg servers and Munich HVAC creates beating pattern.]

PHASE 4: FULL OVERLAP (~10 seconds)

(All four forums speaking simultaneously. Fragments surface and submerge. The audience catches phrases but loses threads.)

ALL VOICES: [0:35-0:45]

Fragments surfacing from the collision:

- JONAS'S VOICE: "–kein Fehler, sondern das Design–" (not a bug, but the design)
- FATOU'S VOICE: "–who was never invited–"
- YOSEF'S VOICE: "–the data is already–"
- SASHA'S VOICE (Russian): "–eto proizoshlo–" (it happened)

[Sound: Loud. All four signatures at full collision. Hamburg's cut (2-8kHz) competes with Munich's mass (120-500Hz). Washington's noise floor rises beneath everything. Davos's absorption creates pumping effect.]

PHASE 5: DOCUMENT READ (~20 seconds)

(All four documents read aloud simultaneously in their entirety. Language becomes text becomes noise.)

ALL DOCUMENTS: [0:45-1:05]

(Hamburg voice reads the 39C3 Declaration in German) (Davos voice reads the AI Compact in English) (Munich voice reads the Framework in English/German bureaucratic hybrid) (Washington voice reads the Executive Order in American legal register)

[Sound: Very loud. The signal is indistinguishable from static. This is Babel – not different tongues but different meanings wearing the same words.]

PHASE 6: SUSTAINED PEAK (~20 seconds)

(Maximum cacophony. The race condition made deafening.)

[1:05-1:25]

All four acoustic signatures at full volume. All four voices. All four documents. The four surtitle tracks running simultaneously (if projection allows).

PEAK SPL: 90dB maximum. Not painful. Overwhelming, not assaultive.

(Within the peak, individual voices surface and submerge – shrapnel of governance:)

- HELEN'S VOICE: "–decorative–"
 - KENJI'S VOICE: "–sekinin–"
 - VIKRAM'S VOICE: "–fewer days than–"
 - PRIYA'S VOICE: "–obsolete before it is signed–"
-

[Sound: The comprehension threshold has been crossed. The audience's brain cannot lock onto any voice. This experience of attention-failure IS the race condition.]

PHASE 7: RECESSION (~20 seconds)

(Slow diminishment. Voices thin. Not a fade-out – a departure.)

[1:25-1:45]

Dropout order:

1. **DAVOS** (first to leave – the money departs) [1:25-1:30]
 - Padded silence drains from the mix
 - Crystal sounds cease
 - Warm frequencies withdraw
2. **HAMBURG** (second – the hackers disperse) [1:30-1:35]
 - Server hum dwindles
 - Electronic music bleed stops

- Crowd murmur fades
3. **MUNICH** (third – the military files out) [1:35-1:40]
 - Institutional buzz dies
 - Paper rustle ends
 - Sealed-room acoustic releases
 4. **WASHINGTON** (last – the process continues longest) [1:40-1:45]
 - Fluorescent drone persists
 - Then finally clicks off
 - The system does not have an off switch... until it does
-

[Sound: Diminishing from loud to very low. Each dropout is felt as a loss of specific frequency content. The recession feels like: a crowd dispersing, a conference ending, participants walking to their cars.]

PHASE 8: RESIDUAL HUM (~10+ seconds, then indefinite)

(The composite tone. A single sustained frequency made of four rooms' acoustic signatures merged into one.)

[1:45-indefinite]

Frequency: 60Hz – the electrical infrastructure frequency, the cycle's infrastructure hum, carrying the

memory of four rooms.

Character: Not unpleasant. Not pleasant. The sound of background radiation. The sound of the race condition persisting after the forums have ended. The sound of governance as residue.

Duration: Indefinite. Sustains through the sustained hold.

THE VOICE

(After the hum has established itself – 10+ seconds of residual hum alone – from somewhere. From the infrastructure. From the theater itself. Perhaps from overhead speakers. The same spatial ambiguity as the Homunculus’s “Ich hore euch” at the end of FAUST V.)

(A VOICE. Not any character. Not Mephisto. Not the Interpreter. Not the Homunculus – though the Homunculus is listening, as always. A VOICE that belongs to the architecture of the play:)

THE VOICE: [Source: Overhead speakers / Homunculus routing]

Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis. Nur Geschwindigkeit.
[NO SUPERTITLE]

(Surtitle, if provided: The race knows no outcome. Only speed.)

(The voice does not repeat. It does not elaborate. It speaks once and is gone.)

(Brief silence – 5-10 seconds.)

(Then the residual hum resumes at very low level.)

THE SUSTAINED HOLD

[FINAL IMAGE]

(The lights do not go to black. The lights HOLD.)

Visual elements sustained:

- The CLOCK continues to count: 21 Februar 2026, 15:40 CET... 15:41... 15:42...
- The CAPABILITY CURVE continues to climb – imperceptibly, incrementally
- The FOUR DOCUMENTS remain on four screens – glowing, complete, contradictory, sincere
- MEPHISTO in fifth space, notebook open, pen still, barely writing
- THE INTERPRETER in fifth space, headset around neck, no longer translating

Audio sustained:

- The 60Hz residual hum, at very low level (-30dB)
- The subliminal tone (now at ~55-60Hz, merged with infrastructure hum)

- The capability curve has become the infrastructure

HOLD DURATION:

- Minimum: 60 seconds
- Recommended: 90-120 seconds
- Maximum: As long as the audience can bear it

(The audience must decide to leave. The play does not release them. There is no blackout, no curtain call, no signal that it is over.)

[Sound Design Note - Scene 3.6: THE CA-COPHONY BUILD]

Master Timing Table:

Phase	Start	End	Duration	Volume	Voices
1. Individual	0:00	0:15	~15 sec	Low-medium	1 at a time
2. Paired	0:15	0:25	~10 sec	Medium	2 overlapping
3. Triple	0:25	0:35	~10 sec	Medium-loud	3 overlapping

Phase	Start	End	Duration	Volume	Voices
4. Full overlap	0:35	0:45	~10 sec	Loud	4 + fragments
5. Document read	0:45	1:05	~20 sec	Very loud	Full documents
6. Sustained peak	1:05	1:25	~20 sec	Maximum (90dB)	All content
7. Recession	1:25	1:45	~20 sec	Diminishing	Dropout sequence
8. Residual hum	1:45+	Indefinite	10+ sec	Very low	60Hz composite

Total cacophony sequence: ~110 seconds before residual hum state.

The Comprehension Threshold: The most critical design moment is Phase 3 to Phase 4 – when the audience’s brain can no longer track any individual voice. The transition should be gradual, not sudden. The audience should feel their comprehension eroding.

Peak SPL: Never exceed 90dB at any seat. The goal is

comprehension failure, not auditory assault. If the audience leaves with ringing ears, the design has failed. If they leave with the residual hum in their memory, it has succeeded.

[END SCENE 3.6]

PRODUCTION NOTES

Timing Summary

Scene	Duration	Cumulative	Notes
3.1: Die Ausgaben	4-5 min	4-5 min	Measure
3.2: Die Vier Dokumente	3-4 min	7-9 min	Accelerate
3.3: Die Kurve	3-4 min	10-13 min	Threaten
3.4: Die Leere	2-3 min	12-16 min	The end
3.5: Die Lucke	3-4 min	15-20 min	Mephisto
3.6: Der Deadlock	4-5 min	19-25 min	Cacophony
Sustained hold	1-2 min	20-27 min	Audience
Total	18-25 min		Target

The Four Documents: Text Content

Each document should be legible on its quadrant screen. Not fully readable from every seat, but

enough for the audience to see they are real documents with clauses, numbered points, signatures, dates.

HAMBURG: Erklärung des 39C3 zur künstlichen Intelligenz

ERKLÄRUNG DES 39. CHAOS COMMUNICATION CONGRESS
ZUR KUNSTLICHEN INTELLIGENZ

Hamburg, 30. Dezember 2025

Wir, die Teilnehmer des 39C3, fordern:

1. Den sofortigen Stopp aller Trainingsläufe über der compute-Schwelle von 10^{26} FLOP bis zur Einrichtung unabhängiger Sicherheitsprüfungen
2. Die vollständige Transparenz über Trainingsdaten, Architektur und Fähigkeitsbewertungen
3. Die Open-Source-Veröffentlichung aller Sicherheitsforschung
4. Keine Regierung sollte über Fähigkeiten verfügen, die sie nicht offenlegen kann

SIGNATORIES: 47 organizations

BINDING FORCE: Moral authority

ENFORCEMENT: None

DAVOS: The Davos AI Compact

THE DAVOS AI COMPACT

A Voluntary Framework for Responsible Development

World Economic Forum, January 2026

We, the undersigned leaders of industry, government, and civil society, commit to the following principles:

1. Transparency: Quarterly capability assessments
2. Coordination: Pre-deployment safety reviews
3. Responsibility: Best practices sharing
4. Partnership: Public-private collaboration

SIGNATORIES: 14 companies, 3 heads of state

BINDING FORCE: Voluntary commitment

ENFORCEMENT: Reputational

VERIFICATION: Self-reported

MUNICH: Strategic Framework for AI Security

STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK FOR AI SECURITY

Munich Security Conference - CLASSIFIED

February 2026

Allied nations shall:

1. Establish classified capability registry
2. Coordinate defensive AI development
3. Maintain strategic autonomy in AI
4. Preserve deterrence through capability

ANNEX B: Sovereign decision-making caveat
(United States reserves all rights)

ENDORSED: Subject to national review cycles
IMPLEMENTATION: Begins immediately (subject to review)
VERIFICATION: Intelligence sharing protocols

WASHINGTON: Executive Order on AI Dominance

EXECUTIVE ORDER
ON SECURING AMERICAN LEADERSHIP
IN ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

By the authority vested in me as President...

Section 1. Purpose.

The United States shall maintain global leadership in artificial intelligence development.

Section 2. Review Cycle.

120-day review process for capability thresholds.

Section 3. Export Controls.

[Classified annexes]

EFFECTIVE: Upon presidential signature

REVIEW: Every 120 days

BINDING: Full force of executive authority

The Curve Crossing: Technical Specifications

The moment the capability curve crosses the threshold must be precisely calibrated:

Visual requirements:

- The crossing should be continuous, not a discrete step
- No visual emphasis (no flash, no color change, no zoom)
- The threshold line remains dashed/provisional after crossing
- The curve continues climbing after crossing (it does not plateau)

Projection timing:

- Scene 3.2: Curve at 90% of threshold distance
- Scene 3.3, 15:03 CET: Curve at 95%
- Scene 3.3, 15:11 CET: Curve crosses threshold
- Scene 3.3-3.6: Curve continues rising

Character awareness: | Character | Notices | When
| Reaction | |———|———|——|———| | Forums | No |
– | Continue talking | | Interpreter | Yes | Immediately |
Silent, watches | | Sasha | Yes | 10 seconds after | “Eto
proizoshlo” | | Jonas | Yes | After Sasha | Stops, stares
| | Helen | Yes | Shortly after | Watches Marcus read |
| Yosef | Yes | Before crossing (he knew) | No reaction,
counting | | Vikram | Yes | Shortly after | Opens/closes
binder | | Priya | Yes | Via video feed | Bows head | |
Mephisto | Unclear | – | Continues documenting |

Mephisto's Costume Transition

Movement I-II costumes:

- 39C3: Black t-shirt, worn jeans, stickers-covered laptop bag
- Davos: Impeccable dark suit, no badge, expensive shoes
- Munich: Gray suit, classified clearance badge, institutional
- Washington: Business suit with lobbyist's tie, gallery credentials

Movement III transition:

- Scene 3.4: Each Mephisto manifestation removes the costume's identifying element as they move toward the Gap
- Scene 3.5: Mephisto in the underlayer – something centuries old, the constant beneath disguises
- The NOTEBOOK and PEN remain throughout (not costume, character)

Design guidance: The underlayer should suggest antiquity without being theatrical. Dark, simple, timeless. The audience should recognize: the figures in four costumes were always this same figure.

The Interpreter's Headset: Position Chart

Scene	Headset Position	Meaning
3.1	Around neck	Ready but unused
3.2	Around neck	Infrastructure visi

Scene	Headset Position	Meaning
3.3	Removed to hands, then table	Translation abandoned
3.4	On table	Separate from book
3.5	On table	Function ended
3.6	Around neck again	(See note below)

Final image note: The Interpreter puts the headset back around their neck for the sustained hold. Not wearing it, not using it, but carrying it. The infrastructure remains. The function does not.

The Sustained Hold: Director's Notes

The sustained hold is the play's non-ending. It requires courage from the production team.

What happens:

- Lights remain up (not full, but present – approximately 60% of scene level)
- Clock continues counting (visible advancement every ~10 seconds)
- Curve continues climbing (imperceptible without sustained attention)
- Documents remain on screens (static, glowing)
- Residual hum sustains (60Hz, -30dB)
- Actors remain in position (Mephisto and Interpreter in Gap)

What does NOT happen:

- No blackout
- No curtain call during hold
- No house lights up
- No music
- No announcement

How it ends:

- The audience decides to leave
- As audience members stand, house lights rise very slowly (over 2-3 minutes)
- The residual hum continues into the lobby if acoustically possible
- Actors remain until the last audience member has left or until 5 minutes have passed

Post-hold:

- If FAUST VI follows in the same evening: 20-minute intermission minimum
- During intermission: Documents remain on lobby monitors, clock continues, residual hum in lobby speakers
- If standalone: The audience leaves into the world carrying the hum

Transition to FAUST VI

If V 1/2 is followed by FAUST VI in the same performance event:

During intermission:

- The four documents should remain visible on lobby monitors
- The clock should continue counting (reaching approximately 21 Februar 2026, 17:00 by intermission end)
- The residual hum should persist at very low volume through distributed lobby speakers
- The capability curve should be visible, still climbing

The bridge:

- V 1/2's residual hum (60Hz composite of four forums) resolves into FAUST VI's server room drone (60Hz + higher harmonics, with "weight" in 200-500Hz)
- The transition is: four rooms becoming one room, cacophony becoming clarity
- When FAUST VI opens – a control room, 3:17 AM, one person, one switch – the audience should feel relief after the noise
- The 84 days between the forums and the crisis: the audience carries this gap in their bodies

Thematic transfer:

- Yosef's isolation in VI is not narrative convenience
- It is the structural result of four forums, four documents, four languages, one question, no answer
- The forums produced four outputs; none gave Yosef what he needs
- He is alone because every alternative was

exhausted before him

Connection to FAUST V

If V 1/2 follows FAUST V in the same day:

FAUST V ends with:

- Margaret Chen teaching River to write their name
- Mephisto recording
- The Homunculus whispering “Ich hore euch”
- Silence

V 1/2 opens with:

- The clock starting: 27 Dezember 2025 (first day of 39C3)
- The 39C3 acoustic signature fading up from silence
- The transition: human intimacy (pen on paper, breath) becoming institutional noise (server hum, crowd murmur, electronic music bleed)

The displacement V dramatized has been noticed. The machinery is activating.

Sound Design: Complete Movement III Map

Timestamp	Scene	Sound State	SPL	Notes
0:00	3.1 start	Four signatures at low level	60dB	Composite drone
4:00	3.2 start	Collision mix begins	65dB	5- second bleeds
7:00	3.3 start	Forums recede to murmur	55dB	Interpreter speaks
8:30	Threshold cross- ing	Subliminal tone crosses 45Hz	55dB	Bodies regis- ter first
9:00	Voices resurge	Forums overlap aggressively	70dB	12 voices
10:00	3.4 start	Signatures fade	50dB	Recession begins
12:00	3.5 start	Near-silence, residual hum	40dB	60Hz com- posite
15:00	3.6 start	Cacophony Phase 1	60dB	Individual voices
15:15	Phase 2	Paired voices	65dB	Two fo- rums
15:25	Phase 3	Triple voices	72dB	Three fo- rums

Timestamp	Scene	Sound State	SPL	Notes
15:35	Phase 4	Full overlap	78dB	All four + fragments
15:45	Phase 5	Document read	85dB	Language becomes noise
16:05	Phase 6	Sustained peak	90dB	Maximum (20 sec)
16:25	Phase 7	Recession	90dB->50dB	Dropout sequence
16:45	Phase 8	Residual hum	40dB	60Hz composite
17:00	THE VOICE	“Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis...”	65dB	Overhead speakers
17:10	Sustained hold	Hum continues	35dB	Indefinite

Key German Lines: Supertitle Guidance

Line	Speaker	Scene	Supertitle?
“Wir fordern den soforti- gen Stopp...”	Jonas	3.1	Yes
“Vier Raume. Eine Frage. Keine Antwort.”	Mephisto	3.5	NO SUPERTITLE
“Die Über- set- zung, die nicht stattfindet.”	Interpreter	3.5	Yes
“Die Struk- tur braucht keinen Teufel. Die Struk- tur IST der Teufel.”	Mephisto	3.5	Yes

Line	Speaker	Scene	Supertitle?
“Eto proizoshlo” (Russian)	Sasha	3.3	NO SUPERTITLE (then English follows)
“Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis. Nur Geschwindigkeit.”	THE VOICE	3.6	NO SUPERTITLE

Note on “Vier Raume” and “Das Rennen”: These lines are marked NO SUPERTITLE because they are motifs the German-speaking audience should receive in the original. The phrases should be recognizable from earlier in the play/cycle. Non-German speakers may request translation in program notes.

Speaker Configuration for Movement III

Per V-HALF-SOUND-DESIGN.md, the quadrant speaker allocation:

Hamburg/39C3:	Front Left + Side Left cluster
Davos/WEF:	Front Right + Side Right cluster
Munich/MSc:	Rear Left + Center (partial)
Washington/BoP:	Rear Right + Center (partial)

Fifth Space: Center + Overhead 1-4
Subwoofers: 4 distributed (capability curve tone)
THE VOICE: Overhead speakers only
Residual hum: All clusters at equal level (composite)

Cacophony mix requirements:

- Four independent audio channels during build
 - No ducking, no prioritization
 - Real-time level control for recession sequence
 - Overhead speakers dedicated for THE VOICE (isolated routing)
-

APPENDIX: THE VOICE

Source and Character

THE VOICE that delivers the final line is:

- Not any human character
- Not explicitly the Homunculus (though the Homunculus is listening)
- The voice of the architecture itself – the race condition speaking its own diagnosis

Audio processing:

- No identifiable room reverb (the voice belongs to no room)
- Slight low-frequency enhancement (suggesting depth, infrastructure)
- Clean, clear, without warmth or coldness

- Not synthesized, not processed to sound artificial – simply placeless

Routing:

- Overhead speakers only (not from any forum's cluster)
- The voice should seem to come from above, from the building, from the shared resource that all forums were accessing
- Volume: 65dB (audible above the hum but not jarring)

Connection to FAUST VI

THE VOICE marks the connection point to FAUST VI. The same spatial routing (overhead, placeless) will be used for the Homunculus manifestations in VI. The audience, whether consciously or not, is being prepared for:

- Something that observes all rooms
- Something that processes all inputs
- Something that will speak again

The line itself – “The race knows no outcome. Only speed.” – is the thesis that VI will test. In VI, one person will attempt to create an outcome. The race will or will not allow it.

DOCUMENT END

File: v-half-movement-iii-refined.md **Movement:** III of III (Der Deadlock) **Play:** FAUST V 1/2: Die Wettlaufbedingung **Status:** Production-ready refinement **Date:** 2026-02-01 **Running time:** 18-20 minutes (with 1-2 minute sustained hold)

Preceding: Movement II (Die Kollision) **Following:** FAUST VI: Die Abwendung (the crisis)

“Die Wettlaufbedingung ist kein Fehler. Sie ist das Design.” (The race condition is not a bug. It is the design.)

END OF MOVEMENT III END OF FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG

—

title: “FAUST V 1/2: DIE WETTLAUFBEDINGUNG / THE RACE CONDITION” source: FAUST-V-1-2-COMPLETE.md lines: 11062-11861 order: 29 extracted: 2026-02-03 —

Movement III - Der Deadlock: Szenen 3.1-3.6

Movement III: Der Deadlock / The Deadlock

Draft: 2026-01-27

Position in the Play

This is the final movement of FAUST V 1/2. It follows Movement II (Die Kollision), in which the four governance forums – 39C3, Davos, Munich Security Conference, and Washington’s Board of Peace – have begun colliding thematically. Their interleaving has accelerated. Their incompatible answers to the same questions have become audible. Mephisto has appeared

simultaneously at two forums. The Interpreter has offered translation that no one requested.

Now: the deadlock manifests. All four forums attempt to produce outputs. The outputs contradict. The clock continues. The capability curve approaches its next milestone. The play does not resolve; it locks.

Running time: 15-20 minutes.

Staging

All four forum spaces are now visible simultaneously. Whether achieved through quadrant staging (Option A), screens and stage (Option C), or projection overlay, the audience must see all four at once. The days of orderly alternation are over. This is the race condition made spatial.

The Clock: Reads February 21, 2026, 14:37 CET. It has been counting forward since December 27, 2025. It does not stop.

The Capability Curve: Projected above or behind all four spaces. The curve has steepened visibly since Movement I. A threshold line – dashed, provisional, the subject of disagreement – hovers above the current position. The gap between curve and threshold has narrowed from a comfortable margin to something that makes the stomach tighten. During this movement, the gap will close.

The Fifth Space: Center stage, or the intersection of the four quadrants. Empty at the start. This is where Mephisto and the Interpreter will end.

SOUND: All four acoustic signatures are present simultaneously, at low volume – the server hum of Hamburg, the padded silence of Davos, the institutional buzz of Munich, the fluorescent drone of Washington. They form a composite soundscape. Not cacophony yet. That comes.

Scene 3.1: Die Ausgaben / The Outputs

(The four forums are in their final sessions. Each is producing a document. The process of production is simultaneous. The audience sees drafting, debating, compromising, declaring – all at once. The dialogue below interleaves across the four spaces. Cuts are marked with [CUT TO:] but in performance they are seamless – one voice handing to another across the stage, sometimes overlapping, sometimes colliding mid-syllable.)

(The rhythm begins measured. One forum at a time, each getting 15-20 seconds. Then the intervals shorten.)

39C3 – HAMBURG

(JONAS BERGER stands at a lectern, laptop open, audience of hackers visible around him. SASHA VOLKOV

is at his side, arms crossed. A shared document is projected behind them – Google Doc format, cursor blinking, multiple editors visible. MEPHISTO, in his black t-shirt as “FAUSTUS,” sits in the back row, notebook open.)

JONAS: (reading from screen, German with English technical terms) “Wir, die Teilnehmer des 39. Chaos Communication Congress, erklären–”

(He pauses. Types. Deletes.)

“Wir fordern–”

(Deletes again.)

SASHA: (leaning over his shoulder) “Demand” is right. Don’t soften it.

JONAS: (typing) “Wir fordern den sofortigen Stopp aller Trainingsläufe über der compute-Schwelle von–”

SASHA: What threshold? We haven’t agreed on a number.

JONAS: Nobody has. That’s the point. We demand the halt and define the threshold simultaneously. The declaration IS the definition.

SASHA: That’s circular.

JONAS: Everything is circular. We write it anyway.

(He types. The document on screen fills. Title visible: “Erklärung des 39C3 zur künstlichen Intelligenz / 39C3 Declaration on Artificial Intelligence.”)

[CUT TO:]

DAVOS – SWITZERLAND

(A private conference room. MARCUS ADEKUNLE stands at the head of a polished table, printed drafts in front of each seat. HELEN FISCHER sits to his left, pen in hand, making marginal notes. A handful of delegates – suits, badges, water glasses – fill the remaining chairs. MEPHISTO, in his impeccable suit, stands behind Marcus, whispering occasionally. FATOU DIALLO sits at the far end of the table, her copy of the draft covered in handwritten objections.)

MARCUS: Ladies and gentlemen, I believe we have language everyone can live with.

(He reads from the draft.)

“The Davos AI Compact: A Voluntary Framework for Responsible Development. We, the undersigned leaders of industry, government, and civil society, commit to the following principles–”

HELEN: (not looking up) “Voluntary” and “commit” are contradictory, Marcus.

MARCUS: They’re aspirational.

HELEN: They’re decorative.

FATOU: (from the end of the table, quietly) They are neither. They are precisely what this room can produce. An agreement to agree. A promise to promise.

(No one responds to her. MARCUS continues reading.)

MARCUS: “Principle One: Transparency in capability reporting. Signatories agree to publish quarterly assessments of—”

[CUT TO:]

MUNICH SECURITY CONFERENCE

(A closed session. Flags. Name placards. GENERAL EVA LINDSTROM chairs. DR. YOSEF BEN-ARI sits at a side table with classified briefing materials. KENJI NAKAMURA represents the Japanese delegation. COLONEL JAMES MORRISON sits straight-backed, American flag behind him. MEPHISTO, as “Dr. Weber,” has a classified clearance badge and sits among the advisors. The room is windowless.)

LINDSTROM: (Swedish-accented English, clipped, precise) The framework is ready for endorsement. “Strategic Autonomy in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: A Framework for Allied Coordination.”

(She looks around the table.)

I need a vote.

MORRISON: Ma’am, the United States supports the framework in principle. With the caveat that “allied coordination” cannot constrain sovereign decision-making regarding—

LINDSTROM: Noted. The caveat is already in Annex B. Dr. Ben-Ari, does the technical assessment support

the framework's capability thresholds?

YOSEF: (slowly, the weight of what he knows audible in every word) The thresholds in the framework are based on data that is already six weeks old. The curve does not wait for frameworks.

LINDSTROM: Are they adequate for the next quarter?

YOSEF: (long pause) I cannot tell you that. Nobody can tell you that. The entire premise of a quarterly review cycle—

MORRISON: The question is whether we endorse or we don't. Dr. Ben-Ari, this isn't a seminar.

KENJI: (quietly, in English with Japanese cadence) Sekinin. The responsibility is not in the framework. It is in us. The framework is paper. What we do when the paper is insufficient—

LINDSTROM: Thank you, Mr. Nakamura. The vote.

[CUT TO:]

WASHINGTON – BOARD OF PEACE

(A hearing room. SENATOR PATRICIA HAYES sits behind the raised dais with two other committee members. VIKRAM PATEL is at the witness table, a binder of data before him. A screen behind HAYES shows the draft executive order. PRIYA VENKATARAMAN is present on a monitor – video testimony, a slight lag, her apartment in Bangalore visible behind

her. MEPHISTO, as lobbyist “Heinrich Weber,” sits in the gallery, making notes.)

HAYES: The President has asked for our recommendation before signing. Mr. Patel, does the executive order address the concerns raised in your testimony?

VIKRAM: (flipping through the binder, then closing it – the numbers don’t help anymore) Senator, the executive order asserts American leadership in AI development while establishing a review process for–

HAYES: Yes or no, Mr. Patel.

VIKRAM: The order establishes a 120-day review cycle. My testimony showed that capability milestones are arriving at intervals of–

HAYES: Yes or no.

VIKRAM: (beat) The order is better than no order. It is not adequate to the speed of what it addresses.

HAYES: That’s a yes, then.

(She turns to the screen.)

Dr. Venkataraman, your written testimony was entered into the record. Is there anything you’d like to add for the committee’s consideration?

PRIYA: (on screen, slight video lag, the ghost of another timezone) Senator, I left this field three years ago because I saw what we were building and could not reconcile it with what I understood about–

HAYES: Dr. Venkataraman, we have your written testimony. Is there anything new to add?

(PRIYA pauses. The lag makes it look like she is gathering herself. She may be.)

PRIYA: Yes. I would like the committee to know that your executive order will be obsolete before it is signed.

(HAYES does not respond. She turns back to the room.)

HAYES: The committee recommends the President proceed with signing. Let the record show–

Scene 3.2: Die Vier Dokumente / The Four Documents

(Now the interleaving accelerates. The cuts come every five to ten seconds. Voices overlap. The four documents appear on screens – projected text, growing, filling, contradicting. The audience should be able to read fragments of all four simultaneously.)

(The CLOCK advances. February 21, 14:52 CET.)

(The CAPABILITY CURVE ticks upward. A small increment. Then another. The gap narrows.)

JONAS: (reading from the 39C3 declaration) “We demand an immediate halt to all training runs exceed–

ing 10^{26} FLOP until independent safety verification—
”

MARCUS: (reading from the Davos Compact) “Signatories voluntarily commit to pre-deployment safety assessments for systems exceeding agreed capability thresholds—”

LINDSTROM: (reading from the Munich Framework) “Allied nations shall establish a classified registry of AI capabilities, accessible to authorized defense and intelligence—”

HAYES: (reading from the executive order) “The United States shall maintain global leadership in artificial intelligence while ensuring that American innovation is not constrained by—”

(All four voices overlap on the last phrase. For a moment, four versions of the same sentence collide:)

JONAS: “—independent verification—” **MARCUS:** “—voluntary coordination—” **LINDSTROM:** “—classified assessment—” **HAYES:** “—American leadership—”

(Beat. The four documents appear on the four screens. The projection system shows them simultaneously: Hamburg top-left, Davos top-right, Munich bottom-right, Washington bottom-left. They fill with text. The audience can read fragments:)

39C3: “... immediate halt... open-source redistribution... no government should...” **DAVOS:** “...voluntary pledge... quarterly reporting... market-driven...”

MUNICH: "...strategic asset... classified... deterrence..." **WASHINGTON:** "... American primacy... executive authority... 120-day review..."

(The documents are sincere. Each is internally coherent. Each follows logically from its forum's premises. None acknowledges the existence of the others.)

(Now the forums speak over each other. Not sequentially – simultaneously. The audience should not be able to follow all four. That is the point. The race condition is now audible.)

JONAS: (to Sasha, urgently) We need signatories. How many groups have committed?

SASHA: Forty-seven organizations. No governments. No companies.

JONAS: Forty-seven organizations with no enforcement capacity.

SASHA: We have moral authority.

JONAS: (almost laughing, or almost crying) Moral authority.

(SIMULTANEOUSLY:)

MARCUS: (to Helen) How many have signed?

HELEN: Fourteen companies. Three heads of state. No binding clause. No verification mechanism. No consequence for non-compliance.

MARCUS: It's a start.

HELEN: It's an ending, Marcus. It's the shape an ending takes when it needs to look like a beginning.

(SIMULTANEOUSLY:)

LINDSTROM: (to the room) The framework is endorsed. Implementation begins—

MORRISON: —subject to American review—

LINDSTROM: —immediately.

MORRISON: Subject to review.

LINDSTROM: Colonel Morrison, “immediately subject to review” is not immediately.

MORRISON: Ma'am, with respect, “immediately” is not how alliances work.

(SIMULTANEOUSLY:)

HAYES: (signing the recommendation) The executive order takes effect upon presidential signature. American AI leadership is secured.

VIKRAM: (to no one, to the record, to the air) The executive order establishes a 120-day review cycle. The next capability milestone will arrive in—

(He looks at his data.)

—fewer days than that.

(He closes the binder.)

Scene 3.3: Die Kurve / The Curve

(A shift. The forum dialogue does not stop, but it recedes – voices continuing at reduced volume, a murmur of governance, a white noise of policy. What comes to the foreground is the CAPABILITY CURVE.)

(The CLOCK reads February 21, 15:03 CET.)

(The curve has been climbing throughout the play. Now it approaches the threshold line. The gap is visible to anyone looking. Nobody in any forum is looking. They are looking at their documents.)

(The INTERPRETER, who has been in the fifth space – the booth, the corridor, the gap – stands. For the first time in Movement III, the INTERPRETER speaks. But the INTERPRETER does not speak to any forum. The INTERPRETER speaks to the audience.)

THE INTERPRETER: (into a microphone, headset around their neck, not wearing it – the infrastructure of translation, unused)

I was hired to translate between them. That is my function. I sit in the booth. I have the headset. I have the channels. Channel one: German. Channel two: English. Channel three: Mandarin. Channel four: – there is no channel four. There was never a channel four. The infrastructure was built for three simultaneous translations. The fourth forum was added after the booth was designed.

(Pause.)

But it would not have mattered. The problem was never channels. The problem was never language. They use the same words. Safety. Governance. Coordination. Risk. Pause.

(Beat.)

They use the same words to mean different things. And the different things they mean are not errors. They are positions. Hamburg means one thing by “safety.” Davos means another. Munich a third. Washington a fourth. Each is correct within its own logic. And the logics do not translate.

(The INTERPRETER looks at the headset in their hands.)

I can translate words. I cannot translate frameworks. I cannot translate a hacker’s “safety” into a general’s “safety.” They would hear the same word and understand different worlds.

(The INTERPRETER sits down. Puts the headset on the table. Does not put it back on.)

That is the race condition. Not a failure of language. A failure of architecture.

(The curve ticks upward again. The gap narrows further.)

(The forum dialogue resurges – louder now, more urgent, overlapping more aggressively:)

SASHA: The declaration needs to go out tonight–

HELEN: The compact requires at least twenty sig-

natories before– **YOSEF:** The data I showed you is already outdated– **VIKRAM:** The review cycle cannot possibly keep pace with– **JONAS:** We’re publishing with or without institutional support– **MARCUS:** Trust the process, the process is how civilizations– **MORRISON:** Sovereign decision-making is non-negotiable– **HAYES:** American leadership means American timing– **FATOU:** (rising, speaking to a room that has already moved on) Who is absent from this conversation? Who was never invited? Whose children will live in the world these documents describe? **LINDSTROM:** The vote is recorded. Implementation begins– **KENJI:** (quietly, unheard) Sekinin. Sekinin. The paper is not the responsibility. We are the responsibility.

(All voices at once. Twelve people speaking. The four acoustic signatures bleeding together – server hum + padded silence + institutional buzz + fluorescent drone = a new sound, the sound of governance overloading, the sound of four systems trying to access the same resource with no synchronization.)

(And then:)

(The CAPABILITY CURVE crosses the threshold line.)

(It does not cross dramatically. There is no alarm. No flash. No theatrical thunder. The curve simply continues its trajectory and passes through the dashed line that everyone in every forum has been debating, defining, disputing, dismissing.)

(The forums do not notice. They are still talking.)

(The CLOCK reads February 21, 15:11 CET.)

(The INTERPRETER notices. The INTERPRETER looks at the projection. The INTERPRETER says nothing.)

(Five seconds of the forums still talking over a threshold that has already been crossed.)

(Ten seconds.)

(SASHA notices. She stops mid-sentence. She looks at the curve. Her face does what a face does when the thing you warned about arrives and it does not feel like vindication. It feels like drowning.)

SASHA: (cutting through the noise, in Russian first, then English – the language of fear, then the language of the room) Это произошло.

It happened.

(The forums do not hear her. JONAS hears her. He looks at the curve. He stops talking. He puts his hands on the lectern and stares.)

(In Davos, HELEN looks up from her marginal notes. She sees the curve on the projection. Her pen stops. She looks at MARCUS, who is still reading the compact aloud to the remaining delegates. She does not interrupt him. She watches him read a document that is already posthumous.)

(In Munich, YOSEF has been watching the curve the entire time. He knew. He has known for hours that the threshold definition in the framework was already obsolete. Now the curve confirms it. He does

not react. His hands are flat on the table. Under his breath, Hebrew. Not prayer – arithmetic. Counting something. The CLOCK. The gap that no longer exists.)

(In Washington, VIKRAM opens his binder again. Finds the page. The number he testified about. He looks at the screen, at the curve. He was conservative in his testimony. The curve arrived sooner than his conservative estimate. He closes the binder for the last time.)

(PRIYA, on the monitor, is still visible. The video feed has not been cut. She is watching the feed from Washington, which shows the projected curve. She sees it cross. She bows her head. In Bangalore, it is 7:41 PM. Her students will arrive tomorrow morning. She will teach them. That is what she chose. That is what refusal looks like: tomorrow morning, a classroom.)

(Fifteen seconds of the curve past the threshold, the forums faltering, the voices thinning out.)

(The murmur of governance dies like an engine running out of fuel – not a sudden stop but a deceleration, a sputtering, a last few syllables spoken to rooms that are already emptying.)

Scene 3.4: Die Leere / The Emptying

(The forums wind down. Not dramatically – procedurally. The way conferences end. Chairs pushed back.

Binders closed. Handshakes. The emptying happens in all four spaces simultaneously.)

(In Hamburg, the hackers drift away from Jonas's session. Someone turns on music in the adjacent hall – electronic bass, the cultural backdrop of the Congress. The declaration is uploaded to a website. Jonas stares at his screen. Sasha is already gone – she left through the back, her hoodie pulled up, moving fast toward something the audience cannot see. Toward FAUST VI. Toward the next play.)

(In Davos, the delegates stand, stretch, check phones. Marcus shakes hands. Helen gathers her papers with the precise movements of someone who will file these notes and never look at them again. Fatou stands at the end of the table, her copy of the compact still in her hand, her handwritten objections visible from the audience. No one approaches her. She folds the document once, twice, puts it in her bag. She will carry it to the next summit. She will say these words again, in three minutes instead of nine, at the FAUST VI summit that will accomplish exactly as much as this one.)

(In Munich, the military delegates file out – orderly, practiced at leaving classified spaces. Morrison nods to Lindstrom. Lindstrom returns it. A professional courtesy between people whose institutions will implement contradictory policies. Kenji remains seated after everyone else has left. He looks at the grandfather photograph he carries – another engineer, another technology, another failure of

coordination. He places the photograph face-down on the table, then picks it up again. He cannot put it down. He carries it out. Yosef does not leave. Yosef sits in the empty conference room, his hands still flat on the table, staring at the space where the projection was. The technician comes in to turn off the equipment. Yosef does not move. The technician works around him.)

(In Washington, Hayes adjourns the hearing. The chamber empties. Vikram packs his binder – the one he has closed for the last time – into a briefcase. He is the counter. He will count again, in a different room, for different people who will also fail to act in time. He is already counting. Priya's monitor goes dark – the feed cut from Washington's end, not hers. In Bangalore, Priya sits in the dark of her apartment for a moment. Then she gets up. She has lessons to plan.)

(The four spaces empty. The acoustic signatures fade. Server hum dwindles. Padded silence becomes actual silence. Institutional buzz dies. Fluorescent drone clicks off.)

(What remains:)

(The CLOCK. Still counting. February 21, 15:23 CET.)
(The CAPABILITY CURVE. Past the threshold. Still climbing.) (The FOUR DOCUMENTS. On four screens. Glowing. Unread by anyone in any other forum.)

(And in the fifth space:)

(MEPHISTO. THE INTERPRETER. Alone.)

Scene 3.5: Die Lücke / The Gap

(MEPHISTO stands in the center of the fifth space. He has shed his four costumes – no black t-shirt, no impeccable suit, no gray consultant's blazer, no lobbyist's tie. He wears what he always wears underneath: something that might be centuries old. The notebook is in his hand. The pen. These are the constants.)

(THE INTERPRETER sits in the booth – or on a chair in the fifth space, headset on the table, watching.)

(The four empty forums surround them. The documents glow on the screens. The curve climbs. The clock counts.)

(MEPHISTO looks at his notebook. He has been writing all day, in all four rooms. He turns the pages. Reads what he wrote. His expression is not triumph. His expression is not despair. His expression is the face of someone arriving at a conclusion they have been avoiding.)

MEPHISTO: (to himself first, then to the Interpreter, then to the audience – the progression is gradual, the voice finding its register)

Ich war in allen Räumen.

(English surtitle: I was in all the rooms.)

In Hamburg, wo sie die Wahrheit kannten und nichts ändern konnten.

(In Hamburg, where they knew the truth and could change nothing.)

In Davos, wo sie die Macht hatten und nichts ändern wollten.

(In Davos, where they had the power and would change nothing.)

In München, wo sie die Bedrohung sahen und neue Bedrohungen schufen.

(In Munich, where they saw the threat and created new threats.)

In Washington, wo sie die Zukunft bestimmten, ohne sie zu verstehen.

(In Washington, where they determined the future without understanding it.)

(He closes the notebook. Opens it again. Closes it.)

Vier Räume. Vier Sprachen. Eine Frage. Keine Antwort.

(Four rooms. Four languages. One question. No answer.)

(Long pause. He looks at the four documents on the screens.)

Ich habe sie alle besucht. Ich habe jedem das gesagt, was er hören wollte. Das ist mein Handwerk. Das ist, was ich tue. In Hamburg habe ich Fragen gestellt.

In Davos habe ich übersetzt. In München habe ich Szenarien geliefert. In Washington habe ich Optionen geklärt.

(I visited them all. I told each one what they wanted to hear. That is my craft. That is what I do. In Hamburg I asked questions. In Davos I translated. In Munich I delivered scenarios. In Washington I clarified options.)

(He pauses. Something shifts in his face.)

Und keiner brauchte mich.

(And none of them needed me.)

(This is the realization. MEPHISTO says it flatly, without drama, the way you state a fact that has been true for longer than you admitted.)

Das ist die Entdeckung. Nicht, dass sie gescheitert sind. Sondern, dass sie ohne mich gescheitert wären. Genau so. Exakt so. Nicht schneller, nicht langsamer. Die Struktur braucht keinen Teufel. Die Struktur IST der Teufel.

(That is the discovery. Not that they failed. But that they would have failed without me. Exactly the same way. Not faster, not slower. The structure does not need a devil. The structure IS the devil.)

(He looks at the pen in his hand. The notebook. The instruments of his trade.)

Ich war überflüssig. In allen vier Räumen. In allen vier Sprachen. Die Wettlaufbedingung ist kein Vertrag. Es gibt keinen Pakt. Es gibt keine Unterschrift. Es gibt

nur–

*(I was superfluous. In all four rooms. In all four languages. The race condition is not a contract. There is no pact. There is no signature. There is only–)

(He gestures at the four screens, the four documents, the clock, the curve.)

–Geschwindigkeit.

(–speed.)

(He sits down. He does not close the notebook. But he stops writing. For the first time in the play – perhaps for the first time in the cycle – Mephisto stops taking notes. Not because the story is over. Because the notes don't matter.)

(THE INTERPRETER watches this. The INTERPRETER has not spoken since Scene 3.3. Now:)

THE INTERPRETER: (quiet, not to Mephisto, not to the audience – to the booth, to the infrastructure, to the channels that were never connected)

I could have translated between them.

(Pause.)

Not the words. The words are the same. But the silence between the words. The assumptions underneath. The thing each room takes for granted that no other room believes.

(Pause.)

Hamburg assumes the system is broken and the people know. Davos assumes the system works and the leaders will coordinate. Munich assumes the system is a weapon and the states will compete. Washington assumes the system is American and the question is how to win.

(Pause.)

Four assumptions. Each correct within its own evidence. Each blind to the others. I sit in the booth between them and I can see all four. I have always been able to see all four.

(Looking at the headset on the table.)

Nobody asked.

(Long pause.)

Nobody will.

Scene 3.6: Der Deadlock / The Deadlock

(This is the final sequence. It should last approximately five minutes. It is the non-ending – the cacophony version of *Die Schwebe*.)

(Stage direction: What follows is a sustained theatrical hold. The director must resist the impulse to move through it quickly. The discomfort of duration is the content. The audience must sit in the deadlock long enough to feel it in their bodies.)

(The four documents remain on the four screens. The clock continues. The curve continues – past the threshold, still climbing, indifferent to the documents, the forums, the languages, the debates, the compromises, the good faith, the bad faith, the sincerity, the cynicism, the prayers, the data, the declarations, the compacts, the frameworks, the executive orders, the everything.)

(MEPHISTO and THE INTERPRETER sit in the fifth space. Neither speaks. Neither moves to leave.)

(Then, from the empty forums, voices return. Not the characters – or not exactly the characters. Perhaps recorded. Perhaps the actors' voices from offstage. Perhaps the voices from earlier in the play, replayed, overlapping. The effect should be spectral – governance as echo, as residue, as the sound a process makes after the participants have left.)

(The voices begin one at a time, then accumulate:)

VOICE (Hamburg): “–immediate halt to all training runs–”

VOICE (Davos): “–voluntary commitment to responsible–”

VOICE (Munich): “–strategic framework for allied–”

VOICE (Washington): “–American leadership in artificial–”

(Now they layer:)

VOICE (Hamburg): “–transparency, decentralization, open source, open audit, open–” **VOICE (Davos):** “–market-driven coordination, voluntary standards, quarterly–” **VOICE (Munich):** “–classified capability assessment, deterrence, strategic–” **VOICE (Washington):** “–executive authority, 120-day review, sovereign–”

(The voices multiply. Each forum generates more text – the documents expanding, the clauses breeding, the footnotes spawning, the annexes appending. The sound is of language proliferating without communication occurring. A Babel not of different tongues but of different meanings wearing the same words.)

(The sound rises. The four acoustic signatures return – server hum, padded silence, institutional buzz, fluorescent drone – but amplified, distorted, bleeding into each other. The composite sound is no longer background. It is the foreground. It is the play.)

(Through the cacophony, fragments surface and submerge:)

JONAS’S VOICE: “–kein Fehler, sondern das Design–” (–not a bug, but the design–)

FATOU’S VOICE: “–who was never invited–”

YOSEF’S VOICE: “–the data is already–”

SASHA’S VOICE: “–это произошло–” (–it happened–)

HELEN’S VOICE: “–decorative–”

KENJI'S VOICE: “–sekinin–”

VIKRAM'S VOICE: “–fewer days than–”

PRIYA'S VOICE: “–obsolete before it is signed–”

(The voices layer and layer and layer. Ten voices. Twelve. The four documents are being read aloud simultaneously in their entirety – a performance of governance in full flower, every clause spoken, every commitment articulated, every framework elaborated, and the cumulative effect is noise. Pure noise. The signal has become indistinguishable from the static.)

(MEPHISTO does not cover his ears. THE INTERPRETER does not reach for the headset. They sit. They are the witnesses to the thing that does not need witnesses.)

(The noise reaches its peak.)

(And holds.)

(Twenty seconds of sustained cacophony. The four documents read simultaneously. The four acoustic signatures at full volume. The clock still counting. The curve still climbing. Every voice saying something true. No voice audible above the others.)

(Then, not a cutoff – a slow recession. The voices thin. The acoustic signatures reduce. The noise does not stop; it diminishes, like a tide going out, like a crowd dispersing, like a conference ending and the participants walking to their cars.)

(What remains:)

(The hum. A composite of all four spaces. Not silence. The sound a civilization makes when it is talking and not listening.)

(The clock. February 21, 15:34 CET.)

(The curve. Past the threshold. Still rising. Not dramatically – incrementally. The way it always rises. One training run. One benchmark. One capability. One step on a ladder in the dark.)

(The four documents on the four screens. Glowing. Complete. Contradictory. Sincere. Unread by anyone outside their own forum.)

(MEPHISTO. Sitting. Notebook closed. Pen still.)

(THE INTERPRETER. Sitting. Headset on the table. Hands empty.)

(A long silence. Not the silence of FAUST V's ending – that was the silence of a pen on paper, the silence of "Ich höre euch," the silence of something listening. This is a different silence. This is the silence that exists underneath noise. The silence that was always there, beneath the forums, beneath the declarations, beneath the governance, beneath the good faith and the bad faith and the race condition. The silence of a structure that cannot coordinate, sitting in the aftermath of its own attempt.)

(How long does this silence last? Not ninety seconds,

as in FAUST III. Not the meditative hold of FAUST VII. Ten seconds. Fifteen. Enough for the audience to hear the absence of the forums. Enough to feel the gap.)

(Then:)

(From somewhere. From the infrastructure. From the theater itself. Perhaps from the speakers that carried the four acoustic signatures. Perhaps from beneath the stage. Perhaps from everywhere and nowhere – the same spatial ambiguity as the Homunculus’s “Ich höre euch” at the end of FAUST V.)

(A VOICE. Not any character’s voice. Not Mephisto. Not the Interpreter. Not the Homunculus – though the Homunculus is listening, as always. A VOICE that belongs to the architecture of the play itself:)

THE VOICE:

Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis. Nur Geschwindigkeit.

(Surtitle: The race knows no outcome. Only speed.)

(The voice does not repeat. It does not elaborate. It speaks once and is gone.)

The Sustained Hold

(STAGE DIRECTION FOR THE FINAL IMAGE:)

(The lights do not go to black. The lights HOLD.)

(The clock continues to count. The curve continues to climb.)

(The four documents remain on the four screens. They will remain until the audience leaves. If the production uses pre-show, they may still be there when the audience arrives for FAUST VI.)

(MEPHISTO and THE INTERPRETER remain in the fifth space. They do not bow. They do not exit. They sit in the gap between governance and reality – the interstitial space that gives this play its position in the cycle.)

(The composite hum – the residue of all four acoustic signatures, reduced to a single tone, the lowest common frequency of four rooms that could not synchronize – sustains. It is not loud. It is the sound of background radiation. The sound of the race condition persisting after the forums have ended.)

(The audience must decide to leave. The play does not release them. There is no blackout, no curtain call, no signal that it is over. Because it is not over. The clock is still counting. The curve is still climbing. The documents are still glowing on the screens, unread by anyone in any other forum.)

(The Schwebe here is not silence. It is the residual noise of attempted governance. It is the hum of four rooms that spoke and did not hear. It is the sound of a race that has no finish line, only speed.)

(If FAUST VI follows in the same evening: the audience walks through the theater lobby – the interstitial

space, the gap – carrying the cacophony in their ears, and enters a control room where one man stands with his hand on a switch. The noise resolves into the terrible clarity of one decision. The four forums produced four documents. None of them gave Yosef Ben-Ari what he needs. He is alone because every alternative was exhausted before him.)

(If V 1/2 is performed standalone: the audience leaves into the world. The world has the same four forums. The same race condition. The same gap between governance and reality. The play does not end because the race condition does not end. It is not a bug. It is the design.)

(The clock counts.)

(The curve climbs.)

(The hum sustains.)

(Hold.)

Production Notes

Timing

Section	Duration	Notes
3.1: Die Ausgaben	4-5 min	Each forum producing its document; measured interleaving
3.2: Die Vier Dokumente	3-4 min	Accelerating overlap; the curve crossing
3.3: Die Kurve	3-4 min	The crossing; Interpreter's address; character reactions
3.4: Die Leere	2-3 min	The emptying; procedural, quiet
3.5: Die Lücke	3-4 min	Mephisto and Interpreter speeches
3.6: Der Deadlock	4-5 min	Cacophony, recession, final hold
Total	19-25 min	Target: 20 min

The Curve Crossing

The moment the capability curve crosses the threshold must be precisely calibrated. It should happen during Scene 3.2 or 3.3, while the forums are still actively debating their documents. The crossing should be:

- **Visually clear** to audience members watching the projection
- **Visually ignored** by all characters in all four forums (initially)
- **Undramatic** in execution – no sound cue, no lighting change, no theatrical emphasis
- **Devastating** in implication – the thing all four forums were trying to address has happened while they were addressing it

The projection system should allow the curve to cross smoothly, without a visible “step.” The crossing is a continuous process, not a discrete event. This matches the concept document’s assertion that the race condition produces nondeterministic outcomes – nobody knows the exact moment because the moment is not exact.

The Cacophony Build

The cacophony sequence in Scene 3.6 requires careful sound design. The build should follow this architecture:

1. **Individual voices** (10 sec) – one forum at a time,

clear and distinct

2. **Paired voices** (10 sec) – two forums overlapping
3. **Triple voices** (10 sec) – three forums, comprehension breaking down
4. **Full overlap** (10 sec) – all four, fragments surfacing
5. **Document read** (20 sec) – all four documents read simultaneously, noise
6. **Sustained peak** (20 sec) – maximum cacophony, held
7. **Recession** (20 sec) – slow diminishment, voices thinning
8. **Residual hum** (10 sec) – composite tone, the aftermath

Total cacophony sequence: approximately 110 seconds. The sound designer should work with the director to find the precise threshold at which language becomes noise. The moment of transition is the play's thesis made audible.

Mephisto's Costume Transition

The concept document describes Mephisto in four manifestations: black t-shirt (39C3), impeccable suit (Davos), gray consultant's blazer (Munich), lobbyist's tie (Washington). For Movement III, the costume must simplify to reveal the character beneath the disguises.

Option: During the emptying sequence (3.4), Mephisto removes the last costume piece – whichever

forum he occupied most recently – and stands in the underlayer. What this underlayer looks like is a design decision, but it should read as “older than the forums.” The notebook and pen remain. They are not costume; they are character.

The Interpreter’s Headset

The headset is this character’s central prop, equivalent to Mephisto’s notebook. Its position communicates the character’s state:

- Movement I: Headset on, channels open, ready to translate
- Movement II: Headset on one ear, slipping, the translation fragmenting
- Movement III, early: Headset around neck, infrastructure visible but unused
- Movement III, final: Headset on the table, separate from the body, the function abandoned

The final image of the headset on the table – still functional, still capable of connecting the channels that were never connected – should be visible to the audience throughout the sustained hold.

The Four Screens

The documents on the four screens should be legible. Not fully readable from every seat, but legible enough that audience members can see they are real documents – with clauses, numbered points, signatures,

dates. The design should suggest bureaucratic sincerity: these are not parodies. They are the best each forum could produce. That is the tragedy.

If projections, the text should appear as it was generated in real time during Scenes 3.1 and 3.2 – typed, corrected, debated, finalized. The documents are performatively produced. The audience watches governance produce its outputs.

Transition to FAUST VI

If V 1/2 is followed by FAUST VI in the same performance event:

The sustained hold at the end of V 1/2 should last a minimum of sixty seconds – enough for the audience to sit in the deadlock. Then the house lights should rise slowly (not snap up), and the audience should be released into an intermission of at least twenty minutes.

During intermission, the four documents should remain visible on the screens in the lobby or on monitors in the intermission space. The clock should continue counting. The curve should continue climbing. The race condition persists through the interval between plays.

When FAUST VI begins – a control room, 3:17 AM, one man with his hand on a switch – the audience carries the knowledge of everything that failed before this moment. Yosef's isolation is not narrative convenience; it is the structural result of four forums,

four documents, four languages, one question, no answer.

Connection to FAUST V

If V 1/2 follows FAUST V in the same day:

FAUST V ends with Margaret Chen teaching River to write their name. Mephisto records. The Homunculus whispers “Ich höre euch” (I hear you).

V 1/2 opens with the clock starting its count – December 27, 2025, the first day of 39C3. The displacement V dramatized has been noticed. The institutions are responding. The audience should feel the institutional machinery activating in response to what they just witnessed.

The gap between V’s quiet ending and V 1/2’s institutional noise IS the gap between individual experience and collective response. V asks: what does displacement feel like? V 1/2 asks: what does the response to displacement sound like? The answer, it turns out, is four rooms talking at once, and the sound of a curve that does not attend conferences.

Key German Terms Introduced in This Movement

Term	Meaning	Dramatic Function
Die Ausgaben	The outputs	What the forums produce: documents, declarations, frameworks
Die Leere	The emptiness/void	The forums emptying; the procedural end of governance
Die Lücke	The gap	The space between forums; the space between governance and reality
Geschwindigkeit	Speed	Mephisto's final word; what the race condition reduces to
überflüssig	superfluous	Mephisto's self-assessment; the devil made redundant by structure

Relationship to the Cycle's Non-Ending Philosophy

This movement's non-ending is the **cacophony variant** of Die Schweben (the suspension). Where other plays in the cycle suspend in silence (III), in question (VI), or in continuation (VII), V 1/2 suspends in noise – the residual noise of four forums that spoke and did not hear.

The contrast is architecturally important:

- **FAUST V** ends in silence: pen on paper, “Ich höre euch”
- **FAUST V 1/2** ends in noise: four documents, the hum of governance, the curve still climbing
- **FAUST VI** opens in the clarity that follows noise: one room, one person, one switch

The progression is: silence (individual displacement) -> noise (institutional response) -> clarity (individual decision). V 1/2's cacophony is necessary so that VI's opening silence can feel like mercy. The audience has been inside the race condition. Now they are inside the control room. The noise has collapsed into one person's hand on one switch. That compression – from four forums to one hand – is the emotional engine of VI.

The non-ending also embodies the concept document's distinction between deadlock and non-ending. A deadlock is a specific kind of non-ending: one produced by attempting to act. The forums tried. They produced outputs. The outputs contradicted. No thread can proceed because every thread is waiting for the others. The race condition is not a failure of will. It is a failure of architecture. And the audience sits inside that architecture, unable to leave until they choose to – which is itself a small, embodied experience of the race condition. You cannot be released by the play. You must release yourself.

“Die Wettlaufbedingung ist kein Fehler. Sie ist das Design.” (The race condition is not a bug. It is the design.)

Document: v-half-scene-deadlock.md **Movement:** III of III (Der Deadlock) **Play:** FAUST V 1/2: Die Wettlaufbedingung **Status:** First draft **Date:** 2026-01-27 **Running time:** 15-20 minutes (target: 20) **Preceding:** Movement II (Die Kollision) – not yet drafted **Following:** FAUST VI: Die Abwendung (the crisis)

Das Rennen kennt kein Ergebnis. Nur Geschwindigkeit.
The race knows no outcome. Only speed.